

THIRD
EDITION

PRESENTING TO WIN

*The Art of Telling Your Story
and Designing Your Slides*



JERRY WEISSMAN

Author of *In the Line of Fire*

Praise for the Third Edition of *Presenting to Win*

“Read this book and get a Masters Degree in effective communications in one afternoon. The executive teams that we have invested with have used Weissman’s communication techniques to dramatically improve team productivity and shareholder value.”

—**David F. Bellet**

Former Chairman, Crown Advisors International Ltd.

“Clear, concise, and high-impact communications are necessary for every business executive in today’s high-speed world. Jerry Weissman provides leaders with simple tools they can draw on quickly in order to maximize the return on all of their communications efforts.”

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Former Senior Vice President, Cisco Systems;
Board of Directors ServiceNow, Anaplan, Nutanix,
Druva, GitLab, Outreach, Samsara

“Jerry Weissman is an expert in helping leading technology executives improve the clarity and substance of their communication. Jerry does an excellent job of giving sound recommendations that will lead to better communications and leadership.”

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Former General Partner, Accel Partners;
Founder, Breyer Capital; Board Member The Blackstone Group

“*Presenting to Win* is the shortest path to applause for any presenter. It will be your bible for the PowerPoint Age. It’s loaded with easy actions and real examples that really work. I’ve used them. I know.”

—**Scott Cook**

Founder, Intuit

“*Presenting to Win* is an essential read for any CEO who intends to raise capital, wishes to elevate the visibility of his/her company in the financial community, or aspires to more credible communication with the company’s employees.”

—**Irwin Federman**

General Partner, U.S. Venture Partners

“I would think that everyone who does business presentations could benefit from this easy-to-read, easy-to-apply book.”

—**Flip Gianos**

General Partner, Interwest Partners

“The perfect presentation has the potential to impact the most important events in your company’s life: financings, mergers, partnerships. Despite this, most executives and entrepreneurs continually fall short when it comes to delivering a crisp, clear message in a compelling and concrete fashion. Luckily for them, the master, Jerry Weissman, has decided to share his secrets in *Presenting to Win*.”

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General Partner, Benchmark Capital

“Compelling, no-nonsense script to clear, winning communication! A must have.”

—**Grant Heidrich**

Partner Emeritus, Mayfield Fund

“Jerry Weissman’s presentation coaching is world class. A person contemplating a presentation without utilizing his expertise is like a soldier going to battle without weapons.”

—**Jay C. Hoag**

Founding General Partner, Technology Crossover Ventures

“Jerry is The Man when it comes to making great pitches. If your pitch doesn’t get a whole lot better after reading this book, something is wrong with you.”

—**Guy Kawasaki**

Chief Evangelist of Canva, creator of
Guy Kawasaki’s *Remarkable People* podcast,
and author of *The Art of the Start 2.0* and *Wise Guy*

“Perception is often as, if not more, important than reality. Great presentation is more important than great substance in creating that perception. I don’t know anybody who has more experience than Jerry in creating great perceptions.”

—**Vinod Khosla**

Partner, Khosla Ventures

“Jerry Weissman makes the challenge of producing and delivering effective presentations delightfully simple. Read it and benefit! Now I remember why I hired Jerry those many years ago!”

—Tim Koogle

Founding CEO, Yahoo!

“Jerry’s book *Presenting to Win* is, like his consulting practice, totally on-point and practical. Jerry has worked with many of the companies I took public as an investment banker or invested in as a venture capitalist. He made a huge difference in each and every situation. The best evidence is that even the most polished CEOs in the Valley made dramatically more effective presentations with his expert guidance. Since Jerry can’t work with everyone individually, it is terrific to have his approach and thoughts available in *Presenting to Win*.”

—J. Sanford Miller

General Partner, IVP (Institutional Venture Partners)

“Jerry’s methods in *Presenting to Win* helped us raise our own first venture fund with twice the commitments we needed in half the time. Those same methods then helped many of our portfolio companies not just in their presentations, but had a significant impact in the marketing of their products.”

—Andy Rachleff

Partner, Benchmark Capital; CEO, Wealthfront

“A great read for all of us who have ever struggled with any aspect of our public speaking skills. *Presenting to Win* contains the same timeless techniques that helped me 11 years ago.”

—Jeff Raikes

Former President, Microsoft Business Division, Microsoft Corporation;
Former CEO, Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation

“*Presenting to Win* should be required reading for any business executive who will be presenting to any group of internal or external constituents. Having been a technology investment banker for nearly 15 years, I’ve seen thousands of road show and company presentations, and many of them failed to incorporate the tips and techniques outlined in *Presenting to Win*. I’ve sent dozens of clients to Jerry over the years, and they have always emerged with crisper, clearer, and more effective presentations.”

—Michael J. Richter

Former Managing Director, Investment Banking CIBC World Markets;
Managing Director and Global Head of Aerospace and Defense, Lazard

“Weissman’s organization of a CEOs thoughts and presentation usually created 15-25% more value to the company from institutional investors.”

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Founder, Robertson Stephens Investment Bank

“Jerry helps you focus on the substance of your presentation rather than just its form. He forces you to think clearly and succinctly. As a result not only does your audience understand your business better, you do too.”

—**Christopher Spray**

Senior Partner, Atlas Venture

“A must read for all high-tech managers.”

—**Anthony Sun**

Managing General Partner, Venrock Associates

“After you spend years building your startup, there’s a fleeting moment in time where perception meets reality in the creation of the market value around it. There’s not a person in the Valley that has coaxed more multiple points out of the market at that point than Jerry. His coaching on how to really efficiently organize and explain ANY subject matter is proven, and shows in his book.”

—**Bill Tai**

General Partner, Charles River Ventures

“*Presenting to Win* identifies the simple rules of a master and communicates those rules in a refreshing way.

—**T. Peter Thomas**

Co-founder and Managing Director, ATA Ventures

“There are those rare people who can stand up in front of an audience and deliver an impromptu, high-impact message. For the rest of us, there is Jerry Weissman, who helps us create a high-impact presentation. Miraculously, your confidence will soar.”

—**Les Vadasz**

Former Executive Vice President, Intel Corporation

“Everything must communicate *Aha!*s has been my cry in marketing for 30 years. What you say and don’t say, what you do and don’t do, it all says something. Now Jerry finally gives all of us the answer on the how to communicate effectively. Thanks, Jerry, the business world really needs this book.”

—**Sergio Zyman**

Former Chief Marketing Officer, Coca-Cola; Chairman and
Founder of Zyman Group; author of *Renovate Before You Innovate*,
The End of Marketing As We Know It, *Building Brandwidth*, and
The End of Advertising As We Know It.

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PRESENTING TO WIN

The Art of Telling Your Story and Designing Your Slides

Third Edition

Jerry Weissman



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*To the cherished memory of
Louis and Rose Weissman, my
beloved father and mother,
fruition at last.*

Case Studies

In order of appearance:

Ben Rosen	Daniel Kahneman	PepsiCo
Don Valentine	Robin Williams	David Brooks
John Morgridge	T-Mobile Earnings Call	Aaron Skonnard
Marshall McLuhan	Microsoft Earnings Call	<i>Portrait of a Minimum Wage Earner</i>
COMDEX	Sand Hill Road Shuttle	<i>Tales of Manhattan</i>
Vani Kola	Writing Center, UNC	<i>The Yellow Rolls-Royce</i>
Don Valentine	John McPhee	<i>Two for the Road</i>
Michael Ball	Chuck Geschke	Safra Catz
Bill Gurley	Marcus Tullius Cicero	Philippe Brawerman
David Ogilvy	Philippe Kahn	Ben Rosen
David Mamet	Ariadne and Theseus	Ray Dalio
L. Gordon Crovitz	Harold Scheub	Wim Coekaerts
Zig Ziglar	Syd Field	Tomer Tagrin
Mortimer Adler	Bruce Schuman	eBay IPO Roadshow
Aristotle	Sir Arthur Conan Doyle	Forrest Li
Jean Shepherd	Mickey Kertesz	Malcom Gladwell
William Shakespeare	Jeffrey Dunn	Scott Cook
Dan Warmenhoven	Kodak	Jim Flautt
Stephen Covey	HP	David Rubenstein
Karen Hughes	Coca-Cola	Howard Wu
Jim Bixby	Nespresso	Virginia Rometty
Lise Buyer	Keurig	Ed Bastian
Bob Tinker	Illy	Daniel Lurie
Cade Collins	CannaKorp	Bill Gates
Endodontic CEO	Cisco IPO Roadshow	Ronald Reagan
John Stark	Patrick Spence	<i>Wall "A-Hed"</i>
Reed Hastings	Sajjid Chinoy	Sajjid Chinoy
Federico Fellini	Indra Nooyi	

CASE STUDIES

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Bud Colligan	Margaret Chase Smith	Steve Jobs
Dan Warmenhoven	Susan B. Anthony	Tim Cook
Jean-Baptiste Rudelle	Barack Obama	Guy Kawasaki
Raul Vazquez	Nike	Klein/Dytham
Gregg Pugmire	Capital One	The Six-Word Story
Reid Hoffman	State Farm	Francis Gagnon
<i>Thelma and Louise</i>	Roger McNamee	John De Goes
Dhritiman Dasgupta	Dean Ormond J. Drake	Bill Colston
Rosser Reeves	William Gillette	Lawrence Lessig
Ken Goldman	Don Listwin	Mark Hanna
Jim Kamradt	Ford Tamer	Jerry Maguire
Sharat Sharan	Mark Twain	Hans Rosling
Classic Rhetoricians	Bixby Jamison	Patrick Spence
William Safire	Bill Gurley	Mitesh Dhruv
Bruce Eric Kaplan	Jeff Bezos	Bill Colston
Virginia Rometty	Winston Churchill	Ford Tamer
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The Testifying CEO	Vinod Khosla	UPS
Vince Lombardi	Reid Hoffman	Walt Disney
Franklin D. Roosevelt	William Wordsworth	General Hugh Shelton
Garry Wills	Irwin Federman	Sir Isaac Newton
Stephen Sondheim	Phil Knight	Alexander Graham Bell
Socrates	Carolyn Davidson	Ernest Hemingway
Dhritiman Dasgupta	Andy Warhol	Salzburg University

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Past Is Prologue

Case Studies: Ben Rosen, Compaq Computer • Don Valentine, Sequoia Capital • John Morgridge, Cisco • Marshall McLuhan • COMDEX

■ Once Upon a Time... ■

...I was living and working in Los Angeles, the opposite end of California from Silicon Valley. I had spent the first half of my professional life in the world of television, most of it as a staff producer-director of public affairs and news programs for CBS in New York but also as a freelance documentary writer and a paperback novelist. During all of those experiences, I had the opportunity to work with some of the most creative minds in media and learned a great deal, particularly about the art of telling a story. If you know anything about the television industry, however, you'll know that it's filled with peaks and valleys, and I had more than my share of valleys.

Until Ben Rosen called.

Ben and I had met as graduate students at Stanford University, where each of us was pursuing a master's degree, he in electrical engineering and I in speech, drama, and television. You might be wondering what an engineer and a liberal artist had in common; it was that we were competing for the affections of the same young woman. But that is a story for another time.

By the time Ben called many years later, he had become a successful venture capitalist and was the chair of the board of Compaq Computer. As is his wont, Ben got right to the point: "I spend all day listening to presentations from CEOs who want me to invest in their businesses. You wouldn't believe how complex and dry most of them are. They don't inspire much confidence. You should move up to Silicon Valley and teach these people how to tell their stories."

I was intrigued but dubious. After all, I didn't know much about the world of business, and even less about technology.

“That’s just the point!” Ben exclaimed with a snap of his fingers. “If you can help make the Valley’s business and technology clear to broader audiences the way you did for so many different subjects in television, there’s an enormous business opportunity—and I’ll help you get started.”

I started Power Presentations, Ltd., in 1988 and, to sharpen the mission to create persuasive presentations that produce results, renamed it Suasive, Inc. in 2018. Now that this powerful methodology has proven successful for more than three decades, let me share it with you.

■ The High-Stakes Presentation ■

True to his word, Ben introduced me to many influential people, primary among them his venture capital colleagues, or VCs, as they are known in the trade. One of them was Don Valentine of Sequoia Capital, the legendary VC who had been an early investor in Apple, Atari, Oracle, and, later, Electronic Arts, Cisco, Yahoo!, and Google. During my first month as a presentation coach in Silicon Valley, Don took me to lunch and told me that my coaching services could be useful for one of Sequoia’s portfolio companies.

“Cisco’s about to go public, and we think it’ll do fairly well,” said Don. “But it has a very esoteric technology that will be difficult to explain to investors. We’re planning on pricing the offering in the \$13.50 to \$15.50 range, but if the IPO roadshow is any good, we can probably increase that share price by a couple of bucks. I’m going to introduce you to the CEO and ask him to have you help him with his presentation.”

The CEO was John Morgridge, and I worked with him and his senior team to make Cisco’s complex networking technology meaningful to investors. (You’ll see how in Chapter Five.) The message got through loud and clear. On the day Cisco went public, its stock opened at \$18 a share and closed the first day of trading at \$22 a share (a then-unheard-of price jump). Cisco quickly became a hot stock in the investment community and a hot story in the media. The *San Francisco Chronicle* wrote:

Cisco originally expected to get \$13.50 to \$15.50 per share for its stock. “But during the road show the company was so well-received” that it managed to sell 2.8 million shares at \$18 apiece, Valentine [Cisco’s then-Chairman of the Board] said. He attributed “at least \$2 to \$3” of the increase to Weissman’s coaching.¹

That was more than 600 IPO roadshows ago, among them Intuit, eBay, Netflix, Yahoo!, Dolby Labs, RingCentral, Twilio, Trulia, Talend, MobileEye, Zuora, Sonos, and Lyft. During this same time, I have also helped thousands of other companies, both public and pre-public—including Microsoft, Intel, Adobe, Ericsson, and Experian—create presentations to grow their businesses.

The IPO roadshow is probably the most high-stakes presentation any businessperson will ever deliver. Succeeding in an IPO is like winning the lottery. Investors are a very tough crowd; they are both demanding and knowledgeable, the stakes are high, and a swing of one dollar in the share price of an offering can translate into millions of dollars. But if you extend the logic a bit further, every audience you encounter in business is a tough crowd, and every presentation you deliver is high-stakes. Every presentation is a steppingstone on the path to ultimate success.

Therefore, in my work with all my clients, I regard every presentation as an IPO roadshow, whether it is a private financing pitch, a product launch, a keynote speech, a panel appearance, an analysts' call, a shareholders' meeting, or a budget approval. You can extend this array to your own presentation situations, whether they are external or internal, for an important contract, a major alliance, a big sale—or even funding for a not-for-profit cause.

Every presentation has one common goal: the all-important art of persuasion, an art with literally dozens of applications for which everyone in business must be prepared. Persuasion is the classic art of getting your target audience to do your bidding, to respond to your presentation favorably.

■ *The Medium Is the Message* ■

Yes, that's right. *Message* is in the original title of Marshall McLuhan's landmark book; look it up. Over time, thanks to extensive usage and the self-validating power of the Internet, public reference to the title has morphed into *The Medium is the Message*. On the influential author's website, his son explains:

Actually, the title was a mistake. When the book came back from the typesetter's, it had on the cover "Message" as it still does. The title was supposed to have read "The Medium is the Message" but the typesetter had made an error. When Marshall saw the typo he exclaimed, "Leave it alone! It's great, and right on target!"²

McLuhan was absolutely correct. "Message" has a much more active connotation than a passive "message." "Message" indicates that the medium plays

FOREWORD: PAST IS PROLOGUE

a transformative role as it delivers the message. As McLuhan put it himself, it is the “medium that shapes and controls the scale and form of human association and action.” The difference is a perfect metaphor for the role of presentations as the medium that conveys business messages.

When I moved from the world of television to the world of business, I found that it wasn’t just the message that needed help, as was the case with Cisco; it was the way those messages were being transmitted to audiences via presentations that were “complex and dry,” as my friend Ben observed. Business presentations, if you will, weren’t massaging the message.

Once again, Ben was correct. A month after moving to Silicon Valley to start my own business, I flew to Las Vegas to attend COMDEX, an annual monster-sized computer trade show with more than 100,000 attendees who visit hundreds of exhibition booths and attend dozens of presentations in breakout rooms. (COMDEX has since been succeeded and exceeded in size and scope by CES, the annual Consumer Electronics Show.) Over the course of several days, I spent most of my time in Las Vegas in the breakout rooms, observing presentations about the latest technology products.

What I saw were uniformly passive transmissions of information to equally passive audiences. The presentations were merely lengthy litanies of features, known affectionately in the high-tech world by the epithets “feeds and speeds” or “stop me if you see anything you like.” They were one-way streets that ground to a halt at dead ends, not communication. None of them achieved McLuhan’s goal of “human association and action.”

In the television medium, ideas and images are also broadcast in one direction over the air, cable, or satellite, but there is a return loop, a feedback, an interaction that comes barreling back at the broadcaster in the form of ratings, critics, sponsors, letters, telephone calls, emails, and sometimes even regulatory legislation.

When the television audience is not satisfied, the series is canceled. When the business audience does not get the point crystal-clear and does not see the benefit of the point, the investment is declined, the sale is not made, the approval is not granted.

In this book and in the Suasive® programs, you’ll find a proven set of media-based techniques that will enable presenters like you to present to win.

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The Primacy of the Story

Case Studies: Vani Kola, Kalaari Capital • Don Valentine, Sequoia Capital

*It's still the same old story.*¹

As Time Goes By
Herman Hupfeld

■ A Trip to India ■

In the more than three decades since coaching the Cisco IPO roadshow in Silicon Valley, I've had the opportunity to deliver those same services in other similarly named technology centers around the United States—New York's Silicon Alley, Dallas' Silicon Prairie, Seattle's Silicon Forest, Salt Lake City's Silicon Slopes—and in other centers around the world—London's Silicon Mall, Paris' Silicon *Sentier*, Israel's Silicon *Wadi*. In each of those hot spots, I learned something new about my own techniques, but in Bangalore's Silicon Plateau, I learned something old.

The first time I arrived in Bangalore in January 2015 was quite an auspicious occasion: India's Republic Day, the anniversary celebration of the Indian Constitution. Everywhere in the city, flagpoles, lampposts, antenna towers, suspension cables, windows, and entire buildings were festooned with flags, bunting, streamers, and banners in India's bold national colors: red, white, and green. Adding to the kaleidoscopic decor—and excitement—were large posters welcoming President Barack Obama, who had arrived that same day to participate in the festivities. To add to all the celebrations, when I checked in to my hotel, a traditional Indian wedding was in full swing, with a roiling sea of people dressed in riotously colorful saris and dhotis, punctuated by dozens of bright pink turbans bobbing up and down among the joyful celebrants.

The next day, when I began the program for my client, there was no letdown in the city's pulsating energy, or in any of the days after that. Bangalore bustles

and buzzes with the relentless vitality of people in constant motion (except for the traffic), all propelled by the booming high-technology industry. Everyone knows everyone, and everyone is busy doing business with everyone else.

One of the most active members of this vibrant community is Vani Kola, a VC whose firm, Kalaari Capital, focuses on early-stage technology companies. I had met Vani many years earlier, in Silicon Valley, when she was the CEO of Nth Orbit, her own startup company. Now living in Bangalore, Vani had learned, through the hyperconnected grapevine, that I was in town and called to invite me to an industry event she was giving for a large group of CEOs from Kalaari's portfolio companies at a hotel in the Whitefield area of the city.

Never shy, Vani asked me to deliver some after-dinner remarks about presentation skills. I obliged with a brief presentation and then opened the floor to questions.

The very first one came from a serious-looking young entrepreneur who asked, "What changes have you seen in presentations over your years in business, and what changes have you had to make in your process?"

At first, I was stumped. Over my many years, I'd been asked many questions, all of them pragmatic, never theoretical; all of them about the presenter, none about me: "How can I control my nerves?" "What do I do with my hands?" "How can I get my message across?" "How do I simplify my slides?" "How can I make my story more concise?" "How do I answer tough questions?"

My mind began racing through all the latest developments in presentation technology—virtual meetings, video teleconferencing, cloud collaboration, arena projectors, over-the-ear wireless microphones—but it didn't stop. My thoughts kept racing, faster and faster, further back, past remote controllers and embedded videos, past the dinosaurs of 35 mm slides and the carcasses of overhead projectors and transparencies, and even further back, until it stopped at the beginning: Aristotle.

"It's still the same old story..." I replied, appropriating the lyric from the famous song in the classic film *Casablanca*, "...it's all about how you tell your story."

The serious young entrepreneur smiled.

"It's all about persuasion," I continued. "To produce results, to convince your audiences to do what you want them to do: to finance your company, buy your stock or your product or your service, form a partnership—or to donate to your not-for-profit cause. It's *not* about your slide deck, or your body language

and voice, or fancy video and audio. All of that is empty sound and fury if your story doesn't work. And the way to create a persuasive story goes back to Aristotle."

■ The Perpetual Source ■

Aristotle was required reading in the studies for my Master of Arts degree at Stanford University, where I had learned about *Exordium*, *Narratio*, *Peroratio*, *Ethos*, *Pathos*, *Logos*, and *Teleology*. But when I left Stanford to work in the television industry, including a decade at CBS in New York, Aristotle went onto the back burner.

Years later, he came rushing back to front and center. During that pivotal lunch with Don Valentine, he told me that the challenge Cisco had of explaining its complex technology business to investors was not limited to high-tech companies. He concluded, "The problem is that nobody knows how to tell a story. And the bigger problem is that nobody knows that they don't know how to tell a story!"

As I began helping craft Cisco's story and the stories of other companies in Silicon Valley, I soon realized that Aristotle's principles had been operating in the back of my mind all the while. They had simply morphed into different terminologies and new processes to arrive at those same basic principles—the same principles that fueled Abraham Lincoln's towering rhetoric, Sir Winston Churchill's inspiring orations, Franklin Roosevelt's assuring fireside chats, and the Reverend Martin Luther King's rousing speeches. The morphing continued as I worked with more and more companies, until they formed the methodology of my coaching programs—and then this book, first published in 2003, a second edition in 2009, and now this edition.

■ The Third Edition ■

The First Commandment of writing is rewriting. This new edition is the product of lessons learned from the thousands of presentations I've coached in the dozen years since the second edition, as well as the numerous new case studies I've compiled along the way. As a result, I've streamlined some steps of the story development processes and expanded some of the others. What has not changed are the original techniques, all of them based on those fundamental Aristotelian principles. I have also replaced the political examples in the first and second

editions with new case studies from the business world and beyond. After all, I wrote this book for the road warriors who must deliver pitches that persuade, as well as for anyone who has to stand up and speak.

Readers of the earlier editions will note that I have expanded the subtitle from *The Art of Telling Your Story* to *The Art of Telling Your Story and Designing Your Slides*. Although slide design constituted a third of the content in each of those earlier editions, I did not include it on their covers—intentionally—because of my persistent focus on the story. However, the equal persistence of the slide “deck” as an irreplaceable component of business has prompted me to add slide design to the subtitle and to update the original chapters. What remains unchanged are the same fundamental design principles based on the science of human perception: how eyes and brains process images.

I’ll also provide more depth from my experience at CBS, where I worked in high tech control rooms equipped with vast color palettes, chroma key, electronic character generators, and computer-driven, on-screen animation. Most of these capabilities are now readily available in consumer software programs, but as anyone who has seen a recent business presentation can attest, most presenters apply these powerful functions with all the subtlety of an Instagram or TikTok video. Here, too, I’ll provide you with a simple set of principles that informed how we deployed all those sophisticated electronic capabilities at CBS: the cinematic fundamentals of composition, montage, and movement.

To illustrate all these design considerations, you’ll find new examples of my principles in action with some of my clients’ slides. You’ll also find updated best practices about slide animation in the current versions of presentation software from Microsoft PowerPoint, Apple Keynote, and Google Slides; and about the latest in virtual presentation platforms from Zoom, Cisco, Microsoft, RingCentral, and Google.

While all these design techniques are important, your slides exist to *only* support you and your narrative. If you take only one message away from this book, it is the primacy of the story. As I responded to the young entrepreneur in Bangalore:

“It’s still the same old story.”

Show and Tell

Case Studies: Michael Ball, Canexia Health • Bill Gurley, Benchmark

The definition of insanity is doing the same thing over and over again and expecting different results.¹

Misattributed to Albert Einstein

In the more than a decade and a half since the publication of the first edition of *Presenting to Win*, I am proud to say that it has made a significant impact on readers, selling more than 120,000 copies in 12 languages. By the same token, I am surprised to say that it has not had as great an impact on the presentation trade. Despite the many gratifying emails, letters, and telephone calls from around the globe praising the book, and despite the continuing stream of participants in the Suasive programs in which we teach and coach the techniques in the book, I've found that most presenters, after reading the book or taking the program, nevertheless default to the contrary legacy practice of making the slides the primary focus.

My seemingly simple plea for a shift of emphasis has found very few converts. Presentations are still universally defined by and equated with the slide deck. This is standard operating procedure in every sector of business from information technology to life sciences, from finance to manufacturing, from real estate to pharmaceuticals, from media to consumer products, and with every type of presentation from product launches to industry conferences, from board meetings to sales pitches, and, most particularly, from venture investments to IPO roadshows. Nowhere is this focus on the deck more deeply entrenched than in the financial community. Invariably, investors ask presenters to send their decks ahead, to use it during the pitch, and to leave it behind for other investors in the firm. Beleaguered presenters, pressured by the exigencies of business, and eager to save time and effort, oblige the request by using the same deck for both display and distribution.

■ The Twofer ■

This combination of the deck's document function with its slide function is known as a "Twofer," from the tried-and-true marketing tactic "two for the price of one." By combining the two functions, however, each function is diminished. Neither stands alone: the document, in its typical bulleted form, is incomplete; and the display, in its highly detailed form, overwhelms the story—as well as the audience. The Twofer is neither fish nor fowl. A display is *not* a document. A display is for you to *show* while you *tell* during your presentation, and a document is for your audience to *read* before or after your presentation. Otherwise, your visual aids become visual hindrances.

Does this mean that I recommend that you abandon all slides? Not at all. Slideshows have become the medium of choice from grade school rooms to boardrooms, and far be it from me to advise a sea change as radical as complete rejection. Slides serve several valuable roles: as illustrations of information, as reinforcement of messages, and as prompts for the presenter. So by all means, employ them for those functions.

But if you need a document, create a document and use word processing software. If you need a presentation, create a presentation and use presentation software. Microsoft provides Word for documents and PowerPoint for presentations. While both products are bundled in the same suite, they are distinctly separate entities, and *never the twain shall meet*.

All I ask—no, urge—you to do is to use your slides properly, by applying the repertory of design techniques you'll find in the latter third of this book. When you do, you'll see that they all fall under one overarching principle: your slides exist *only* to provide support for you, the presenter. They are secondary to your story.

■ The Primacy of the Story ■

Michael Ball is the CEO of Canexia Health, a startup company that empowers clinical labs to deploy cancer genomic tests in their facilities. Although Michael has had extensive experience of scaling global companies from startup through acquisition and IPO, he decided to leave nothing to chance when he was about to pitch for a B round of financing of \$20 million and engaged me to help him and his senior leadership team to sharpen their presentation.

INTRODUCTION

Having made countless pitches to the financial community, Michael was ready to start our first session by showing me his existing investor presentation deck. I asked him to put aside the slides and focus on his story first. Using the methodology you'll be learning in the following pages, he developed a first draft of his outline in less than two hours. To validate the logic of the story, he delivered the outline to the working group in what was essentially one long sentence—without *any* slides:

We will lead off with the market problem to establish that there is a need for our company and our solution.

And then establish that the size of the market is sufficient to build a big enough company for a large exit for our investors.

Then we move on to the business model which is essentially how we are going to approach this market and win in that market opportunity.

Then onto commercial traction, which is proof that we are executing, and that this is a repeatable model that will build the valuation we're talking about.

And then finally wrap up with a description of both the science and the commercial expertise of the organization to reinforce our potential success.²

At that point, we opened Michael's existing deck and found that, although it began in much the same way as did his new outline, it did not get around to the market potential—the principal interest of every investor—until eight slides in. By starting the story with the market, we made it more relevant to investors, and by starting the process with the story rather than the slides, we made the story more impactful.

■ Presenter Focus ■

The reason for this emphasis on the story—which goes far beyond structural flow to include narrative linkages, added value, and even authoritative language—is that the story is far more important than the slides. No audience will react affirmatively to a presentation based on a deck alone. No decisions are made, no products sold, no partnerships forged, no projects approved, and no ships of

state launched based on a deck. Witness the powerful speeches that move hearts and minds: keynote speeches, eulogies, sermons, state of the union addresses, inaugurals, commencements, and even locker room pep talks—not one of them uses slides.

Therefore, what presenters *say* and how they say it take precedence over what they *show*. This makes the presenter the focus of the presentation, a companion corollary to the primacy of the story.

That is why the lion's share of this book is devoted to helping you tell your story and why I have even separated the delivery of your story—your body language, your eye contact, and your voice—into another book in this trilogy: *The Power Presenter: Techniques, Style, and Strategy to Be Suasive*. I have also further separated an equally important part of *all* presentations, answering your audiences' questions, into the third book in the trilogy, *In the Line of Fire: How to Handle Tough Questions*. I hope you'll read them, too, and when you do, you'll see that they all tie back to the integrity of the story.

Bill Gurley, a general partner at Benchmark, is one Silicon Valley's preeminent venture investors. Among his portfolio companies are eBay, Uber, Snap, Dropbox, Instagram, Yelp, and Zillow. Bill also writes a perceptive blog, *Above the Crowd*, in which he offers sound advice to entrepreneurs about growing a business, including the importance of telling a story:

*Investors are not solely evaluating your company's story. They are also evaluating your ability to convey that story.... You want to walk the listener through an argument as to why this is going to be an amazing business. The goal is to bring the investor to the VC equivalent of Q.E.D.**

Bill's words underscore the core message and value of this book to you, no matter what role or level in business you currently occupy. Perhaps one day you'll go public with a company of your own, and I hope the techniques you'll learn here will help you earn millions of dollars. Before that happens, however, as Bill goes on to say:

...you will need to tell your company's story in high-stakes situations over and over and over again. Because of this, venture capitalists place

* The Latin phrase Q.E.D., or *quod erat demonstrandum*, translates to "what was to be shown," meaning "thus shown or proven."

INTRODUCTION

*huge positive weight on how good you are at this skill. The great storytellers have an unfair competitive advantage.*³

So please deploy the same persuasive techniques you'll find in these pages for those scores of other steppingstones along the way.

This book is about presentations, yes. But it's about much more than that. It's about *communicating*, about *persuading*, about *selling*, about *storytelling*, about getting every audience to respond to your call to action. Q.E.D.

■ Book Conventions ■



Throughout the book, you'll see this icon, which indicates video and audio files referenced as examples. All the video references are listed in Appendix A. To view select videos, please visit our website, Suasive.com.

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Persuasion

Case Studies: David Ogilvy, Ogilvy & Mather • David Mamet • L. Gordon Crovitz, *The Wall Street Journal* • Zig Ziglar • Mortimer Adler • Aristotle • Jean Shepherd • William Shakespeare • Dan Warmenhoven, Network Appliance • Stephen Covey

*When Aeschines spoke, they said, “How well he speaks.”
But when Demosthenes spoke, they said, “Let us march.”¹*

Confessions of an Advertising Man

David Ogilvy

■ Selling ■

David Ogilvy, known among his peers as “The Father of Advertising” for the extraordinary success of his powerhouse Ogilvy & Mather advertising agency, knew a thing or two about selling and always urged his clients to “march.”

Playwright David Mamet understands selling, too. His Pulitzer Prize-winning play *Glengarry Glen Ross*, which has had frequent revivals on Broadway and was turned into a star-studded Hollywood film, has broad appeal because its story—about the cutthroat world of real estate sales—resonates with the public far beyond selling homes. Mamet reinforced that universality by having his main character recite the salesperson’s credo: “ABC. Always be closing.”²

PRESENTING TO WIN

L. Gordon Crovitz, the former publisher of *The Wall Street Journal*, sees sales applicable beyond real estate:

*[W]e all engage in sales of one sort or another. Parents sell the idea of eating vegetables to their children; reporters sell their latest story idea to editors; university presidents sell their institution's neediness to potential donors.*³

Despite the utter simplicity of this lesson, sales training remains a necessary part of business worldwide. Legions of trainers, courses, and courseware, following in the footsteps of Zig Ziglar, the great-granddaddy of sales training, are perpetually occupied offering, as the title of one of Ziglar's 30 bestselling books puts it, *Secrets of Closing the Sale*.⁴

Ogilvy, Mamet, Crovitz, and Ziglar are all echoing Aristotle, whose *Rhetoric* was essentially the first playbook for sales, also known by the more erudite term, "persuasion." Mortimer Adler, who was the chair of the Board of Editors at *Encyclopedia Britannica*, was also a scholar of the classics. In his excellent book *How to Speak How to Listen*, Adler described an invitation for him to speak at the Advertising Clubs of California:

*They asked me in advance for a title. I suggested that it be "Aristotle on Salesmanship."*⁵

Yet, somehow, all this collective wisdom has not gotten through to the fraternal relative of sales, presentations.

Most people in business, including the most successful ones, are too busy doing their jobs to think about telling their stories. They spend their waking hours focused on competitive strategies, product launches, financial analyses, marketing plans, mergers, and acquisitions—the plethora of important business matters that fill your days, too. They live, eat, drink, breathe, and dream their businesses. They see every single one of the trees but not the forest. They rarely take the opportunity, or feel the need, to step back from the details of their daily duties to shape their stories and express them compellingly.

They are guilty of the charge that Don Valentine leveled in the Preface: "The problem is that nobody knows how to tell a story. And the bigger problem is that nobody knows that they don't know how to tell a story!"⁶

That overarching charge breaks down into the Five Cardinal Sins of stories:

■ The Five Cardinal Sins of Stories ■

The best way to identify these problems is with the questions they evoke in the minds of audiences. I know because I often form these questions in my own mind as I sit through countless presentations—and have been doing so ever since my marathon at COMDEX:

1. How often have you sat all the way through a presentation and, at the end, said to yourself, “What’s the point?” Or, as teenagers put it, “...and your point is?”

The sin: No clear point, purpose, or goal.

2. How often have you sat through a presentation and repeatedly said to yourself, “Why should I care?” or “So what?”

The sin: No benefit for or value to the audience.

3. How often have you sat through a presentation and, at some point, said to yourself, “Wait a minute! What does that have to do with the previous point? How did they get there?”

The sin: No clear flow or structure.

4. How often have you sat in on a presentation and said to yourself, “What does that mean?”

The sin: Too technical or detailed.

5. How often in your entire professional career have you ever sat through a presentation that you wished would go on longer?

The sin: Too long.

While presenters commit many other story sins—failed humor, tired clichés, disparaging comments, vulgar language, negative ideas, vague information, or dubious claims—none of them is as common or as frequently committed as the first five. Moreover, none of the others is as central to the structure of the story.

The Five Cardinal Sins in Action

Suppose you and I were chatting, and I suddenly said, “Let me tell you what I had for dinner last night.”

You’d know what my point is—to share with you what I had for dinner—but you’d probably look at me curiously and say, “Why should I care?”

PRESENTING TO WIN

Why on Earth should you care about what I had for dinner last night? Unless you had said, “I’m bored with all the restaurants in the area. Can you recommend a new place you’ve been to recently?”

Then if I were to respond, “Let me tell you what I had for dinner last night,” you’d have a reason to care.

Now, if I were to tell what I had for dinner by starting with the dessert and then go back to the salad, then jump forward to the cheese course, then back to the main course, you’d have difficulty following me. Instead, if I went from soup to nuts, you’d follow easily.

If I were to describe each of the courses in the dinner by using the phylum, class, order, genus, and species of every animal and vegetable product in the dinner, it would be far too technical and too detailed. Instead, if I used only adjectives and nouns, you’d understand.

Finally, if I were to take five hours to describe a meal that took me two hours to eat, you would find it too long. If I did it in two minutes, you’d get a succinct picture.

Although each of these sins is unique and independent, they can all be summarized in one least-common denominator: a data dump—an excessive, complex, meaningless, formless outpouring of data without purpose or plan.

The inevitable reaction of audiences to a data dump is the dreadful effect known as MEGO: My Eyes Glaze Over.

Why would any presenter do that to any audience?

The reason is that most presenters labor under the misconception that, in order for their audiences to understand anything, they have to be told everything.

I was guilty of that misconception when I was just 24 years old. Fresh out of Stanford, I returned to New York and landed a job working with radio personality Jean Shepherd. Shep, who later created the classic holiday film *A Christmas Story*, was the host of a late-night talk show on New York’s WOR radio. His rambling, free-form monologues earned him a cult following. One day, Shep turned to me and, apropos of nothing, said, “If Hollywood decided to do the Jerry Weissman story, do you think they could do it justice?”⁷

My immediate reaction was to scoff and say, “No way, there’s far too much to tell!”

This tell-all tendency is best captured by the tale of the chatterbox who, when asked for the time, tells you how to build a clock. Or, as I once heard a wit describe a garrulous speaker, “I asked him the time, and he told me how to build Switzerland!”

The audiences to these data dumps are hapless victims. But sometimes these victims rebel and interrupt with questions—which serve to throw the story further off track. Those interruptions are made more out of self-protection than rudeness. As Cassius says in *Julius Caesar*,

*The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, but in ourselves.*⁸

The goal of this entire book is to show you how to avoid each of these Five Cardinal Sins, starting with the first: *no clear point*.

■ Point A to Point BSM ■

To reiterate L. Gordon Crovitz, everyone is called upon almost every day to persuade other people in a variety of situations, each posing its own unique challenges and opportunities. In presentations, every presenter's challenge is to move the audience from where they are at the start of the presentation, which is Point A, to the presenter's objective or goal, which is Point B. This dynamic shift is persuasion. Point B is your call to action. That's the point!

Every audience, whether for a formal presentation, keynote, sales pitch, or panel appearance, enters the room at Point A in one of three states:

- **Unknowing.** Completely unaware of you and your business.
Why are we here? Dunno, my boss couldn't make it and asked me to cover.
- **Dubious.** Highly skeptical about you and your business.
Hmm? This company has little traction, and I'm from Missouri: I need to see results. I don't like to take chances.
- **Resistant.** Firmly against you and your business.
*This company is going up against the 800-pound gorilla in their market. They can't possibly win. Let's listen politely and send them on their way.**

To get your audience to Point B, you must move the uninformed audience to understand, the dubious to believe, and the resistant to act. In fact, understand, believe, and act are not three separate goals but three stages in reaching one cumulative, ultimate goal. Your audience will not act as you want them to act if they don't first understand your story and believe your message.

* There is a fourth state, in which the audience is eager to listen to anything you have to say and do your bidding, but that only happens when the audience is your mom.

When I coach presenters to prepare a product launch, we start by identifying their endgame with audiences of prospective customers. Point B is the moment when those customers commit to a pilot trial or a purchase order.

When I coach senior executives for their IPO roadshows, we start with their prospective investors' endgame. Point B is when those investors commit to a ten percent tranche of the total offering, a commitment that can represent tens of millions of dollars.

Point B in Action

Dan Warmenhoven, the CEO of Network Appliance, a data management company now called NetApp, began his IPO roadshow with this opening statement:

What's in a name?⁸ What's an appliance?⁹ A toaster is an appliance. A toaster does one thing and one thing well: It toasts bread.

Managing data on networks is complicated. Until now, data has been managed by devices that multitask; they do many things, not all of them well. Our company makes a product that, like a toaster, does one thing and does it well: It is a dedicated device that manages data on networks. We call that appliance a File Server.

If Dan had stopped right there, his investor audience would have understood what his company did. But Dan went beyond that description to add:

When you consider the explosive growth of data in networks, you can see that our File Servers are positioned to be a vital part of that growth, and Network Appliance is positioned to grow as a company. We invite you to join us in that growth.⁹

That last sentence is Dan's call to action. Notice that he did not ask the investor audience to buy his stock. That would have been presumptuous; after all, their job is to buy stock and their job titles usually include the word "invest." By inviting them to join Network Appliance as it pursues a growing market, Dan led his audience from Point A to Point B.

Point B is the endgame of every presentation, the call to action. As you'll see in the coming chapters, this endpoint is also the starting point in developing your story. When you begin with the destination, the journey is easier to map. This is an age-old concept that Aristotle called *teleology*¹⁰: the study of matters with their end or purpose in mind.

PERSUASION

Today's business consultants advocate the same idea. The second of *The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People*, by author Stephen R. Covey, is "Begin with the End in Mind."¹¹ Aristotle in modern terms.

Few executives study Aristotle these days, but Covey has been read by millions. Nonetheless, this vital concept of starting with the goal has yet to penetrate how presenters think about their stories. That's why it's the first of the Five Cardinal Sins.

If you're a sales professional and you want your customer to make a purchase, ask for the order. If you're a corporate manager and you want the members of your team to support your new initiative, tell them exactly what you want them to do. If you're an ambitious young employee and you want your manager to give you a raise or promotion, ask for it. If you're Demosthenes in ancient Greece and you want to rally your fellow Athenians against the threat of a Macedonian invasion, you say, "Let us march!"

As the old saying goes,

Faint heart ne'er won fair lady.

If you want your audience to respond to your call to action, you have to give them a good reason, and the reason has to be theirs.

In the next chapter, you'll learn just how to define and express that reason.

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The Power of “You”

Case Studies: Karen Hughes, Burson-Marsteller • Aristotle • Jim Bixby, Brooktree • Lise Buyer, Class V Group • Bob Tinker, MobileIron • Cade Collins • The Endodontic Instrument CEO • John Stark, Quantum-Si • Reed Hastings, Netflix

MARILYN IVE POURED MY ♥ OUT NOTHING LEFT LUV WES.¹

Ten Minutes from Normal

Karen Hughes

■ Point of View ■

Karen Hughes, who was the communications advisor for President George W. Bush and is now the worldwide vice chair of the multinational public relations and communications firm Burson-Marsteller, cannot take a vacation from evaluating messages. In her autobiography, she recounted a time she was strolling on a beach and saw a small propeller airplane towing a banner with the plaintive plea in the epigraph above. Then she continued:

I could have given [Wes] some message advice: the banner is clearly some sort of appeal to Marilyn, but the words are about Wes—what he has done, how he feels. He should have made this message about her.²

Hughes’ advice to Wes is spot on. Clearly, he had committed the common relationship felony of being “All about you, Babe!”

Wes' story echoes the tale of the opera diva who receives an adoring fan in her dressing room after a performance. The diva goes on and on about how magnificently she sang her arias, about her dramatic acting, her expressive gestures, and her fabulous costumes. After holding forth for half an hour, the diva turns to the fan and says, "But enough about me, what did *you* think of my performance?"

Karen Hughes' advice to Wes about his inverted focus would also be applicable to salespeople who are perpetually being reminded by their sales managers to sell benefits rather than features. And to presenters who repeatedly dump lengthy laundry lists on their audiences as part of a "Stop me if you see anything you like" torrent.

Hughes' colleagues in journalism are also keenly aware of the importance of the correct point of view. Reporters diligently avoid using "I." If they must validate a detail of a story and they are the only observer, they refer to themselves as "this reporter."³

■ Audience Advocacy ■

In order for an audience to respond favorably to a presenter's call to action, or Point B, the audience needs a reason, and the reason has to be theirs and not that of the presenter.

This simple concept falls under the overarching principle of Audience Advocacy: as a presenter, you must advocate as much for your audience's interests as for your own. Learn all you can about your audience so that you can identify their needs, wants, fears, concerns, and hot buttons. Research who they are and what they know. Ask your colleagues for their input. You can even ask your colleagues to play the role of your prospective audience when you rehearse your presentation.

In coaching sessions with my clients, I play the role of their audience, whether it be potential investors, prospective customers, or would-be partners. In developing my own program material, I take the point of view of my clients. Do the same for every one of your presentations. Shift your thinking to your audience.

As you might expect, Audience Advocacy also has roots in Aristotle, whose term for it was *pathos*, Greek for "emotion":

*...persuasion may come through the hearers when the speech stirs their emotions.*⁴

THE POWER OF “You”

The best way to describe Audience Advocacy is to distinguish between Features and Benefits. A Feature is a fact about you or your company, the products or service you sell, or an idea you’re advocating. A Benefit is how that fact will help your audience. Remember that the second of the Five Cardinal Sins is lack of a benefit for the audience.

In presenting to potential investors, a CEO may go on and on about the features of the company’s leading product and then conclude, “We’ve built a better mousetrap.” But investors care more about the size of the market than they do the quality of the mousetrap. The CEO must go beyond the mousetrap and state the benefit to investors: “...and the world is beating a path to our doorstep.”

When you seek to persuade, you must translate every Feature into a Benefit.

■ What's In It For You ■

To identify the correct benefits, pose the rhetorical question “What’s in it for *you*?”—a variation of the common axiom “What’s in it for me?” The shift in the ultimate word to “you” is deliberate. “You” identifies the correct recipient of the benefit, shifting the focus from you to your audience.

Marilyn, not Wes.

If you search the web for “persuasive words,” you’ll find millions of results. Many of them refer to a Yale University study that ranked the 12 most persuasive words in the English language. “You” leads the list. The study has never been substantiated by Yale but, like so many other urban myths on the internet, this one has taken on a life of its own.

“What’s in it for *you*?” is also expressed by its acronym, WIIFY[®], pronounced “whiffy.”

WIIFY Prompts

In my coaching sessions, when I hear presenters make a statement or provide a detail without a clear audience benefit, I interrupt and ask them to start the following sentence:

This is important to you because...

PRESENTING TO WIN

And then to finish it with a WIIFY. Or I ask them to pose the following rhetorical question:

What does this mean to you?

And answer it with a WIIFY. Or to pose this rhetorical question:

Why am I telling you this?

And answer it with a WIIFY. Or this rhetorical question:

Why should you care?

And answer it with a WIIFY. Sometimes, after I've interrupted several times, I simply say:

And...?

In each case, my prompt produces a WIIFY and, more often than not, a sly smile.

WIIFY Examples

When a CEO delivers an IPO roadshow for potential investors, one WIIFY could be:

Our unique operating efficiencies produce attractive margins.

When a corporate headhunter makes a job offer to a sought-after young recruit, one WIIFY could be:

Our company offers great pay, fascinating challenges, and many opportunities for advancement.

When a partner in a marketing consulting firm makes a new business proposal to the CMO of a prospective new client, one WIIFY could be:

Our expertise can help implement your promotional plans and increase your market share.

WIIFY in Action

When Jim Bixby was the CEO of Brooktree—a company that made and sold custom-designed integrated circuits (ICs) used by electronics manufacturers—he

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engaged my services to help prepare the company's IPO roadshow. In one of our rehearsal sessions, I played the role of a money manager at Fidelity. During the product portion of his presentation, Jim held up a large, thick, bound manual, looked at me, and said, "This is our product catalog. No other company in the industry has as many custom ICs in its catalog as we do in ours."

Jim set down the catalog and was about to move on to the next topic when I raised my hand and used one of the WIIFY prompts above, "Why should I care about the size of your catalog?"

Jim smiled, held up the catalog again, and replied, "With this depth of product, we protect our revenue stream against cyclical variations."⁵

The first benefit, the largest catalog, was a customer benefit. Customers want selection, investors want protection. "Protect our revenue stream" is an investor benefit.

Customize every WIIFY for every audience.

No one knows what investors want more than Lise Buyer who, with her partner Leslie Pfrang, are the principals of Class V Group. After successful individual careers spanning institutional investing, investment banking, venture capital, IPO project management, securities law, and accounting at such large firms as Deutsche Bank, T. Rowe Price, Credit Suisse, and Google, the two women decided to join forces and start their own firm. Class V Group was born with the exclusive focus on the IPO market, to advise companies on how to navigate the complex process of going public, from hiring the right bankers, to crafting the S-1, to meeting the right investors at the right time with the right story.

Those last three words are where our paths crossed. I've had the pleasure and privilege of working with Lise and Leslie to help companies make the transition from pitching customers to pitching investors.

On one such occasion in Silicon Valley, Lise and I were working with the CEO and CFO of a technology software company to develop their IPO roadshow. As she had many times before, Lise heard me prompt the CEO in much the same way I prompted Jim Bixby, to identify the WIIFYS of his potential investor audience. With little hesitation, the CEO quickly identified the two essential WIIFYS for all investors: a return on their investment (ROI) and at low risk. The classic risk/reward ratio. In more primal terms, fear and greed. WIIFYS must allay the fear of risk and stimulate the potential of the return.

Then I asked the team if they had any more WIIFYS. The CFO said, "Synergy!" and then she continued, "Investors usually hold shares of many different

companies in their portfolio. Some of those portfolio companies may be our customers or partners. Our success could bring success for their portfolio companies.”

“Super WIIFY!” I said. “Any more?”

Together the CEO and CFO fired off others: “large and growing market,” “high margins,” “low cost of operations,” “recurring revenues”...

“Those are all great,” I said. “They’re all variations of risk/reward. Any others?”

The two executives had run dry. They searched their minds in silence.

Lise could no longer be still. With a sly smile, she said drolly, “If those investors were early advocates, they get to talk about it over a high-end Pinot at the Village Pub!”⁶

The Village Pub is the popular watering hole for VCs and investment bankers in Silicon Valley. Lise’s extra WIIFY was the undeniable guilty pleasure of bragging rights.

I also told the Brooktree story to Bob Tinker. At the time, Bob was the CEO of MobileIron, a fast-growing startup that provided security and management for mobile phones. We were working together to develop MobileIron’s IPO roadshow. In the years of building his company from scratch, Bob had made countless pitches to customers about customer benefits and the importance of mobility. In the sessions with me, he recognized that he had understood the WIIFY for his customer audience, but as it is for a lot of founders, it was almost subconscious.

Now, getting ready for the IPO roadshow, Bob seized on the WIIFY construct. He realized that he needed to consciously create a WIIFY for a new audience for him—the public market investors. “The WIIFY created a major mindset change for me,” he said. “A little piece of my brain is now sitting in the audience’s chairs, constantly evaluating me, what I’m saying, and the content. Is it useful for them? Is it impactful to them? Is it worth their time?”

The value of WIIFYS stayed with Bob when, several years after MobileIron went public, he was invited to speak as part of the prestigious Entrepreneurial Thought Leaders (ETL) series at Stanford University. “Turned out that preparing for the ETL talk, for me, was more stressful than preparing for our IPO roadshow,” Bob revealed. “I was used to speaking about our market, our business, our product. The talk was about my journey, my learnings, and my mistakes. It was way more personal. How to be interesting? And not sound preachy? I was struggling.”

Bob said that the WIIFY was his breakthrough for the ETL talk. It dawned on him that, a decade before, he had been that young entrepreneur sitting in the

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audience. “Realizing that helped me frame the WIIFY,” Bob recounted. “Being a first-time entrepreneur is scary. I didn’t know what I didn’t know. I remembered that feeling. If I could go back in time to that first day as a first-time CEO, what would I tell myself?” Bob’s WIIFY became “Letter to Myself: 5 Things” (see Figure 2.1).

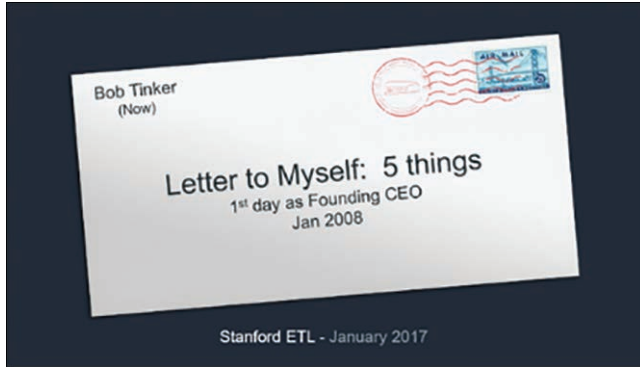


Figure 2.1 Bob Tinker’s Presentation to the Stanford University ETL

Bob continued, “The WIIFY was more than just the idea. It became the construct for the entire talk. It created meaning. It became the filter for what would be useful for the audience. And it naturally became much more personal for me and for the audience”⁷ (see Figure 2.2).

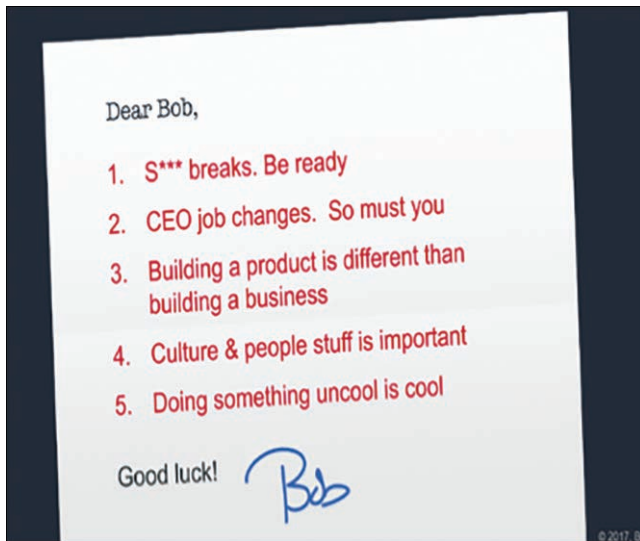


Figure 2.2 Bob Tinker’s Presentation to the Stanford University ETL

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Bob's letter to himself was a business variation of a tradition among modern U.S. presidents: to leave a letter for the incoming commander in chief on Inauguration Day.⁸

As a result of Bob's one good turn for the students, Bob became the beneficiary of another good turn, a WIIFY, for himself: He expanded the content of his talk into two successful books, *Survival to Thrival: Building the Enterprise Startup* and *Change or Be Changed*.

WIIFYs work for people of all ages.

14-year-old Cade Collins of Maryville, Tennessee, wanted a black Labrador puppy his relatives had offered him, but he knew that his mom and dad would be resistant. Cade decided to try to persuade them with a slide presentation. A *New York Times* article about kids who deliver presentations to their parents described Cade's pitch, complete with the boy's unique spelling and impressive WIIFY:

I've heard it from you mom, "We would but there is just too much stress with moving houses." Well, boy do I have an answer for you. Studies have shown that when petting a dog your body releases a number of "feel good" hormones, such as serotonin, prolactin and oxytocin. There for releasing stress."

The article concluded:

*"What did Mr. and Ms. Collins say? What do you think?"*⁹

Whether your audience is composed of parents, students, investors, customers, partners, or managers, do as Bob Tinker did: sit in *their* chairs, think as *they* think, and give them WIIFYs.

You may say, as many of my clients do, "Isn't the benefit obvious? Won't my audiences get it themselves?" Yes, they may, but why take a chance? Connect the dots for them, give them a reason to move from Point A to Point B. That's Aristotle's *pathos*, and that's what produces persuasion.

There's an old adage: "You can never be too thin or too rich." I amend that with: "...or offer too many WIIFYs."

■ Quantify the “You” ■

A participant (let’s call him Mark) in one of our programs was the CEO of a company that manufactured instruments for endodontic procedures. Mark’s prior experience had been as a top salesperson for another dental instrument company. Now, as a CEO, Mark was preparing to take his new company public. I coached him through a rehearsal of his IPO roadshow as I usually do, by assuming the role of an influential fund manager at Fidelity.

Mark articulated the strengths of his company effectively, focusing on the high quality of their products. As an example, he described the features of his company’s newest endodontic instrument. Mark held up the actual device, looked at me, and said, “With this instrument, you can do better root canals, more quickly and with less pain.”

I held up my hand to stop Mark. “I don’t do root canals!”

“Hmm,” he said, smiling. He thought for a moment, then held up the instrument again and said, “So you can see that the tens of thousands of endodontists across this country and thousands more around the world who want to do better root canals will have to buy this superior instrument from us!”

Mark quantified the “you.”

Another life sciences firm named—appropriately for our purposes—Quantum-Si, quantified the “you” exponentially. The company, which offers Next Generation Protein Sequencing (NGS) that makes diagnostics digital, sells their initial product to tens of thousands of commercial diagnostic laboratories around the world. In their IPO roadshow, CEO John Stark described Atto, a home version of their technology that they intend to sell to *billions* of consumers around the world.

Consumer volume is the perfect force multiplier to quantify the “you.”

Reed Hastings, the founder and CEO of Netflix, now the successful content platform and production company, took the company public in the spring of 2002. I had worked with Reed in 1996, when he headed another company, called Pure/Atria Software. When Reed emailed me the draft of the Netflix roadshow deck, one of the first slides described the company’s original business as an online DVD subscription company (see Figure 2.3).

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Rent All the DVDs You Want for \$20/Month



- ☐ No Due Dates
- ☐ 600,000 Subscribers
- ☐ Unlimited DVD Access
- ☐ No Late Fees
- ☐ Every DVD Made
- ☐ US Postal Delivery

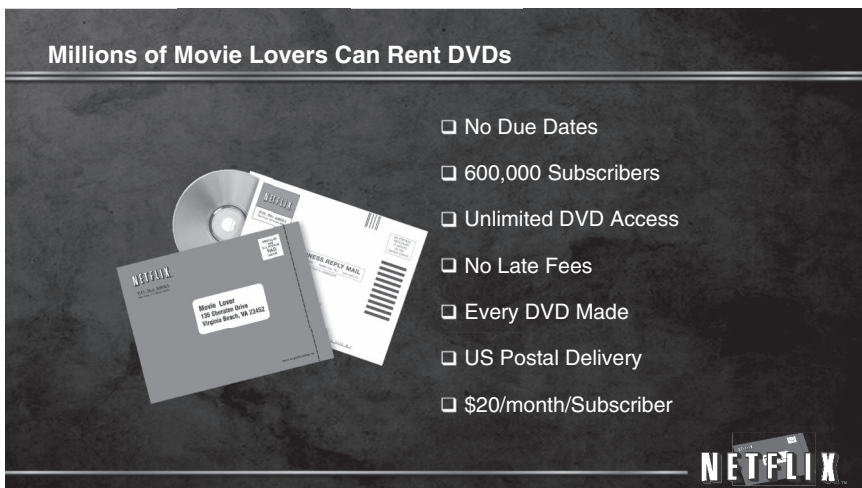


Figure 2.3 *Netflix IPO Roadshow Slide*

When Reed arrived for our coaching session, I assumed my usual role as a potential investor in Netflix's stock offering. I said, "Reed, this presentation makes me really eager to sign up and become a loyal subscriber of Netflix, but you didn't come here today to get me to subscribe. I can sign up online. Treat me as an investor."

Reed smiled and said, "What do you suggest?"

"I suggest that you quantify the 'you,'" and revised Reed's slide as Figure 2.4.



Millions of Movie Lovers Can Rent DVDs



- ☐ No Due Dates
- ☐ 600,000 Subscribers
- ☐ Unlimited DVD Access
- ☐ No Late Fees
- ☐ Every DVD Made
- ☐ US Postal Delivery
- ☐ \$20/month/Subscriber



Figure 2.4 *Revised Netflix IPO Roadshow Slide*

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Suddenly, the entire frame of reference changed from the attractiveness of Netflix’s consumer offering to how large the market opportunity was—a much more important consideration for Reed’s potential investor audience.

Reed smiled broadly and said, “How about tens of millions of movie lovers?”¹⁰

“Great!” I concurred. “How about, ‘tens of millions—in the U.S. alone?’”

Reed accepted the revision, polished his presentation, and then left to begin the roadshow. One month later, when Netflix went public, the company offered 5.5 million shares for sale. They received orders for 50 million shares: oversubscribed by nearly 10 times. Today, Netflix has moved far beyond DVDs and has become a major producer and distributor of films and television series.

■ The “You” Rule ■

“You” can exert its innate power all the way from the high-stakes of an IPO roadshow to mundane email. I apply the “You” rule to everything I write: books, articles, blogs, and even emails and texts. Before dispatching any written communication, I make one final review to see where I can insert additional instances of “you.”

For example, if I meet someone at a business function, I might write a follow-up email as follows:

It was great to meet at the conference. I look forward to working together in the future.

With the “You” rule applied, it would read:

It was great meeting you at the conference. I look forward to working with you in the future.

Try the “You” rule yourself. It will personalize the tone and heighten the impact of any presentation, blog, memo, report, document, or email you write.

In this chapter alone, “you” and its variations appear more than 70 times.

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The Art of Telling Your Story

Case Studies: Federico Fellini • Daniel Kahneman • Robin Williams • T-Mobile Quarterly Earnings Call • Microsoft Quarterly Earnings Call • Sand Hill Road Shuttle • The Writing Center, University of North Carolina • John McPhee • Chuck Geschke, Adobe Systems • Marcus Tullius Cicero • Philippe Kahn, Fullpower-AI

I should find it false and dangerous to start from some clear, well-defined complete idea and then put it into practice....I can find the resources I need only when I am plunged into obscurity....The child is in darkness at the moment he is formed in the mother's womb.¹

Federico Fellini

■ Creativity ■

The creative process described above by Federico Fellini, the legendary Italian cinema director of such classic films as *La Dolce Vita*, *8½*, and *Roma*, is the antithesis of the process used to create presentations. Businesspeople, who are under the constant pressure of deadlines and workload, default to the legacy practice of taking a set of slides that are begged, borrowed, stolen, mandated by the company's marketing department, or designed by an outsourced third party and then shuffling them into a slide-to-slide sequence. The result is a presentation that essentially restarts with every slide. Audiences to this non-story find it hard to follow and inevitably interrupt the presenter—or worse, stop listening.

This failure to communicate occurs because the presenter has used a process contrary to the natural functioning of the human mind.

In earlier editions of this book, I described those natural processes as left- and right-brain thinking, but in the interval, I read a powerful new book that describes those processes in different terms that add more depth to the creative process. As a result, I have incorporated those new concepts into my story development techniques to help you create your story even more effectively.

■ Thinking, Fast and Slow ■

In 2011, Nobel Prize winner Daniel Kahneman wrote the bestselling *Thinking, Fast and Slow*,² in which he eloquently described how the human mind functions in two innately distinct phases. Let me briefly summarize the main concepts underlying Professor Kahneman's phases as they relate to my methodology:

- Fast Thinking is the mind's automatic response to a new task: *I have to deliver a presentation!* That response brings with it a flood of thoughts and ideas, all of them tumbling around in the mind randomly. Slow Thinking involves deliberation and reasoning: *I'll start with X and then move on to Y*—sequencing.
- Fast Thinking is a close cousin to the functions of the right hemisphere of the brain, the intuitive side, which controls nonlinear *random* ideas that come with preconceived notions, biases, and tangential associations. Slow Thinking relates to the linear functions of the left hemisphere, the analytical side, which controls *logical* functions such as structure, form, sequence, ranking, and order.

Improvisational comedy is a perfect example of Fast Thinking. The late comedian and actor Robin Williams was a master at what one critic called:

[A] pell-mell process of associative thinking, a process so playful, fluid and free...the free associations, the intuitive leaps can still leave audiences breathless. When writers describe his comedy, they usually fall back on such metaphors as synaptic storms, jazz riffs and computers, though computers are stumblebums when it comes to [his] intuitive leaps.”³

Williams' rare talent was to create crackling humor out of randomness, but every other human's mind makes those identical intuitive—and abstract—leaps.

Fast Thinking Exercise

To demonstrate the randomness of Fast Thinking, try this brief exercise. Select an inanimate object nearby: a coffee cup, a pen, a water bottle, a box of tissues. (Your mobile phone is *not* inanimate!) Fix your eyes on that object and stare at it silently for about 15 or 20 seconds.

What went through your mind? Most likely a set of quite disparate thoughts. Most of the participants in our programs have told us that their minds ranged far and wide, from the design of the object, to the function of the object, to where they bought it, to how they used it and, sometimes, to a thought that is completely unrelated to the object.

That's random thinking—and it is precisely what your mind does when you are tasked with coming up with a presentation:

How long do I have? Where will I find the time to get it done? I have a new client meeting the same day! And I have to submit my strategic plan the same week! Where can I get the latest data? Can I get marketing to help me with new slides?

Most presenters, in their rush to get the job done, jump directly to the shuffle-the-deck approach, trying to find a sequence, but they ignore the cascade of random ideas that are bubbling up in their minds in no particular order, overwhelming any sense of story.

A vivid illustration of the difference between Fast and Slow Thinking is in spoken language. Speech is spontaneous and proceeds with frequent leaps of logic, following no grammatical or syntactical rules. Read the transcription of any interview or testimony, and you'll see that the text is filled with ellipses and filler words such as “um,” “yeah,” and “you know.” Mind you, this has nothing whatsoever to do with a speaker's education, experience, intelligence, or ability to articulate, it's just the mind doing what it does naturally: Fast Thinking.

Fast Thinking in Action

Investment bank analysts are exceptionally capable people. Their jobs require them to become expert in a particular business sector and to make decisions that could impact millions of dollars of market value. They spend endless hours becoming familiar with the most minute details of an industry and its players. And they must have those details at the tips of their tongues at the high-pressure moment when they get to ask questions of a company's chief executives during

a public company's quarterly earnings calls. At one such event by T-Mobile, here's how one analyst posed a question:

It looks like the guidance for EBITDA at the midpoint gets you to about 4% growth for the year and I think that's versus about 8% of what we saw in '19. Is that just some conservatism built in or is there some extra costs built in for the super-cycle maybe that Mike [Sievert, President and Chief Operating Officer of T-Mobile] referenced in the call, and maybe, if so, what that might look like? And then similarly on the capex side, it looks like the network capex is being guided for down slightly on a year-over-year basis. It is our sort of belief that on a stand-alone basis, you guys would need to ramp up the expenditures on small cells and additional capacity. So I was just wondering if that number is the number on a stand-alone basis going forward or something else, that'd be great? Thanks.⁴

During a Microsoft quarterly earnings call, an analyst asked CEO Satya Nadella a question this way:

Satya, a question for you. You did a really great job of talking to how well the expanded portfolio, really broad portfolio that Microsoft brings to the market has helped customers during a crisis period and a period that engendered a lot of change within the way organizations were operating. Can you talk to us a little bit about how much of that's sort of assistance and how much of that you were able to actually take to revenues, if you will? How much of that is stuff that you could actually monetize today versus given the customer relationships, given the focus on the long term, you have to sort of let play out over time and it's about kind of expanding usage and expanding the relationships with customers that you expect to pay out over a longer period?⁵

The tendency to ramble is so prevalent, transcription software programs and services provide a feature that allows end users to add clarifying comments, mark unclear words, and remove filler words.⁶

By contrast, written language is governed by Slow Thinking. When people start to write a letter, memo, or report, their minds are front-loaded with logic, grammar, spelling, and punctuation. Rather than bouncing freely from one idea to the next, writers move methodically through a sequence of points, meticulously self-correcting their syntax, spelling, and logic as they go.

You've probably written this way yourself: sitting down cold at your keyboard to type an email, memo, or letter and "editing" it for style and content on-the-fly. Upon rereading the text, however, you likely discovered that you forgot to include an important word, fact, or idea or may have included an irrelevant detail.

If you start to develop your presentation with Slow Thinking considerations such as logic, sequence, and word choice (or, for that matter, the color, style, font, and design of your slides) while your Fast Thinking is churning out those random ideas, the whole process descends into disarray.

The key then is to allow the Fast Thinking to run its course *before* attempting to impose a sequence with Slow Thinking.

To reinforce that separation, start with Fast Thinking and use the guidelines, exercises, and examples below. Only when you have captured the full rush of ideas should you move on to Slow Thinking and apply logic. As the constant guide for your creative process, always separate the two functions.

■ FrameForm: Establish the Context ■

As you start to develop your presentation, do you want to be thinking about that other appointment you have on the day of your presentation? Or about the strategic plan due the same week? Those thoughts may be bouncing around in your mind, but they are only peripherally related to this presentation.

The first step, then, is to focus on this presentation and only this presentation. Frame your task. Define the playing field. Every sport sets the boundaries for its arena. The same initial step is necessary for your story. Without those boundaries, the tendency is to throw everything into the mix, creating a confusing jumble.

Start by considering your story as a blank frame, just as painters start with an empty canvas. *Tabula rasa*, a clean slate.

Then establish the context of your presentation by defining the outer parameters. On the left side of the frame is what you want to accomplish in your presentation, your goal, your Point B. On the right side is your analysis of your target audience: who they are, what they know, what they need to know, and, most important of all, their benefits, their WIIFYs. Capture this fundamental information on the Suasive FrameForm in Figure 3.1.

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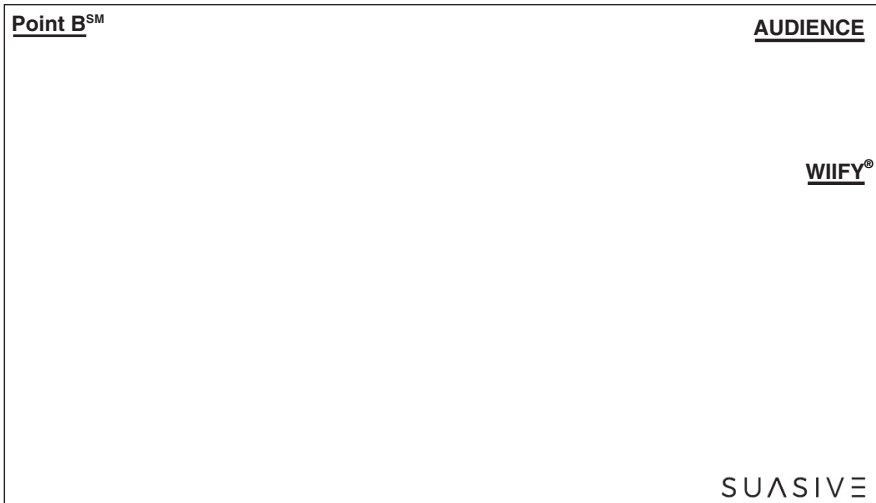


Figure 3.1 *Suasive FrameForm (available for download from www.suasive.com)*

Define all these essential factors clearly and specifically. Build every presentation for *one* audience, on *one* occasion, presented by *one* set of presenters, conveying *one* story, with *one* purpose.

Among my most frequent clients are startup companies seeking to develop financing pitches. Most of them are planning to present to as many VC firms as they can; and most of those firms are concentrated in the sleek office compounds that line Sand Hill Road in Menlo Park. Seeking the pot of gold at the end of the rainbow, the startups either climb aboard the Sand Hill Shuttle or seek to pitch the VCs in a virtual meeting.

I begin every coaching session by asking participants to identify the specific venture firm they want to pitch. Invariably, the answer is “All of them.”

To which I respond, “Do you intend to present to Sequoia?”

If the answer is “Yes,” I ask, “Is Sequoia an investor in your first round?”

If the answer is “Yes,” I ask, “Do you intend to present to Greylock?”

If the answer is “Yes,” I ask, “Is Greylock an investor in your first round?”

If the answer is “No,” then I say, “You cannot deliver the same presentation to Sequoia and Greylock.”

Does that mean that you must begin every presentation from scratch? Not at all. You may re-purpose much of the content, but you must customize each presentation for each audience. After you’ve used this process to create one

presentation, the second time and all subsequent times will be much shorter. In the more than 30 years I've been in business, the process has never taken me more than a couple of hours the first time. The process works for the most complex biotech technology concept as well as the simplest retail story. By the second time, the process takes around 15 minutes, and even less each time thereafter.

Eventually, you'll be able to click and drag parts of one presentation into another. The key is to develop each presentation by starting with the basic concepts in the FrameForm.

The FrameForm dispels the pervasive business myth of the one-size-fits-all presentation or corporate pitch. Every presentation must be unique for every audience.

Once you have established the context and focus, you're ready to begin developing the supporting content. That is the time to capture and manage that surging flood of Fast Thinking ideas, and that is where we turn to Brainstorming.

■ Brainstorming: Capture Your Ideas ■

Brainstorming is an important part of the curricula at many colleges. The Writing Center at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill calls Brainstorming "Freewriting" and advises students to begin with an open mind:

Allow yourself to start with chaos.

The chaos is the obscurity that Fellini described as the start of his creative process. Let it be the start of yours. Moving forward from the chaos, the UNC program recommends:

Let your thoughts flow as they will, putting pen to paper and writing down whatever comes into your mind. You don't judge the quality of what you write, and you don't worry about style or any surface-level issues, like spelling, grammar, or punctuation.'

Here's how to implement Brainstorming for your story.

You can start your Brainstorming by "putting pen to paper," as the UNC program recommends. Or you can write your ideas on sticky notes, a legal pad, a whiteboard, or a state-of-the-art digital whiteboard. You can also scribe your ideas on a computer—but be sure to use one of the wide array of Brainstorming software programs available rather than word processing. The latter invites

stacking, which is counterproductive (for reasons you'll see in a moment). In my pre-digital and pre-sticky note days at CBS, we wrote our ideas on 3×5 index cards and mounted them on a corkboard wall with pushpins.

Capture your thoughts as concepts in words, rather than images—and certainly not as slides. If you think about slides, you will front-load your mind with style factors—color, size, and position—and stop thinking about the more substantive factor of ideas. The purpose of this part of the process is to get your random, free-flowing, Fast Thinking ideas out of your mind and onto an external surface where you can see them in an objective, panoramic perspective.

Brainstorming your ideas is similar to how artists sample their colors on a palette before applying them to the canvas.

The Brainstorming process involves five guidelines.

Five Brainstorming Guidelines

1. Don't Stack

Most people tend to start their Brainstorming sessions by writing words on a whiteboard in a vertical stack, bullet-style, complete with a ladder of dashes. But that seemingly innocuous step creates priorities: “Is this in ascending order or descending order?” Stacking is a Slow Thinking approach that arrests the free flow of Fast Thinking ideas.

To avoid stacking, write one idea on the left or right side of the FrameForm and the next on the opposite side of the blank space. In my coaching sessions, when I see participants scribing words in a stack, I ask them to disperse their ideas across the FrameForm. As soon as they do, the free flow resumes and, often, new ideas start to emerge.

You'll note that the FrameForm is in landscape view—intentionally. Human minds find wide angles more pleasing for a basic reason: our eyes are set side-by-side in our heads. Hollywood realized this simple factor in the 1950s and introduced CinemaScope, Cinerama, and other widescreen formats to replace the box-like shape of earlier screens.⁸ In Brainstorming, the portrait view leads to stacking, while the landscape view facilitates the free flow of ideas.

2. Don't Rank

Ranking imposes a hierarchical order. But a “first this, then that...” or “that should go up front” or “this should go at the end” approach is linear sequencing,

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another Slow Thinking function. When those random, nonlinear Fast Thinking ideas continue to pop up, they clash with the Slow Thinking and produce gridlock.

Multitasking usually produces multiple mediocre tasks.

3. Scribe Only Two- to Three-Word Phrases

If you write sentences, your mind becomes front-loaded with spelling, punctuation, and grammar—all Slow Thinking functions. Scribe short phrases and confine them further within small circles as idea bubbles. Write all your random ideas in the center of your FrameForm, as in Figure 3.2.

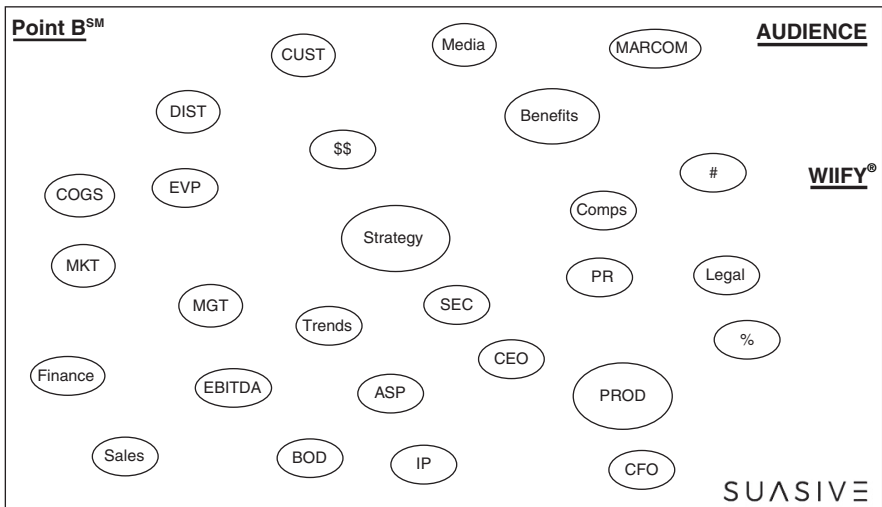


Figure 3.2 *Suasive FrameForm with Brainstormed Ideas*

4. Don't Wordsmith

If you stop to think about the proper word—even in the short phrases—you'll impede the free flow of new ideas. You can do your fine-tuning later. If your mind begins to hitch on a word choice, quickly add two or three close synonyms and resume capturing new ideas. Keep the ideas flowing.

5. Don't Censor

There are no bad ideas in Brainstorming. Even if an idea feels tangential or trivial, capture it. Assess its relevance later. You don't want to discover that you've

thrown out the baby with the bathwater. Just as with stacking and ranking, if you stop to assess ideas, you are using logic and that will inhibit the free flow. During Brainstorming, consider all ideas as candidates, not finalists.

Most professional writers—be they novelists, journalists, playwrights, technical writers, or historians—follow this free-form process. None of them will write a single page of text until they’ve done their research, brooded over their topic, and assembled a mass of notes about it.

John McPhee, who is a Pulitzer Prize-winning author of 30 books and a professor of journalism at Princeton University, fully understands the process. In *Draft No. 4*, his book on the craft of writing, McPhee described the culmination of eight months he spent developing an article for the *New Yorker* magazine:

*I had read all the books I was going to read, and scientific papers, and a doctoral dissertation. I had assembled enough material to fill a silo, and now I had no idea what to do with it.*⁹

Ironically, businesspeople willingly engage in free-form out-of-the-box thinking for strategic planning, product development, or problem-solving sessions, but they are reluctant to use the same process when it comes to creating a presentation or, for that matter, writing a report, speech, or memo. Their daily results-driven behavior impels them to get to the endpoint as quickly as possible. Seeking the shortest distance between two points, they ignore the thundering herd of Fast Thinking ideas the mind is generating at a furious rate. Capture them in your Brainstorm.

Perhaps the biggest benefit of Brainstorming is that it provides a panoramic view of your story. Think of how you lay out all the parts of a new item of Ikea furniture before assembling them; or how a chef lays out all the ingredients, utensils, pots, and pans before cooking a meal. A chef does not want to start cooking and suddenly realize that the saltshaker is empty. Laying out the raw materials of your story *before* organizing them assures that you have all the necessary ingredients.

Brainstorming in Action

During my early days in Silicon Valley, another of Ben Rosen’s introductions led to an assignment at Adobe, the famed software company. The company was about to introduce its Acrobat product, and I had the opportunity to help develop the launch pitch with the senior management team that included its founding chair

and CEO, John Warnock, and his co-founding partner and president, Chuck Geschke.

As always, we started with a blank slate. I stepped up to a large whiteboard in the executive conference room at Adobe's then-brand-new corporate headquarters in Mountain View and started drawing information from the group. As they called out their replies, I scribed them on the whiteboard. We began with Point B, continued to the audience and their WIIFYs, and then moved on to Brainstorming. As the team continued to call out their ideas, I raced to capture them on the whiteboard: the rollout schedule, distribution plan, partners, the market, the Acrobat product benefits, and many more ideas. Before long, I had the whiteboard filled to the edges with idea bubbles.

When the calling out started to slow down, I looked around the room and said, "Please take a moment and look at all the ideas on the whiteboard. Tell me whether we need to add anything, whether we need to change anything, or to consider shifting things around."

After a thoughtful silence, suddenly there was a sharp *thwack!* Chuck Geschke had slapped his palm against his forehead. He broke into a sheepish grin and said, "We've left out what Acrobat does!"¹⁰

Once the Brainstorming, the Fast Thinking, has run its course, you are ready to move on to Slow Thinking and organize your ideas—the point at which most results-driven businesspeople want to begin the process.

■ Distillation: Define Your Key Ideas ■

The first organizing step is to look at the many ideas in the raw data you captured and find relationships. Here, too, the University of North Carolina writing program teaches how to proceed with this step:

*After the chaos subsides, you will be able to create some order out of it...go back to link the words together into a sort of "map" or "web" that forms groups from the separate parts.*¹¹

As you make those links among the mass of disparate ideas, they begin to form a spider web of connections. Then, as the ideas continue to aggregate, they distill into groups or clusters.

There are four guidelines to distill your story.

Four Distillation Guidelines

1. Select an Initial High-Level Idea

Look at all the ideas in your Brainstorm and pick one high-level idea that you consider essential for your audience to know. Ultimately, your story, like most stories, will have anywhere from two to six high-level ideas (maximum of six; more than that is difficult for both the presenter and the audience). Start the process with one high-level idea.

2. Find Related Ideas

With the one high-level idea in mind, think about ideas that relate to it. For example, if your initial idea is “Strategy,” the related ideas could be “what are we trying to achieve?” and “how will we implement?” and “who will be in charge?” and “when do we want to implement?”—as in Figure 3.3.

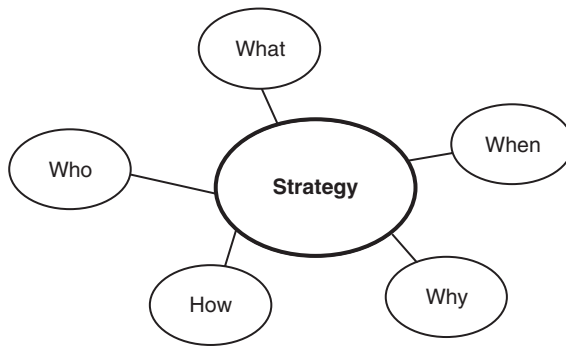


Figure 3.3 *Strategy and Related Ideas*

The related ideas may be among the free-floating ideas you captured in the FrameForm or brand-new ideas.

3. Make It Vital to the Audience

As you choose each of the related ideas, think about your audience. Is it important for them to know this information? Or is it all about you?

4. Support Point B/WIIFY

Apply a high-level filter: as the ideas emerge, think about whether each of them supports your Point B and/or provides a WIIFY for your audience. As you scribe

THE ART OF TELLING YOUR STORY

the related ideas around the high-level idea, draw connecting lines between them, as in Figure 3.4.

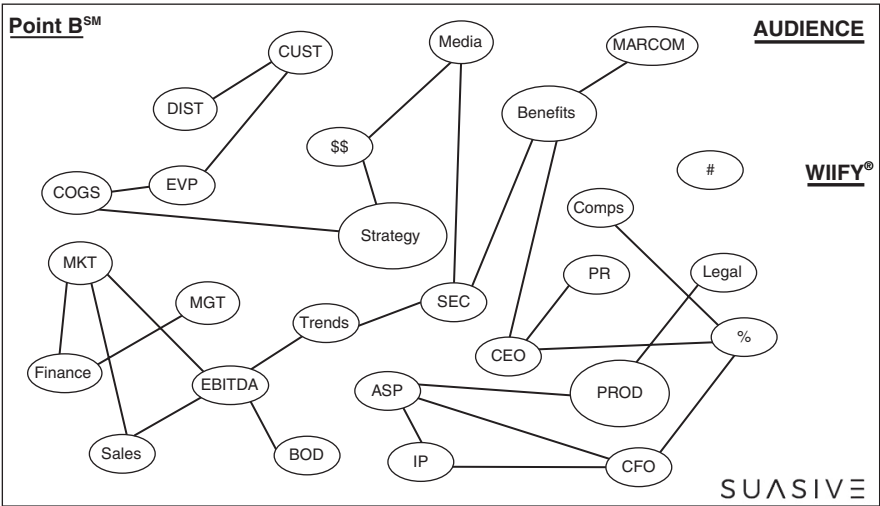


Figure 3.4 *Suasive FrameForm Brainstorm with Connections*

At first, all those connections will look like a spider web or a bowl of spaghetti, but as you continue, you'll find that they distill into clusters of ideas around central themes, as in Figure 3.5.

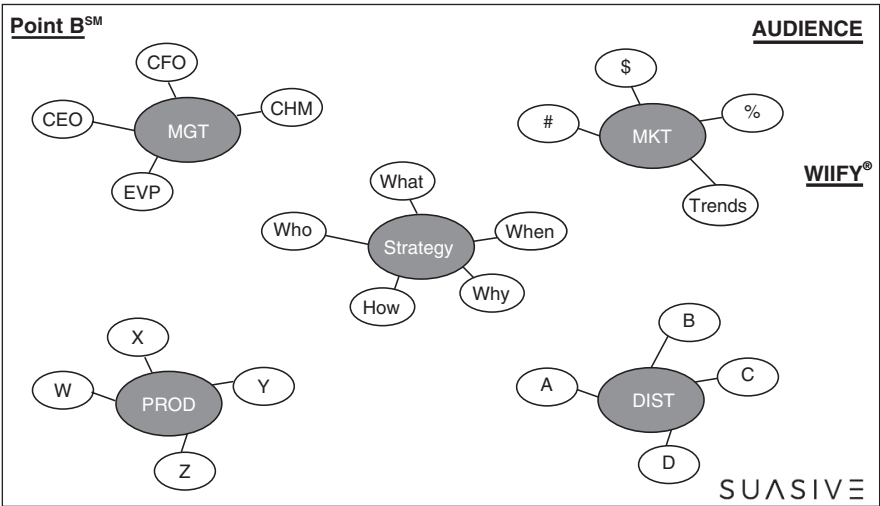


Figure 3.5 *Suasive FrameForm with Clusters*

The clusters are also called “parents and children,” “buckets,” “pillars,” “themes,” or “Roman Columns.”

Roman Columns: Distillation Points

If you visit Rome today and tour the ruins of the great Forum, your guide is likely to describe the glory days of the Roman Empire, around 100 B.C.E.. Your guide is also likely to reference Marcus Tullius Cicero, the famous Roman senator and orator, and his colleagues, all of whom spoke there for hours on end without any notes—because paper had yet to be invented. To help them remember what to say, the orators used the marble columns of the Forum as memory prompts. As they strode around delivering their rhetoric, they would stop at individual columns to discourse on their themes. Each column represented the focal point for a group of subordinate or related ideas. (See Figure 3.6.)

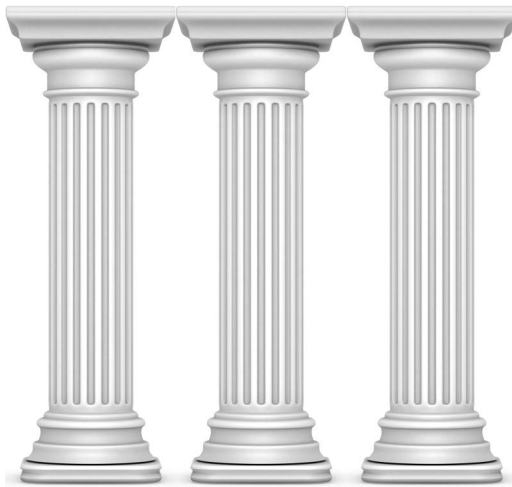


Figure 3.6 *Roman Columns*

Today, the Roman Column legend has morphed into the widely popular “Roman Room Method,” with books, courses, and videos that instruct how to enhance memory by associating ideas with physical objects.¹²

In no way am I suggesting that you memorize your story. Just the opposite: *never* memorize. If you miss one word, you will become stressed, and the rest of your words will go up in smoke. Consider the Roman Columns as distillation points to simplify and clarify your story.

Distillation in Action

Philippe Kahn, now founder and CEO of Fullpower-AI, was also co-founder and CEO of Borland Software when that company went public. We had an initial session to prepare for the company's IPO roadshow during which we developed a rough first draft of the narrative. Philippe went off, reviewed, and edited the content. When we regrouped for a run-through, he entered armed with a legal pad with the full text, which he proceeded to read aloud in a monotonous drone.

I stopped him and asked him to convert each paragraph into a four-word bullet, as a headline, and to deliver it again. With only those abbreviated prompts, Philippe had to pause from time to time to regroup his concepts. But his thoughts crystallized quickly; after all, having created the company, he was quite familiar with his story.

After that run-through, I asked him to convert each four-word bullet to one word and deliver it again. This time, with all the concepts distilled to their essences, his delivery became more fluid.

For a third run-through, I asked Philippe to put away the sheet with the bullets and to deliver it again, without any aids. This time, he told the story without a hitch and delivered it with enthusiasm and conviction.

Distillation creates clarity.

Do Not Pass "Go"

You may be tempted to short-circuit the entire Brainstorming process and skip straight to the clusters. You might think, "Why not start with the clusters? I could probably list four or five main ideas right now. That would save me a lot of time." That is your results-driven habit of trying to cut to the chase. But the human mind doesn't work that way. You cannot avoid the uncontrolled process of free association.

Start by unloading and capturing all your ideas in whatever order they come, free form. To appropriate my Army sergeant's favorite phrase in basic training, I call this "Splat and Polish": splat your idea first and save the polishing for later.

Focus must precede flow.

Do the Data Dump in your preparation, not in your presentation.

Now, having distilled your Data Dump into a few Roman Columns, you are ready to arrange them into a sequential, meaningful structured flow, which is the ultimate step in Slow Thinking—in the next chapter.

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The Story Arc

Case Studies: John McPhee • Ariadne and Theseus • Harold Scheub • Kurt Vonnegut • Syd Field • Bruce Schuman, Intel

We could write anything we wanted to, but each composition had to be accompanied by a structural outline....The idea was to build some form of blueprint before working it out in sentences and paragraphs.¹

Draft No. 4

John McPhee

■ A Legacy of Sequence ■

The esteemed professor of journalism and Pulitzer Prize–winning author John McPhee, whom you met in the previous chapter, still credits Olive McKee, his Princeton High School English teacher for her rule about structure.² Mrs. McKee’s teachings about compositional logic have deep roots that reach back in time to primitive societies and even further back, to mythology.

The Red Thread

In Greek mythology, the tale is told of Ariadne and Theseus, young lovers whose bond is tested when Theseus volunteers to enter a labyrinth and slay a minotaur. When Theseus sets out on his challenge, Ariadne gives him a ball of red thread that he unrolls on the way into the maze so he can find his way back out.

The concept of the red thread has carried forward to the present day as a metaphor for a method to bring order to a maze of fragments. In France, it's called *le fil rouge* and in Germany, *der rote Faden*; in both cases the term refers to an organizing principle that ties together diverse elements.

Griots

In pre-literate societies, where tales were passed from generation to generation by oral historians, sequence was essential. In Africa, these historians, called *griots*,³ were highly respected members of their communities for their skill at structured storytelling.



(Video 1) *Harold Scheub, African Languages and Literature*
<https://youtu.be/SHeIaDhv2U8>

Professor Harold Scheub of the Department of African Cultural Studies at the University of Wisconsin–Madison, who was an expert in the oral literature of Africa, related one such tale in English in a YouTube video.

Cinema and Fiction

In Hollywood, continuity is called the Story Arc, referring to a clear plot line that runs from the beginning, through to the middle, and on to the end of a film script. To implement this sequence, many scripts follow a formula popularized by the influential bestseller *Screenplay: The Foundations of Screenwriting*, by Syd Field. He recommends a three-act structure consisting of a setup, a confrontation, and a resolution.⁴



(Video 2) *Kurt Vonnegut on the Shapes of Stories*
<https://youtu.be/oP3c1h8v2ZQ>

In fiction, writers attend classes that teach a *narrative arc*, which consists of exposition, rising action, climax, falling action, and resolution.⁵ Superstar novelist Kurt Vonnegut has his own version of the rising, falling, rising action curve that he describes with delightful humor in a short video, “The Shape of a Story.”⁶

THE STORY ARC

In the theater, playwrights learn to construct their works in three acts with, respectively, a setup, a confrontation, and a resolution, also known as a denouement.⁷

Business Stories

Businesspeople, who bristle at all things fictional (with good reason) and theatrical, would be hard-pressed to compose a presentation as a three-act play or as a story with rising actions, falling actions, and climaxes. Moreover, businesspeople consistently default to that shuffle-the-deck legacy that results in a logic from slide-to-slide but no overarching structure.

Remember Cardinal Sin Three: *No clear flow*. When your audience can't follow your story, they start thinking. Now, you definitely want your audience to think about *what* you're saying; you just don't want them to have to think about *how* you're saying it. If they do, they will stop listening. After a moment, they might figure out where you are and start listening again, but by then you've moved further ahead in your story, and they can't catch up. Your audience needs a red thread.

Good presentations are like good massage therapy. Good massage therapists never take their hands off the body. Good presenters never let go of their audience's minds. Good presenters grab their audience's minds at the beginning, navigate them through all the various parts of the presentation, *never letting go*, and then deposit them at Point B.

In Chapter Fourteen, you'll learn how to design your slides to help express flow, but before you can do that, you have to organize the disparate elements from the Brainstorm into a structured progression, a Story Arc.

The Story Arc

To demonstrate why sequence is important to your audience, let's turn to written text in either print or digital copy. In both cases, the reader is the audience to the writer. The reader has a unique capability: random access to the writer's content. If the reader of a print book, magazine, or newspaper sees a word or reference that is unclear but looks familiar, the reader can riffle back and forth through the pages; in digital text, the reader can scroll up or down with a few flicks of the finger.

Your presentation audience, on the other hand, does not have that capability. They do not see the forest, only the trees. With only linear access to your story,

your audience sees one tree at a time. You might do an excellent job of presenting the first tree, and your audience may be impressed, thinking, “That’s a superb tree: deep roots, thick bark, rich foliage.” But if you move on to the second tree and do not make crystal clear how the second tree relates to the first tree, your audience will stop listening and start thinking, “Wait a minute, what does the second tree have to do with the first tree?” After a moment, they may deduce the relationship and start listening to you again. But if you’ve moved on to the third tree, your audience will have fallen too far behind to catch up.

Game over!

Bring your audience up from the level of the trees and give them a view of the entire forest, to provide a roadmap, to create the Story Arc.

You can create your Story Arc by using two forms of reasoning:

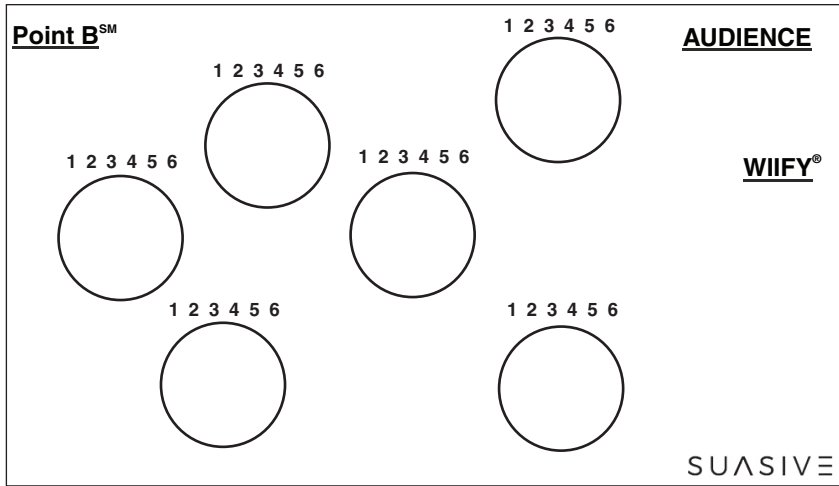
- **Inductive Logic:** Moving from a set of separate individual elements to a general idea, or from the bottom up
- **Deductive Logic:** Moving from general idea to a set of separate individual elements, or from the top down

■ Inductive Logic: The Why?/Why Not? Rationale ■

The set of separate individual elements are the Roman Columns that you distilled from Brainstorming. Assuming the maximum of six, you are now ready to assemble them in a logical order. To do that, apply the Why?/Why Not? Rationale.

Let me demonstrate how I do this with my clients. As always, we begin with the Suasive FrameForm, this time on a digital whiteboard, and focus on one presentation. First, we scribe the Point B, the audience, and their WIIFYs. Then we add six circles to represent the main clusters, or Roman Columns you saw in Figure 3.5. Then we scribe the total number of circles over each circle, as in Figure 4.1. If a story has fewer Roman Columns or clusters, then scribe that total over each circle.

THE STORY ARC

Figure 4.1 *The Why?/Why Not? Rationale in the Suasive FrameForm*

Then I ask the presenter, let's call him Bruce, which of the circles would be best to start his presentation. When he makes his selection, I ask why he made that choice. Then, playing devil's advocate, I ask why another of the circles can't be first. When he tells me why that circle cannot be first, I put an X over the 1 of that circle. Continuing in this manner, we apply the Why?/Why Not? Rationale for each of the remaining circles, writing an X over the 1s over the circles as we eliminate them for first position. When we determine which is the best circle to be first, I put a check over the 1 of that circle and Xs over the rest of the numbers over that circle, confirming that that circle is going to start the sequence.

Moving forward, we apply the same rationale for each of the other five circles until we get to a sequential order. At that point, I ask Bruce to restate his rationale by stringing together all the circles into one long sentence based on their numbered sequence: “I began with...because, and then I moved on to...because...”

Inductive Logic involves creating an overall logical flow by connecting a set of Roman Columns.

The Why?/Why Not? Rationale in Action

I coached an actual Bruce in the Why?/Why Not? Rationale. He is Bruce Schuman, the CFO of Data Center Group (DCG), Enterprise and Government (E&G) at Intel Corporation, the giant multinational technology company. In a

PRESENTING TO WIN

conference room at Intel's San Jose offices, Bruce stepped up to a tempered glass whiteboard and scribed his FrameForm.

Bruce's Point B was "Focus on investments to win AI [Artificial Intelligence] leadership," his audience was "DCG staff," and their WIIFYs were "Leadership in a \$10 Billion AI Market" and "Extend DCG franchise into the future." Then we Brainstormed and distilled his many ideas. He had only five Clusters: "Competition," "Financials," "Customer Needs," "Intel Capabilities," and "Future Compute Model" (see Figure 4.2).

As Bruce defined the clusters, I joined him at the whiteboard and highlighted them by double-circling the Roman Columns with a marker. Then I wrote 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 over each circle and asked Bruce which he would choose to start his presentation. He said, "Future Compute Model."

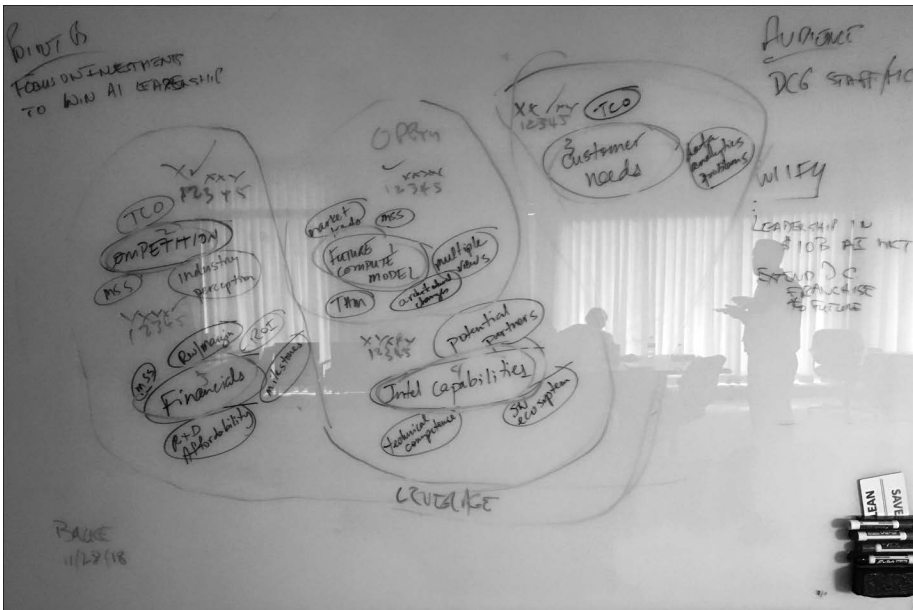


Figure 4.2 Intel's Bruce Schuman: FrameForm with Five Clusters

"Why?" I asked.

He replied, "Because the North Star of our market is AI. Our market—and the whole world—wants to develop AI."

"Why not 'Competition?'" I asked. "Intel has always been an aggressive competitor."

THE STORY ARC

Bruce replied, “Yes we have, but we need to have a long view focus.”

I said, “So ‘Competition’ can’t be first,” and wrote an X over the 1 on top of its circle. Then I asked, “Why not start with ‘Financials?’”

“Too soon,” he replied. “It would be best to save ‘Financials’ for the end, after I’ve made my case to tell them what it costs.”

I wrote an X over the 1 of “Financials,” and asked, “Why not ‘Customer Needs’? Isn’t Intel always focused on satisfying its customers?”

“Yes, that’s important,” he agreed. “But it’s second tier to ‘Future Compute.’ I have to show where the market is going and then talk about what it will take to help our customers get there.”

I wrote an X over the 1 of “Customer Needs” and asked, “Why not ‘Intel Capabilities?’”

“We know our capabilities, but we have to set up a reason for us to deploy them first.”

I wrote an X over the 1 of “Intel Capabilities” and said, “That makes ‘Future Compute Model’ first,” and checked 1 over ‘Future Compute Model.’ Then, as I said, “By default, ‘Future Compute Model’ can’t be 2, 3, 4, or 5,” I wrote Xs over those numbers. “Now which cluster is next?”

Bruce replied, “Competition.”

“Why?”

“Because it justifies the need for us to act.”

“Why not ‘Customer Needs?’”

“That’s important, but ‘Competition’ is more urgent.”

We proceeded with the Why?/Why Not? Rationale for each of the clusters until we had all five circles in sequence. At that point, I asked Bruce to confirm the rationale of his sequence by repeating the main clusters and stringing them into one long sentence.

He cleared his throat and said, “I began with ‘Future Compute Model’ because it establishes the need for a long-term strategy, then I moved to ‘Competition’ to create the urgency of getting started ahead of the others; from there I went to our ‘Customer Needs’ because they’ll need our help to get there; ‘Intel Capabilities’ is next because it’s about where we are today and what we need to develop the technology quickly to lead that market—and finally what it will cost to get us there, ‘Financials.’”

“Congratulations!” I said. “The first draft of your pitch.”⁸

The Why?/Why Not? Rationale Exercise

Try the process yourself. For your convenience, I've provided a clean worksheet of the FrameForm below.

<u>Point BSM</u>	1 2 3 4 5 6 1 2 3 4 5 6	<u>AUDIENCE</u> <u>WIIFY®</u>	
	1 2 3 4 5 6 1 2 3 4 5 6		SUASIVE

Start by scribing your Point B, a brief description of your audience, and their WIIFYs. Next, scribe the main clusters in the circles, and then, using the Why?/Why Not? Rationale for each cluster, create your own sequence.

Once you've determined a sequence, confirm your rationale by repeating your main clusters and stringing them into one long sentence—just as Bruce Schuman did:

"I began with...because..., and then I moved to...because..., and from there I went on to...because...."

After Bruce spoke his one long sentence, I stepped to a flip chart, scribed a box headed "Roman Columns," and wrote his clusters in a vertical stack under the header, as in Figure 4.3.

Roman Columns
Future Compute Model
Competition
Customer Needs
Intel Capabilities
Financials

Figure 4.3 Bruce Schuman's Roman Columns Stacked

THE STORY ARC

Do the same with your story. Stack your clusters by scribing them under the heading “Roman Columns” on a clean sheet of paper, apart from the Brainstorm, so you can see the structure clearly.

I asked Bruce to repeat the one long sentence once more. When he did, his words flowed more smoothly than they did the first time.

“Second draft!” I smiled.

Bruce smiled back.⁹

If this “one long sentence” technique looks familiar, it should. It is the same process I used with Michael Ball, the CEO of Canexia Health in the Introduction. This consolidating technique applies a sequence to your story early in the story development process—far in advance of the slides.

“But we’re not done yet,” I cautioned Bruce, “We created that flow from the bottom up, using Inductive Logic. As a double-check, we can also apply Deductive Logic—a general idea to organize a set of diverse elements—from the top down, a view of the forest.” We’ll do that with a set of rhetorical templates called Flow Structures that serve as overarching concepts to arrange the Roman Columns. See Figure 4.4.

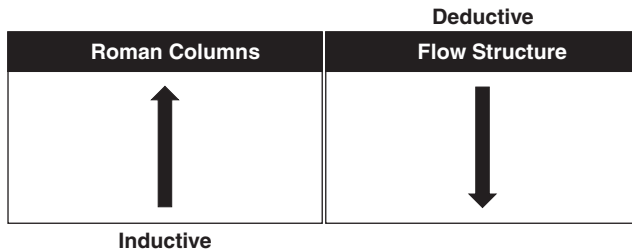


Figure 4.4 *Inductive and Deductive Logic*

“By using both forms of logic,” I continued, “you validate the sequence of your story.”

In the next chapter, you’ll find 12 Flow Structures.*

* Readers of the earlier editions will recall that I listed 16 Flow Structures. In streamlining the content for this edition, I decided to reconfigure and composite them into 12.

■ Inductive and Deductive Logic ■

Readers of the first and second editions of this book will note that the Inductive Logic techniques in this chapter are brand new. In those editions, I recommended sequencing using only the Flow Structures. The reason I added this extra step goes back to Cardinal Sin Three: *No flow*—caused by that routine practice of shuffle-the-deck legacy that results in a fractured flow. By imposing both forms of logic, you can now double-check that your story structure has the precise logic of a fine Swiss clock.

The 12 Flow Structures

Case Studies: Sir Arthur Conan Doyle • Mickey Kertesz, Karius • Jeffrey Dunn, SI-BONE • Gillette • Kodak • HP • Coca-Cola • Nespresso • Keurig • Illy • CannaKorp • Cisco IPO Roadshow • Patrick Spence, Sonos • Bruce Schuman, Intel • Sajjid Chinoy • Stephen Covey • Indra Nooyi, PepsiCo • David Brooks • Aaron Skonnard, Pluralsight • *Portrait of a Minimum Wage Earner* • *Tales of Manhattan* • *The Yellow Rolls-Royce* • *Two for the Road* • Safra Catz, Oracle • William Shakespeare • Philippe Brawerman, Cisco • Ben Rosen, Compaq Computer • Ray Dalio, Bridgewater • Wim Coekaerts, Oracle • Tomer Tagrin, Yotpo • eBay IPO Roadshow • Forrest Li, Sea, Ltd.

“You see I have a lot of special knowledge which I apply to the problem, and which facilitates matters wonderfully. Those rules of deduction...are invaluable to me in practical work.”¹

Sherlock Holmes: A Study in Scarlet

Sir Arthur Conan Doyle

■ Logic ■

One of the main characteristics of Sir Arthur Conan Doyle’s famous fictional detective, (aside from his deerstalker hat and cherry-wood pipe) was his uncanny

ability to solve crimes using deductive reasoning. The author, who was also a physician, enabled his protagonist to identify a culprit by diagnosing and analyzing seemingly unrelated clues.

Deduction, or top-down logic, starts with an overarching premise and organizes seemingly unrelated elements into a unified entity. A Flow Structure is a rhetorical template that organizes individual Roman Columns into a complete story. Having first linked those Roman Columns with Inductive Logic, you can now validate your story flow with Deductive Logic.

Let's look at each of the 12 Flow Structures and then dive deeper with brief examples. Along the way, you'll see which option Intel's Bruce Schuman chose.

■ Deductive Logic: The 12 Flow Structures ■

1. **Problem/Solution.** Start with a problem and then describe the solution you, your company, product, or service offers to address that problem.
2. **Form/Function.** Start with a single form, a central business model, method, technology, or secret sauce, and then move on to describe the many functions, applications, or paths you can take to build additional lines of business extending out from that core.
3. **Opportunity/Leverage.** Describe a business opportunity and how you, your company, product, or service is positioned to leverage that opportunity into a profitable venture.
4. **Chronological.** Organize your clusters along a timeline or roadmap—for example, yesterday, today, and tomorrow or past, present, and future.
5. **Numerical.** Organize a series of disparate or related ideas with a defined number—for example, Top Ten, Five Favorite, or Three Best.
6. **Physical/Spatial.** Organize ideas by their physical location or by concept, using a physical metaphor or analogy to create a spatial arrangement—for example, top-down, bottom-up, inside-out, or outside-in.
7. **Case Study.** Present a step-by-step narrative of how you, your company, product, or service solved a particular problem or met the needs of a particular client; in the telling, cover all the aspects of your business and its sector or market.

THE 12 FLOW STRUCTURES

8. **Argument/Fallacy.** Raise arguments that have been or might be made against your business premise and then rebut them by proving their fallacies or inaccuracies.
9. **Features/Benefits.** Select the primary features of your product or service and then describe the benefits each of them provides.
10. **Compare/Contrast.** List a series of key factors and then compare the performance differentials between your company and those of your competitors or other companies in the same sector.
11. **Rhetorical Questions.** Pose questions that your audience is likely to have or ask about your business and then provide the answers.
12. **Parallel Tracks.** Establish a series of related ideas and then drill down into each of them with an identical set of subordinate ideas.

1. Problem/Solution

Life sciences companies—pharmaceuticals, medical devices, genetic research, health care—usually use the Problem/Solution option to raise financing from non-scientists. Such companies begin their presentations by discussing a recognized medical problem and then go on to describe how they can solve it with their unique product or service. Cancer is a problem, a new drug is the solution; accurate diagnosis is a problem, genomics is the solution; invasive surgery is a problem, laparoscopy or laser scalpels are the solutions.

In Information Technology, data security is a problem. Every business, from the smallest home office to the largest global enterprise, experiences attacks from hackers, spammers, viruses, and identity thieves. Technology companies offer their hardware and software solutions to defend against such attacks.

Travel for business meetings and presentations is time-consuming, difficult, and expensive; virtual meetings are a time-efficient, simple, and cost-effective solution.*

The Problem/Solution option is also synonymous with learning. The essence of learning is to replace a lack of knowledge with skills. As a coach, I am also an educator, and so I structure my programs and this book with the Problem/Solution format. Think back to Chapter One, where I introduced the problems

* You'll find a comprehensive set of techniques to optimize your virtual meetings in Chapter Sixteen.

with stories as the Five Cardinal Sins. Since then, all the chapters have provided solutions to avoid those sins.

If you consider using Problem/Solution for your presentation, be aware of the time and weight balance of the two parts. Because everyone can relate to the pain of cancer, invasive surgery, security breaches, and flight delays, these problems do not need tutorials. Unfortunately, too many presenters spend too much time on the problem and not enough time on the solution, leaving their audiences feeling as if they have slogged through a long, tragic Russian novel.

This time and weight balance is best illustrated by cinematic story structures. In a Western film, the problem (the bad guys in the black hats, the Indian attack, the tornado, the wildfire) lasts for a long time, almost the full length of the movie. That's because those problems produce suspense for the audience and empathy for the endangered protagonists. Those heightened emotions keep audiences glued to their seats, munching popcorn and slurping big drinks. The solution, by comparison, happens in short order: The U.S. Cavalry arrives and rescues the hero and heroine. The End.

If you choose Problem/Solution for your business presentation, balance the time and weight properly. Touch on the problem briefly and then call in the cavalry of your solution and parade it in, clad in full-dress regalia, accompanied by a rousing marching band.

Problem/Solution in Action

Mickey Kertesz, the CEO of Karius, a life sciences company focused on generating genomic insights for infectious diseases, engaged me to coach him and his senior team to develop a pitch to raise \$15 to \$20 million of Series A financing. After completing the first three steps of the Story Development process, Mickey decided on the Problem/Solution flow with the following outline:

- **Problem:** Confusion, misdiagnosis, mistreatment
- **Solution:** Genomics for infectious diseases
- **Technology:** Microbial cell-free DNA, molecular biology, data analytics
- **Clinical Results:** Clear utility in a range of use cases
- **Markets:** \$1.5B “niche,” growing to \$20B and beyond
- **Sales Strategy:** Geography and use case focus
- **Financial Projections**

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Another example of Problem/Solution was used by Jeffrey Dunn, the CEO of SI-BONE, a publicly traded medical device company that treats sacroiliac (SI) joint dysfunction. I first met Jeff when, as the CEO of AccelGraphics, a 3D graphics system supplier, he retained me to coach his IPO roadshow.

When Jeff founded SI-BONE, he called again and asked me to coach the roadshow for that company's IPO. Although several years had elapsed, Jeff still remembered the techniques he had used to create his software company's presentation and applied them to his life sciences roadshow. Jeff promptly chose the Problem/Solution option and, although he had multiple Roman Columns, he grouped them into two major sections in the outline in Figure 5.1.

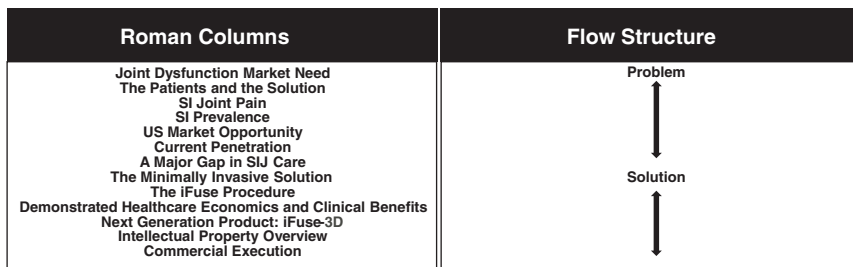


Figure 5.1 SI-BONE IPO Roadshow

2. Form/Function

Think of Form/Function as a musical main theme and several variations; or as a hub and radiating spokes; in business, as a core technology platform and multiple applications; or a secret sauce and its distribution via thousands of franchises.

Make a product once, sell multiple iterations. The initial cost is in the core product; the profit is in the disposables. A high-margin business.

Form/Function in Action

Business schools often teach this classic model with well-known business brands:

- Gillette razors are the Form; replacement blades, shaving cream, and after shave lotion are the Functions.
- Kodak cameras are the Form; black and white film, color film, processing, printing, and mounting are the Functions.
- HP printers are the Form; replacement toner cartridges are the Functions.

- The formula for Coca-Cola's famous syrup, their secret sauce, is locked in a vault at its headquarters in Atlanta. When Coca-Cola combines the secret sauce with bubbly water, they sell the beverage as Classic Coke; when they use a sugar substitute in the secret sauce, they sell it as Coke Zero; when they add cherry flavoring to the secret sauce, they sell it as Cherry Coke; when they leave out the secret sauce and the bubbles, they sell it as Dasani.

A recent example of this model is the automatic coffee-making machine and single-serve capsules business. Since their launch, Nespresso, Keurig, Illy, and a host of similar manufacturers have revolutionized the industry, selling tens of millions of machines placed in homes and hotel rooms around the world and hundreds of billions of capsules to serve their end users.

In an enterprising variation of the coffee model, CannaKorp intends to bring the capsule model to the evolving cannabis industry. Working with three former Keurig executives, CannaKorp has developed a single-use pod-based cannabis vaporizer system.²

Form/Function is the option of choice for companies presenting to peers at industry conferences. In the life sciences sector, one of the most prominent such events is the annual J.P. Morgan Health Care Conference. Over the years, I've had the opportunity to coach a number of the attendees' presentations. Most of them chose to address their scientifically oriented audiences by beginning with a deep dive into the scientific platform—the Form—and then go on to show how that platform expands as a business venture—the Function.

However, when these same life sciences companies pitch for financing to investors who are not scientists, they establish a recognizable Problem before diving into the science with their Solution.

You can make the switch from one audience to another—or one Flow Structure to another—with a simple shift of one or two of the Roman Columns.

3. Opportunity/Leverage

This Flow Structure starts with a description of an attractive business opportunity such as a new market, a shift in technology, or an economic driver and then quantifies the potential and the size. The story then moves on to describe how the unique product or service leverages that opportunity. The leverage continues on with the marquee customers who have bought that product or service, the go-to-market plan, and the growth strategy.

Opportunity/Leverage is the prevailing choice for financing presentations, including internal pitches for budget approval or resource requisitioning, as well as external pitches for private or public funding. This option is particularly appropriate for IPO roadshows because it maps to what is known as “The S-1,” the formal registration form required by the Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) for companies going public.³

The S-1 is largely a boilerplate document with pro forma sections labeled “Risk Factors,” “Historical Financial Information,” and “Management’s Discussion and Analysis.” However, the section that is most individualized is “Business,” which is divided into two major parts, usually called “Industry Overview” and “Our Solution.” The first describes the business opportunity, and the second describes how the offering company leverages that opportunity. Investors, accustomed to reading S-1s, resonate with the Opportunity/Leverage Flow Structure in roadshows.

Opportunity/Leverage in Action

You’ll recall from the Foreword that I coached the Cisco IPO roadshow early in my coaching career. Cisco, too, was early in their marketplace, when their technology was still an esoteric novelty. Because investor audiences at the time were not yet familiar with computer networks, the team decided that, before trying to explain the technology, they would begin by demonstrating the enormous potential of networking.

The roadshow started with a brief discussion of the *shift in computing from mainframes to PCs*. Investors immediately understood that shift because they were experiencing it in their own home offices. The story then moved on to the *rapid growth of local area networks and wide area networks (LANs and WANs)*, another familiar subject because investment firms were installing their own LANs and WANs; then it covered the significant *improvements in speed, bandwidth, and power*; and culminated with the anticipated *shift in businesses from enterprise-centered to remote-based computing*.

Taken together, the story described an attractive opportunity.

Next, the story moved on to how Cisco’s new device, the (now ubiquitous) *router*, would internetwork all networks; how Cisco *manufactured the router*; how they *served it*; how they *sold it through channels and strategic partnerships*; and where the company intended to *go beyond the router*.⁴

Cisco clearly demonstrated how they leveraged the opportunity (see Figure 5.2).

PRESENTING TO WIN

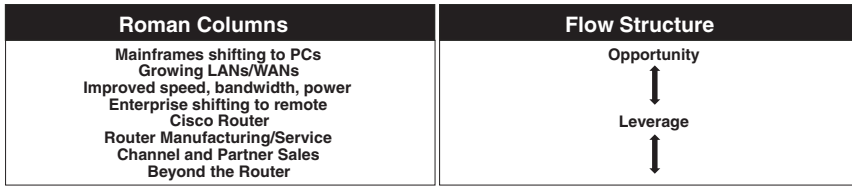


Figure 5.2 Cisco IPO Roadshow

Following its highly successful launch as a public company, Cisco became the darling of Silicon Valley and was invited to present its hot new router product at industry conferences. In a shift similar to that of the life sciences example above, Cisco switched from Opportunity/Leverage for investor audiences to Form/Function for their technology peer audiences. They made the shift by moving the Roman Columns about the router to front and center (see Figure 5.3).⁵

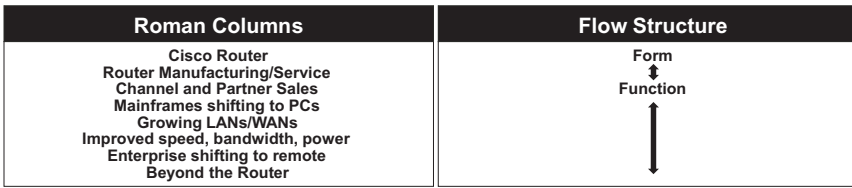


Figure 5.3 Cisco Industry Conference Presentation

Another company to use Opportunity/Leverage was Sonos, the popular audio company that develops and manufactures smart speakers. CEO Patrick Spence engaged me to coach his company's IPO roadshow. Working with Patrick and Sonos' CFO Michael Gianetto, CPO Nick Millington, and the lead banker teams from Morgan Stanley and Goldman Sachs, we arrived at a traditional Opportunity/Leverage outline (see Figure 5.4).⁶

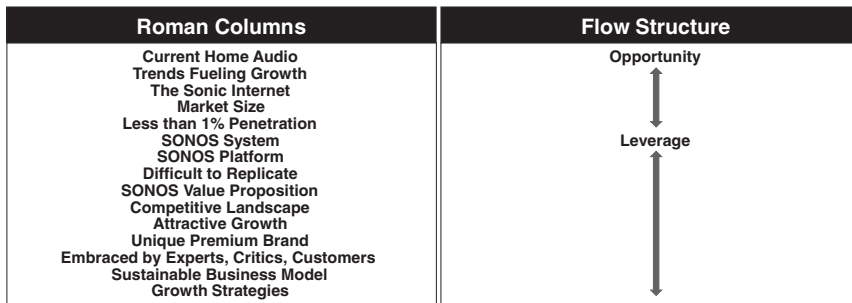


Figure 5.4 Sonos IPO Roadshow

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Returning to the case study of Bruce Schuman of Intel, you can see in Figure 5.5 that, by beginning with “Future Compute Model,” and following it with “Competition” and “Customer Needs,” Bruce was setting up the Opportunity; and then by following that with “Intel Capabilities” and “Financials,” he expressed the way he intended to Leverage the opportunity.

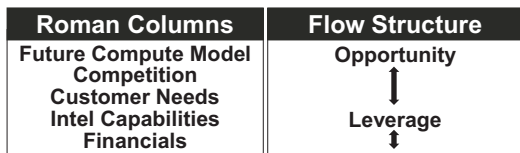


Figure 5.5 Intel’s Bruce Schuman’s Roman Columns and Flow Structure

By using the Deductive Logic of a Flow Structure, we validated Bruce’s initial Inductive Logic of stringing together the Roman Columns in one sentence.

4. Chronological

This option organizes your clusters along a timeline or roadmap, stepping through phases or events in the order in which they occurred or could occur.

Chronological in Action



(Video 3) Questions of Culture

<https://youtu.be/ryxK3B31XCE>

When Sajjid Chinoy, now the long-tenured chief India economist for J.P. Morgan in Pune, India, left India in 1992 to start his studies at the University of Richmond in Virginia, he was uncertain about how he would fit as a stranger in a strange land. Four years later, he was the student speaker at the commencement ceremony. In his speech, he described the milestones of a four-year journey that began with a long flight from Bombay:

Ladies and gentlemen, after that bumpy aircraft ride, this young Indian student had found his answer [to how he would fit]. He had been witness to the four most spectacular years of his life at the University of Richmond. The academics were great; the extracurriculars were great; his graduate plans were great. But what left an indelible impact on his mind was none of this. No, instead it was those special moments,

those moments of human interaction, those human relationships that can never quite be translated into words:

- *The time this young Indian student spent his first Thanksgiving dinner with his debate team coach. That Thanksgiving evening when I ate my first American turkey and saw my first American football game, not knowing the difference between a tackle and a touchdown. And yet, all of a sudden, just like that, this very different Indian student had become an inherent part of the great American tradition of giving thanks.*
- *The time I spent my first Christmas Eve with my journalism professor. That Christmas evening when the relationship wasn't of a faculty member and a student anymore, but of two buddies who fought fiercely over every point in Ping-Pong.*
- *The time I had a long and honest talk with an American friend on the eve of a calculus exam. I didn't learn much calculus that night, but what I did learn was that as different as we are—different countries, different cultures, different continents—inherently we are still the same.*
- *The time in December 1992 when India was hit by communal riots, when violence and bloodshed were but a few hundred yards from my family and my home, and when my fantastic roommate from my freshman year sat up the entire night, giving me hope, strength, and courage at every step.*

Yes, four years after that bumpy aircraft ride, I have found the answer to the question of culture. I have found that it has taken just a little understanding, just a little sensitivity, just a little open-mindedness, just a little empathy on the part of this community—this University of Richmond community—to change my life like never before. I have found that it makes no difference what culture you follow, what your background is, what your experiences are, what language you speak, what accent you have. The commonality of the human bond far transcends these superficial differences.⁷

The timeline of Sajjid's personal journey became an inspiration for his fellow graduates.

5. Numerical

Look at any magazine or newspaper, either online or in print, and you're likely to see a sidebar to a larger story or even a standalone sidebar that contains

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a numbered list such as “Top Ten” or “Five Favorite.” Current journalists and bloggers refer to these as “listicles.” Because of the commonly-held theory that three is an easy quantity to remember, one of the most popular organizing principles is “Three Best.”

The Numerical Flow Structure is an all-purpose option that provides a connected sequence for a group of ideas that relate to a single overarching theme but have no apparent sequence with either Inductive or Deductive Logic. I’m sure that Stephen Covey, as accomplished a writer as he is, had a specific rationale in mind when he wrote his book *The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People* in 1989. He listed the habits in this order:

1. Be Proactive
2. Begin with the End in Mind
3. Put First Things First
4. Think Win/Win
5. Seek First to Understand, Then to Be Understood
6. Synergize
7. Sharpen the Saw⁸

In looking at the individual habits, I can see how they might be listed in a different order and still provide a set of invaluable lessons for millions of readers.

The Numerical option enables you to put all the clusters in a common envelope, assign a number, and then count down during the presentation. The last point is quite important because we’ve all heard presenters who start their story with a number in the title but lose track of their countdown—and lose the audience in the process.

Follow the yellow brick road.

Numerical in Action



(Video 4) *Never Be Happy with What You Know: Indra Nooyi*
<https://youtu.be/24d4rfnsOxg>

Indra Nooyi spent 12 years as the CEO of PepsiCo, during which time she improved the company’s annual net profit from \$2.7 billion to \$6.5 billion.⁹ She also became the reference point and role model for successful female executives.

Forbes named her the second-most-powerful woman in business in their annual list, second only to Mary Barra of GM.¹⁰

Nooyi's successes and prominence brought her countless other honors, among them being named as one of the "25 Greatest Global Living Indian Legends" by NDTV (New Delhi TV). At the awards ceremony in her native India, she structured her acceptance speech with the Rule of Threes:

First, please, be a lifelong student. You know when we are kids, we ask questions like: "Why is the sky blue?" "Why is the bird flying so high?" But for some reason as we get older that curiosity goes away and if we're happy with the knowledge we have then we are actually going to atrophy. So please, remain a lifelong student. Don't lose that curiosity.

Second, whatever you do throw yourself into it. Throw your head, heart, and hands into it. I look at my job not as a job, I look at it as a calling, as a passion. And I don't care about the hours, I don't care about the hardship, because to me everything is a joy. So whatever you do please look upon it as a calling and a passion not as a job, not as something temporary.

The third and the most important one, please help others rise. Greatness comes not from a position but from helping build the future. All of us in positions of power have an obligation to pull others up. You know as I stand here today, I look at my responsibility not as accepting an honor. I look upon it as accepting a challenge and a responsibility, an obligation to actually make it possible for the people who are younger to come up and achieve levels of greatness so they too can be on the stage sometime in the future.¹¹

6. Physical/Spatial

With this option you can organize your clusters by physical arrangement or geographic location; or by concept, using a physical metaphor or analogy to create a spatial arrangement—for instance, top-down, bottom-up, inside-out, outside-in, clockwise, or counterclockwise.

For example, the market for a product or service can be represented by a series of concentric circles, like those on a target. The outer circles represent large, diffuse, and hard-to-reach markets, and the center, the bull's eye, is the heart of the market, the customers who are most likely to buy that product or service.

A common variant is the metaphor of constructing a house. The foundation serves to describe the platform, product, or service; the superstructure of supporting beams represents the organizations and partners; the wires and pipes of the internal infrastructure depict the technology; and the glass, brick, and mortar of the external interface stand for the marketing and branding.

Physical/Spatial in Action



(Video 5) *The Second Mountain: The Next Big Challenge in Your Life*

<https://www.aspeninstitute.org/videos/second-mountain-next-big-challenge-life/>

I was in the audience at the Aspen Ideas Festival when David Brooks, the noted op-ed columnist for the *New York Times* and bestselling author, gave a speech that turned out to be a preview of his next book, *The Second Mountain: The Quest for a Moral Life*. It, too, became a bestseller when it was published, and its structure serves as an example of the Physical/Spatial option.

In the story of his own quest, Brooks looked at life as a climb up two mountains. The first ascent was of early accomplishment, marriage, and family, followed by a descent into divorce and disarray. Then there was another climb up a second mountain to a second marriage, commitment, and connection. Along the way, Brooks shared not only his own journey but the journeys of other people from which he drew life lessons about experiencing—and handling—successes and failures.¹² The mountain metaphor provided a map for the many emotional ups and downs of life.

The Physical/Spatial option also works in business stories.

Aaron Skonnard, the co-founder and CEO of Pluralsight, a provider of technology skill development and engineering management solutions on its cloud-based platform, and I are fellow educators. When we worked together on his company's IPO roadshow, we shared many aspects of the learning process. One of Aaron's insights was that a descent can sometimes send a positive message: the often-referenced business sales funnel. The familiar image starts wide at the top to indicate a broad net to reach out to potential customers and then descends through progressively narrower stages, until the sale is closed at the bottom of the funnel—which also happens to be the bottom line (see Figure 5.6).

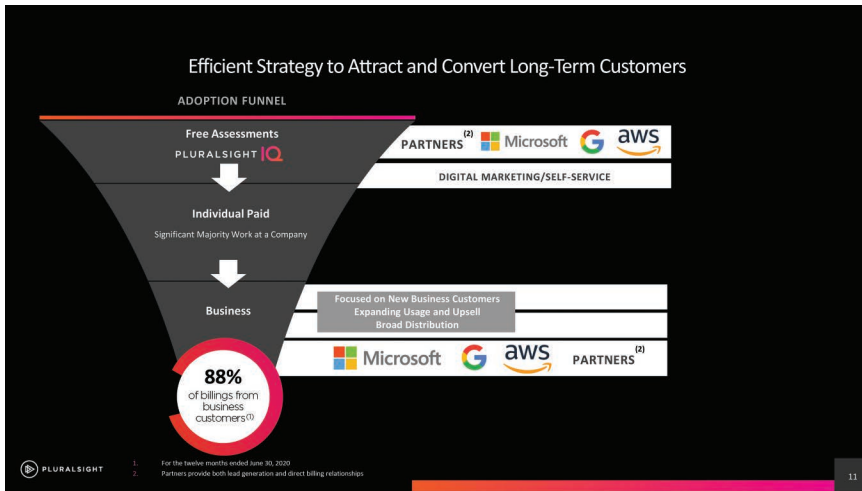


Figure 5.6 Pluralsight Adoption Funnel

In Aaron’s slide version of the funnel, he showed that Pluralsight’s strategy to attract and convert long-term customers reached the impressive figure of 88 percent.¹³

7. Case Study

“A Day in the Life” is a popular format in all forms of media. In it, a single item, individual, or group of individuals steps through a series of events or experiences that tell a larger economic or social story. At CBS, I produced a documentary called *Portrait of a Minimum Wage Earner*, in which we followed one man through his home life, his commute, and his job.

Over the years, Hollywood has made appealing vehicles using this humanizing structure:

- *Tales of Manhattan*: A formal black tailcoat passes through the lives of five different people.¹⁴
- *The Yellow Rolls-Royce*: A single luxury car passes through the lives of three different owners.¹⁵
- *Two for the Road*: A man and a woman meet, flirt, court, marry, quarrel, and have affairs in a series of road trips through the French countryside.¹⁶

The business equivalent is a case study that recounts how a company’s product or service solved a particular problem or met the needs of a particular

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customer. In the telling, the example serves as a central spine that connects multiple diverse components and covers all the aspects of a business and its environment.

This technique is particularly useful for life sciences stories. The narrative starts with a patient named Mary Smith and the illness she contracted. Then it goes on to describe how many other Mary Smiths there are in the world, how much is spent on treating all those Mary Smiths, and how long they've suffered without a cure. With the problem defined, the story moves on to how the company's drug cured Mary Smith and others, the drug's regulatory status, its clinical status, the cost of manufacturing the drug, its average selling price, and its potential profit margin. Finally, the story culminates with how Mary Smith was rehabilitated and reimbursed, thus extending the business premise to its position in the managed-care environment.

A single patient tells a large business story.

Case Study in Action



(Video 6) *SheBelieves Summit: Keynote Address—Safrat Catz*
https://youtu.be/ip9_CVRww40?t=529

Safrat Catz, the CEO of Oracle, was the keynote speaker at the SheBelieves Summit, an event to encourage young women and girls to reach their dreams. She began:

I was actually asked to share the unlikely route that got me here today.

Catz went on to describe her life, starting with her arrival in the U.S. from Israel at the age of five, unable to speak a word of English. She proceeded to step through her milestones: a college she chose because it was “the most fun,” attending law school, working as a woman in a male-dominated Wall Street firm, and then making a jump into the early days of high technology, pointing out along the way, that she didn't always make the “obvious choice.” Then she concluded with this observation:

Look, there are three kinds of people, that's what I've noticed. There are folks who lead and change constantly. Every opportunity they want in and they're—you know, “Put up your hand. Who wants to run

this?” “Me.” “Who wants to do this?” “Me.” Whatever it is, they’re the ones, they see there is an opportunity. ‘Course you don’t want to be obnoxious about it but, nonetheless you want to try.

Now there are folks who once they see it, they’re going to go with and they’re even going to make it better. That’s that second group. And then there’s the group in the back that are so terrified or don’t want any part of change and when you go to them, they’re like, “No, that’s not how we do things. That’s not, that’s not, no, no, no, that’s not how we did it last year, and I don’t wanna change this year.”

Ok. I will tell you, first group—excellent, second group—excellent, third group—don’t wanna be any of those. I am pretty sure none of you are that third group...

Where are you in all that? I will tell you that my own management team, which is dominated by women, are in group one.... They are so self-directed, self-motivated they make me look good because every single time they’re doing more, they’re changing, they’re adopting.¹⁷

Catz’s personal journey provided an inspirational lesson for all the young women in her audience.

8. Argument/Fallacy

To preempt potential objections in the minds of your audience, you raise arguments against your own case and then rebut them by pointing out the fallacies. In doing so, you create a level playing field for a positive presentation of your company’s strengths.

Argument/Fallacy in Action

The classic example of this technique occurs in William Shakespeare’s *Julius Caesar*. After the title character has been murdered by a group of conspirators, Brutus, one of the conspirators, delivers a eulogy at Caesar’s funeral, in which he argues that Caesar was assassinated because he was too ambitious.

After Brutus’ speech, Marc Antony, Caesar’s friend, steps forward to deliver his own eulogy. In the speech, he refutes Brutus’ reasoning three times:

Brutus says he was ambitious;

And Brutus is an honourable man.

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He hath brought many captives home to Rome

Whose ransoms did the general coffers fill:

Did this in Caesar seem ambitious?

When that the poor have cried, Caesar hath wept:

Ambition should be made of sterner stuff:

Yet Brutus says he was ambitious;

And Brutus is an honourable man.

You all did see that on the Lupercal

I thrice presented him a kingly crown,

Which he did thrice refuse: was this ambition?

Yet Brutus says he was ambitious;

*And, sure, he is an honourable man.*¹⁸

By the end of his speech—one of the most famous of all of Shakespeare's soliloquies—Marc Antony, with a sharp twist of irony, has proved Brutus' rationale false, and the citizens in the crowd shout out in agreement.

But Argument/Fallacy is a risky option for business presentations for these important reasons:

- Begins negatively
- Sounds defensive
- Raises issues the audience might not have considered

However, just as it did for Marc Antony, the technique can serve to turn the tables.

Turning from the Bard back to business:

Shortly after my work with the Cisco IPO roadshow team, the company asked me to coach other executives. One of them was Philippe Brawerman,

then president of Cisco EMEA (Europe, Middle East, Africa), who had a most urgent mission. He had just learned that Cisco lost out to Wellfleet, one of their main competitors, on a very large bid to provide products and services to Opel, a subsidiary of GM.

Undaunted, Philippe asked the CEO of Opel for one more meeting. In his presentation, he began by complimenting Opel for having chosen Wellfleet, listing the value of the features of his competitor's product offering. But then Philippe went on to show how Cisco's offering not only matched those features, point for point, but, in many ways, exceeded them.

Later Philippe added, "What turned the deal was to be able to explain to the CEO that Wellfleet features were technical. Cisco had a business vision to accompany our customers."¹⁹ Audience Advocacy.

The Opel executives changed their mind and gave the contract to Cisco.

Today, Wellfleet, having been through a merger and an acquisition, is a part of Nortel Networks, the telecommunications conglomerate, while Cisco is a public company with a market capitalization north of \$200 billion.

Philippe's presentation was actually a composite of Argument/Fallacy and the next two options, Features/Benefits and Compare/Contrast. The point being, you can combine Flow Structures, but limit them to two or three—and *not* all 12.

An example of pure Argument/Fallacy comes from my Stanford friend, Ben Rosen. When he was the chair of the board of Compaq during its public company days, Ben often spoke at investment conferences. At one such conference, he titled his presentation "Seven Reasons Why NOT to Invest in Compaq." Listing the seven reasons from negative analysts' reports, Ben rebutted them one by one. When he was finished, the inescapable conclusion was that Compaq stock was indeed a good buy.

Ultimately, HP came to the same conclusion and acquired Compaq for \$25 billion.²⁰

9. Features/Benefits

This is the most conventional choice for organizing product launches. The presentation proceeds through a series of Features of a product or service, and each one is accompanied by the Benefits to the customer or client.

Features/Benefits in Action

Cisco's Philippe Brawerman added a twist to this popular format by demonstrating how the features of Cisco's products were better than Wellfleet's.



(Video 7) Zoomtopia 2020: Opening Keynote

<https://youtu.be/2IM9C2kF4ao?t=3166>

Ray Dalio, the billionaire hedge fund manager of Bridgewater Associates and a prolific author, brought his structural skills to a launch pitch for Dot Collector, a new software product he developed for Zoom. At Zoomtopia, the annual Virtual Zoom User Conference, Dalio used the Features/Benefits structure, starting with a Feature:

Here's how it works. If you want to give someone feedback or tell them what you think, simply select the attribute, rate it, and write them a note. They will do the same with you. It's like giving 360-degree feedback in real time. All of the dots are automatically saved and summarized in a grid...

Benefits:

...so it's easy to see the highlights or drill down into whatever anyone is thinking.

Feature:

[Dot Collector] even produces automatic summaries of the meeting for those who want to see it later.

Benefits:

Over time this data paints rich pictures of people and their performance, which is invaluable for helping people in their teams improve. It's great for reviews, too.²¹

Features/Benefits is the structure of choice for sales pitches because it puts the customer front and center. Audience Advocacy.

10. Compare/Contrast

By listing a series of key factors of a product or service that you and your competitor(s) share and then comparing the performance differentials of those factors, you can demonstrate your superiority.

As with Argument/Fallacy, this option has several risks. By bringing up another company, you may sound defensive. If you criticize them, you may sound contentious. Finally, you may create a conflict with someone in the audience who may have a direct connection with the other company. This is particularly relevant in finance, where some investors, to spread their risk, own shares in multiple companies in a given sector.

Most presenters, however, sail full speed ahead to differentiate their businesses.

Compare/Contrast in Action



(Video 8) *Oracle's Infrastructure Strategy for the Cloud and On Premise: Oracle OpenWorld 2019*
https://youtu.be/5A-_iJTL0ec?t=58

At the Oracle OpenWorld conference, Wim Coekaerts, Oracle's senior vice president, Operating Systems and Virtualization Engineering, compared and contrasted his company's technology with that of Microsoft and Amazon:

[W]e're a little bit unique in terms of being a cloud vendor. That is, the hardware we use, the software we use as an operating system, and the infrastructure piece, the virtualization layer—all that stuff is exactly the same as what we provide to our customers on-premises. And that sets us apart from other companies like Amazon with AWS, Microsoft with Azure, because you don't know what they run.²²

Compare/Contrast is the option of choice for startup companies seeking to raise capital because their potential investors could very well be considering other players in the same market.

When Tomer Tagrin, the CEO of Yotpo, an e-commerce marketing platform, set out to raise a \$230 million round of financing for his company, he knew that he had to differentiate Yotpo from many others in the crowded space.²³ To indicate how many different services and applications exist to market to consumers,

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Tomer designed a slide called “The Tech Stack,” which showed how customer data is siloed (see Figure 5.7).

The Tech Stack



Figure 5.7 *The Tech Stack*

Then, to demonstrate the Yotpo strategy of unifying the siloes, he showed another slide that showed how Yotpo integrated those applications into one application layer (see Figure 5.8).

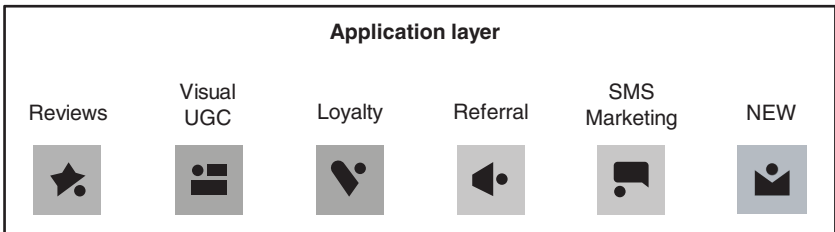


Figure 5.8 *The Yotpo Application Layer*

PRESENTING TO WIN

In the next slide in the sequence, Tomer went on to show that the application layer is just one part of “The Yotpo Multi-Product Platform” (see Figure 5.9).

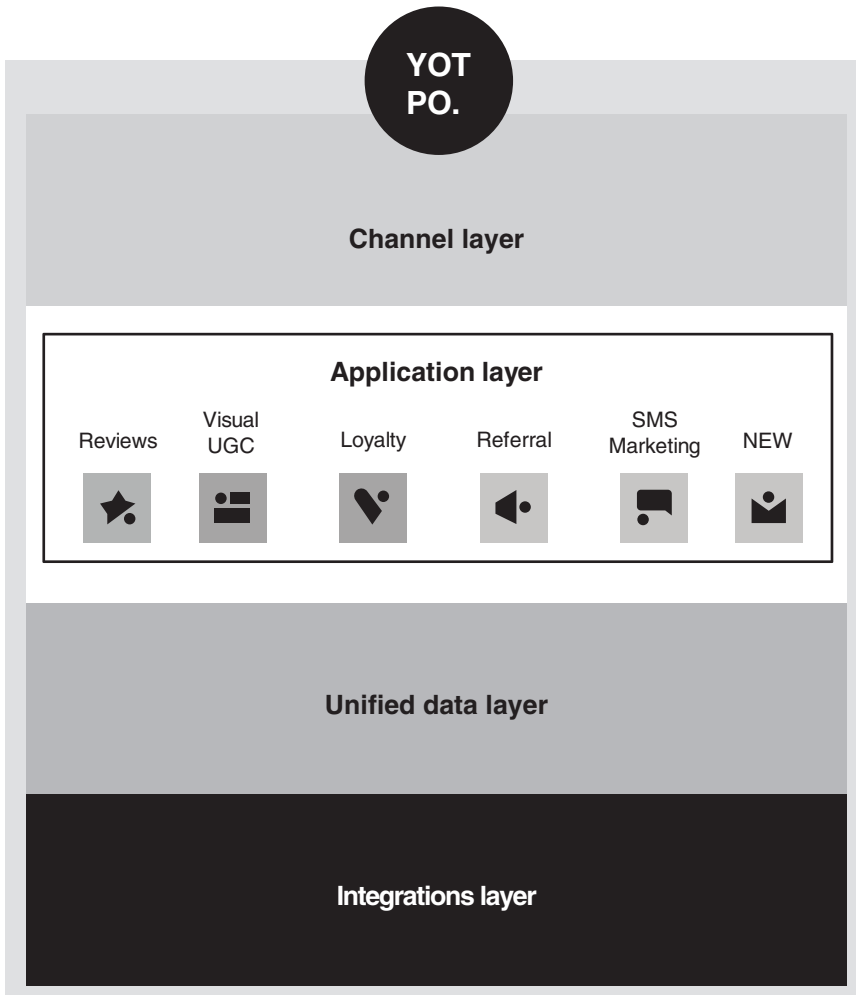


Figure 5.9 *The Yotpo Multi-Product Platform*

Tomer’s presentation is an example of the well-known successful business strategy of providing a “one-stop shop.”²⁴

When Philippe Brawerman compared and contrasted Cisco with Wellfleet, he demonstrated Cisco’s superiority and won the business.

11. Rhetorical Questions

The ultimate form of Audience Advocacy is to pose questions your audience is likely to ask and then to provide the answers for them. By saying “You might be wondering...,” you bring your audience’s point of view forward, and then by answering, you promptly resolve their question.

The Rhetorical Question technique dates back to the fifth century B.C.E., when Socrates asked questions of his students to prompt discussion and to test the validity of assumptions.

Rhetorical Questions in Action

When eBay, the e-commerce company that facilitates consumer-to-consumer and business-to-consumer sales, went public, I had the opportunity to work with founder Pierre Omidyar, CEO Meg Whitman, and CFO Gary Bengier to develop their IPO roadshow. The team decided to tell their entire story in four attractive investment metrics—the same metrics Whitman had used to evaluate investments when she was at Bain and Company, the noted management consultancy. Their four investment metrics were:

- Compelling consumer proposition
- Profitable business model
- Significant barrier to entry
- Superior growth prospects²⁵

Best of all, they posed those four metrics as Rhetorical Questions to test these assumptions as they applied to eBay. By demonstrating that eBay had a positive answer for each of the four questions, potential investors could conclude that the company was a worthy investment.

The technique worked: on the first day of trading, eBay stock jumped from \$18 per share at opening to \$47 at close, up 163 percent.²⁶

12. Parallel Tracks

This option drills down into several sections of a story with identical subsets; or it drills down into each of a series of related ideas with an identical set of subordinate ideas.

Parallel Tracks in Action

Forrest Li, the CEO of Sea, Ltd., a leading global consumer internet company based in Singapore, had an accessible story to tell, but it was somewhat complicated by the fact that the company was an amalgam of three related but distinct lines of business:

- Garena, which was focused on digital entertainment
- Shopee, which was focused on e-commerce
- SeaMoney (then known as AirPay), which was focused on digital financial services

All three units competed with global giants in their spaces. However, at that time, Sea's business was largely focused on markets in Southeast Asia, including Indonesia, Vietnam, Thailand, the Philippines, Malaysia, and Singapore, as well as Taiwan. These were regions not immediately familiar to investors on the New York Stock Exchange, where Sea was to be listed for their forthcoming IPO.

Forrest invited me to Singapore to coach him and his senior team for their IPO roadshow. In our story session, we reduced the potential complexity of the story by applying the Opportunity/Leverage option arranged in three Parallel Tracks. First, Forrest described the Opportunity in the overall Southeast Asia market and Sea's unique position to Leverage; then he stepped through the same Opportunity/Leverage pattern for each of the business units: Garena, Shopee, and SeaMoney.²⁷

Two and half years after Sea went public, it attained a market cap of close to \$40 billion.²⁸

■ Choosing a Flow Structure ■

After two chapters of the tools and techniques of Inductive and Deductive Logic, let me now add a final set of four guidelines to help you choose a Flow Structure for your story.

THE 12 FLOW STRUCTURES

1. **Audience.** Choose a Flow Structure that focuses on the interests or concerns of your audience:
 - *Customers* want Solutions to their Problems.
 - *Investors* want to know that there is a large Opportunity and how you or your company can Leverage the upside.
 - *Industry peers* want to understand your Form, your core business model or platform, and whether the many Functions expanding from that Form have a long runway for additional revenue streams.

Both Cisco and the life sciences company switched Flow Structures when they moved from investor audiences to peers. And they made the switch with a simple shift of just one of their Roman Columns.

2. **Individual style.** Choose a Flow Structure that feels right for you. During the development process, try different Flow Structures before you decide which option works best for you. If you work with a colleague, you may jointly develop a set of Roman Columns you both intend to use, but each of you may decide on a different Flow Structure to sequence them. You can do that with a simple shift of a Roman Column or two and still maintain the integrity of the Story Arc.

Not only does this flexibility allow for individual styles, but it also gives the lie to the common notion of the one-size-fits-all corporate pitch.

3. **Innate story factors.** Some stories lend themselves naturally to a particular Flow Structure: most customer pitches respond to the same frequently asked questions (FAQs); a company or an industry going through a transition is a prime candidate for the Chronological option; and audiences with diverse interests can all stay on track with a straightforward Numerical countdown.
4. **Established agenda.** If you are participating in a conference that has a set format for all speakers, follow that Flow Structure.

Selecting a Flow Structure is more art than science. Try different Flow Structures. You can combine two or three Flow Structures in a single presentation. The key is to limit the total number of Flow Structures. Where presenters get into trouble is when they choose all 12—and sometimes all 12 on each slide. Think of the 12 as choices on a restaurant menu: select only what you need.

PRESENTING TO WIN

It's less important which Flow Structure you choose than that you choose a Flow Structure.

With both the Deductive Logic of Flow Structures and the Inductive Logic of the previous chapter, you have now validated the integrity of your story. Let's flash forward to the moment you step up in front of your audience to deliver that story.

No Second Chance ...for a First Impression

Case Studies: Malcom Gladwell • Scott Cook, Intuit • Jim Flautt, DigitalThink • David Rubenstein, The Carlyle Group • Ray Dalio, Bridgewater • Howard Wu, Ericsson Technologies • Virginia Rometty, IBM • Ed Bastian, Delta Airlines • Daniel Lurie, Tipping Point Community • Bill Gates • Ronald Reagan • *The Wall Street Journal* A-Hed • Sajjid Chinoy • Yang Shuping • Bud Colligan, Macromedia • Indra Nooyi, PepsiCo • Dan Warmenhoven, Network Appliance • Jean-Baptiste Rudelle, Criteo • Raul Vazquez, Oportun Financial • Gregg Pugmire, Fortem Technologies • Reid Hoffman, Greylock Partners • *Thelma and Louise* • Dhritiman Dasgupta, Cisco • Rosser Reeves, The Ted Bates Agency • Ken Goldman, Yahoo! • Jim Kamradt, Resolute Capital Partners • Sharat Sharan, ON24

*Blink is...about those first two seconds.*¹

Blink

Malcom Gladwell

■ First Impressions Last ■

In his international bestseller *Blink: The Power of Thinking Without Thinking*, author Malcom Gladwell writes about how people make snap judgments based on first impressions. While Gladwell's time frame for a first impression is just two seconds, I'll give you a bit more leeway for your presentations: you have 90 seconds to engage your audience. Either way, you never have a second chance to make that first impression.

Picture your audience at the start of your presentation: a small group of potential customers entering an executive briefing center to hear you introduce your company's latest product; a busy VC rushing into a sleek modern conference room to hear you pitch for a round of financing; a large group of institutional investors and analysts sitting in a hotel banquet room ready to hear your IPO roadshow; or your company's senior management, concerned about rising costs, convened to hear your request for an increase in head count.

Where are their minds? Chances are, not on you. More likely, they are thinking about an urgent message on their mobile phone, a triple-digit swing in the NASDAQ, their next appointment, an overdue report, or the tiff they just had with their significant other.

If you were to launch into a deep dive of your presentation, describing your product, service, or technology, you would vault ahead of your audience, and they would be forced into catch-up mode.

You can capture your audience immediately with an Opening Gambit, a short statement that seizes their attention.

■ Seven Opening Gambits ■

1. **Rhetorical Question.** A question relevant to the audience
2. **Factoid.** A striking statistic or little-known fact
3. **Retrospective/Prospective.** A look backward and/or forward
4. **Anecdote.** A brief human-interest story
5. **Quotation.** An endorsement from a respected source
6. **Aphorism.** A well-known saying, maxim, or idiom

7. **Analogy.** A comparison between two seemingly unrelated subjects to illustrate a complex or obscure topic

1. Rhetorical Question

Get your audience thinking about your message by posing a meaningful question that is relevant to them.

Scott Cook, the founding CEO of Intuit, now a public business and financial software company, used a question to powerful effect while Intuit was still a private company. Scott presented at the Robertson, Stephens and Company Technology Investment Conference in San Francisco. Here's how he began:

Let me begin today's presentation with a question. How many of you balance your checkbooks? May I see a show of hands?

Almost everyone's hand went up.

Okay. Now, how many of you like doing it?

Everyone's hand went down, and they were all paying attention to Scott, as he continued:

You're not alone. Millions of people around the world hate balancing their checkbooks. At Intuit we have developed a new simple, easy-to-use, inexpensive, personal finance tool called Quicken.²

If Scott had launched into his presentation with a detailed description of Quicken accounting software, he might have lost his audience; instead, he had everyone thinking about balancing their checkbooks.

However, direct questions can backfire—for some very good reasons:

- Adult audiences don't like to be treated like schoolchildren.
- Asking the audience to respond cedes control of the floor. It's as if a chairperson were to hand the gavel to someone in the audience immediately after calling the meeting to order.
- Call and Response, a form of direct questions, is useful in religious rituals, public gatherings, or political rallies, where audience participation is desirable. In business, all you need to do is gain the audience's attention.

PRESENTING TO WIN

- Direct questions are sometimes asked as patently obvious leading questions. “How many of you would like to be rich and famous?” *Duh!*
- You may not get the show of hands you expect, and your mind will start racing “Yikes! Only one person! What do I do next?”

Of course, direct questions are quite appropriate in school settings.

Jim Flautt, who is now CEO, Asia Pacific at Asurion, a company that provides insurance for consumer electronics, used direct questions for a scholastic audience.

When Jim was with another company, called DigitalThink, he participated in a Suasive program. Two days later, Jim, an Annapolis graduate and a former naval officer aboard the *USS Albany*, was scheduled to speak about submarines to his son’s first-grade class at Laurel Elementary School. He realized that a roomful of seven-year-olds, the ultimate short-attention-span audience, would be as challenging as any business audience, so he started with a direct question.

Using a format quite familiar to his young audience, Jim asked three call-for-a-show-of-hands questions:

How many of you know what a submarine is?

All the first graders raised their hands.

How many of you have ever seen a submarine?

Half the first graders raised their hands.

*How many of you have ever seen a submarine fly?*³

Now all the first graders smiled, giggled, and gasped. Jim had their attention.

Direct questions work with students of all ages.



(Video 9) David Rubenstein | Full Address and Q&A |
Oxford Union
<https://youtu.be/wuzz3R2MUN0>

David Rubenstein, the co-founder and co-executive chairman of The Carlyle Group, a private equity investment company, was invited to speak at The Oxford Union, a British debating society whose members are drawn from the University

NO SECOND CHANCE ...FOR A FIRST IMPRESSION

of Oxford. With a full appreciation of his audience, Rubenstein decided to start with *nine* rapid-fire, call-for-a-show-of-hands questions:

How many people here are from England?

How many from the United States?

How many people are from the rest of the world?

Anywhere else?

How many people here think Oxford's the best university in the world?

How many people think your parents think that you're not working hard enough?

How many people here know exactly what they're gonna do when they graduate?

How many people have no clue what they're gonna do?

How many people want to work in private equity?

In short order, Rubenstein got the full attention and participation of his audience and set himself up to describe the purpose of his appearance:

I'd like to talk a little bit about my own background because it might be similar to some of yours and tell you how I came to be in the position where I was invited today to speak.⁴

If you are not speaking to students or do not possess the consummate skill of a Scott Cook or a David Rubenstein, make your questions *rhetorical* and immediately provide the answer yourself.

Scott Cook could have reframed his direct question as a Rhetorical Question: "If I were to ask how many of you balance your checkbooks, the likelihood is that most of you would say 'Yes.'" He would then have had everyone in his audience thinking about balancing checkbooks. Rhetorical questions not only get your audience focused on your subject, but they also keep the proverbial gavel in your hands.

PRESENTING TO WIN

In Ray Dalio's product launch pitch from the previous chapter, he began with a string of Rhetorical Questions:

How many times are you in a meeting and wondering “what are others thinking?” “How do I give feedback without interrupting?” “Can we save the learning from this meeting to use later and share with others?” While I love Zoom meetings, it drives me crazy that I am missing all of this information...

He then answered the questions:

*...so I asked my team to build the Dot Collector to use on Zoom.*⁵

Dalio moved on to describe the Features and Benefits of Dot Collector.

2. Factoid

You can convert any question to a simple, striking statistic or factual statement to capture your audience's attention. For instance, instead of asking, “How many iPhones are sold each year?” (which cedes control of the floor), turn it into a Factoid: “185 million iPhones are sold every year.”⁶

Of course, the Factoid you choose must be related to the main theme of your presentation and not just dropped in for shock value. We've all heard off-the-wall statements that only serve to throw the audience off track.

Howard Wu participated in a Suasive program when he was a vice president at Ericsson Technologies, the multinational networking and telecommunications company. Howard chose to begin his presentation with four striking Factoids about connected devices and servers:

*We are now standing at the cusp of a historical moment as we enter into the network society. In today's world we have seven billion connected devices being managed by 100 million servers. Within four years this number will grow to 30 billion connected devices and the backend has to be managed by 500 million servers globally.*⁷

The four Factoids set up a growing market for Ericsson products.

3. Retrospective/Prospective

A Retrospective (backward) or Prospective (forward) look allows you to grab your audience's attention by moving them in one direction or another, away from their

present, immediate concerns. Consider this technique as a flashback or flash-forward, or “That was then, this is now.”

For instance, you could refer to the way things used to be done, the way they are done now, and the way you project them being done in the future.

Technology companies often chose to start their presentations with a look back to earlier functions to contrast how their new technology disrupts the same functionality: library search before the internet, cassette tapes before digital music, brick and mortar shopping before e-commerce, a rat’s nest of tangled wiring before Bluetooth, and keypad entry before facial recognition.

Even businesses that evolve over a longer time frame can use the Retrospective/Prospective approach.



(Video 10) *A New Era of Value: A Conversation with Ginni Rometty, NRF 2014 Keynote*
<https://youtu.be/whwRMzwGXIQ>

Virginia Rometty, the executive chair and former CEO of IBM, used the same device for her keynote at the annual conference of the National Retail Federation (NRF), which she began by acknowledging IBM’s long relationship with the organization:

I have to tell you I am excited to be here, and while it’s my first keynote with you, you might be surprised: IBM’s been involved with NRF—it’s been over 40 years. 40 years. So now, right— [APPLAUSE] Oh, that must be my IBMers clapping. Okay, 40 years. But today, what do I want to talk about, because there are some great, great things happening. Call it possibilities at the intersection of our two industries: mine, yours.⁸

While IBM as a technology player was experiencing significant change, many other industries, the airlines among them, remained fairly stable; but more recently, even they realized that they had to step up the pace of change.



(Video 11) *CES 2020 Delta Keynote and State of the Industry Address* <https://youtu.be/ZFQOB4jqkM>

PRESENTING TO WIN

Ed Bastian, Delta Airlines CEO, chose the past, present, and future approach to begin his keynote at the Consumer Electronics Show (CES). His Opening Gambit was teed up by host Gary Shapiro, the CEO of the Consumer Technology Association, who concluded his introduction of Bastian with a question: “What is an airline executive doing coming to CES?”

Bastian replied:

[T]o answer that question you have to look back more than a century when technological innovation brought the life-changing magic of powered flight to our world; and we’re here today because we still think that the gift of flight is the ultimate innovation...and as aviation soars into its second century, we see technology as the tool to advance our mission of connecting people and creating opportunities...

So today you’re going to see what travel will look like in 2025 and the steps that Delta is taking to bring it to life.⁹

Not-for-profit organizations can also look down memory lane and forward to a brighter future.



(Video 12) Closing Tipping Point Breakfast 2019—Daniel Lurie
<https://youtu.be/iIkoGuRnIgE>

Daniel Lurie, founder of the Tipping Point Community, a grant-making organization aiming to break the cycle of poverty in the San Francisco Bay Area, decided to step down after a decade and a half as its leader. In a speech to announce his decision, he began by looking backward and forward:

As I prepared to transition roles from CEO to replacing an incredibly successful run of Chris James’s Chair of the Board, it was obviously a natural time to reflect on the past 15 years. I could tell you about our first office space donated to us by Barney Osher for two years free rent, 23,000 square feet of office space on Third and Townsend. Times have changed...

But you all have gotten to know me pretty well. I have always tended to push Tipping Point to look forward and this morning even though

*my Dad asked me to take a look down memory lane, I'd rather talk about us all of us. It's not about the past. It's about the future that we're fighting to create together.*¹⁰



(Video 13) Bill Gates | TED2015 | *The Next Outbreak?*
We're Not Ready https://youtu.be/6Af6b_wyiwI

The most dramatic Retrospective/Prospective trope *ever* was delivered by Bill Gates, the co-founder of Microsoft, who spoke at the TED2015 Conference. Bill entered the stage wheeling two large green barrels on a dolly. He set down the dolly and said:

When I was a kid, the disaster we worried about most was a nuclear war. That's why we had a barrel like this down in our basement, filled with cans of food and water. When the nuclear attack came, we were supposed to go downstairs, hunker down, and eat out of that barrel. Today the greatest risk of global catastrophe doesn't look like this:

The screen behind him showed the mushroom cloud of a nuclear blast.

Instead, it looks like this:

The screen behind him showed a 3D model of influenza virus H1N1.

*If anything kills over 10 million people in the next few decades, it's most likely to be a highly infectious virus rather than a war. Not missiles, but microbes. Now, part of the reason for this is that we've invested a huge amount in nuclear deterrents. But we've actually invested very little in a system to stop an epidemic. We're not ready for the next epidemic.*¹¹

How prophetic! Five years later, the world was ravaged by the COVID-19 pandemic.

4. Anecdote

By an Anecdote, I do *not* mean a joke. No one—including professional comedians—can predict the success or failure of a joke. Now more than ever, as the world expands globally and diverse cultures commingle, one person's taste in humor may be another person's dud.

PRESENTING TO WIN

Even if a joke does get a laugh, it will most likely distract from rather than enhance your message. *Never* tell a joke in a presentation.

By an Anecdote, I mean a *very* short story, usually one with a human interest angle.

Ronald Reagan, “The Great Communicator,” rarely spoke for more than a couple of minutes without using an Anecdote to humanize his speech. He usually illustrated his stories with a brief tale about a brave soldier, a benevolent nurse, or a dedicated student.

Newspapers and magazines, as a matter of regular practice, use Anecdotes to capture their readers’ attention. A daily feature on the front page of the *Wall Street Journal* is a human interest story they call the “A-Hed.” More often than not, the first sentence in the article contains the name of the individual around whom the story is built.

“Personal stories” have recently become the holy grail of storytelling. A tsunami of consultants, courseware, workshops, seminars, blogs, and publications are now advising individuals and businesses to develop their speeches and presentations by reaching deep inside themselves for a heartwarming anecdote. A Google search for “personal stories” at the time of writing produced over 3.5 *billion* entries. And with good reason: people naturally identify with other people, and a personal story can create empathy.

But it can also backfire because a personal story is all about the presenter and not about the audience. Human interest stories are effective in newspaper or magazine feature stories and in political or ceremonial speeches because these vehicles are meant to evoke emotion. Business presentations are meant to evoke action. In the time-pressured environment of business, an Anecdote can sound digressive or presenter-centric unless it supports the story and is clearly related to the main subject.

I recently read a blog purporting to offer advice about the value of personal stories. Unfortunately, the writer (whose identity I will mercifully omit) extolled the power of sentimental tales for several hundred words. Only at very end, almost as an “Oh, by the way,” did the writer say that the Anecdote should be tied to the point of the story.

Here are three examples of personal stories, each tied directly to the main theme.

Sajjid Chinoy, whose commencement speech you read in the previous chapter, began with a very moving Anecdote about a young boy leaving his home and his family in India for the first time:

*I can visualize the scene again and again: 11:30 p.m., Saturday night, the fifteenth of August 1992, Bombay International Airport, India. I was leaving home for the University of Richmond. And as I said that final goodbye to my parents, my family, and my friends; and as I saw hope, expectation, even a tinge of sadness, in their eyes; and as I stepped aboard the Boeing 747 in front, I knew my life had changed forever.*¹²



(Video 14) Chinese Student Abused for Praising “Fresh Air of Free Speech” in US
<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2017/may/23/china-yang-shuping-free-speech-university-of-maryland-us-student>

Another young student with a similar tale to tell in her commencement speech is Yang Shuping, who described her dramatic transition from her home in China to study at the University of Maryland:

*People often ask me, “Why did you come to the University of Maryland?” I always answered, “Fresh air.”...I grew up in a city in China where I had to wear a face mask every time I went outside, otherwise I might get sick. However, the moment I inhaled and exhaled outside the airport, I felt free....No more fog on my glasses, no more difficult breathing. No more suppression....At the University of Maryland, I will soon feel another kind of fresh air for which I will be forever grateful, the fresh air of free speech.*¹³

Bud Colligan told a personal story to powerful effect in an IPO roadshow. Today Bud is a community activist, social entrepreneur, and investor, but when I met him for the first time many years ago, he was the newly-appointed CEO of Macromedia, a software company that made authoring tools for multimedia. The company was ultimately acquired by Adobe, but at the time, it was going

public, and Bud engaged me to coach the roadshow. We developed the following Anecdote for his Opening Gambit:

*Last year, I was king of the hill at Apple Computer. I had a great job that provided me with boundless resources, deep staff, and abundant budgets. Why, you might ask, would I make the leap to this risky startup? The reason is that my job at Apple was to evaluate and develop new technologies. Many fascinating new programs and devices came across my desk, but the one that really caught my eye was multimedia.*¹⁴

While Bud's Anecdote was about him, it provided several strong values for potential investors: it validated his own qualifications by referencing the responsibility Apple had given him, demonstrated his courage to take a risk, and introduced a new technology with growth potential.

5. Quotation

Begin your presentation with a positive statement about your company, its products, or services from a respected source—a customer, an analyst, an industry publication, or a thought leader. This third-party reference serves as a direct endorsement of your business premise.

You can also use a relevant quotation from a well-known, reliable source such as William Shakespeare, Winston Churchill, John F. Kennedy, Tom Peters or, as many businesspeople do, Sun Tzu's *The Art of War*. If you do, be sure to tie the quotation closely to your content. Just as Indra Nooyi did.

The former CEO of PepsiCo, whose acceptance speech you read in the previous chapter, chose a well-known source and a quote as her Opening Gambit:

*Malcom Gladwell in his book The Outliers said, "Who you are cannot be separated from where you came from." I left India 35 years ago, went on to the United States, and had tremendous success in that meritocracy. But none of that could have happened if I hadn't had a wonderful upbringing very much here in India. So I have a lot to thank India for.*¹⁵

I practice what I preach: you'll note that each chapter in this book begins with an epigraph of a quote from a relevant text or song lyric that establishes the main theme of the chapter.

6. Aphorism

An Aphorism is well-known saying, maxim, or idiom. Because of its familiarity, as soon as you state an Aphorism, it rings a bell in your audience's minds. They may not even recognize the source, but it brings them to attention. Our culture provides many options.

Dan Warmenhoven, the CEO of Network Appliance whose IPO roadshow you read about in Chapter One, started with an Aphorism:

*What's in a name?*⁹

Sound familiar? It should, as it's been around since 1595, when William Shakespeare wrote those words in *Romeo and Juliet*.

Dan went on to pose a Rhetorical Question:

What's an appliance?

...and then to provide an answer with an Analogy:

*A toaster is an appliance. A toaster does one thing and one thing well:
It toasts bread.*

An Aphorism, a Rhetorical Question, and an Analogy—Dan created a *triple Opening Gambit*!

I shared Dan's choice of the Shakespeare phrase with Jean-Baptiste Rudelle, the founder and CEO of Criteo, a personalized retargeting company that works with internet retailers. J.B., as he is called, had retained me to coach Criteo's IPO roadshow, and given his company's unusual name, decided that he, too, would appropriate the Bard's words:

*What's in a name? What's in our name? "Criteo" is Greek for "I predict."*¹⁶

J.B. then went on to explain that his company's business was to enable e-commerce retailers to predict how best to match web advertisements to consumers.

Raul Vazquez, the CEO of Oportun Financial, a provider of financial services for customers with credit invisibles, wanted to demonstrate the potential of what is, by definition, a niche market. When we worked together on his IPO roadshow, Raul chose to lead off some of his presentations with *Hidden in plain*

sight, an Aphorism that captured Oportun's entire investment premise. These four familiar words, which indicate undiscovered value, are from Edgar Allen Poe's detective story "The Purloined Letter,"¹⁷ in which the sleuth theorizes that the best place to hide a clue is right out in the open.

Gregg Pugmire, the VP of worldwide sales at Fortem Technologies, a leader in airspace security and defense, uses *Under the radar* as his Aphorism in his pitches:

As a result of countless military, commercial, and recreational applications, drones are filling our skies. Most of them serve to improve our lives, but drones can also be a threat—if they are controlled by terrorists. The challenge in defending against such attacks is that radar detection techniques to find objects in the sky were designed to find large high-flying planes, not low, slow, and small drones. Therefore, these drones fly under conventional radar's field of view. Fortem's powerful AI technology overcomes that challenge by creating a new generation of radar sensors that are designed to "see" this area near to the ground that is missed by traditional radar systems. In essence we have built an "under the radar radar"—a whole new class of sensor to detect drones.

The phrase, which indicates a stealth strategy, originated during World War II to describe the flight pattern of military aircraft that flew close to the ground to avoid radar detection.¹⁸

Other Aphorisms include:

- ***If you build it, they will come***, which implies taking an opportunistic risk, originated in the baseball film *Field of Dreams* and became widely popular.¹⁹
- ***History repeats itself***, indicating lessons learned from the past, had its origins with writer-philosopher George Santayana's "Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it."²⁰
- ***The whole is greater than the sum of its parts***, which represents the benefits of joining forces, goes all the way back to the fourth century and Euclid, the founder of geometry.²¹
- ***Seeing is believing***, which indicates visible proof of authenticity, dates back to ancient Greek times and appears in numerous proverb collections from the seventeenth century.²²

- ***Easier said than done***, which denotes a challenging action, also implies the facility of speech, such as the value of speech recognition technology.
- ***Control our own destiny***, which could describe the goal of a unit of a larger company spinning off into an independent line of business with its own profit and loss accountability. The words were originally in President James Monroe's 1823 Monroe Doctrine, to establish independence from European colonialism.²³

7. Analogy

An Analogy is a comparison between two completely unrelated items. In Chapter Four, I drew an Analogy between massage therapy and storytelling. Hopefully, that got your attention.

Analogies help explain complex subjects. If your business involves highly technical or specialized products, services, or systems, a simple analogous comparison can help clarify. During the early days of the internet, companies developing networking products analogized the web to highways: with main roads to represent carriers, interchanges to represent routing and switching equipment, on-ramps and off-ramps to represent local carriers, and tolls to represent revenues.

But an Analogy can also help explain a more accessible subject, such as pitching to investors. Reid Hoffman, co-founder of LinkedIn and now a partner at the venture capital firm Greylock Partners, hears many pitches from entrepreneurs. In a post on his website, he offered advice on how “entrepreneurs should approach the pitch process”:

Every great consumer internet company grows up to be a unique organization. But in the early days, you want to use analogies to successful outcomes to describe what your company is and what its potential could be. Time is short—it helps to refer to what those investors already understand.

The best pitch I know was in Hollywood for a film called “Man’s Best Friend.” The pitch was “Jaws with Paws.” Investors thought that if the movie “Jaws” was a huge success, maybe a similar premise on land with a dog could be a huge success. The movie turned out to be terrible, but the pitch was excellent.”²⁴

Hoffman’s advice echoed a well-known tale in Hollywood—where pitching is a matter of life and death, and analogies are the pitch drug of choice—that the

pitch that got the green light for the pioneering feminist buddy film *Thelma and Louise* described it as “*Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid* with women.”

Films, being a universal culture, provide an endless source of Analogies.



(Video 15) *AI, ML, and the IoT Will Destroy the Data Center and the Cloud (Just Not in the Way You Think)*
<https://youtu.be/4T7PqObkSOA>

Dhritiman Dasgupta is the vice president of product management, cloud and compute solutions at Cisco. When D.D., as he is known, presented at the Strata Data Conference, he also chose a movie Analogy:

So there have been 26 James Bond movies made since 1962. It turns out, if you watched one, you kind of watched them all... But if you're like me, my favorite part of every James Bond movie is that five-minute visit to Q's labs because, you see, that's where I learned about the latest cars before I saw them on the roads. That's where I learned about the GPS before each one of us had it in our pockets. That's where I learned about artificial intelligence before it became the sexy thing that it is today. The reason I bring this up to you is because it's those tools, the data center infrastructure, the underlying infrastructure, on which all of the applications that you folks write, that is analogous to the tools that Q builds in his labs.²⁵

D.D. made the impressive leap of positioning Cisco's products in the same league as James Bond's repertory of glitzy gadgets.

■ Beyond the Opening Gambit ■

Let's return to Scott Cook's presentation at the investment banking conference and see how he continued beyond his Opening Gambit. After asking the two show-of-hands questions, Scott went on to link forward saying:

You're not alone. Millions of people around the world hate balancing their checkbooks. We at Intuit have developed a new, simple, easy-to-use, inexpensive, personal finance tool called Quicken.

Then, linking forward again, he said:

We're confident that those millions of people who hate balancing their checkbooks will buy many units of Quicken...

And then he finished his sentence:

*...making Intuit a company you want to watch.*²⁶

That was a clear statement of his Point B.

At that point in Intuit's history, the sole purpose of Scott's presentation at that investment banking conference was to raise awareness of the forthcoming IPO. All the other CEOs of private companies presenting at that conference were there to raise financing. Not Scott. His objective was to get on the radar screens of potential investors and analysts. (In fact, at that very conference, Scott declined an investment offer because he had all the working capital he needed from his primary investors, the Kleiner Perkins venture capital firm.)

To review the two important steps Scott made beyond his Opening Gambit: First, having established the common aversion to balancing checkbooks with his questions, he described Quicken as a solution in a concise sentence called the Unique Selling Proposition:

*...a simple, easy-to-use, inexpensive, new personal finance tool called Quicken.*²⁷

Then, having proposed a viable solution to a common problem, he culminated the sequence with the second step, his call to action. Let's look at each of those steps in greater detail:

The Unique Selling Proposition (USP) is a succinct summary of your business, describing the basic premise that describes what your company, product, or service does, makes, or offers. One of the most common complaints about presentations is "I listened to them for 30 minutes, and I still don't know what they do!" The USP is what they do.

"Unique" describes a company's differentiation, and "Selling" describes its commercial value.

Think of the USP as your elevator pitch. But make your ride in a six-story building, not the Burj Khalifa in Dubai, the tallest building in the world!²⁸ Brevity is the essence of the USP.

The USP is a concept and term coined by Rosser Reeves, a famous executive with the noted Madison Avenue advertising firm, The Ted Bates Agency. Reeves was so famous, that he became the model for Don Draper, the leading character in the popular *Mad Men* television series. The most memorable USP Reeves created was:

*M&M's® melt in your mouth, not in your hand.*²⁹

Scott's second step was to present his Point B, a clear call to action:

*...making Intuit a company you want to watch.*³⁰

Scott is never shy about asking for the order, but he is exceptional. Of the more than 600 CEOs I've coached for IPO roadshows, I've had to prompt more than a few to make their call to action by asking them the notorious teenager question "...and your point is?"

Of those who do make a clear call to action with their Point B, most CEOs are reluctant to use the "i" word—"invest"—out of concern that it will appear presumptuous. Instead, I suggest words like "invite," "join," "participate," and "share." Of the many CEOs I have coached for their IPOs, only Scott Cook culminated the Opening Gambit sequence of his roadshow by boldly asking:

*Why should you invest in Intuit?*³¹

He then provided answers to this question in the balance of his presentation.

These two steps beyond the Opening Gambit propel your story forward into the full presentation. Dan Warmenhoven took the same two steps beyond his triple Opening Gambit. First, he linked forward:

Link: *Managing data on networks is complicated. Until now, data has been managed by devices that multitask, they do many things, not all of them well.*

USP: *Our company makes a product that, like a toaster, does one thing and does it well: It is a dedicated device that manages data on networks. We call that appliance a File Server.*

Having defined his new technology simply and concisely, Dan linked further forward, saying:

Link: *When you consider the explosive growth of data in networks, you can see that our File Servers are positioned to be a vital part of that growth, and Network Appliance is positioned to grow as a company.*

And then he concluded with...

Point B: *We invite you to join us in that growth.*

What's Your Point B?

Dan Warmenhoven's IPO Point B is at the opposite end of a spectrum from Scott Cook's IPO Point B, a spectrum that ranges from soft sell to hard sell (see Figure 6.1).



Figure 6.1 Soft Sell/Hard Sell Scale

The difference is in the “i” word: “invite” is soft sell, “invest” is hard sell.

Some presenters have no difficulty being as direct as Scott Cook; others prefer a touch of subtlety.

Ken Goldman is a veteran Silicon Valley CFO who has held that demanding role at seven companies that went public, including Yahoo! During the IPO roadshows for three of those companies (Excite@Home, a web portal; Fortinet, a cybersecurity company; and VLSI Technology, an integrated circuit [IC] manufacturer), Ken used his own distinctive way of closing:

*So, what do you think?*³²

Another veteran who has been in sales for over 30 years also prefers Ken's subtle approach. Jim Kamradt, the managing director of syndication at Resolute Capital Partners, who was born without a reticence gene, nonetheless uses a soft sell Point B to close sales. At the ends of his pitches, Jim asks:

*Are you in?*³³

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The operative principle for the relative strength of Point B is the comfort level of the presenter—as well as that of the audience. Some audiences are guarded, others engaging.

In presenting to an audience that had traveled from China to Silicon Valley, Howard Wu of Ericsson, whom you met earlier in this chapter, chose a Point B in the center of the sell spectrum. Here's how Howard got to his Point B after his Opening Gambit about the explosive growth of data on the internet:

Link: *The data centers of today are clearly not up to the task. In today's data center operations, we are siloed, complex, and full of vendor specific hardware, which is ruining your TCO [total cost of ownership] on your data center.*

USP: *Ericsson today brings you a unique solution that is modular, simple, and software defined. Not only can we save you more than 30% of your total cost of ownership from day one, but we also help you to manage that growth that is coming in the next four years.*

Point B: *Thank you for coming all the way from Beijing. We would really like to be your partner in bringing this world class solution to China.*³⁴

Five different presenters, five different Points B ranging from hard sell to soft sell:

- *We would really like to be your partner.*
- *We invite you to join us.*
- *Why should you invest in Intuit?*
- *So, what do you think?*
- *Are you in?*

What's *your* Point B?

Gauge your own comfort level and that of your audience by finding the right point on the sell spectrum. What you cannot do is leave them thinking "...and your point is?"

Given that the first of the Five Cardinal Sins is the lack of a clear point, you won't be surprised to know that, when I coach, one of my most frequent prompts is to remind participants to ask for the order, to state their Point B.

Sharat Sharan, the CEO of ON24, a company that markets a digital experience platform that includes live webinar and virtual event experiences, is a very experienced executive who spent 20 years building his company. He has made countless presentations to customers and private investors. When I coached Sharat for his IPO roadshow, he had little trouble extolling the value of the ON24 platform. In one of our run-throughs, he said:

The ON24 Digital Experience Platform enables thousands of companies around the globe to convert millions of prospects to customers.

I prompted Sharat to go beyond that statement to add "...that conversion produces greater revenue for our customers—and for ON24—increased value for our shareholders."

At first, Sharat said, "That's too sales-y!"

I replied, "Just asking to stretch your goal. What would feel more comfortable to you?"

He replied, "Greater revenue for our customers."³⁵

"Great! That'll do it!"

As one final example of the full sequence beyond the Opening Gambit, let's look at how a typical insurance agent might proceed:

Opening Gambit (Anecdote): *Last year, one of Acme's customers had a flood in their home. The sprinkler system broke and damaged all the furniture, carpets, and other possessions. Not only did they lose their home, they took a big financial hit.*

Link: *This customer is like many customers who purchase a basic policy not customized to their individual needs. That means being just one step away from disaster.*

USP: *Acme Insurance has a solution. We can provide you with a customized, value-added package of insurance that provides for your individual needs to protect you against serious financial loss.*

Proof of Concept (POC)—evidence that your USP is worthy: *That's why Acme is one of the fastest-growing insurance brokers in the state.*

Link: *I know that you'll want to take advantage of this opportunity...*

Point B: *...and sign up for this important coverage today.*

With the connected progression of the Opening Gambit, USP, and Point B, you set up the rest of your presentation. Better still, you establish yourself, upfront, as a storyteller. The POC is an optional extra step to validate your USP.

■ Opening Gambit Summary ■

Looking back at all seven Opening Gambit options, you'll see that, in addition to capturing the audience's attention, each one of them establishes a need. The USP is a clear, viable solution to that specific need. Continuing along that line of logic, therefore, Q.E.D., what you are asking your audience to do—your Point B—is worthy of their consideration.

Taken together, the Opening Gambit, USP, and Point B form a syllogism, a logical string of connected points that begins with a premise and leads to a conclusion (see Figure 6.2).



Figure 6.2 *The Opening Gambit Sequence*

In the Suasive programs, after I've coached my clients to develop their Opening Gambits and they've found the value of the succinct capture of the essence of the story, they often ask why we didn't develop it before the central outline structure. My response is that it would be like writing the Executive Summary before a report, or the abstract of a study before writing the study, or making the topping of a cake before baking the cake. And so, in the program, as in this book, build the body before the introduction.

When you launch a presentation with an Opening Gambit sequence, your audience will have no doubt about where you're going. Now it's time for you to tell them how you intend to get them there.

Beginning, Middle, and End

Case Studies: The Classic Rhetoricians • William Safire • Bruce Eric Kaplan • Virginia Rometty, IBM • Jim Flautt, DigitalThink • *60 Minutes* • Anton Chekhov • Philippe Brawerman, Cisco • Bruce Schuman, Intel • American University • Ovation • The Scientist CEO • The Testifying CEO • Vince Lombardi • Franklin D. Roosevelt • Garry Wills

Exordium, Narratio, and Peroratio

■ The Same Old Story ■

Nearly two and a half millennia ago, the rhetoricians of ancient Greece and Rome defined the essential parts of a speech as *Exordium*, *Narratio*, and *Peroratio*. In English, that translates to the Beginning, Middle, and End.

These days, the triad is more informally known as “Tell ’em what you’re gonna tell ’em, Tell ’em, and Tell ’em what you’ve told ’em”—the universal axiom for speechmaking taught from kindergarten through college. Even professional writers follow this formula. Pulitzer Prize winner William Safire, who, after a lengthy career as a presidential speechwriter, wrote the esteemed “On Language” column in the weekly *New York Times Magazine*, agreed:

That simple organizing principle is the primary adage of speechmaking. That old saying, you’ll note, is packaged in perfect oratorical style:

*the imperative mood, the force of a command, the parallel structure that invites a rhythm in delivery.*¹

In presentations, the “Tell ’em” triad is usually implemented with an Agenda, a main section, and a Summary. But many speakers, rather than starting with an attention-getting Opening Gambit, launch into an Agenda—which turns the first moments into a laundry list recitation: “First, I’d like to talk about ... Then I’d like to talk about...” and on to the last item—wait for it—“Last but not least...”

The laundry list litany was lampooned by cartoonist Bruce Eric Kaplan in the *New Yorker*. Kaplan shows a man delivering a presentation next to a screen with a slide reading “Overview.” The caption reads “First, I want to give you an overview of what I will tell you over and over again during the entire presentation” (see Figure 7.1).



Figure 7.1 New Yorker Cartoon by Bruce Eric Kaplan²

To avoid such mockery, put the entire Opening Gambit sequence *before* the Agenda and *then* move forward to the middle, or the central body, which consists of the Roman Columns sequenced into a clear, logical order validated by the Flow Structure, as in Figure 7.2.

BEGINNING, MIDDLE, AND END

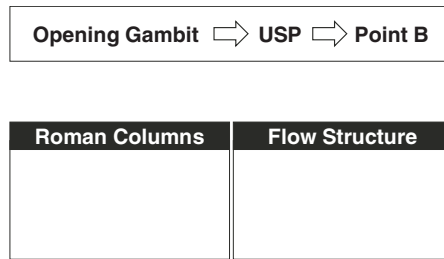


Figure 7.2 The Beginning and Middle of a Presentation

■ Tell 'em What You're Gonna Tell 'em ■

You'll note that the Opening Gambit sequence (Opening Gambit, USP, Point B) in Figure 7.2 is separated from the main body by a blank space. That is where to put the Agenda, or the first of the three iterations of “Tell 'em”. Consider the Agenda as a rhetorical bridge between the beginning and the middle by making it a fluid arc of continuity.

Before you learn how to do that, let's define the true role of the Agenda as a slide or, as it is sometimes called, the Overview: it is a preview of the Roman Columns in the main body and *nothing* more. Resist the temptation to load up the Agenda with multiple sub-bullets, the value proposition, customer logos, and an award or two—all of which are valuable pieces of information but belong later in your deck. The Agenda is *only* a condensed version of the Roman Columns. In IPO roadshows, the Agenda is called the Investment Highlights.

To make the “Tell 'em what you're gonna tell 'em” slide into a fluid narrative arc, let's return to the end of the Opening Gambit sequence, which ends with a call to action to invest:

*We invite you to participate in that growth.*³

Let's say that the investment is for an IPO with a traditional Opportunity/Leverage structure, and the Investment Highlights slide contains the following Roman Columns:

- Large, growing market opportunity
- Best-of-breed product portfolio
- Comprehensive go-to-market strategy
- Global growth strategy

- Experienced management and board
- Profitable financial model

After stating the Point B, you then proceed through the bullets with the narrative in the paragraph below. As you read through, note how the underlined words key to the bullets.

To help you evaluate our offering for your portfolio, let's look at the size of our market and how our industry-leading product portfolio is positioned to be the product of choice for millions of customers; how we take those products to market with our domestic partners, and our plan to expand internationally with our seasoned management team; who are uniquely qualified to execute that strategy; and operate our efficient business model which is designed to make a positive impact on our financial bottom line.

Please consider this the outline for the next 20 minutes of our presentation. Let's start at the top with the Market Opportunity.

The text in the narrative above contains five inflection points that created a fluid arc of continuity.

Five Steps of Continuity

1. **Link forward from Point B.** Follow your Point B with a forward reference that offers to prove or validate your call to action with supporting evidence: *To help you evaluate...*
2. **Narrate the Agenda as one long sentence.** Just as Intel's Bruce Schuman connected his Roman Columns in one long sentence during the development of his presentation, you can use the same technique in the delivery of your presentation with your "Tell 'em" slide. The "one long sentence" provides a roadmap for your audience. Narrate your Agenda as a string. Avoid the laundry list and the clichéd "Now I'd like to..."

Speaking the words in the Agenda also provides a benefit to you, the presenter. When you state the Roman Columns for your audience, it serves as a memory prompt of your main ideas.

Moreover, someday, you are going to arrive somewhere to deliver what was scheduled to be a 30-minute presentation, and someone will say, "Gee, I'm sorry, but we're running late. We planned to give you half an hour, but we can only spare ten minutes."

Panic time? No, simply put up your Agenda slide and step through your Roman Columns within the shortened time frame. This is essentially an application of the “one long sentence” approach to flow.

3. **Identify your Agenda as a roadmap.** Just as airline pilots go on the airplane’s public address system after takeoff to announce the route of a flight, tell your audience how you’re getting them to their destination: *Please consider this the outline....*
4. **Forecast the time.** ... *for the next 20 minutes.* When you establish the endpoint of your presentation at the beginning, your audience sees the light at the end of the tunnel rather than feeling they are plunging headlong into an unknown darkness. By stating the length of your presentation, you also demonstrate respect for your audience’s time. Again, Audience Advocacy.
5. **Link to the first Roman Column.** *Let’s start at the top...* This is the last span of the bridge, the off-ramp into the heart of the matter.

Continuity in Action



(Video 16) *A New Era of Value: A Conversation with Ginni Rometty, NRF 2014 Keynote*
<https://youtu.be/whwRMzwGXIQ>

Here’s how IBM’s Virginia Rometty, from the previous chapter, moved forward beyond her Retrospective/Prospective Opening Gambit. After recalling the 40-year relationship between IBM and the National Retail Federation and teeing up the future, she said:

There are some great, great things happening.

Then she went on to Tell ’em what she was gonna tell ’em. Although Rometty didn’t precisely follow the five steps above, she delivered a clear, concise roadmap:

I’m going to describe three technology trends to you—they are transforming my industry, but I want to convince you that this isn’t about technology. This is all about business paradigms that are going to change for you. And so I’m going to briefly talk about each, I am going to focus on what they mean from a business perspective.

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*So, I'm going to talk about big data, I saw that in the trailer, but I want to convince you that information is going to be the basis of competition for your entire industry, in no matter what you do. I'm going to briefly touch on cloud, but I want to convince you it's not about the technology. You are making business model choices. And then third, really quick, there is a radical new era of technology, something called cognitive. That means systems that learn. I assert this will radically change your industry. It will allow you to build relationships in a way that build trust that you never had before.*⁴

Not only did Rometty enumerate her three Roman Columns, she also stated her Point B, *I want to convince you...*, three times.

Jim Flautt, also of the previous chapter, went beyond his three show-of-hands questions for the first graders, directly to his Point B:

Well, I'm here today to tell you all about submarines.

Then, linking forward, Jim Told 'em what he was gonna tell 'em:

I'll tell you all about what goes on in a submarine, how to drive a submarine, how to repair a submarine, and some cool things that a submarine does. When I'm done with all of that, about 15 minutes from now...

Jim forecast the time and continued:

...I'm going to show you a submarine that flies!

That got smiles, giggles, gasps, and delighted cheers from the children. Jim had them, and he kept them in rapt attention for the entire 15 minutes. Then, true to his promise, Jim clicked on a video clip of a U.S. Navy submarine going through an emergency surfacing exercise, leaping up out of the ocean like a dolphin performing a circus stunt.⁵

If the five steps of continuity can work with short-attention-span seven-year-olds, they can work with occupationally-short-attention-span investors looking to make a return on their investment. They can also work with a concerned customer looking to find a product that performs a vital function, or with a stressed manager looking for a strategy to compete more effectively—and they can work for you.

The First 90 Seconds

At my alma mater CBS, the producers of *60 Minutes* begin every broadcast with a 30-second video clip that previews each of the three stories in that episode.

BEGINNING, MIDDLE, AND END

In this “tease,” they carefully edit the clips to capture the essence of each story. Then, as the hour proceeds, they go into each of the stories in greater depth. This 90-second opening model has worked to great success for the program for over half a century; make it work for your presentation.

There is ample precedent for this preview approach in other forms of storytelling:

- In business writing, an *Executive Summary* precedes a full report.
- In technical and scientific writing, an *Abstract* precedes a full report.
- In newspaper and magazine writing—both print and digital—the headline and subhead provide the essence of the entire story.

In your presentation, the Opening Gambit sequence and all the links forward through the Agenda and into the first Roman Column serve as a preview of your *entire* story. All that follows is a matter of you guiding your audience through the roadmap.

The ultimate benefit of this compact sequence is that it serves to make your *entire* presentation more succinct.

The First 90 Seconds Summary

Let’s recap the entire introductory sequence from this chapter and the previous:

- Opening Gambit
- Link forward to the USP
- USP
- Link forward to the Proof of Concept (optional validation of USP)
- Proof of Concept (optional)
- Link forward to your Point B
- Point B
- Link forward to “Tell ’em what you’re gonna Tell ’em”
- String the Agenda in one long sentence
- Identify the Agenda as a roadmap and forecast the time
- Link forward into the first Roman Column

■ Tell 'em ■

Now you can proceed from your forecast of “Telling ’em” to “Tell ’em,” the main body of your story, as shown in Figure 7.3.

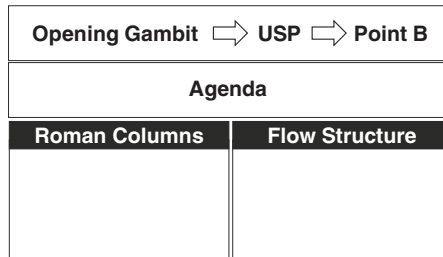


Figure 7.3 *The Main Body of Your Story*

Here is where you dive deeper, adding substance to each of your Roman Columns with added details and information.

Supporting Evidence

1. **Data.** This is where you can provide and discuss your numeric data. Cite market research, forecasts, financial results, and analytical reports that validate your ideas.
2. **Example.** The best evidence of the viability of your company’s product or service is to show it in action. Scientists and engineers call this “Proof of Concept.” Writers call it “Show, don’t tell.” The great Russian novelist Anton Chekhov advocated that technique when he advised his brother to describe the effect of moonlight on a broken bottle as “glittered like a bright little star.”⁶ Presenters implement this advice by showing customer use cases.
3. **Analogy.** In the previous chapter, you saw how analogies can get your audience’s attention at the beginning of the presentation. They are also useful within the body to help explain esoteric ideas.
4. **Contrast.** Show how you differentiate. You can count the ways, as Cisco’s Philippe Brawerman did when he won a contract that had been awarded to a competitor.
5. **Dialogue.** Presenters often speak in dry, formal, and impersonal facts and figures. You can liven up those facts and figures by referencing

dialogue: “Just before I came here, our sales director urged me to tell you about....”

6. **Endorsement.** Consider this another form of Proof of Concept, except that it comes not from a test but from a reputable, respected external source: a thought leader, an analyst, a satisfied customer.

■ Tell 'em What You've Told 'em ■

What comes next is no surprise: the Summary. Here, too, you must go beyond the laundry list recitation to a fluid string. The Summary is a mirror of the Agenda, and both are condensations of the main body. In an IPO roadshow, the slide is called the Investment Highlights (see Figure 7.4).

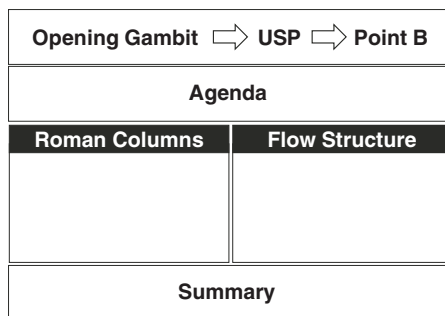


Figure 7.4 *The Summary*

An important caveat about your Summary: make it short. In novels, authors understand that, during the last few pages of a book, a reader will know that the end is in sight, and so they must quicken the pace of the narrative. The same is true for a presentation. When you get to your Summary slide, be brief. Run through it more succinctly than you did the Agenda—and make it one long sentence.

The Summary also neatly resolves the entire presentation. Express that resolution with a restatement of your Point B. The last words your audience should hear are those of your call to action.

You have now effectively grabbed your audience at the beginning, navigated them through all the parts, and deposited them at Point B. Your story has fulfilled the classical requirements for any story: a strong beginning, a solid middle, and a decisive end.

In our Suasive programs, we provide a StoryForm that captures all of the above (see Figure 7.5). You can download this useful tool from our website, and use it as a template for any presentation.

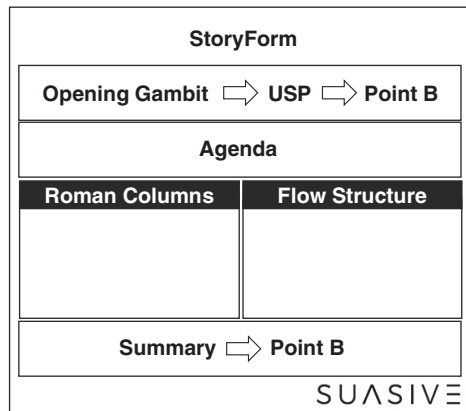


Figure 7.5 The Suasive StoryForm

While the StoryForm lays out the overall flow of your presentation story, it is still only a high-level outline, containing only the salient inflection points. To bring your story to life, you now need to add granularity, the specific words you will use to flesh out your story.

■ Verbalization ■

To expand your outline into a full presentation, practice it aloud with a unique rehearsal technique called Verbalization. Speak the actual words you will use in your presentation, and speak in tandem with your slides. Do it alone. Do it to an imaginary audience, but do it just the way you will do it when you are in front of your actual audience.

Many businesspeople are reluctant to Verbalize. Some claim that the presentation isn't "baked" yet, unaware that Verbalization will move the baking process along. Others feel uncomfortable because speaking aloud without an audience feels as if they are "performing." Still others consider Verbalization too elementary. Whatever the reason, they short-circuit the process.

Their reduced or modified rehearsal form often lapses into a patter: "Okay, with this slide I'm going to say something about our sales revenues—and then

with this slide I'll talk about our path to profitability—and then with this next slide I'll show a picture of our lab and talk a little about R&D.”

Sound familiar? As a form of rehearsal, this is completely unproductive. Talking *about* your presentation is not an effective way to practice—any more than talking *about* tennis would be an effective way to improve your backhand. This disembodiment separates the presenter from the presentation.

A relative of disembodiment, and an even more common practice, is mumbling. As speakers click through the slides on the computer or flip through the pages of a hard copy of the slides, they mutter unintelligible words.

Neither of these methods is Verbalization.

The only way to rehearse is to speak your presentation aloud in practice, just as you will in front of your actual audience. Each iteration will crystallize your ideas, each iteration will find logical connections. Each progressive iteration will improve the clarity. The more you Verbalize, the more smoothly your words will flow.

Remember the story development session with Intel's Bruce Schuman in Chapter Four. After he strung his clusters together in one long sentence, I asked him to do it a second time. And when he did, his words flowed more smoothly. That was Verbalization.

Verbalizing works in other situations, too. Many years ago, when I wrote a paperback novel, my editor recommended that I read my words aloud to validate their flow. Writers who create in silence find this technique invaluable for reviewing their creation.

Verbalization works. People in business and interpersonal relations who want to clarify matters “sit down and talk things over.”

Some people Verbalize to unusual audiences. A *New York Times* article described a speaking skills program at American University's Kogod School of Business that pairs “anxiety-prone business school students...with amiable, if unpredictable, dogs.”⁷

Technology is a bit more predictable than dogs. A company called Ovation has developed a virtual reality solution that helps speakers in their practice “by providing a supportive audience that feels real.”⁸ Whichever method you choose, Verbalization is the key to a successful delivery.

Verbalization in Action

Despite my many years as a coach, every time I have to present new material, I prepare by Verbalizing extensively. When I have to deliver completely new material, I increase the number of iterations.

Another perspective is that of a former client, a CEO of a startup technology company. The man, who began his professional career as a scientist, had developed an esoteric technology in his garage and then bootstrapped his company without ever having to give a presentation. But when his technology took off and his company was about to go public, he knew that he would have to stand and deliver the IPO roadshow. He retained my services, and we went through all the steps you've learned in this book, except for Verbalization.

On the morning he was to deliver his roadshow to the investment banking team for the first time, he panicked. I printed out his slides, spread out the sheets on a conference room table, and asked him to talk through them. He stammered as he did, and his panic intensified. I asked him to start again. As he worked his way through the slides the second time, he stammered less. I asked him to do it again and again.

By the fourth run-through, his stammering had disappeared; by the fifth he was beginning to develop continuity; by lunchtime, when the bankers arrived, he was able to deliver a fluid presentation. One of the bankers said, "You're ready for prime time!" The solid foundation of the well-developed story combined with Verbalization gave the anxious presenter comfort and confidence.

The CEO of a Silicon Valley chip company was asked to testify before Congress. Although he had delivered a successful IPO roadshow and presented frequently in quarterly earnings calls and at industry events, he left nothing to chance for his Washington D.C. appearance. He rehearsed by rearranging the tables and chairs in the company cafeteria to resemble the arc layout of the often-televised congressional hearing room. He then had his employees occupy the seats of the representatives and he rehearsed—aloud—multiple times.

Verbalize to the point of familiarization but *not* to the point of memorization. Remember my caution in Chapter Three: memorizing can backfire. Each time you Verbalize your presentation and each time you deliver it before a live audience, you should expect the words of your narrative to vary slightly. Verbalizing will make your narrative clear and consistent—and also fresh and alive.

As the legendary football coach Vince Lombardi, put it, "Practice does not make perfect. Only perfect practice makes perfect."⁹

■ Timing ■

Another important benefit of Verbalization is timing. Earlier in this chapter, I recommended that, as part of your 90-second opening sequence, you forecast the length of your presentation. The only way to know that is to Verbalize and to time yourself as you do.

And, by the way, Verbalizing will make you more succinct and, thus, avoid the Fifth Cardinal Sin: *too long*.

Follow the wisdom of President Franklin D. Roosevelt, who was to have advised:

*Be sincere, be brief, be seated.*¹⁰

Time management also has a place in the story development process.

■ Spaced Learning ■

Educators draw a distinction between distributed learning and massed learning. Distributed learning, which occurs over time, is the more efficient method because it allows for absorption and understanding. Distributed learning is a synonym for what the scientists call Spaced Learning¹¹; massed learning is a synonym for cramming.

Given the extreme time pressures of business, most presenters resort to cramming. When I ask clients if they ever whip their own presentations together at the last minute, I usually get a round of embarrassed looks, accompanied by one of these alibis:

Oh, I didn't have time to do my presentation, but I'll wing it!

I ran late in a meeting so I'll ask my colleague to deliver my pitch for me.

I won't have time to work on it so I'll ask Marketing to put something together.

Finally, there's the approach that, unfortunately, far too many businesspeople use:

Let's see, I can use three of Tom's slides, six of Dick's, and four of Harry's.

These presenters are likely resonating the tale they learned in grade school that Abraham Lincoln wrote the Gettysburg Address on the back of an envelope.¹² The implication is that he dashed off that historic speech with little or no advance preparation.

In his Pulitzer Prize-winning book *Lincoln at Gettysburg*, distinguished historian Garry Wills dispelled what he calls that “silly but persistent myth” by citing several items of evidence indicating that Lincoln organized his ideas in Washington at least two days before the speech. He continued to work on the text at multiple points as well as during his travel to the Gettysburg site. Wills also explained that Lincoln combined Verbalization with Spaced Learning: “This surely is the secret of Lincoln’s eloquence: he not only read aloud, to think his way into words, but wrote as a way of ordering his thoughts.”¹³ Then, on the memorable day of November 19, 1863, Lincoln rose “with a sheet or two” to deliver it.¹⁴

All of this for a speech that was just 272 words long!

From the sublime oratory of Abraham Lincoln to the mundane hobby of crossword puzzles. Veteran crossword fans know that when they become stuck with a puzzle, they put it aside briefly. When they return to it a while later, they are unstuck.

In my writing, I apply Spaced Learning by creating a draft of a passage or chapter, put it aside, and then return to it later. When I do, I discover new approaches, words, and ideas.

A *Wall Street Journal* article, referencing a scientific study, described the phenomenon succinctly: “Walking away from a problem to do simple, routine tasks, and letting the mind wander in the process can spark creative new connections or approaches to solving dilemmas.” Walking away clears the slate, just as an Etch A Sketch does when you turn it upside down. When I return to my drafts, having cleared my creative slate, I start with a fresh point of view.

The ever-present pressures of business make finding time for Spaced Learning a challenge, but well worth the effort.¹⁵

The beginning, middle, and end of your story is not the end of the process. You still have to add the finishing touches—and you’ll find them in the next two chapters.

Finishing Touches: Internal Linkages

Case Studies: Stephen Sondheim • Socrates • Dhritiman Dasgupta, Cisco • Reverend Martin Luther King, Jr. • Margaret Chase Smith • Susan B. Anthony • Barack Obama • Nike • Capital One • State Farm • Howard Wu, Ericsson

*Entering the world of the hat,
Reaching through the world of the hat
Like a window,
Back to this one from that.¹*

Stephen Sondheim

■ Bricks and Mortar ■

The George in the title of Stephen Sondheim’s musical *Sunday in the Park with George*, is Georges Seurat, the famed French post-Impressionist artist. One of the songs, about Seurat putting the final touches on a painting, is called “Finishing the Hat.”

The StoryForm is your hat—a set of building blocks that still needs finishing touches. Extending the blocks metaphor, the finishing touches are the mortar needed to bind the blocks together. The mortar is a set of narrative tools called linkages: verbal transitions from one slide to the next and connections between your presentation story and the audience.

These connections take two main forms: Internal Linkages, or statements that tie together the parts of your presentation, and External Linkages, or

statements that tie your presentation to your audience. We'll start with 12 Internal Linkages in this chapter and then provide seven External Linkages in the next.

■ Internal Linkages ■

To illustrate the importance of linkages, think of the *New Yorker* cartoon you saw in the previous chapter. Chances are you've sat in on many presentations like that, where the presenter clicks through and says, "Now I'd like to talk about..." and then talks about that slide. Then the speaker clicks to the next slide and says, "Now I'd like to talk about..." and talks about that slide. A click to the next slide, and the presenter says, "Now I'd like to talk about..." and so on, throughout the presentation.

Not only is this trite phrase a useless cliché, but it also destroys any continuity or flow. In effect, it makes each slide start the presentation anew. Rebooting presents a major problem for the audience. With no context for the diverse ideas and no connection among the ideas, the audience is stranded at the level of the trees, seeing only one tree at a time. Although the Story Arc provides an overarching view of the forest, your narrative must connect the individual trees. For that, there are 12 Internal Linkages.

12 Internal Linkages

1. **Reference the Flow Structure.** As you move through your presentation, track your progress with repeated references to your Flow Structure.
2. **Logical Transition.** Close your outbound slide and lead to your inbound slide.
3. **Cross-Reference.** Make forward and backward references to other subjects in your presentation. If you are part of a team, refer to your colleagues and their parts of the presentation.
4. **Rhetorical Question.** Pose a relevant question and then provide the answer.
5. **Recurring Opening Gambit.** Restate the Factoid, Anecdote, Analogy, etc. you have chosen for your Opening Gambit several times throughout your presentation.
6. **Bookends.** After establishing your Opening Gambit, never mention it until you refer to it again at the end.
7. **Mantra.** Repeat a catch phrase or slogan.

- 8. Internal Summary.** Pause at major transitions and recapitulate.
- 9. Enumeration.** Present related concepts as a group and count down through each of them.
- 10. Do the Math.** Give numeric information perspective by positioning or comparing it to a related number.
- 11. Reinforce Point B.** Restate your call to action at several points throughout your presentation.
- 12. Say Your Company Name.** Say your company, product, or service name often.

Let's look more closely at each of the 12 Internal Linkages, with brief examples of each.

1. Reference the Flow Structure

While all the other Internal Linkages are options that you can mix and match at will, referencing the Flow Structure is not an option but a necessity. It keeps your audience on track with your Story Arc.

If you've chosen Problem/Solution as the Flow Structure, keep referring back to the problem your business addresses.

Similarly, if you've chosen Opportunity/Leverage, keep referring back to the large opportunity that your company's products or services are deploying to leverage it.

If you've chosen Numerical, such as "Five Reasons to Buy Our Product," then count down or, if you prefer, count up. At pivotal points in your presentation, track for your audience: "Here's the first reason....Now reason number two....Finally...."

2. Logical Transition

This is the most straightforward linkage of all. Simply make a relational connection between one subject and the next. Provide closure for the outbound (one part of the presentation) and a lead to the inbound (the next part of the presentation). For instance, as you move from describing a new product to distribution say:

All these new features require a concerted sales effort, so let me show you how we go to market.

You can also create a relational connection between one presenter and the next. For example, let's say you are one of a team of managers presenting your company's future plans to the board of directors. If you were to finish your portion by saying, "Well, that about wraps up what I have to say. Now I'd like Barbara to come up and say what she has to say," there would be no connection between your material and Barbara's. It would be like a relay racer dropping the baton, forcing the next runner to bend down to pick it up.

Instead say:

I hope you see the value in the opportunity we're pursuing. To tell you how that works financially, let me turn the floor over to our CFO, Barbara, who will explain.

Place the baton directly into the hand of your teammate.

3. Cross-Reference

Let's say you introduce a technical concept early in the presentation but don't want to get into the details at that point. Make a forward reference by saying, "We'll take a deeper look at that technology later." Then, when you get to that concept, make a backward reference by saying, "Now let's go under the hood of the technology you heard about earlier."

When you are part of a team presentation, you can also cross-reference people. Say one another's names—preferably first names—during the presentation: "As Frank told you..." or "As you heard Judy explain...." Such statements send the message that the team is aligned.

4. Rhetorical Question

A Rhetorical Question creates a short, pivotal transition. Pose a Rhetorical Question after you've made a particular point and then provide the answer yourself. Consider these examples:

- After describing what your company has done over the past year, transition to your future plans with:

Where do we go from here?

- After explaining how your company intends to enter a major new market segment, transition to your plan by asking:

How are we going to implement that?

- After describing your business results, transition to those of your competitors by asking:

How do we stack up against the other players?

In each case, continue on to the answer.

Posing questions is a rhetorical device that has been around for almost two and a half millennia. Rather than lecture his students, Socrates, the great Greek philosopher, taught them by asking questions that prompted them to think critically.² Today, teachers all around the world educate using the Socratic method.

5. Recurring Opening Gambit

Let's say you used an Anecdote about a customer named Louise King as your Opening Gambit. You can then reference Louise King, and the millions of satisfied customers like her, several times throughout your presentation. When you describe the efficiency of your manufacturing processes, you can say, "Because of the low unit cost of our product, we're able to sell it at a price that people like Louise King can afford."

6. Bookends Opening Gambit

After beginning your presentation with an Opening Gambit, never mention it again until the end. If you start with an Anecdote about Louise King, for example, wait until the end and say, "Remember how our low prices were able to attract customers like Louise King?"

In Chapter Six, you read how D.D. Dasgupta of Cisco used an Analogy of James Bond films for his Opening Gambit at a technology conference. Six and a half minutes later, when D.D. finished his presentation he returned to James Bond as a Bookend:

*And so, now you know what we've been cooking in the Q labs at Cisco and we're working really, really hard to make each one of you a better James Bond in your organization.*³

7. Mantra

A Mantra is a phrase that you repeat several times during your presentation. The Greek orators called this technique *anaphora*. Many modern-day orators have also used it to great effect.

When the Reverend Martin Luther King, Jr., delivered his historic civil rights speech during the March on Washington in 1963, he used the phrase “I have a dream” 16 times.

Margaret Chase Smith, the first woman to serve in both houses of Congress, was troubled by the aggressive investigations being conducted by her fellow Republican Senator, Joseph McCarthy. She decided to take a stand and gave her famous “Declaration of Conscience” speech, in which she used seven repetitions of “I speak”:

I speak as briefly as possible because too much harm has already been done with irresponsible words of bitterness and selfish political opportunism. I speak as simply as possible because the issue is too great to be obscured by eloquence. I speak simply and briefly in the hope that my words will be taken to heart.

*Mr. President, I speak as a Republican. I speak as a woman. I speak as a United States senator. I speak as an American.*⁴

In her historic “On Women’s Right to Vote” speech, Susan B. Anthony, the co-founder of the National Women’s Suffrage Association, used six repetitions of the word “we” to great effect. After quoting the preamble to the U.S. Constitution, “We, the people of the United States, in order to form a more perfect union,” Anthony went on to say:

*It was we, the people, not we, the white male citizens, nor yet we, the male citizens; but we, the whole people, who formed this Union. And we formed it, not to give the blessings or liberty, but to secure them; not to the half of ourselves and the half of our posterity, but to the whole people—women as well as men.*⁵

Like Susan B. Anthony, President Barack Obama chose the first three words of the Constitution for his Mantra. In his second inaugural address, Obama repeated them in five consecutive paragraphs:

...We, the people, understand that our country cannot succeed when a shrinking few do very well and a growing many barely make it...

We, the people, still believe that every citizen deserves a basic measure of security and dignity...

FINISHING TOUCHES: INTERNAL LINKAGES

We, the people, still believe that our obligations as Americans are not just to ourselves, but to all posterity...

We, the people, still believe that enduring security and lasting peace do not require perpetual war...

We, the people, declare today that the most evident of truths—that all of us are created equal...⁶

Corporations spend enormous amounts of time and money on specialized marketing consultants to develop corporate slogans or tag lines that they repeat in advertising:

- “Just Do It” from Nike
- “What’s in Your Wallet?” from Capital One
- “Like a good neighbor, State Farm is there”

You can use your company’s slogan as your Mantra, or you can create a Mantra specifically for your presentation. If you were presenting your company’s turnaround strategy and the changes your company has made, you could say repeatedly, “That was then, this is now.” If you were trying to persuade new customers to start a trial with your product or service, you could refer to the Chinese proverb “The journey of a thousand miles begins with a single step.”⁷

The Mantra might turn out to be the best-remembered phrase or sentence from your presentation, so make it pithy, concise, and persuasive.

8. Internal Summary

Thanks to your carefully crafted Flow Structure, you know where your presentation is going and can proceed forward at full speed, but it is still brand new to your audience. They need a moment to digest what you’ve said. If they don’t get that moment, they will stop listening and start thinking or, worse, interrupt you and throw your presentation off onto a tangent.

Pause at a pivotal point or two in your presentation and give them an Internal Summary by saying, “Let’s review what we’ve covered so far....”

9. Enumeration

Let's say you have four new products in your product line to present. Rather than stepping through the four products one at a time, tell your audience that there are four in all as you begin to discuss them.

Introduce them as a group: "Today we're announcing a new line of four products, each targeted to a different market segment." Then discuss each one in detail, as necessary. After discussing all four, briefly recap the whole product line: "I hope you will see that these four products can serve anyone who needs...."

Use Enumeration sparingly. Don't give your audience six sub-themes under each main topic and eight subheads under each of the six sub-themes. Your audience can't follow your thinking that far down the path.

10. Do the Math

When you discuss numeric information, add perspective by comparing, contrasting, or interpreting the numbers.

In Chapter Six, we saw how Howard Wu of Ericsson cited figures about connected devices and servers and then forecast how those figures would increase over time:

*We are now standing at the cusp of a historical moment as we enter into the network society. In today's world we have seven billion connected devices being managed by a 100 million servers. Within four years this number will grow to 30 billion connected devices and the backend has to be managed by 500 million servers globally.*⁸

Had Howard started with only the forecast without relating it to the present, the growth potential would not have been as significant.

11. Reinforce Point B

As you saw in the StoryForm, you should state your Point B at the beginning and then again at the end of your presentation. However, in any other than the briefest presentation, you can reinforce your Point B throughout, at pivotal points.

12. Say Your Company Name

Whenever you refer to your company during a presentation, say its actual name rather than "our company," "the company," "we," or "us." This technique is

FINISHING TOUCHES: INTERNAL LINKAGES

important at industry events, such as conferences or trade shows, where your company is competing for mindshare against many other companies.

It becomes even more important in IPO roadshows. Prior to the offering, a company's senior management team will have spent several months meeting with bankers, attorneys, and auditors to discuss and write the prospectus or S-1. The established legal style of this document is to state the actual name of the company up front and then, after the boilerplate parenthetical phrase "(hereinafter called the 'Company')," rarely mention the actual name again. By the time the roadshow launches, the management team has become conditioned to refer to themselves as "the company."⁹

Small problem: on any given day, your company will be only one of several companies pitching to a given investment firm. Every company must make its mark.

Saying your company name also creates brand identity. Businesses today spend a great deal of time, effort, and money to develop their corporate image in logos, colors, and slogans; they spend even more time, effort, and money publicizing that image on everything from coffee mugs to T-shirts to baseball caps. It is far more time- and cost-efficient to have the company spokespeople promote the brand in person, in real time, to live audiences.

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Finishing Touches: External Linkages

Case Studies: Roger McNamee, Elevation Partners • Dean Ormond J. Drake • William Gillette • Don Listwin, Cisco • Nike • Ford Tamer, Inphi • Mark Twain • Bixby Jamison, Twilio

It's death if you give a speech or a presentation that sounds like a pre-recorded announcement.¹

Roger McNamee

■ The Power of Customization ■

On my very first day as an undergraduate at New York University, I attended the orientation session for incoming freshmen in a state of suspended animation. I had left behind the camaraderie and the cinder-block walls of a New York City public high school, and now, alone and apart from my close friends, I entered the marble halls of NYU's Gould Memorial Chapel. I was a solitary speck in a sea of strangers, all of us intimidated by our imposing surroundings and further humbled by our requisite freshmen headdress: bright violet beanies.

My awe was heightened when a procession of austere deans and professors, clad in black academic robes, entered and took their seats on the elevated stage, looking down at the lowly frosh. As each of these august sages stood in turn to address us, their stentorian tones and crisp articulation echoed off the domed ceiling of the chapel. How different they sounded from my high school teachers, whose strident New York accents were marked by a staccato

pace. I was still in the same city, but I might as well have been at Oxford or Cambridge.

Finally, the most impressive and most articulate dean of the group rose to speak. “Gentlemen,” he began (there were no female students at NYU at the time), “by now you realize that your life here at the university is going to be vastly different from high school. However, there is one high school practice that we have carried forward. We take attendance.”

At that, he reached under his robe into his coat pocket and pulled out a set of what looked like business cards. “These are your attendance records,” he said. Then, as if holding up a bridge hand, he fanned out the cards in one hand and, with his other, reached forward and plucked out one of the cards. Reading from it, he said, “Suppose you’re Jerry Weissman...”

Imagine my reaction. I couldn’t have been more stunned if I’d heard the voice of God intoning my name from the dome.

I wasn’t the only one to react. Several other freshmen sitting nearby, whom I’d just met, turned to look at me, and their stirring rippled through the audience like a wave.

I later learned that the dean’s selection of my card was completely arbitrary; he always picked an actual card from among the members of each new audience. I also learned that that same dean happened to be the chair of the Speech Department.

In time, Dean Ormond J. Drake became my mentor. Later still, he became my supervisor when I served as an instructor in his department; my sponsor when he gave me a consulting assignment at a Wall Street brokerage house; and my colleague when I produced and directed an episode of his talk-show series for CBS Television. But to this day, what I remember most about Dean Drake is the startling moment when he spoke my name in the welcoming speech he’d given to generations of entering freshmen.

■ The Illusion of the First Time ■

Many business presentations contain information that must be conveyed multiple times to multiple audiences. For example, a salesperson may have to present a new product to many different groups of customers; a human resources manager may have to explain the new company benefits plan to dozens of small groups of employees. In the world of IPO roadshows, a company’s senior executives

have 60 to 80 meetings with investors over a period of two weeks, often 6 to 8 meetings a day.

Keeping your presentation fresh in such circumstances is difficult. In part, this is a matter of energy and focus. When you have to make the same points for the third, or tenth, or fiftieth time, it's hard to feel the same sense of enthusiasm and excitement as the first time. But if you go into autopilot, your presentation comes across as “canned.” As a result, the audience is uninvolved, unmoved, and unconvinced.

The challenge is to achieve “the illusion of the first time,” a phrase that comes from the theater, where actors often have to perform the same role in the same play hundreds of times and still convey a sense that every speech and action is completely spontaneous.

The phrase originated with William Gillette (1853–1937), an American actor whose claim to fame was his portrayal of Sherlock Holmes, a role he played more than 1,300 times. No presenter is ever going to tell the same story 1,300 times, but road warriors who do multiple iterations of their pitch—to sell products, seek partners, or solicit financing—face the challenge of keeping each of those iterations fresh.

Gillette met that challenge by creating what he called “The Illusion of the First Time in Acting,” a subject he described in his book of the same name:

*There yet remains the Spirit of the Presentation as a whole. Each successive audience before which it is given must feel—not think or reason about, but feel—that it is witnessing, not one of a thousand weary repetitions, but a Life Episode that is being lived just across the magic barrier of the footlights.*²

Create the illusion of the first time every time.

Deliver each and every iteration of every presentation as if your audience is seeing it for the first time. Make your eightieth iteration as fresh as the first—and with Verbalization, the first as polished as the eightieth.

Fortunately, as a business presenter, you enjoy a freedom that stage actors don't have: you can reshape your script and give every presentation a new dose of freshness and spontaneity. Does this mean that you have to change your recurring content every time? Not at all. You can use the same core material and customize it with *External Linkages*. You can use the same techniques to customize a one-time-only presentation, as well as every presentation you ever give to every audience.

■ External Linkages ■

While the Internal Linkages of the previous chapter connect the components of your presentation, it's equally important to connect your presentation (and you, as the presenter) to each audience. You can customize your story by inserting words, phrases, stories, and other materials throughout your presentation by using any of the following seven External Linkages.

Seven External Linkages

1. **Direct Reference.** Address the members of your audience by name.
2. **Mutual Reference.** Refer to a person, a company, or an organization related to both you and your audience.
3. **Ask Questions.** Address a question directly to one or more members of your audience.
4. **Contemporize.** Refer to an event that is happening on the same day as your presentation.
5. **Localize.** Refer to the venue of your presentation.
6. **LinkedIn.** Learn about professional career paths of your audience members to find common ground.
7. **Customized Opening Slide.** Start your presentation with a slide that includes your audience, the location, and that day's date.

Let's look more closely at each of the seven External Linkages, with brief examples of each.

1. Direct Reference

Specifically reference one or more members of your audience by name. This is the technique that Dean Drake used during my freshman orientation at NYU, and the fact that I still recall the moment all these decades later is testimony to its effectiveness.

Most of my coaching sessions are with groups of four or five people each. From the moment every session begins, I address each person by name, and I continue to do so each time I address them or call on them. When I conduct large group workshops, we give each participant a name tag printed in bold font

so I can continue to address each person by name. When I coach virtual sessions, the virtual platforms make my life easier by showing the names below the images. In all cases, I make it a practice to use a person's name whenever I engage with them.

In addition to stating names, you can also reference words and actions the participants have said and done during the session. “Earlier today, Jennifer asked about...” “Jose said he wanted to be able to...” “During the break, I was speaking with Ron, and he told me that...”

2. Mutual Reference

Refer to a person, a company, or an organization that has connections to you and your audience. Think of a Mutual Reference as a tasteful form of name-dropping. If you are pitching your services to Company A, you could describe the work you did for Company B, which has a close business alliance with Company A; or the work you did for Company C, whose CEO sits on the board of Company A.

IPO management teams scan the portfolios of the investment firms they are about to visit to find companies that are their customers as well. The CEO can then make the mutual connection during the roadshow.

Remember the CFO in Chapter Two who came up with this WIIFY®:

Synergy! Investors usually hold shares of many different companies in their portfolio. Some of those portfolio companies may be our customers or partners. Our success could bring success for their portfolio companies.

3. Ask Questions

Posing questions is an excellent way to engage your audience. Ask your audience to share their experiences, reactions, or opinions. Getting people to think and talk about your subject turns your presentation from a one-way transmission into a two-way interaction, increasing your audience's involvement.

Opening the floor to questions, however, does pose a risk. An audience member's response to one of your questions may raise an irrelevant issue or jump ahead to an idea you will cover later in the presentation. Avoid such detours with a brief reply and promptly return to the main line of your story.

4. Contemporize

Find current events that affect the sector or vertical of your audience—ideally events that occur on the very same day as your presentation. Reference those events. Did Congress pass a new bill? Link to how the legislation will affect the industry. Did the stock market take a sudden nosedive or make a remarkable rally? Mention it and link to how it might affect your audience.

You can also Contemporize right up to the minute. Refer to prior speakers, to statements they made, to earlier questions from the audience, or to moments that occurred from the time you entered the room. Weave these references throughout your presentation at every opportunity.

5. Localize

Localize your presentation by citing information about the city or state that relates to your message. For example, you can talk about a particular client or customer of yours located in the same city and then go on to illustrate the benefits your company provided to that client.

You can cite an interesting fact about the city or state that supports your message: “Last year, more than 500 patients in this city’s hospitals died from drug interactions. Many of those deaths could have been prevented with our automated drug dispensing system.”

Or you can refer to a noteworthy local person, landmark, or incident that has a connection to your subject.

6. LinkedIn

LinkedIn, the social networking service for business, has become an integral part of all business today, and is of particular importance to presentations. LinkedIn provides online access to people’s resumes, allowing presenters to find common ground with the audience. Search to see if you have had contact or experience with any of the companies in a person’s career path and make an appropriate reference. In business, and particularly within any given vertical, the usual “Six Degrees of Separation” is often reduced to three or four.

In my own business, I never begin a program or engage with a person until I have looked at their LinkedIn profile or found other information on the web. I search for what I call “the gingerbread trail” to see if we have mutual contacts or experiences that can enhance our communication.

7. Customized Opening Slide

Begin your presentation with a slide that contains the location and date of your presentation. As an extra touch, include the logo of your audience's company or organization.

A Customized Opening Slide has a powerful effect on both the presenter and the audience. For the presenter, it forces a final double-check to avoid the embarrassment of the wrong slide. For the audience, it sends the message that you've prepared this presentation especially for them—that you've created a custom-made work, tailored to their needs and interests.

■ Customization in Action ■

Roger McNamee, co-founder and managing partner of Elevation Partners, is one of the most influential investors in the technology sector and one of the best presenters I know. He is always in great demand to offer his unique business views at major industry conferences and on television. Roger carefully crafts each speech in advance and is keenly aware of the importance of Customization. In his words:

Speaking engagements are an opportunity to make a difference to a group of people. They can also be great branding opportunities, but only if you do a good job. Failing to optimize every speech for the audience is worse than a missed opportunity. It harms the audience, and it should harm your reputation. If you are not willing to put in the work, do not accept the invitation.

Every audience person is fighting his or her own battle. They look to speakers for inspiration and guidance. If you are entrusted with that privilege, there is an implied contract that you will bring your A game. No excuses.

Reputations have a life of their own, dependent on the perceptions of others. It's like cartoon characters who run off the edge of a cliff: they keep running in space until they realize there is nothing supporting them, at which point they plummet. A reputation works the same way. At the moment when everyone comes to believe that there is nothing supporting you, that your reputation collapses. Public perception is everything.

*It's death if you give a speech or a presentation that sounds like a pre-recorded announcement. Odds are that you don't understand the critical success factors in your business well enough if you don't understand this truth.*³

Roger heeds his own advice. When he published his latest book, *Zucked: Waking Up the Facebook Catastrophe*, he went on an extensive book tour during which he presented about 150 times and made each iteration fresh as a daisy.

Customization is also important in one-off presentations.

Don Listwin, now the founder and chair of The Canary Foundation, a non-profit organization devoted exclusively to early detection of cancer, was for many years the executive vice president of Cisco, second in command to long-time CEO John Chambers. I first met Don when he was a junior product manager and was a participant in a Suasive program in which we prepared a presentation for the launch of a major new Cisco product.

As the launch date neared, Don spent the weekend before the launch Verbalizing his pitch multiple times. On the day before the launch, Don did a trial run in front of an internal Cisco audience and went into autopilot. His presentation had become dry and robotic.

He called me and said, “Jerry, I’ve gone stale! What do I do?”

I reminded Don about the Customization techniques and the next day, just before his presentation, he went into the audience and chatted with several people. Then he stepped up to the stage and began his presentation. Shortly after his Opening Gambit, Don looked at one of the people with whom he’d chatted and addressed him by name. The man smiled, and Don could feel the spark of recognition radiate through the crowd.

Be in the moment.

Of all the many presentation methods I’ve given clients over the years, the Customization techniques are implemented the least. Yet they provide the biggest bang for the buck. Dean Drake’s lesson inspired me and has stayed with me all this time. Make it your big bang for the buck.

■ Preparing for Customization ■

Begin the preparation process early, days or even weeks before the presentation, and continue right up until the moment you approach the front of the room.

Prior to D-Day

- **Research your audience.** Learn all you can about who will be attending: their knowledge level, key interests and concerns, and personal or professional biases. Read their LinkedIn profiles, browse their company websites.
- **Learn the names of key audience members.** Know which people in the crowd are influencers, the highest-ranking company officer, the most respected technical expert, or the manager with the most authority to make decisions.
- **Get current on industry news and trends.** Search out news and media stories and web items related to the company and the industry to which you'll be presenting.

On D-Day

- **Customize your opening slide.** Produce an initial slide that shows the audience, venue, and date of your presentation. Program your presentation software to refresh the current date automatically.
- **Contemporize your presentation.** When you wake up on the day of your presentation, watch the morning business channels on television, read the daily newspapers, and browse the web; use these sources to find items relevant to your presentation and your audience.

Browse websites that list significant events on any given date in history. To add this important dimension to your presentation, find an event that takes place on the day you plan to present that parallels your story and include it in your narrative.*

- **Localize your presentation.** The website Newseum (newseum.org), an interactive virtual museum, provides links to the front pages of newspapers in major cities across the world. If you present to audiences in the cities Newseum covers, you can use the site to find items of local interest on the day of your presentation.
- **Prior to your presentation, mingle with your audience.** Do as Don Listwin did: go out into your audience and chat with several

* Here are additional sources for finding contemporary events: <https://www.history.com/this-day-in-history>; <https://www.onthisday.com>; <https://www.britannica.com/on-this-day>; <http://www.scopesys.com/today/>.

individuals (also known as “schmoozing”). Choose strangers as well as people you know. Ask them questions. Listen to their conversations. Gather valuable information as well as names and facts that you can reference in your narrative.

■ Language ■

We’ve now arrived at the final finishing touch: the words you use to express your story. Think of the ideas in your story as your product and your words as its packaging. Despite the well-known aphorism about the disparity between books and covers, attractive packaging does captivate readers. Captivate your audience with expressive language.

Technical Terms

The fourth of the Five Cardinal Sins is *Too technical or detailed*. A story that is bulked up with language and terminology rife with obscure words, acronyms, buzzwords, and alphanumeric commits this sin. Today, we live in a high-tech world, and such language has become an integral part of our daily discourse. If you are presenting to an audience composed entirely of industry peers, use the alphabet soup of such terms freely.

But these days, any audience is likely to be made up of a combination of techies, technophobes, and tech agnostics. In the spirit of Audience Advocacy, you want every member of every audience to understand every word. So, if you assume that just one person in your audience does not understand a particular term, define it for them. But precede your definition with this phrase:

For those of you who might not be familiar with...

That brief phrase provides a double benefit:

- Those people in the audience who are not familiar feel grateful for the definition.
- Those who are familiar feel as though they are among the elite.

PowerWords

For the final finishing touch, let’s focus on the specific words you use to express your story. The following sections focus on some of the phrases most commonly

used in presentations, each of which will diminish the effectiveness of your story. Each problem phrase is followed by a better, clearer, more assertive way to state the same idea; I call these improvements *PowerWords*.

The first example is perhaps the most common of all.

1. I'd Like to...

Sound familiar? You've probably heard this phrase as often as I have. It's used pervasively not only in business presentations but in political speeches, college lectures, award acceptances, wedding toasts—the list is endless.

The phrase is all about the presenter. It implies that the presenter is making an exclusive decision without any regard for the audience. The phrase is also vague and indefinite. If you'd like to do it, just go ahead and do it. Think about the many times you have been on an airplane and, upon landing, heard the flight attendant say, "I'd like to be the first to welcome you to San Francisco."

How about simply saying, "Welcome to San Francisco"?

The solution: follow the advice from Nike and just do it.

Or you can drop the "like" and make the phrase audience focused, inclusive, and definite:

- "Let me..."
- "Let's..."

2. Like I Said...

This phrase is a backward reference, linking to a point earlier in the presentation. Unfortunately, the phrase implies that your audience didn't understand your brilliant pearls of wisdom the first time you spoke them, and so you are going to have to repeat yourself to bring the laggards up to your speed.

This is not to say that you can't make a backward reference to reinforce earlier content, but do so by giving your audience credit for having understood and remembered (even if they didn't) by saying:

- "As you recall..."
- "We discussed earlier..."
- "You saw..."
- "Remember..."

3. I Want You to Know...

This is another bad attempt to reinforce an earlier point because the phrase sounds demanding. Here, too, you are free to reinforce earlier content, but do it politely:

- “Please note...”

4. I'll Tell You Quickly...

This phrase implies that you're apologizing for your own material and that what you have to say isn't important. Other commonly used variations of the apology are:

- “I'm running out of time...”
- “If you could read this slide...”
- “This is a busy slide...”
- “This isn't my slide...”
- “Disregard this...”
- “Before I begin...”

Never apologize. Again, follow Nike's advice and just do it.

5. We Believe..., We Think..., We Feel...

All three of these phrases express uncertainty and imply doubt. Your job is to project certainty to your audiences. The way to get from doubt to certainty is to avoid doubt by dropping the “believe,” “think,” and “feel.”

I recently ordered new coffee mugs from an online vendor. When they arrived, my wife asked me if they were dishwasher safe. I didn't know, so I queried the vendor's customer service department in an email. The reply came back, “It should be.” Such a reply does not inspire confidence that the cups will survive a trip through the suds.

This is not to say that you should start making forward-looking statements or forecasts in your presentations. Doing so is risky business in this day and age when corporate attorneys, particularly in public companies, insist on avoiding forward-looking statements. They do so by proliferating documents—and presentations—with many “believes.” Nowhere is this more relevant than in IPO roadshows trying to project an attractive opportunity.

The company believes that it will achieve profitability in Q4.

I am *not* going to recommend shifting to a forward-looking statement:

The company will achieve profitability in Q4.

Doing so would be delinquent because if the company were to fail to achieve profitability in Q4, it would risk facing a class action suit for having made a forecast it did not meet. To avoid litigation and avoid using the weak words “think,” “believe,” and “feel,” try these phrases:

- “We’re confident...”
- “We’re convinced...”
- “We’re optimistic...”
- “We expect...”

6. We Aren’t...

Far too many presentations begin with a description of a company’s business by telling what they are *not*. Most human beings, businesspeople in particular, react negatively to negativity. Instead, tell us what you are:

- “We are...”

7. Progress Has Been Made...

When I show this phrase to clients and ask them to identify the problem, they respond:

- “There’s a long way to go!”
- “How much progress?”
- “When will it be done?”
- “What was the progress?”

All of these are accurate descriptions of missing information. But there is one other important factor absent: however much longer it will take, and however little progress has been made, *who* made the progress?

We don’t know because the phrase is formed in the passive voice—without the doer of the action. Did the progress happen by itself? The passive voice diminishes the role of the presenter. Switch to the active voice by adding the doer of the action. Make the presenter the focus of the story.

- “We’ve made progress...”

Many of my clients are highly skilled and educated people with multiple degrees, and many of them have PhDs. But in their years of education, they were trained to follow the formal style of academic writing, which recommends the passive voice as a matter of form.⁴ In business, the necessary form is to be assertive.

State the doer of the action.

Use PowerWords.

■ The Ten Steps of Story Development ■

So far, we've come from a blank canvas to a fully developed story—and we *still* do not have a slideshow. We did this with the Suasive Ten Steps of Story Development, which emerged from the way we produced programs at CBS. There we did not expose a single frame of film, record an inch of videotape, or design a single graphic until we had the story set. The Suasive process always starts with the primacy of the story and only then moves on to slide design, and that process begins in the next chapter.

In its entirety, the Suasive Story Development process has ten key steps.

Suasive Ten Steps of Story Development

1. **FrameForm.** Establish the context of your presentation with your Point B, your audience, and their WIIFs.
2. **Brainstorm.** Explore and capture all your potential ideas in a free flow. Do the data dump in your preparation, *not* in your presentation.
3. **Distillation.** Find the two to six key ideas, clusters, or Roman Columns.
4. **Flow Structure.** Arrange your Roman Columns in a sequential progression using both Inductive and Deductive Logic.
5. **Opening Gambit Sequence.** Capture your audience's attention with a digest of your entire story.
6. **StoryForm.** Wrap your story in a package that has a clear beginning, middle, and end.
7. **Verbalize/Timing.** As Vince Lombardi is said to have advised, "Practice does not make perfect. Only perfect practice makes perfect."⁵
8. **Spaced Learning.** Another look is a fresh look and helps you to discover what might not have been apparent in the first look.

9. **Linkages.** Bind the building blocks of your story with verbal mortar.
10. **Language.** Express confidence with PowerWords.

These steps can be further distilled into Four Key Questions.

■ The Four Key Questions ■

1. What is your Point B?
2. Who is your audience, and what are their WIIFYs?
3. What are your Roman Columns?
4. Why have you put the Roman Columns in a particular order? In other words, which Flow Structure have you chosen?

Every time a client asks me to review a presentation, before I look at a single slide or listen to a single word, I ask these four questions. Apply the same advice to yourself—and to your colleagues, as well. All the members of your team can use the four questions as a checklist to unify messaging. Pose and answer each of these questions for every presentation.

The Four Key Questions in Action

Ford Tamer, the CEO of Inphi Corporation, a company that makes high-speed data movement interconnects, and his CFO, John Edmunds, took the Sua-sive program in 2012, and then proceeded to call on me to support the two of them on earnings calls, presentations, and various documents for shareholder communications.

During the coronavirus pandemic of 2020, Ford asked for my help with a different communication medium: a new blog for the company's website that would address the impact of the crisis on Inphi's operations and financial results.⁶

Those two major themes were the opposite poles of a bad news/good news spectrum for Inphi. The bad: Inphi's operations, like those of every other company in the world, had been constrained by social distancing, sheltering in place, and the phenomenon of millions of people working from home. WFH, the acronym for what many were doing, had become a buzzword of the times and was also a source of good news for Inphi's financial results. Because the company's products provided the technology required to meet the skyrocketing demand for internet bandwidth, Inphi's revenues improved significantly over the previous

year—a modern-day realization of an observation attributed to Mark Twain: “During the gold rush, it’s a good time to be in the pick and shovel business.”⁷

Although a blog is different from a spoken narrative, they are both stories, and they can be developed using the same methodology. As with all our other sessions, before looking at a single word, I asked Ford the first two of the Four Key Questions: “What is your Point B?” and “Who is your audience, and what are their WIIFYs?”

He was ready with his answers: “I want to send a message to the people who look at our website—our customers, partners, investors, and employees—and make them feel that Inphi is in good shape in these trying times. I would like to thank our employees and stakeholders for their support during this unprecedented crisis, discuss the trends impacting internet bandwidth demand in a positive way, and demonstrate how effectively we’re managing the crisis. But...” he added, “I don’t want to come off saying that we’re doing well while everybody else is suffering. That would be like saying, ‘One man’s meat is another man’s poison.’ I want to be empathic.”

“As for the WIIFYs,” Ford continued, “I want our investors to feel confident that we have a solid sustainable business that will continue to deliver differentiated revenue and EBITDA [Earnings Before Interest, Taxes, Depreciation, and Amortization] for the next few years. I want our customers, partners, and employees to know that we are committed to staying the course in investing for the long term. COVID-19 will not slow us down. In fact, we will invest in the crisis to come out of it stronger than ever.”

I asked the third of the Four Key Questions: “What are your Roman Columns?”

Ford replied, “I’ll begin by expressing my sincere gratitude to the first responders—the doctors, the nurses, the police, the emergency personnel—and the service employees—delivery people, post office workers, grocery store staff—all of whom are keeping the rest of us safe and going strong. And, in gratitude to our employees, who are keeping the business running in this difficult time. And finally, to our communities; Inphi and I personally have contributed resources to nonprofit organizations focused on medical supplies and hunger. Then I’ll move onto how the world has changed as a result of the pandemic, what the world has done to adapt, how Inphi has adapted its operations, what lies ahead for everybody, and finally, what all this means for our business.”

“Why have you put them in that sequence?”

FINISHING TOUCHES: EXTERNAL LINKAGES

He replied, “The gratitude is to start with a note of empathy—to set the proper tone. After that, it’s Problem: Operational constraints, and Solution: how we’re managing WFH. And after that, it’s Opportunity: increasing need for bandwidth and speed, and Leverage: Inphi’s innovative products deliver that speed.”⁸

The Four Key Questions work for blogs as well as presentations.

My son, Bixby, the director of sales, Latin America at Twilio, a cloud communications company, recently asked for my feedback on an email he was composing to an important client. He was considering many items to convey to his client and wasn’t quite sure how to organize them. Rather than review the items, I asked, “What’s your Point B, and what are your WIIFYs?”

Although Bixby is quite familiar with my book and coaching and has become an excellent presenter, he had not brought the Four Key Questions from his presentation techniques to email. As soon as he answered those questions and set the context of his message, he composed his email in a few moments.

The takeaway here is that all communications—email, blogs, and reports as well as presentations—are about getting your story straight. The Four Key Questions enable you to do so in a quick snapshot.

Before you deliver your next presentation, ask yourself the Four Key Questions. If you can answer them, pass “Go” and collect your proverbial \$200. If not, reschedule the meeting for when you can.

Now, and only now, are you ready to turn your story into slides, and that process begins in the next chapter.

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Design Your Slides as a Science

Case Studies: Bill Gurley, Benchmark Capital • Jeff Bezos, Amazon • Winston Churchill • Robert Cialdini • Dan Warmenhoven, Network Appliance • True Temper Tools • Joel Goldberg, ABC • Lawrence Lessig • Ludwig Mies van der Rohe • Vinod Khosla, Khosla Ventures • Reid Hoffman, Greylock Partners • William Wordsworth • Irwin Federman, USVP • Phil Knight, Nike • Carolyn Davidson • Andy Warhol • The Beatles

*The purpose of a presentation deck is to enable entrepreneurs to effectively tell the story of their business. In many ways it's like a structured scientific proof....A well-organized deck will gradually transport the listener to the desired conclusion—"this will be a great investment."*¹

Bill Gurley

Benchmark Capital

■ Seeing Is Believing ■

As Bill Gurley's words in the epigraph and, as you read in the introduction, indicate, he sees as much value in slide decks as he does in the art of telling your story. But Bill is also fully aware of the downside of decks:

*Many believe that PowerPoint decks are emblematic of the type of bureaucracy disparaged in Dilbert cartoons.*²

Among those disparagers are the anonymous assassin who coined the phrase “Death by PowerPoint” and Edward Tufte, professor emeritus of Yale University and well-known infographics author, who famously wrote, that the PowerPoint “cognitive style routinely disrupts, dominates, and trivializes content.”³

I disagree with Professor Tufte, the assassin, and the many businesspeople who roll their eyes in pained agreement because they are blaming the pen and not the penmanship. Bad slideshows are the result of operator error, not the software. But I share the disparagers’ frustration with the continuing existence of Twofer slides in business—the pervasive practice of mashing together the functions of a presentation and a document.

■ The Twofer Redux ■

This unholy alliance attempts to force the slides into a dual role: as both a display and a record, both show and tell. Unfortunately, the merging diminishes both functions.

Clearly the solution is to drive a wedge between the two functions. We begin that process by defining the true function of each element, beginning with documents.

Business documents are:

- *Annual reports* filled with dense text and highly detailed tables, charts, and graphs.
- *Strategic plans* filled with dense text and highly detailed tables, charts, and graphs.
- *Market analyses* filled with dense text and highly detailed tables, charts, and graphs.
- *Meeting notes* filled with dense text and highly detailed tables, charts, and graphs.

See the pattern? This level of detail is necessary in documents because they need to stand alone, to be understood by the reader without having anyone present to interpret, discuss, or add value.

So the true problem with slides occurs when presenters take that flood of data—the dense text and the highly detailed tables, charts, and graphs—and, with only a slight bit of modification and abbreviation, recruit them for their presentations, relegating their own narrative to a mere accompaniment.

DESIGN YOUR SLIDES AS A SCIENCE

Many businesspeople act as if the presenter is completely dispensable. They say, “I can’t attend your presentation next week. Just send me your slides.” or “Send me your slides in advance.” The slides are treated as standalone handouts when, in blunt fact of the matter, they cannot and must not stand alone.

Some presenters provide slides as handouts in advance of the presentation in what is known as a “pre-read.” Then, during the presentation, the audience, having seen the slides, sees them again and hears the presenter read what is on the slide—a triple assault on the audience’s senses.

Using slides as handouts is but one manifestation of the Twofer. Presenters pile on even more functions:

- *Prompts* to remember what to say
- *Proof* to demonstrate thoroughness
- *Uniformity* to enable anyone else using the same deck to deliver the same message

If you do need a document of your presentation, all the leading presentation software providers—Microsoft PowerPoint, Apple Keynote, and Google Slides—offer a Notes Page view in which the top of the page contains only the slide image, and the bottom provides the additional content for the handouts (see Figure 10.1).

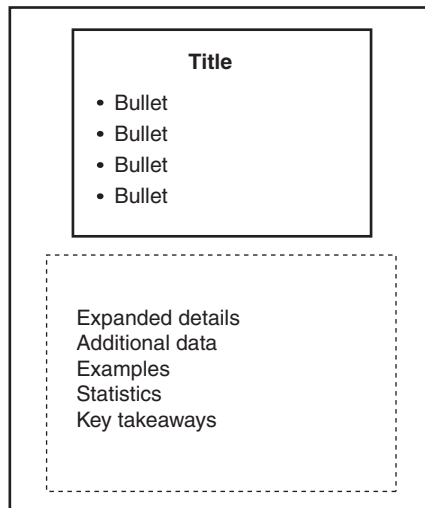


Figure 10.1 *The Notes Page View*

Distribute those Notes Pages only *after* your presentation. If you hand them out before or during your presentation, your audience will flip ahead as you speak and will not listen to what you are saying.

If you're asked to provide a copy of your presentation for a conference so that the slides can be printed in book form, use the Notes Page view. Maintain the single function of your slides as a display.

If you're asked to send your slides in advance—a common practice in venture capital, finance, and investing—politely decline and instead offer to send a business plan or an executive summary. And create that document with word processing—not presentation—software, using complete sentences that do indeed stand alone.

Another negative effect of the Twofer is what happens when a dense slide suddenly flashes onto the screen. The audience immediately—and reflexively—looks at the slide and starts to read. When they start reading, they stop listening. The slides then become the center of attention, and the presenter becomes subordinate to the slideshow, serving, at best, as a voice-over narrator and, at worst, as a ventriloquist.

Compounding the problem, the presenter becomes a reader, too. And the reading often fails to rise above the level of a verbatim recitation. Reciting verbatim is patronizing to the audience. They think to themselves: "I'm not a child! I can read it myself!" The results are a failure to connect, a failure to communicate, and, most likely, a failure to persuade.

And let me remind you that the first time anyone read to you was to put you to sleep; and thus you—and every person in every audience—are forever programmed.

An even worse variant is when the presenter rambles on, talking about content that has nothing to do with what is on the slide. This disparity jams the audience's eyes and ears, producing confusion and annoyance. It's like crossing the video and audio cables on a television set, producing a scrambled image and incomprehensible static.

Jeff Bezos, the founder and CEO of Amazon, got fed up with poor slide-shows. In 2004, he mandated that, for internal meetings at the company, his employees use memos rather than slides, explaining in an email:

*PowerPoint presentations somehow give permission to gloss over ideas, flatten out any sense of relative importance, and ignore the interconnectedness of ideas.*⁴

Then, in a 2018 letter to shareholders, Bezos elaborated:

*We don't do PowerPoint (or any other slide-oriented) presentations at Amazon. Instead, we write narratively structured six-page memos. We silently read one at the beginning of each meeting in a kind of "study hall."*⁵

Bezos could very well have been inspired by Winston Churchill who, according to biographer Erik Larson:

*...was particularly insistent that ministers compose memoranda with brevity and limit their length to one page or less. "It is slothful not to compress your thoughts," he said.*⁶

However, Amazon does communicate in the outside world where slideshows are the *lingua franca* of business presentations. As a *New Yorker* article on the subject put it:

*[T]here are great tracts of corporate America where to appear at a meeting without PowerPoint would be unwelcome and vaguely pretentious, like wearing no shoes.*⁷

Even almighty Amazon understands this fact of life and uses slideshows for their external customer-facing events. One is their annual *re:Invent* conference, in which large audiences attend keynote speeches delivered by Amazon senior executives, guests, and customers, all accompanied by elaborately animated slideshows displayed on five giant screens. *re:Invent* also has multiple break-out sessions⁸ delivered by mid-level executives, also accompanied by slides, to smaller audiences.

Beyond the business and social “no shoes” pressures, there is another important reason to use slides: they reinforce ideas and promote retention, a fact confirmed by nearly 80,000 scientific studies, most of them neurological, found in a JSTOR search at the time of writing.

The best proof of the value of slides was discovered by social scientist Robert Cialdini, PhD, the author of the bestselling *Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion*. In fact, Dr. Cialdini took the benefits of slides far beyond reinforcement and retention and brought them all the way to persuasive results.

To determine the influence of slides, Dr. Cialdini and his team conducted a study in which they asked volunteers to evaluate a fictional high school student for a college football scholarship based on his performance statistics. First, the team presented the statistics to three groups of novices. Each group saw a different level of “technological sophistication of presentation” categorized as:

low [typed summary of statistics] vs. moderate [printed PowerPoint® charts] vs. high [computer-based animated PowerPoint® charts]

Then the researchers repeated the same sequence with three groups of sports experts. Their results:

*Both novice and expert participants were more swayed by the greater the technological sophistication of the presentation.*⁹

As an ancient Chinese proverb tells us:

I hear and I forget;

*I see and I remember.*¹⁰

For this reason alone, slides must and will remain an inextricable part of business communication. To make them effective, however, we must drive that wedge all the way through the separate functions of Twofers. To do so, we need to define the true role of slides.

■ The True Role of Slides ■

A presentation must exist as a pure play. Remember the words of Dan Warmenhoven in his Opening Gambit for the Network Appliance IPO roadshow: “Do one thing and one thing well.”¹¹ If a presentation tries to serve two or more purposes, it dilutes both purposes.

A presentation is a presentation and only a presentation, and never a document. After all, Microsoft provides Word for documents and PowerPoint for presentations. As the old advertising slogan for True Temper tools advised: Use the right tool for the right job.¹²

The *only* role of slides in a presentation is to support the presenter’s story.

■ The Presenter Focus Model ■

The Presenter Focus Model is the same model we see demonstrated on the nightly network television news broadcasts on ABC, CBS, and NBC. (Cable news programs use a different model for their graphics, but that is a subject for another time.) The network anchors present, discuss, and interpret the stories for us.

Yes, the broadcasters use graphics, but they play only a supporting role. The images usually consist of a simple picture and a word or two: a photograph of the Capitol and the words “Tax Debate,” or a medicine vial and the words “Prescription Drugs,” or a man in a hoodie and the words “Massive Hackers Attack” (see Figure 10.2).



Figure 10.2 *News Anchor with Graphics as Headline*¹³

Think of the graphic image as a headline in a magazine or newspaper and think of the anchor’s narrative as the body text of an article. Or think of the graphic image as what is known in television and film as the B-reel, the supplementary footage used to illustrate the main sequence.

My cousin Joel Goldberg worked for more than 25 years as a graphic artist at ABC News. Using elaborate electronic tools, Joel often spent an hour getting the appearance of a single image or word exactly right, with highlights, tints, dimension, shadowing, and other tricks of his trade. That image or word would then appear on the screen behind the anchorperson for just a few seconds before vanishing forever. The prime-time persona is the ultimate model of Presenter Focus.



(Video 17) *Lawrence Lessig | TED2007 | Laws That Choke Creativity*

https://www.ted.com/talks/lawrence_lessig_laws_that_choke_creativity?language=en

The purest role model of this headline approach with presentation slides is Lawrence Lessig, the Roy L. Furman Professor of Law at Harvard Law School. Professor Lessig is an active proponent of reducing restrictions on copyright and trademark laws, and he speaks frequently on the subject. When he does, most of his slides consist of one or, at best, a few words in white text in the center of a black screen, intermixed with other slides composed of simple images. All those images serve only to support the professor's spoken narrative. In his TED talk "Laws That Choke Creativity,"¹⁴ Lessig's illustrated lecture had so many slides it bordered on being a full-motion documentary—evidently the result of extensive preparation and rehearsal.

Given the time constraints of business, Lessig's elaborate approach can only be considered as aspirational. For all your presentations, use the Presenter Focus Model: design your slides as headlines, while you deliver the discussion, analysis, and added value.

■ Less Is More ■

The guiding principle to realize all of the above is Less Is More—the phrase attributed to one of the foremost architects and designers of the twentieth century, Ludwig Mies van der Rohe (1886–1969), the father of the minimalist school of architecture. Mies directed the influential Bauhaus School of Design in Germany in the 1930s¹⁵ and then moved to the United States, where he designed such sleek structures as the bronze-and-glass Seagram Building in New York City.

Mies' famous maxim became the benchmark for many of the most influential designers of our time.¹⁶ Less Is More should be your benchmark when you create your presentation slides, too.

It is mine after years of working in television, with access to the vast tools and capabilities of professional graphic artists like my cousin Joel, who operate in million-dollar electronic control rooms known as "paint boxes." It is mine after

more than 30 years of working with many generations of presentation software programs which have evolved to now having capabilities approaching those of the professional paint boxes. While it is reassuring to have all those powerful tools, when designing slides, I've learned to rely on the wisdom of Less Is More, as well as its corollary: when in doubt, leave it out.

Less Is More in Action

The best metric for validating the Less Is More principle comes from Vinod Khosla, the founder of his own venture capital firm, Khosla Ventures. Vinod is one of the most influential people in Silicon Valley having helped bring hundreds of technology companies to market. Like his colleagues in venture capital, he sees at least as many pitches as a presentation coach—most of them made by entrepreneurs of startup or portfolio companies seeking lifeblood financing.

One of Vinod's venture colleagues, Reid Hoffman of Greylock Partners, described just how high the stakes are:

[T]he classic general partner in a venture firm is exposed to around 5,000 pitches; decides to look more closely at 600 to 800 of them; and ends up doing between 0 and 2 deals. The goal of an entrepreneur is to be one of those deals.¹⁷

During those critical pitch sessions, Vinod applies his “Five-Second Rule”: he puts a slide on a screen, removes it after five seconds, and then asks the viewer to describe the slide. A crowded slide fails the test—and likely the financing.*

Think of every slide in your deck as a highway billboard. Advertisers design these expensive displays for their audiences—seated in automobiles zipping by at high speeds—so that the drivers can take them in quickly.

Your presentation audiences will be stationary, but their minds will be zipping by at high speeds, thinking about emails, text messages, phone calls, meetings, or personal matters. They do not want to spend more brain cycles trying to figure out what you are trying to communicate.

If your slide is designed following the Less Is More principle, your audience will look at it, understand it quickly, and turn back to listen to you. A More Is Less slide will force your audience to spend more time trying to decipher it—during which they stop listening to you.

* For more on Vinod's Rule, please visit my blog: <https://www.forbes.com/sites/jerryweissman/2011/10/26/vinod-khoslas-five-second-rule/?sh=293cd6b26b07>.

■ Nurture and Nature ■

In addition to the Presenter Focus and Less Is More concepts, a third vital element in the presentation equation is your audience and how their eyes and brains process what they see. All human eyes are driven by two powerful—and yet contradictory—forces: nurture and nature. Nurture is what our eyes have learned, and nature is what they do reflexively.

Nurture

In Western languages (English, French, Spanish, Italian), everyone learns to read left to right. In the Middle East (Hebrew, Arabic), everyone learns to read the opposite way, right to left. Because I'm writing this book in English, our fundamental reference point will be the inherent left-to-right movement. Readers of other languages please consider the reverse. Nurture is the primary factor, however, in all languages.

The left-to-right practice has deep roots that go all the way back to Medieval times. A millennium before Johannes Gutenberg invented the printing press, cloistered monks scribed manuscripts by hand on parchment, painstakingly illuminating the first letter in colored pigment or gold or silver leaf at the upper left—indicating “Start here” (see Figure 10.3).



Figure 10.3 *Illuminated Manuscript*

The ornate initial letter tradition continues to this day, not only to start new chapters in fine manuscripts and handsomely printed books but even to start articles in print magazines, newspapers, and on the web; all based on the principle that Western readers' eyes are conditioned to make their first move to the upper-left.

In presentations, the audience's eyes make this same starting movement every time a new slide appears. Then, having made that initial move, nature comes into play with another move—in the opposite direction.

Nature

Suddenly aware that there is more information on the screen, the audience's eyes make another move to take in the new image. This second move is more powerful than the first because it is completely involuntary; the optic nerves react to images instinctively. Audiences can't *not* look at the new information. You experience the same reflex action every day when a pop-up notification appears on your computer or mobile phone. Your eyes quickly dart over to look at the new image. You cannot resist. You *must* look.

In 1798, long before computers, mobile phones, and slideshows, the British poet William Wordsworth wrote of such natural instincts:

The eye—it cannot choose but see;

We cannot bid the ear be still;

Our bodies feel, where'er they be,

*Against, or with our will.*¹⁸

This involuntary action, illustrated in Figure 10.4, is called the reflexive cross sweep.

This left-to-right impulse also plays out in book publishing. The first page of a book, and usually the first page of every chapter, is printed on the right page, known as the recto—from the Latin word for right; the left page is known as the verso—from the Latin for back.¹⁹ While this convention had its origins in ancient woodblock printing, it clearly fulfills any reader's natural impulse to move from left to right after turning to a new page.

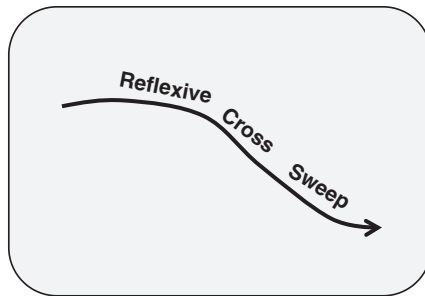


Figure 10.4 *The Reflexive Cross Sweep*

In presentations, the reflexive cross sweep can be down and to the right, or it can be up-and-to-the-right.

Artists often arrange their paintings based on the down-and-to-the-right eye movement. That's why so many painters sign their canvases in the lower-right corner: they know that a viewer's eye sweep culminates at the signature of the creator.

Businesspeople also intuitively follow the reflexive sweep to the right, but they prefer to take the high road, following the desirable growth path of revenue and profits, symbolized by the hockey stick (see Figure 10.5).

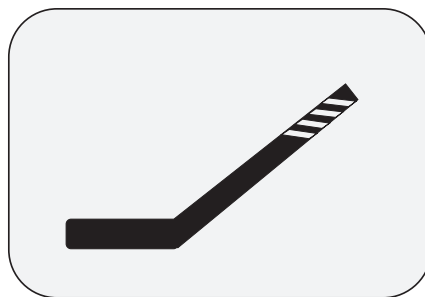


Figure 10.5 *The Hockey Stick Movement, Up-and-to-the-Right*

Irwin Federman, a partner at USVP, a leading Silicon Valley venture firm, appreciates the positive message represented by a hockey stick: he has one on the wall of his office. Irwin has been a founding or lead investor in numerous successful technology companies, such as SanDisk, Check Point Software, Mellanox, MMC Networks, and Crescendo Communications. Before joining USVP, Irwin was the CEO of Monolithic Memories, a company that produced programmable

logic devices and logic circuits. At Monolithic, the VP of sales was Tom Branch, whom Irwin credits with providing the up-and-to-the-right symbolism:

Tom sent me a Wayne Gretzky hockey stick firmly attached to a poster board imprinted with an X/Y axis chart depicting revenues over four fiscal periods, as a reminder of who he was and what I should expect.

It turns out that virtually all new product plans and start-up companies optimistically predict extraordinary sales growth in their out years. So, when Monolithic Memories merged with AMD, I took the hockey stick/poster with me into the venture capital world, where it proved to be generally prescient over a 30-year span.²⁰

You'll read more about how the hockey stick applies to numeric slides in Chapter Eleven.

When Phil Knight founded Nike, he commissioned Carolyn Davidson, a graphic design student at Portland State University, to come up with a logo. Inspired by the company's name, taken from that of the Greek Goddess of Victory, Davidson created the now-iconic swoosh symbol that follows the positive up-and-to-the-right path, as in Figure 10.6.



Figure 10.6 Nike Swoosh

The famous pop artist Andy Warhol also understood the power of the left-to-right dynamic. Early in his career, just before he created his legendary *Campbell's Soup Cans*, he became intrigued with a newspaper advertisement for rhinoplasty. The plastic surgeon had composed the ad with an image of a long nose on the left and a bobbed nose on the right. Warhol enlarged the ad, projected it, and traced it onto the surface of a canvas, titling it *Before and After* (see Figure 10.7).²¹

If Warhol had flipped the position of the images, he would have had to change the title to “After and Before.”

The Beatles also valued the left-to-right dynamic. The cover of *Abbey Road*, one their most famous albums, has a photograph of the Fab Four marching left-to-right in single file across a zebra-striped pedestrian crossing on a street in London called Abbey Road. During the shoot, the photographer snapped six images of the group going back and forth across the intersection. Paul McCartney decided that left-to-right direction was the best.²²



Figure 10.7 Before and After by Andy Warhol, 1961

The final image, and even the outtakes, went on to become expensive collectors' items. And the Abbey Road intersection went on to become one of London's most popular sightseeing destinations, where tourists pose for selfies while following in the Beatles' footsteps, from left-to-right, as in Figure 10.8.²³



Figure 10.8 Abbey Road with Tourists

Whether up-and-to-the-right (as in business) or down-and-to-the-right (as in art), this reflexive left-to-right movement is deeply embedded in every reader, every viewer, and, for our purposes, every audience member. You can feel it yourself as you scan this page or any of the illustrations in this book.

However, there is one significant difference between text and slideshows: when a reader's eyes shuttle across a page in a book or magazine, they move only 5 to 8 inches at a time. In a presentation, when your audience's eyes move from you to a large screen in a conference room or auditorium, they travel anywhere from 2 to 20 feet, depending on the size of the screen. Even when you present from the screen of a laptop or iPad, the distance of the move from you to the screen is still a couple of feet.

In all cases, when a new image flashes on the screen, your audience's eyes make two quick moves: one to the left to start the slide (nurture) and one to the right, either up or down, to take in all the rest of the information (nature).

If your slide is densely packed with images, numbers, and/or text, your audience's eyes will not be able to take in the entire image on the first left-to-right move, and so they will have to come back with a right-to-left move to restart the image, and then make another left-to-right move to take in the rest of the image. This third move will be backward and against the grain. And so will all subsequent moves. The denser the slide, the more times your audience's eyes have to traverse the screen, and the more traverses they make, the less they hear of what you are saying. What little they do hear will clash with what their eyes are seeing—a colossal case of cognitive dissonance.

■ Minimize Eye Sweeps ■

Do you see where we are going? Right back to the Less Is More principle—but now with this new additional principle: minimize the number of times your audience's eyes must travel to understand your slide. Minimize the processing their eyes—and their brains—must do. Let them spend their energy and time focused on you.

Minimize Eye Sweeps.

Nowhere is awareness of eye movement more critical than on the internet. To help create compelling ads and captivating web pages, advertisers and web designers diligently study how viewers' eyes scan images. The designers retain the services of a cottage industry of companies that provide eye tracking software. A Google search for “eye tracking software” produced 142 million results at the time of writing. The first page alone listed six different companies.

Be just as diligent about your audience's eye movements in your presentations. Design all your slides to Minimize Eye Sweeps. Make it easy for your audience, and they will make it easy for you. Beware the alternative!

To implement all of the above, there are two meta design techniques for you to apply to every slide you ever present.

■ The Suasive Meta Design Techniques ■

These two Suasive Meta Design Techniques work in tandem:

- **@ Glance.** Design every slide so that your audience, just like drivers on a highway zipping by billboards, can get it @ Glance. The longer it takes for your audience to understand, the less they listen. @ Glance design shortens their intake time.

To validate that your audience can understand your slides @ Glance, you should be able to describe every slide in one sentence using:

- **TitlePlusSM.** Describe your slide in one sentence, using both the title and the *plus* graphic material—that is, the other elements below the title. To borrow from financial parlance, the title is “Above the Line,” and the *plus* is “Below the Line.”²⁴ The *plus* refers to the bullets, bars, pie charts, diagrams, icons, or images that constitute the larger part of the slide. A cluttered slide cannot be described in one sentence. The TitlePlus combined with the Less Is More design enables your audience to understand the entire slide @ Glance. Once they do that, they will turn back to you to listen as you discuss and add value.

For instance, if you have a slide like the one in Figure 10.9, with the title “Revenue Growth” and four bars, the TitlePlus would be “Here you see how our revenues have grown over the past four years” or “This chart represents how our revenues have grown over the past four years.”

If you have a slide like the one in Figure 10.10, with the title “Product Features” and several bullets, the TitlePlus would be “These are the key features our product provides for our customers” or “These four features make our product the market leader.”

Your audience will understand the slide @ Glance and then turn their attention back to you to listen as you discuss and add value to each bullet.

DESIGN YOUR SLIDES AS A SCIENCE

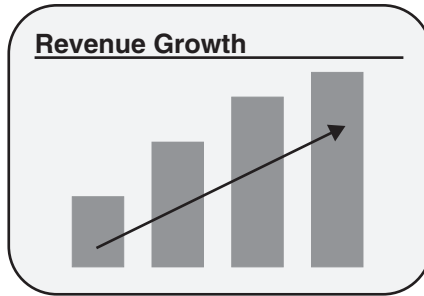


Figure 10.9 *Revenue Growth Bar Chart*

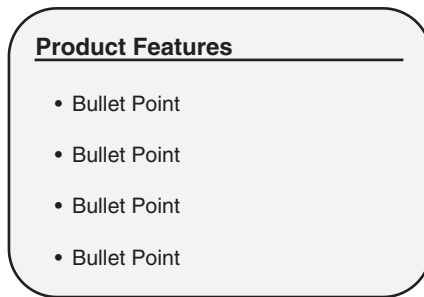


Figure 10.10 *Bullet Chart*

@ Glance and Title*Plus* work in tandem to make your slides easy for your audience to understand in an instant. They also provide a measurable method by which you can design all your slides. Finally, they both address the scientific dynamics that drive your audience's perception. Ignore these forces at your risk.

Slide Design Summary

The five principles of effective slide design are:

- Presenter Focus
- Less Is More
- Minimize Eye Sweeps
- @ Glance
- Title*Plus*

To put these fundamental principles into practice, let's look at the available graphic tools.

■ Graphic Design Elements ■

The graphic options in all the presentation software programs exist in just four basic design options:

Images



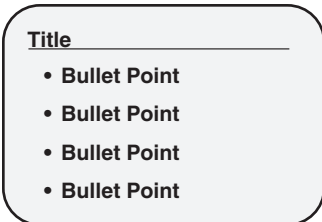
Images: Photographs, sketches, maps, icons, logos, screenshots, and infographics

Tables



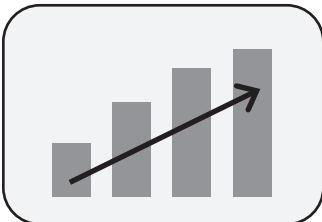
Relational graphics: Tables, matrices, hierarchies, and organizational charts

Text



Text: Bullets and sentences

Numbers



Numeric graphics: Bar graphs, pie charts, area charts, line charts, and histograms

DESIGN YOUR SLIDES AS A SCIENCE

When you choose either of the first two options—images or relational graphics—you achieve Less Is More by default. A picture is worth a thousand words. And a table or matrix, by definition, organizes and digests multiple diverse elements into a unified whole, reducing more information into less imagery.

The last two options, however, are where presenters go wrong. Because of their detailed function in documents, text and number slides often fall into the Twofer trap. You'll find best design practices for these options in each of the next two chapters. The focus in both of those chapters will be on how to create Less Is More slides that your audience can understand @ Glance and that you can describe in a single sentence with a *TitlePlus*.

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Design Your Text as Headlines

Case Studies: Steve Jobs, Apple • Tim Cook, Apple • Guy Kawasaki • Astrid Klein/Mark Dytham, *PechaKucha* • The Six-Word Story • Francis Gagnon, Voilà: • John De Goes, Ziverge • Lawrence Lessig

*EXTRA! EXTRA! Read all about it!*¹

Newsboy shout

■ Headlines ■

Headline writing—capturing the essence of the story in a crisp, concise banner—has been a highly valued art and science ever since the early days of newspaper publishing. Here in the age of the internet, that skill has taken on new imperatives: headlines must now escalate appeal for search engine optimization (SEO) and serve as clickbait to attract prospective online customers.

Unfortunately, the presentation world has not adopted the concept of crispness and concision. Driven by the legacy of the Twofer, most slide decks are weighted down with voluminous verbiage.

But some presenters have broken the mold.

Headlines in Action



(Video 18) *Steve Jobs Introducing the iPhone at MacWorld 2007*
<https://youtu.be/x7qPAY9jqE4>

On January 9, 2007, Apple CEO Steve Jobs—wearing what had become his trademark uniform: black mock turtleneck, blue jeans, and white sneakers—walked onto the stage of the company’s annual Macworld conference.

Behind him was a giant screen displaying nothing more than a big glowing Apple logo.

Today, we’re introducing three revolutionary products of this class. The first one is a widescreen iPod with touch controls.

The screen image shifted to an icon of an iPod and five bolded words: **Widescreen iPod with touch controls.**

The second is a revolutionary mobile phone.

The image shifted again to an icon of a phone handset and three bolded words: **Revolutionary mobile phone.**

And the third is a breakthrough Internet communications device.

The image shifted to an icon of a compass and three bolded words: **Breakthrough Internet communicator.**

So, three things: a widescreen iPod with touch controls, a revolutionary mobile phone, and a breakthrough Internet communications device.

An iPod, a phone, and an Internet communicator. An iPod, a phone—Are you getting it?

*These are not three separate devices, this is one device, and we are calling it iPhone!*²

The image shifted to a pitch-black screen with one large word emblazoned in bold white text: **iPhone.**

Each slide was simple and succinct. The text on each slide was composed as a headline, using adjectives and nouns, no articles or conjunctions, and a solitary preposition. All those other parts of speech, as well as the narrative linkages, were in Jobs' spoken words.

The iPhone went on to revolutionize the technology industry, countless other businesses, the global economy, and even social media. And so did Jobs' launch presentation, which went on to become the benchmark by which all other launches—if not all other presentations—would be measured.



(Video 19) WWDC: Apple CEO Tim Cook Delivers Keynote
<https://youtu.be/1-G1M-EassA>

Tim Cook succeeded Jobs as Apple's CEO and continued to lead the company's growth—and presentation style. At the company's annual Worldwide Developer Conference, Cook walked onto the stage to deliver the keynote.

Behind him was a giant screen displaying only a big glowing App Store icon.

Now the way the developers get to share their amazing work is through the App Store. Your creativity and hard work have made the App Store the best place to get the very best apps. Next month, the App Store turns ten, and in these ten years the App Store has fundamentally changed the way we all live.

The screen suddenly filled edge-to-edge with an enormous digital quilt composed of dozens of app logos.

It's enabled countless new companies, created tens of millions of jobs, spawned entirely new industries, and it has forever changed our lives. The App Store is the world's largest app marketplace.

The image shifted to a pitch-black screen with four words emblazoned in bold white text: **World's largest app marketplace.**

And we now welcome over 500 million weekly visitors.

The black screen changed the text to even larger text: **500 million Visitors per week.**

This is mind-blowing, it's the most incredible app marketplace that the world has ever seen.³

Steve Jobs developed an interest in design long before he started Apple. As a student at Reed College, he attended a calligraphy class taught by a Trappist Monk and, years later, reflected on the experience:

*If I had never dropped in on that single course in college, the Mac would have never had multiple typefaces or proportionally spaced fonts.*⁴

He went on to implant a deep sense of minimalist design in Apple's culture, as is apparent in the sleek, sophisticated look of all its products, packaging, advertising, and messaging. One of Apple's most famous advertising campaigns was "Think Different."⁵ That slogan could very well be applied to how to think about presentations.

During the early glory years at Apple, one of Jobs' disciples was Guy Kawasaki, who carried the weighty title of Chief Evangelist. Guy went on to become a successful Silicon Valley venture capitalist, author, keynote speaker, and podcast host. Along the way, Guy became famous for evangelizing his own "10/20/30 Rule of PowerPoint" for presentations:

*[A] pitch should have ten slides, last no more than twenty minutes, and contain no font smaller than thirty points.*⁶

Guy's rule was echoed by Astrid Klein and Mark Dytham, two Tokyo-based architects, who created *PechaKucha* ("chit-chat" in Japanese), a minimalist presentation format that they popularized around the world. More than 50,000 people present at more than 1,000 of their events every year. The format's guidelines state that:

*PechaKucha is what "Show and Tell" always dreamed of becoming. 20 slides. 20 seconds of commentary per slide. That's it. Simple. Engaging.*⁷

Klein and Dytham admitted that they were motivated to develop the minimalist format "because, well, people talk too much!"⁸

It's a safe bet that Guy and the architects were also motivated to find a remedy for the endless profusion of Twofer slides in presentations. While their intentions are admirable, their rules would be difficult to apply to quotidian business pitches. For the rest of us, and for road warriors in particular, consider the evangelists' rules as aspirational, and apply the following basic design techniques.

■ Bullets Versus Sentences ■

Bullets and sentences, the two options for text slides, are distinctly different entities with separate purposes and forms. A bullet exists to express a key idea and takes the form of a headline; a sentence exists to express a complete standalone idea and takes the form of a proper grammatical structure that contains a subject, a verb, and ends in a period:

The House and Senate pass a bill for education.

Headlines downshift. Look at any digital or print newspaper, and you'll see that the headlines are composed primarily of nouns, verbs, and adjectives. They usually omit the parts of speech that form complete sentences: articles (the, an, a), conjunctions (and, but, or), and prepositions (of, to, by, for, with, through). In the bolded sentence above there are two articles, one conjunction, and one preposition. Transforming the same information into a headline:

Congress Passes Education Bill

Same message, fewer words. No period. Headline versus sentence.

Another sentence:

A software giant will stop providing free upgrades to its new and existing customers.

One article, one preposition, one conjunction, and a period.

Headline:

Software Giant Ending Free Upgrades

Same message, fewer words. No period. Headline versus sentence.

Editors use this shorthand style for headlines with good reason: when they put fewer words into an available space, they can enlarge the size of the font to capture attention. Even more important, when they provide the essence of a story in a few words, their readers can quickly scan a page full of stories and select the ones of interest to them.

Presenters, however, given their devotion to Twofers—as well as their notorious inclination to describe how to construct a clock when asked for the

time—have difficulty being brief. To help overcome that obstacle, let's look at how you can learn to condense.

Headline Development

For decades, numerous workshops, instructors, classes, magazines, newsletters, blogs, and websites have counseled aspiring fiction writers to sharpen their skills by composing a complete story in just *six* words, citing as an example one such story attributed (but never substantiated) to Ernest Hemingway:

*FOR SALE. BABY SHOES. NEVER WORN.*⁹

While this book is about facts and not fiction, you can consider the six-word approach an exercise in concision. Think of it as raising the bar to raise the level of the skill; like practicing tennis with a ball machine to develop the skills necessary to play a real opponent.

For starters, try writing a succinct Unique Selling Proposition for your Opening Gambit that you read about in Chapter Six. You may very well have to go beyond six words, but the exercise drives you toward brevity. You could then move on to writing the titles or bullets of your slides with the guidelines above: use mainly nouns, verbs, and adjectives; and, as best you can, limit your use of articles, conjunctions, and prepositions. If you're diligent enough, you will be able to create your headlines using fewer and fewer words.

For instance, a pie chart showing relative market share could be titled as a sentence:

We have a leadership position in a large market.

Not only is the sentence long, but it is also unclear. A headline makes it shorter and punchier:

Leadership in Large Market

Same message, fewer words. Headline versus sentence.

Use sentences only when you need verbatim accuracy, such as with an endorsement from a customer, a validation from an industry analyst, or a quote from a respected authority. If you do use a quotation, make it relevant and keep it short. Add the value in your discussion.

Do you see where this is going? Right back to the Presenter Focus Model, in which the slides serve *only* as headlines for the presenter's discussion.

Because you will have distilled your ideas into clusters during the Brainstorming process and Verbalized them to the point of familiarity, you can summarize your clusters in brief headline-style bullets that will prompt your fuller discussion. For instance, here are three typical topics that might be part of any business story:

- Breakthrough Product Line
- Exploding Market Trends
- Targeted Growth Strategy

How long would you be able to speak about any of these topics as they relate to your business? Probably for several minutes each, if not longer.

Therefore, as the default for your presentation slides, use the headline approach for all bullets and titles.

■ Text Problems and Solutions ■

In this section, you'll see a progression of text slide problems, followed by the same information expressed more effectively. If you've attended only one presentation in your career, these problems will undoubtedly be familiar. As you look at the "before" and "after" images, please be aware how you Minimize *your own* Eye Sweeps.

Wordwrap

We begin with wordwrap, the most consistent of all text problems because it pervades all text slides. Wordwrap occurs when text is too long to fit on one line and the software automatically continues the text onto a second line. This is very convenient during composition, but in presentations, wordwrap forces the audience's eyes to make four moves: first to the left to start reading, then to the right for the reflexive cross sweep, then back to the left to restart the wordwrapped line, and then to the right to take in that line—violating the Minimize Eye Sweeps principle. You can feel all the moves in Figure 11.1.

PRESENTING TO WIN

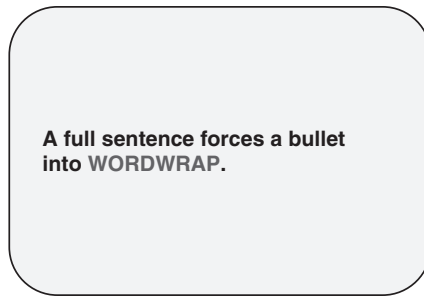


Figure 11.1 *Wordwrap Forces Eye Sweeps*

Headlines remove the unnecessary words, reduce the text to a single line, and Minimize Eye Sweeps. Feel the single sweep in Figure 11.2.



Figure 11.2 *Headlines Minimize Eye Sweeps*

The map of the London tube lines has become one of the most famous graphic images in the world, a cultural icon applied to T-shirts, coffee mugs, and other Anglophile knickknacks. Professional designers have admired the map—praising, studying, and copying it for their own transportation systems. The designers value its highly efficient use of locations, lines, space, and distance to simplify the complex system. But it took Francis Gagnon, the founder of Voilà!, an information design company, to admire the map’s text design. In a Tweet he wrote, “If the London Tube map can use only horizontal text, so can you”¹⁰ (see the map in Figure 11.3).

Francis, whose company is dedicated to conveying complex information visually, clearly appreciates the value of single-line text in design. While this concept is important for readers of maps, it is even more important for presentation audiences because their eyes and brains must process *two* images: the slide—be it a map or a bullet chart or a bar chart—and the presenter. Single-line text is a central element in making that processing easier for audiences.

DESIGN YOUR TEXT AS HEADLINES

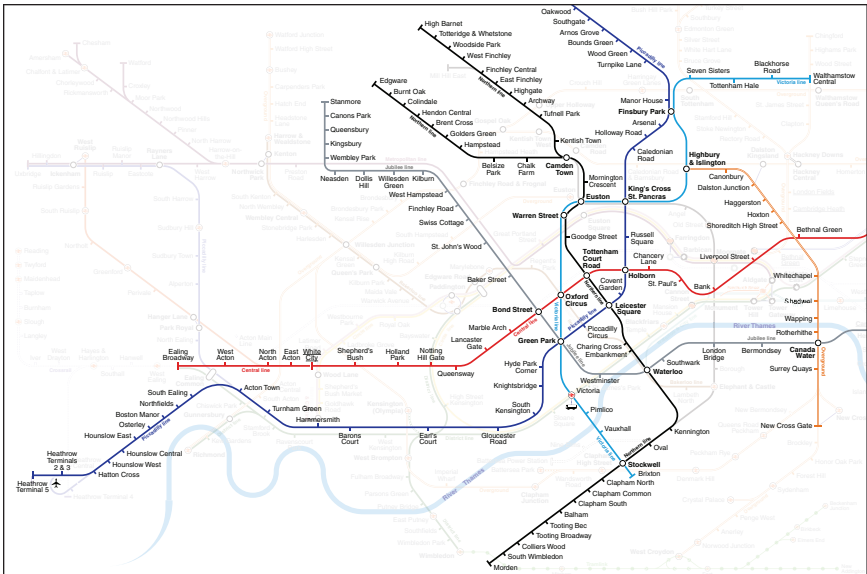


Figure 11.3 Map of Piccadilly metro line in London¹¹

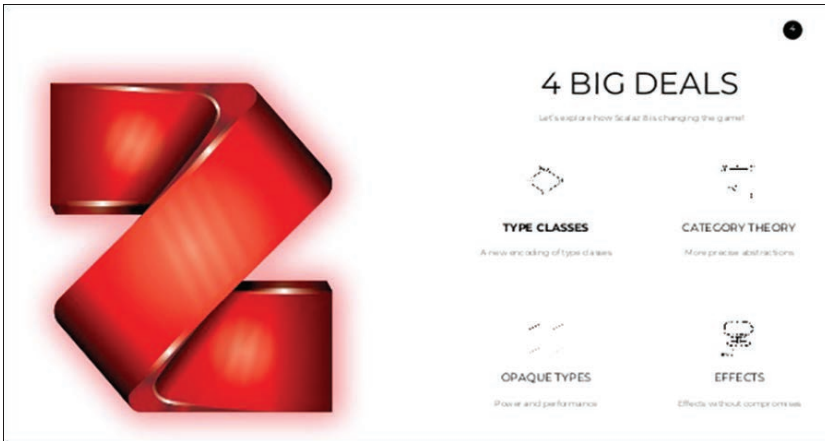
Single-Line Headlines in Action

As you saw earlier, Steve Jobs and Tim Cook used single-line headlines for their slides. You might say that that style works for keynotes, which fly at a 35,000-foot-conceptual level, but that in quotidian presentations, presenters need to provide a deeper layer of granularity.

Not necessarily.

Granularity was very much in order at flatMap (Oslo), in Norway, a conference for technical software developers. One of the presenters was John De Goes, the CEO of Ziverge, a company that designs and develops big and fast data solutions using industry-standard technologies. I found De Goes' deck featured on SlideShare, LinkedIn's excellent source for users to "Discover. Share. Learn... through presentations, infographics, documents and more."¹²

De Goes' subject matter was far above my pay grade, but his use of single-line headlines provided a clear through line of his story. The deck began with a slide showing the "4 Big Deals" of his agenda, expressed in simple icons accompanied by one or two words, as in Figure 11.4.

Figure 11.4 Ziverge Agenda Slide¹³

Mind you, I didn't have De Goes' narrative, but as I clicked through his deck, the single-line titles kept me on track even when he added the Byzantine symbology and text of computer code to his slides (see Figure 11.5).

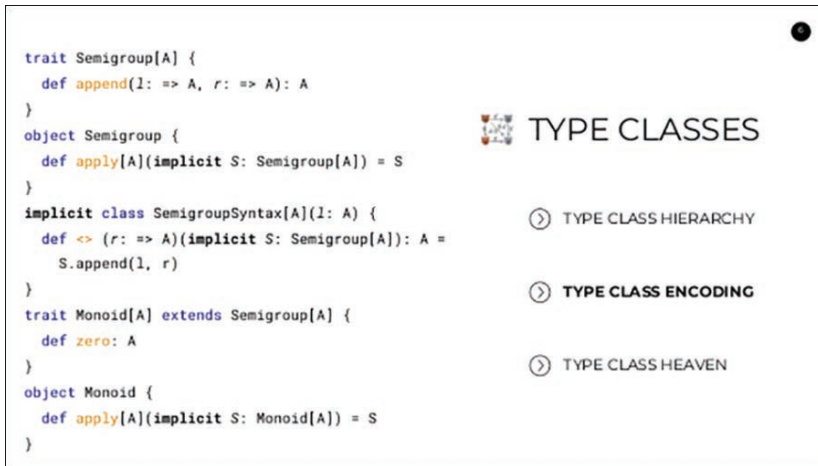


Figure 11.5 Slide from John De Goes' Ziverge Presentation



(Video 20) *scalaz 8: A whole new game (John A. De Goes)*
<https://youtu.be/sFGnFKMSmL0>

Because the slides cannot stand alone, I searched further and found the video of De Goes' presentation. Sure enough, his verbal narrative validated his

flow—and validated the Presenter Focus Model: the slides serve *only* to support the presenter's discussion.

Text Slides

Text slides continue to be the workhorse of business presentations and, despite all the advice to the contrary, also continue to be generated as Twofers. Presenters load up such slides for their document function, but they truncate the bullets, resulting in a bastard form that is neither a document nor a slide, as in Figure 11.6.

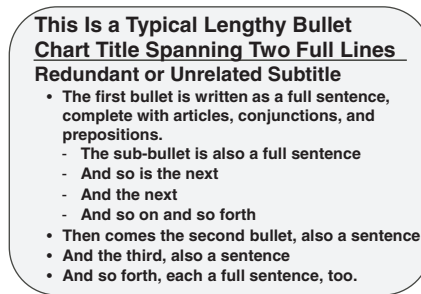


Figure 11.6 *Twofers Text Slide*

Look familiar? When I show this slide during my programs, my clients' groans, snickers, and eye rolls are proof that slides like this are all too common. Such a slide needs radical surgery, as in Figure 11.7.

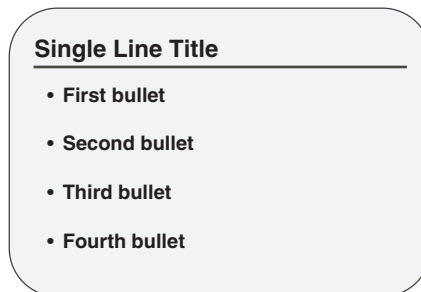


Figure 11.7 *Less Is More Text Slide*

Here's what changed:

First, the two-line title was too long. Wordwrap causes an extra eye sweep. By reducing the two-line title to a single-line headline, your audience gets it in one sweep @ Glance.

Next, the subtitle is gone. Subtitles often do nothing more than repeat the content in the title or introduce brand new content that has nothing whatsoever to do with the title. This makes the audience work hard not only to interpret the new information but also to try to figure out its relationship to the main title. *Whew!* Worse still, is the subtitle that follows the pervasive apocryphal belief that the message of the slide should be upfront, in the title or subtitle. Unfortunately, this misguided practice contradicts the Presenter Focus Model.

If you do use a subtitle, choose one that clearly relates to the main title. Better still, omit the subtitle and deliver your message yourself.

The first bullet had all the parts of speech that make it a complete sentence and produces wordwrap. More eye sweeps for the audience. Make it a single-line headline. Make all the other bullets and sub-bullets single-line headlines as well.

Now for a fine but important point: in common practice, many presenters indicate sub-bullets in slides with dashes. Many writers do the same in their documents, and so do people who scribe on whiteboards. A dash is a minus sign and indicates a loss to a businessperson, and particularly, to a financial person. Perhaps these number crunchers won't make that connection, but why risk sending a negative subliminal message?

You could change the default symbol to a dot, which is an improvement but still clutters the slide. Eliminate the Morse code effect of dots or dashes by using dots for only the main bullets and none for the sub-bullets, simply tabbing them instead. The space creates an offset and makes Less out of More.

Finally, do you really need all those sub-bullets? Most likely not. Sub-bullets often add a layer of complexity and an extra burden for the audience without any offsetting benefit. You can readily provide the content of the sub-bullets in your discussion.

That's how to design a Less Is More text slide.

Text Slide Guidelines

Now, having been separated from its document function, the text slide is ready to serve its pure display function with these simple guidelines:

- Each text slide is about one unified concept, expressed in a single-line title.
- The subtitle is best omitted.

- You can describe each slide with a *TitlePlus* so that your audience can get it @ Glance.
- Bullets contain only key words such as nouns, verbs, and modifiers. Avoid articles, conjunctions, and prepositions. Especially avoid prepositions; not only do they add extra words, but they also juxtapose and separate the important words. See the difference between:

Strengths of Our Company

Company Strengths

To make your text slide clean and crisp, try to follow the 4×4 formula: four lines down, four words across; or, if the subject warrants, go up to 6×4: six lines down and still no more than four words across.

Line Spacing

Let's say you've followed the 4×4 rule for your bullet slide, and it looks like the slide on the left in Figure 11.8. All the bullets are bunched up in the top half of the slide, leaving the bottom half empty. Not only does the image appear top heavy, but the empty space causes the audience to wonder to think that there are more bullets to come.

Instead, create a balanced image by distributing the bullets evenly over the entire slide with proportional spacing, as in the slide on the right.

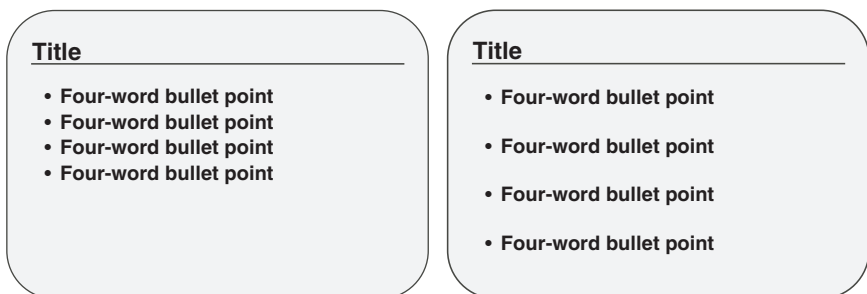


Figure 11.8 *Four by Four: Top Heavy Versus Proportional Spacing*

Parallel Grammar

Please read the bullets in Figure 11.9.

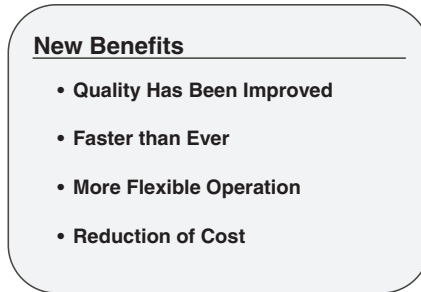


Figure 11.9 *Bullets Composed with Different Grammatical Structures*

Took you a while, didn't it? That's because each of the bullets has a different grammatical structure and each starts with a different part of speech. The first bullet starts with a noun, the second with an adjective, the third with an adverb, and the fourth with a noun. This composition is akin to the "floating decimal" in accounting, where a series of numbers is represented with irregular decimal places, making the numbers difficult to read—anathema to any financial person. In bullet slides, the irregular composition of bullets is anathema to your audience because it forces them, as it did you, to restart their thinking at each line, taking longer to process.

To avoid this distraction, create the list of bullets using parallel grammar, in which each bullet starts with the same part of speech. In Figure 11.10, each of the bullets starts with the same part of speech: an adjective. The audience gets it @ Glance—in less time. Feel the difference as you look at it.

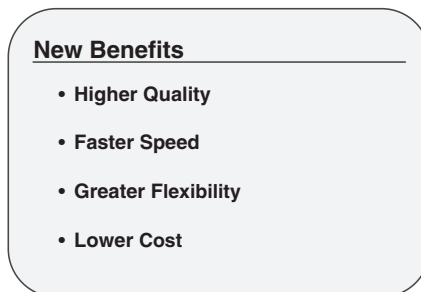


Figure 11.10 *The Same Information as in Figure 11.9, but Now with Parallel Grammar*

Because all the bullets are related in subject and form, you can display all of them at once.

Parallel Grammar in Action

Bill Colston—the CEO of Sestina Bio, a life sciences company with a technology platform that marries genetic engineering to digital biology—developed a deck to pitch for financing. To describe Sestina’s investment thesis, Bill designed a slide with parallel grammar in which each single-line bullet began with an adjective, as in Figure 11.11



Figure 11.11 *Sestina Bio Investment Thesis Slide*

Sometimes parallel grammar isn’t possible, even if all the bullets relate to a central idea, as in Figure 11.12.



Figure 11.12 *Central Idea with Diverse Bullets*

In such a case, you can still display all the bullets at once but, as always, first identify the central idea with your Title*Plus*: “These are the dynamics that impact our marketplace.” Then go on to discuss each bullet.

Bullet Levels

Some presenters are not satisfied with one bullet level and so, to elaborate on their ideas, they add another sub-bullet level. For other presenters, this isn’t enough either, so they add a sub-sub-bullet level. And some presenters, surrendering to their inner document spirit, go deeper, deeper, deeper, and deeper—all the way down into the sub-basement, as in the slide on the left in Figure 11.13.

If you do use sub-bullets, limit them to one level and distribute the same number of sub-bullets at each level. If the first bullet has two sub-bullets, then every other bullet should have two sub-bullets. Create symmetry in your slide and pattern recognition in your audience, as in the slide on the right.

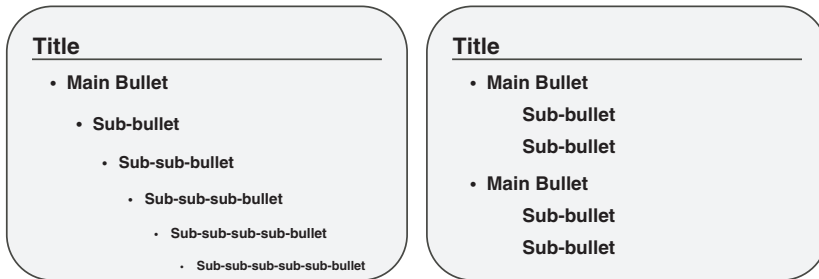


Figure 11.13 *The Wrong and Right Way to Design Sub-bullets*

Remember, too, to avoid the Morse code effect by eliminating symbols for sub-bullets. Instead, indent to create an offset. Use symbols only for the main bullets. Less Is More.

Line Breaks

Some text slides, such as a corporate vision statement or a branded company description, are composed of carefully crafted and painstakingly agreed-upon words that cannot be altered and cannot fit onto a single line, as in the slide on the left in Figure 11.14. However, the line breaks make this composition confusing: the adjective “Premier” is separated from “Producer,” the noun it modifies; the adjective “Leading Edge” is separated from “Technologies,” the noun it modifies; and the same fragmentation occurs with “Broad” and “Market Opportunities.”

Instead, keep each adjective on the same line as the noun it modifies. As you can see in the slide on the right, it makes for a smoother sweep of the eyes.

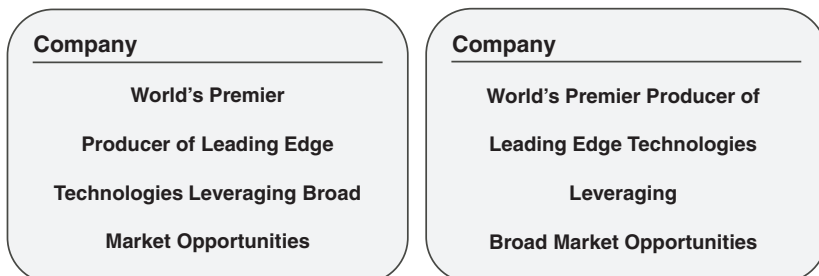


Figure 11.14 *Fragmented Versus Logical Line Breaks*

Punctuation of Possessives and Plurals

The world is divided into casual and aggressive readers, the latter being those detail-driven people for whom the rules of punctuation, as well as those of grammar, spelling, and syntax, are observed, practiced, and proselytized with religious zeal. Among their most impassioned causes are the Oxford comma and single spacing after a period. These matters relate to punctuation in the more orthodox rules of fiction and nonfiction, which are outside the scope of this book's focus. However, there is one undisputed rule of punctuation that is frequently violated in presentation text slides. Because one of those aggressive readers could very well be in your audience—as the decision maker—you can avoid their displeasure by diligently following this rule:

The apostrophe plus “s” (’s) has *only* two uses:

- To indicate a possessive (IBM’s new product, the company’s headquarters)
- To indicate a contraction in which a word or phrase is shortened by omitting one or more letters (I’ll, can’t, you’d, haven’t, wouldn’t, shouldn’t, couldn’t)

Unfortunately, some people mistakenly use the apostrophe “s” for plurals, or for the plural forms of acronyms or numbers. The incorrect usage in the slide on the left in Figure 11.15 would immediately set off red flags for those aggressive readers.

The correct way to indicate the plural of acronyms is with a lowercase “s” and no apostrophe, as in the slide on the right.

Title		Title	
	OEM’S		OEMs
	VAR’S		VARs
	PC’S		PCs
	ASP’S		ASPs
	SKU’S		SKUs
	20’S		20s

Figure 11.15 The Wrong and Right Way to Form Plural

In the slide on the left in Figure 11.16, the two instances of apostrophes would also set off red flags because they are intended for different meanings: the

first is for plural form of the acronym CD, and the second for possessive form of CD. But the plural usage is wrong.

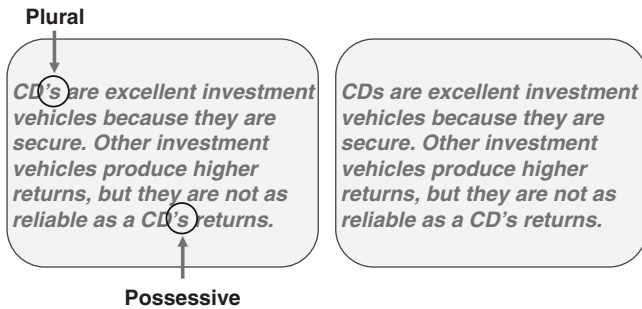


Figure 11.16 One Acronym, Two Meanings, Two Different Uses of Apostrophes

The correct way to indicate the plural is with a lowercase “s” and *no* apostrophe, and the correct way to indicate the possessive is *with* an apostrophe, as in the slide on the right.

You might protest, “Wait! What about the M&M’s brand logo in Chapter Six? It has an apostrophe after an acronym for plural!” Yes, it does, but that usage is correct because the apostrophe is actually a possessive of the original name of the company, “Mars & Murrie.”¹⁴

The apostrophe “s” for possessive is necessary in sentences, but, because text in slides is headlines and not sentences, you can exercise literary license and omit the apostrophe “s.” Look at the difference:

IBM’s New Product

New IBM Product

Eliminating the extra character makes the text easier for the audience to read and faster for them to comprehend.

■ Visual Style ■

Despite all the preceding exhortations from me and from countless other consultants, as well as aggrieved audiences, the Twofer legacy continues—for good reason: those same audiences continue to request documents of presentations, and audiences, like customers, must be served.

In all fairness, I must admit that the design of Twofer text slides has improved over time. Many have added pictures, icons, tables, and infographics, but text still dominates. And while many text slides have moved the design meter needle closer to Less Is More, there is still room for improvement.

Take, for example, the slide on the left in Figure 11.17. Although it follows all the preceding recommendations—single-line bullets, parallel grammar, one sub-bullet level, and each bullet with the same number of sub-bullets—it is utterly vanilla bland in appearance. Reading a slide like this feels like a chore.

You can make the slide more interesting and easier to read by simply embedding the text in rectangles of a contrasting shade or color, as in the slide on the right. All this without adding or subtracting a single letter.

All the software programs have design toolboxes with countless options such as fill, font, and line colors, textures, shadows, reflections, soft edges, 3D, and a wealth of shapes in which to embed text. All these options, however, are matters of individual choice and, as the Latin maxim tells us, *De gustibus non est disputandum*: in matters of taste, there can be no dispute.

Insurance Solution

- **Dealership**
Facilities, Inventory, Employees
- **Employees**
Life, Health
- **Customers**
Warranty, Collision, Liability
- **Management**
Patents, Libel, Work Stoppage

Insurance Solution

Dealership	Facilities, Inventory, Employees
Employees	Life, Health
Customers	Warranty, Collision, Liability
Management	Patents, Libel, Work Stoppage

Figure 11.17 Identical Text With and Without Visual Styling

What is indisputable is the perpetual requirement to implement Audience Advocacy. Make every slide you show understandable to your audience @ Glance.

Rather than wade into the style waters with specific recommendations, let me offer you a few high-level guidelines. Follow them, and you can avoid the common design distractions that occur when presenters dip too eagerly into their toolboxes, and their More slides become Less effective.

Font

Presentation software programs provide dozens of different font styles (Arial, Calibri, Verdana, Times New Roman, etc.). Some cost-conscious presenters might

think, “We’ve paid for all these fonts, so let’s amortize the cost and use them all!”—and they produce slides that look like ransom notes, as in the slide on the left in Figure 11.18.

Keep it simple. Send the same message in fewer fonts, as in the slide on the right.

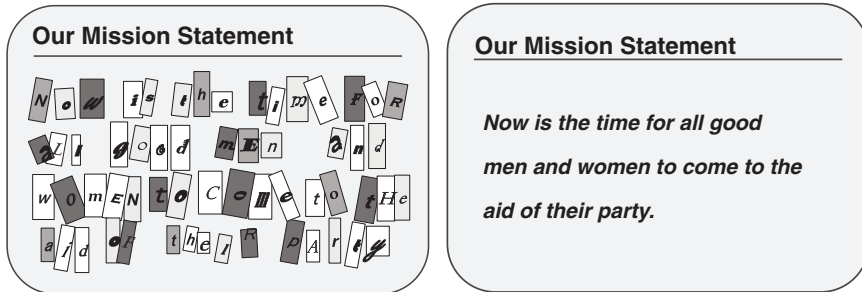


Figure 11.18 Ransom Note Versus Less Is More

Resist the temptation to get too creative with your font choices. Use two or, at most, three different type styles for the entire presentation. The result will be a unified look that conveys a clear, consistent message.

A simple and easy way to add style is to use one font for the titles and another for the bullets. Another is to use two different sizes of the same font, a larger one for titles and a smaller one for bullets; or to use one color for titles and another for bullets.

Gradient Shading

A frequently used style option is to apply gradient shading to the background color such that the chosen color or shade starts at one intensity at the top and progressively changes to another intensity at the bottom, as in the slide on the left in Figure 11.19. This looks cool at first, but you quickly realize that the last bullet is difficult to read. Not to worry, there’s always another bell or another whistle in the design toolbox. One is a double gradient, as in the slide on the right.



Figure 11.19 Gradient Shading Looks Cool but Is Hard to Read

But now you realize that you can't read the first bullet! The beat goes on. And some presenters do indeed go on to add stripes, borders, edges, and cornices. **More Is Less!**

Some of the most effective slideshows have a solid all-black background, as in Steve Jobs' iPhone launch pitch, the Netflix IPO roadshow, and Lawrence Lessig's TED talk; or an all-white background, as in John De Goes' slides in Figures 11.4 and 11.5.

Contrast

Make legibility the absolute default in all your slides. Contrast the text from the background. Graphic designers use a technique called *reverse out*, in which the foreground is set off from the background—for example, light text on a dark background or vice versa. The simplest illustration is in monochrome, as in Figure 11.20.

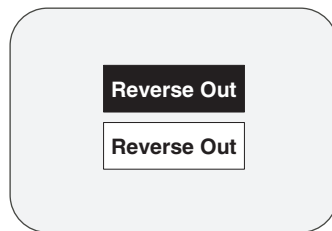


Figure 11.20 *Reverse Out for Contrast*

Color Contrast

You can also create contrast by applying the reverse out effect with color. The main colors of the spectrum are red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, violet; schoolchildren learn to memorize this list by its acronym, ROY G BIV. The given name represents the warm colors, and the surname the cool colors, with green in the middle. Create the reverse out effect with a warm color over cool, or a cool color over warm.

The point here is the same as where we began: *Less Is More*. Many presenters get carried away with the plethora of fancy design toys available. Choose one or two graphic effects that will enhance the clarity and attractiveness of your slide design. Select a limited color palette—two or three colors at most—to complement the colors in your company logo and use them consistently.

Take as your aspirational role model Lawrence Lessig and his minimalist illustrated lectures. The number of slides he uses is a bridge too far for frequently given business pitches, but you can aspire to the spirit of his intent.

Finally, to optimize all your text slides, follow this checklist:

Text Guidelines

- Create a consistent look and feel design template and maintain it throughout.
- Be consistent in your choice of font, as well as in your choice of case.
- Keep text size to a minimum of 24 or 28 points.
- Avoid abbreviations.
- Use contrast or reverse out to create legibility.
- Display your company logo but treat it as a watermark, with a subtle, embossed effect, rather than as a neon sign.
- Avoid the familiar clutter of datelines, copyrights, and the ubiquitous “Company Confidential” notice on every single slide. If the latter is required by your company, make it as small as possible and keep it in the periphery.
- Use blank space. You don’t have to fill every nook and cranny of every slide with information. Newspaper advertisements are sometimes composed with just an image or a line or two of text in the middle of a full page of white space. Find such an ad and see how it stands out, particularly in comparison to ads filled with text. Learn to value the cleanliness of blank space.

You’ll notice that I haven’t mentioned serif and sans serif fonts, text justification (right, left, center), or case choice (uppercase, lowercase, sentence case, initial caps). These typographic style points are matters of individual taste, and for them, I restate the Latin phrase *De gustibus non est disputandum*.

Follow these guidelines, and your text slides will be simple, consistent, and, best of all, helpful to your audience.

In the next chapter, you’ll see how the same basic principles that create effective text slides also apply to numeric slides.

Design Your Numbers as Visuals

Case Studies: Mark Hanna • *Jerry Maguire* • Hans Rosling • Patrick Spence, Sonos • Mitesh Dhruv, RingCentral • Bill Colston, Sestina Bio • Ford Tamer, Inphi

There are two things that are important in politics. The first is money and I can't remember what the second one is.¹

Mark Hanna

■ The Vital Importance of Numbers ■

What Mark Hanna, once the chair of Republican National Committee, said about politics can also be said of business. Money and the numbers that track the money are the life force and stock-in-trade of every company. The keepers of that valuable stock are the financial people who tally, sort, analyze, dissect, report, and present results.

Every person who works in finance is familiar with the common boilerplate section “Management’s Discussion and Analysis” that appears in many financial documents. Also known by its acronym MD&A, this passage of text accompanies numeric charts and tables.

MD&A, then, is a perfect analog for the role of the presenter, which brings us right back to the Presenter Focus Model. Just as presenters must go beyond the text headlines to add value, they must also go beyond numeric charts and

tables to add discussion and analysis. Numbers, even more so than text, cannot speak for themselves. The MD&A model applies to *anyone* who presents numbers.

To fulfill that role, you must design your slides to serve as support for your narrative. As you think of the function of numeric slides, think of the famous slogan from the Tom Cruise film *Jerry Maguire*: “Show me the money!”

But slides cannot show the money with the detail required in a standalone financial document, where the reader, as the audience to the absent writer, needs complete information to understand and evaluate the numbers. If a presentation slide contained that level of detail, the audience would be forced to make multiple eye sweeps to process all the numbers, and their minds would be simultaneously processing what their eyes were seeing.

Game over!

■ The Quest for Imagery ■

In their perpetual search to express numbers clearly, businesses turn to Data Visualization, a burgeoning cottage industry focused on the visual representation of information, data, and numbers using charts, graphs, and maps. Although the concept has been around since prehistoric cave drawings, Data Visualization capabilities have escalated with the advent of technology. A Google search for the term at the time of writing produced 159 million results, showing countless software programs, schools, courseware, consultants, books, associations, and professional conferences.



(Video 21) *Hans Rosling's 200 Countries, 200 Years, 4 Minutes—The Joy of Stats—BBC Four*
<https://youtu.be/jbkSRLYS0jo>

The supreme exemplar of Data Visualization is the late Hans Rosling, the Swedish physician, academic, and public speaker. In a BBC documentary called *The Joy of Stats*, Rosling displays a scatterplot chart that shows 120,000 numbers, 200 countries, and 200 years, but he does so with exquisite simplicity. Striding

into a large empty room, Rosling opens a transparent floor-to-ceiling screen in front of him and swipes the lines of the x- and y-axes onto the screen. Speaking all the while, he pops transparent animated bubbles of different colors onto the screen. As the bubbles dynamically change size and move, he tells his entire story in just four minutes.

You may never get to use the sophisticated display technology that Rosling used, but you can use his simplicity as your role model when you design your slides with conventional software programs.

■ Design Techniques for Numbers ■

We begin at the meta level with the five overarching principles of effective design for all slides:

- Presenter Focus
- Less Is More
- Minimize Eye Sweeps
- @ Glance
- *TitlePlus*

To apply this guiding quintet to numeric slides, let's use the Problem/Solution approach for each of the major categories that display numbers, beginning with bar charts.

Bar Charts

We begin with one of the most frequently used—and frequently abused—charts, the bar chart (see Figure 12.1).

Just as we did with the busy text slides, this one needs radical surgery. Figure 12.2 shows the post-operative results.

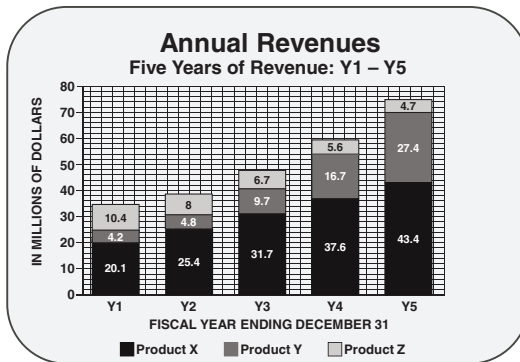


Figure 12.1 *How Not to Design a Bar Chart*

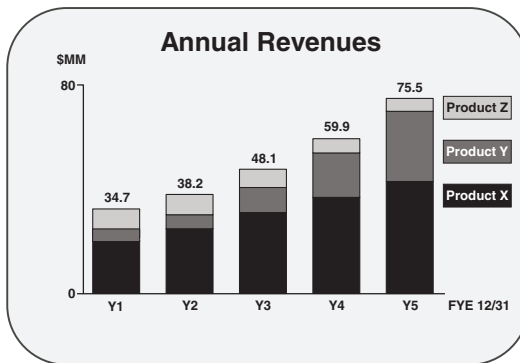


Figure 12.2 *The Same Bar Chart, Simplified*

Here's what changed:

First of all, the subtitle is unnecessary because it repeats the same information as the title, and the graph shows five bars with the years clearly marked.

The first chart had two labels, one at the left side standing on end ("IN MILLIONS OF DOLLARS") and one sprawled out across the bottom ("FISCAL YEAR ENDING DECEMBER 31"). A little information occupying a lot of real estate.

To simplify, the latter is abbreviated with the familiar acronym FYE, as is the dollar amount, as MM. You can also use M, as both forms are acceptable among financial professionals.²

Please note that to be general and universal, in this slide and all other numeric slides in the book, the years are represented as Y1, Y2, Y3, etc. This approach also avoids repeatedly reminding your audience that they are in the third millennium.

When you show the actual years in your slides, omit multiple iterations of “20” and show only the decades, using an apostrophe to indicate the contraction, *e.g.*, 'X1, 'X2, 'X3, etc. And if you are showing quarterly results, you can achieve further brevity by representing the months as digits rather than letters.

There were 31 numbers on the first slide: 9 along the y-axis, 14 on the five bars, the 5 dates along the x-axis, and 3 numbers in the subtitle and an axis label. The five bars depicting revenues were each subdivided into three different tinted sections, representing three different products. For good measure, all this data was backed by grid lines that looked like bargain basement bamboo shades.

Does the audience really need the dollar figure for each product? Depends on the context. In this case, because the title indicated that the focus was annual revenue growth, the individual figures for each product are not needed. If the focus were to be on the products, the numbers remain and the title would change.

If the audience wanted to know the dollar value of a particular year, they would have to swing their eyes back and forth between the y-axis and the individual bar, Ping-Pong style—a futile search because, at a distance, the human eye can't find the exact tick mark. Minimize Eye Sweeps by placing the total amounts directly on top of each bar; and to indicate the range of the y-axis, show only the minimum and maximum amounts of the scale.

When the legend is at the bottom of the slide as in Figure 12.1, to identify the different shaded/colored segments, the audience must drop their eyes down and up again, repeatedly, like a yo-yo. Did it make you dizzy?

Minimize Eye Sweeps by moving the legend from the bottom all the way up-and-to-the-right—at the end of the eye sweep. For further clarity, embed the label text in large rectangles as opposed to using the conventional but hard-to-see little squares. Match the color or shade of each rectangle with the color or shade of the segment on the bar, and position the rectangle immediately adjacent to each segment.

Feel the sweep @ Glance.

PRESENTING TO WIN

Now you have just four simple guidelines to design effective bar charts:

- Locate the numbers on top of the bars.
- Design the y-axis with only minimum and maximum amounts.
- Color-code or shade the labels with legible size text.
- Minimize search.

Bar Charts in Action

Patrick Spence, the CEO of Sonos, whose IPO roadshow story you read about in Chapter Five, wanted to demonstrate the market potential for investors by showing four different positive trends. Because all the trends were heading in the desirable up-and-to-the-right direction, Patrick decided to put all four bar charts on a single slide for cumulative effect. He kept the four charts simple by positioning the numbers directly on the bars and omitting all the y-axes (see Figure 12.3).

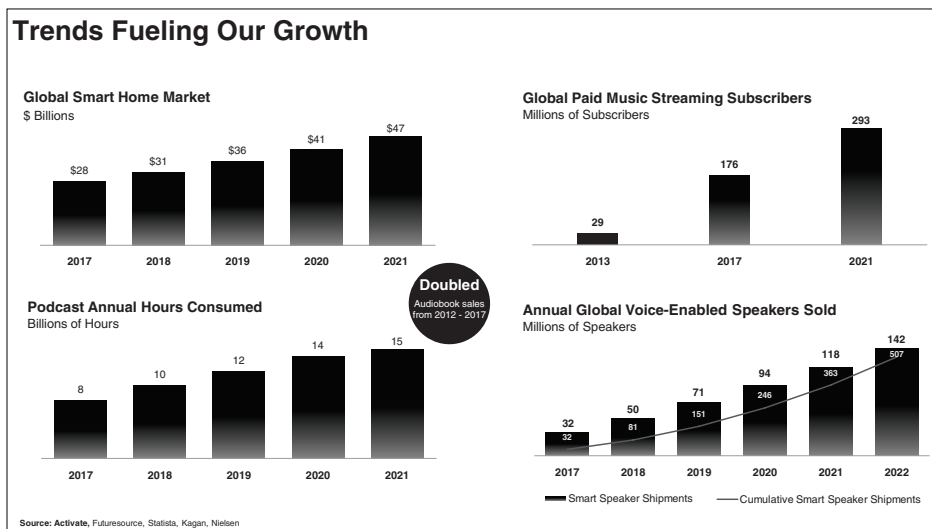


Figure 12.3 Sonos IPO Roadshow Bar Chart

Mitesh Dhruv, the CFO of RingCentral, a cloud-based communications company, also decided to use a complex bar chart to describe his financial model in a presentation to analysts. Although he referenced three factors (percentages,

amounts, and dollars) to illustrate net booking and revenue growth, Mitesh simplified his slide by placing the relevant numbers on and between a set of color-coded bars and progressively animated them during his narrative (see Figure 12.4).

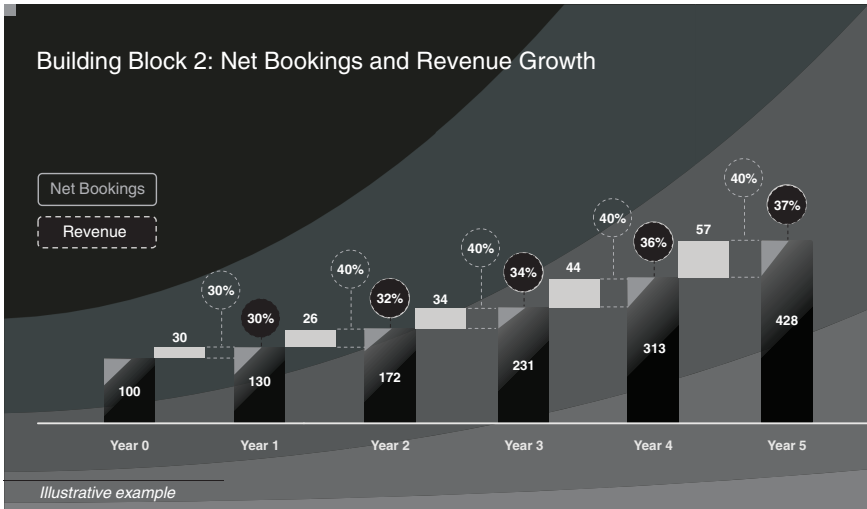


Figure 12.4 RingCentral Bar Chart

In his MD&A, Mitesh discussed how the compounding impact of net bookings growth eventually translated to overall revenue growth for a SaaS model. He concluded by saying that net bookings was a pre-cursor to the SaaS business model and resulted in improved shareholder value at RingCentral.

You'll note that all the preceding bar charts are two-dimensional in keeping with a minimalistic approach. Some financial people prefer to show bars and pies in three dimensions but, as with text in the previous chapter, the choice is a matter of individual taste. *De gustibus non est disputandum*.

Text Position on Bar Charts

In the slide on the left in Figure 12.5, the letters in the label ("REVENUES") are stacked one on top of the other—which causes the audience to make eight eye sweeps. *Whew!*

Showing the label REVENUES in a horizontal or landscape view, as in the slide on the right, enables the audience to see it in one sweep.

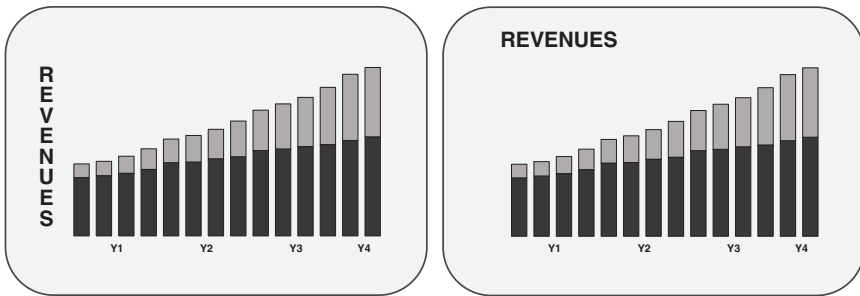


Figure 12.5 *Portrait Versus Landscape Title*

A related version of the stacked vertical label is the label on end, as in Figure 12.6.

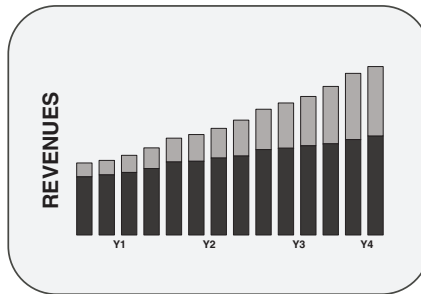


Figure 12.6 *Vertical Title on End*

This practice is a carryover from documents, in which readers can rotate the physical copy to read the word REVENUES. In a projected presentation slide, however, the audience members are forced to rotate their heads in an adult variation of the children’s game, Simon Says: “Simon says, ‘Left ears on left shoulders!’”

Make the label legible by showing it in a horizontal or landscape view, as in slide on the right in Figure 12.5. Minimize Eye Sweeps for the audience, but also minimize their head movements.

Line Charts

Line charts should follow the same guidelines as bar charts, as you can see in Figure 12.7.

DESIGN YOUR NUMBERS AS VISUALS

Just as with bars charts, the pertinent numbers in a line chart should be located directly at the inflection points in the lines, eliminating tick marks on the y-axis, where only the minimum and maximum figures show the scale. The labels for each line are coded in the same shade as the lines and are located to the right, at the end of the eye sweep.

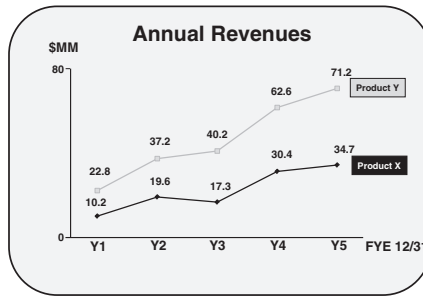


Figure 12.7 Annual Revenue Line Chart

Pie Charts

Pie charts are easy to read because the share that each wedge of the pie represents is clear from its relative size. Unfortunately, in the slide on the left in Figure 12.8, there are three different labels—the sales region, the dollar figure, and the percentage—bunched together at each wedge, forcing the audience to process diverse data information at each wedge. Another *Whew!*

Distribute the data for clarity as in the slide on the right.

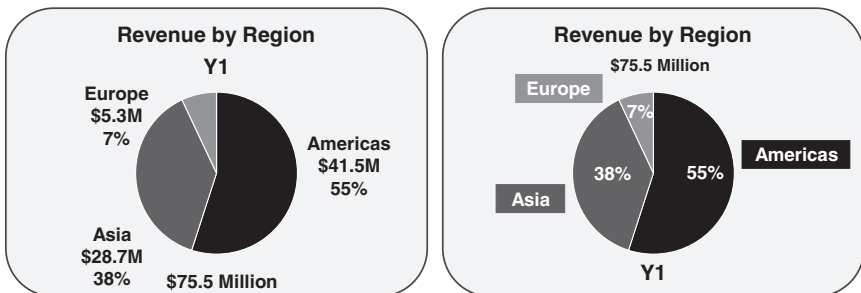


Figure 12.8 How Not to and How to Design a Pie Chart

PRESENTING TO WIN

The guiding principle: text labels, because of their length, should remain outside the pie; and percentages/numbers, because of their brevity, should go inside the wedges. As with the labels for bar charts, embed the text of the pie labels in colored or shaded rectangles adjacent to their related wedges. If any wedge in the pie is too narrow, place the number outside the pie with a callout.

Because the main focus of any pie chart is relative size, you can omit the dollar figures unless you intend to discuss that factor.

Finally, as a convention, most financial charts place the timeline along the bottom, so place the dateline of your pie charts at the bottom.

Pie Chart in Action

Bill Colston of Sestina Bio, whose model bullet slide you saw in the previous chapter, wanted to show prospective investors the market potential for Sestina's diverse product segments. He depicted all the data in a single pie chart that followed the simple guidelines of positioning the color-coded labels outside the wedges, the digits inside the wedges, and the dateline at the bottom, as in Figure 12.9.

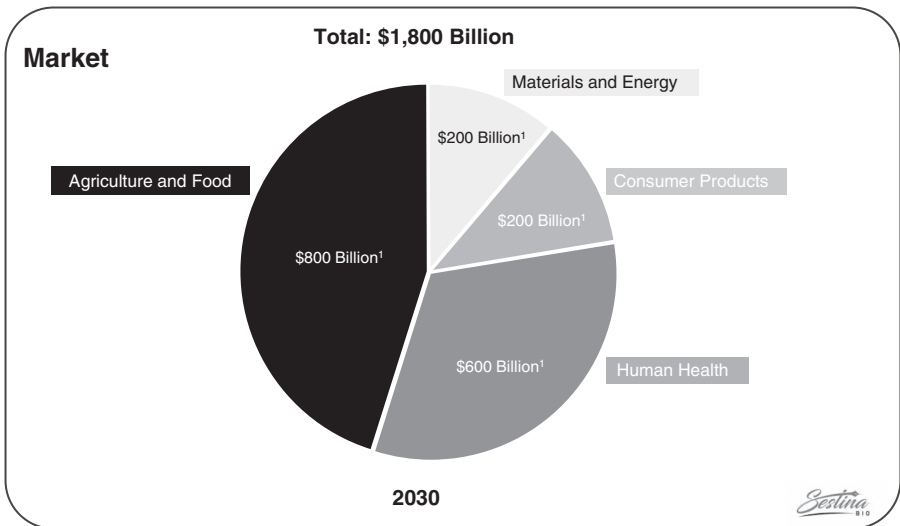


Figure 12.9 *Sestina Bio Market Potential Slide*

■ The Left-to-Right Dynamic ■

In Chapter Nine you read how nature and nurture make left-to-right movement natural for audiences, and how, for business audiences in particular, the up-and-to-the-right image of a hockey stick represents growth, the endgame of success. That dynamic is particularly relevant in numeric charts.

Unfortunately, many presenters, as well as newspapers, magazines, financial publications, and even professional graphic artists, design bar charts counter to those innate forces. Under the mistaken assumption that the most important figure should come first, presenters display their own superior results at the beginning of a series of bars and follow it with the lesser results on the competitors' bars, as in the slide on the left in Figure 12.10 below. Not only does this slide head downhill, but the last image the audience sees is a competitor's logo.

By placing your own superior results at the end of the series, to the right, as in the slide on the right, you express the rising action of a hockey stick. Furthermore, the last image the audience sees in your logo.

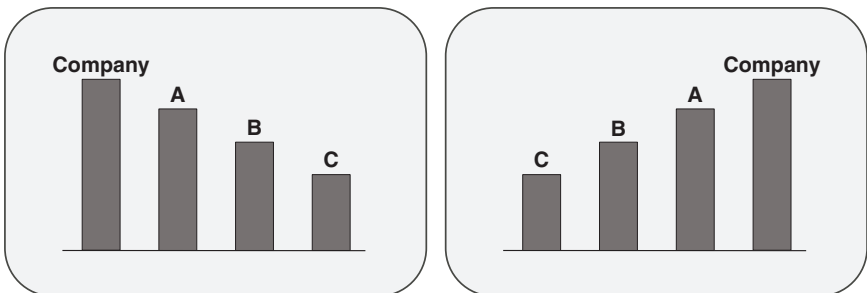
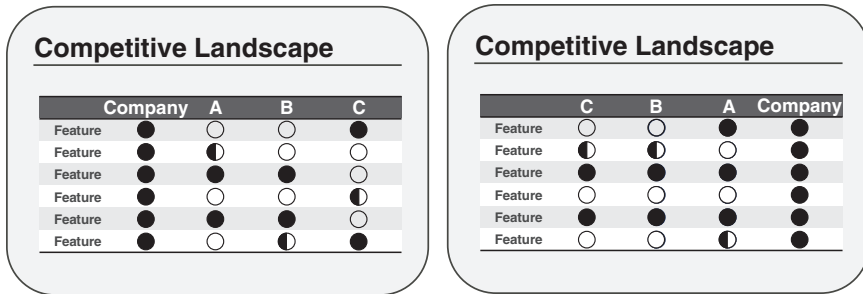


Figure 12.10 *Reverse Hockey Stick and Hockey Stick Effect*

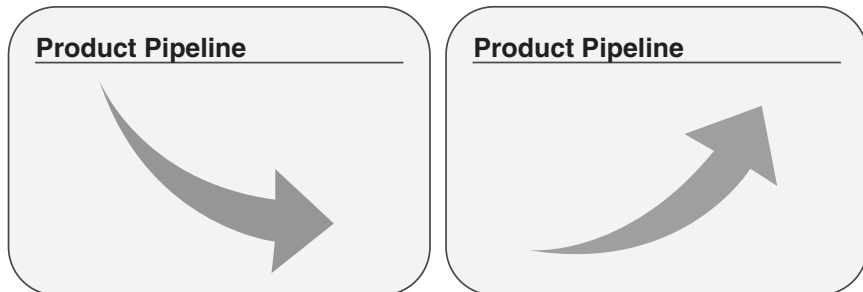
A variation of the first/last misplacement occurs in a common business slide known as a moon chart, which is often used to compare competitive differences. The chart uses circles filled to varying degrees: a full moon represents full value, half moon, half value, and an empty moon, no value. For instance, the presenting company in the slide on the left in Figure 12.11 below compared itself to three of its competitors. Because all of the presenting company's features rated full moons, they put themselves in the first column. Yes, the audiences saw their logo first—and the competitor's last.

Instead make your company the last to be seen as in the slide on the right.

Figure 12.11 *Moon Chart: First Place or Last?*

Another variation of the hockey stick confusion comes in a slide that represents a progression, such as a product release roadmap. The path is represented by an arrow going from left to right. But if the arrow descends as in the slide on the left in Figure 12.12 below, despite the left-to-right direction, the message is decline.

If the arrow rises, the product release path creates the hockey stick effect, as in the slide on the right.

Figure 12.12 *Downhill Versus Uphill*

In Chapter Nine you read about Ford Tamer, the CEO of Inphi, who developed the content for a blog about the impact of the coronavirus pandemic on Inphi's business. Ford also wanted to create a presentation with a slide that showed that Inphi's business was stable. He sent me a first draft of that slide: the one on the left in Figure 12.13.

I reminded Ford about the hockey stick effect, and he promptly asked Molly Barber, his executive assistant and an expert with PowerPoint, to revise the slide. Molly did a quick turnaround and sent the up-and-to-the-right version, in the slide on the right.

DESIGN YOUR NUMBERS AS VISUALS

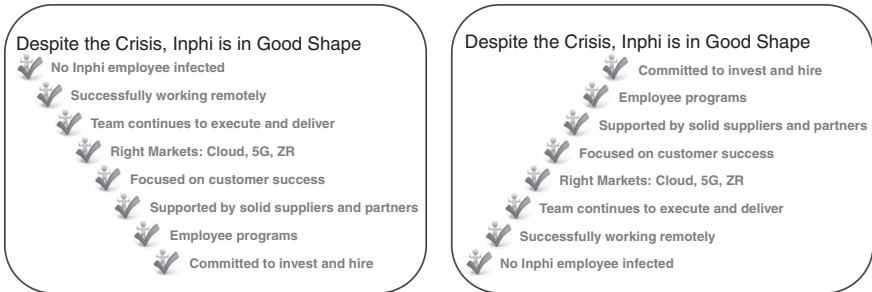


Figure 12.13 *First and Second Drafts of Inphi Slide*

In a related design matter, many presentations show a picture of their product and accompany the image with descriptive bullets, as in the slide on the left in Figure 12.14. In this arrangement, however, the audience sees the image four times, at the end of each eye sweep of each bullet.

Minimize the Eye Sweeps by positioning the picture at the left and the bullets at the right, as in the slide on the right.



Figure 12.14 *Picture on the Left Versus Picture on the Right*

In this arrangement, the audience sees the picture once and then focuses on each of the bullets.

Circles

Another example of the left-to-right dynamic occurs in a common business slide of interlocking arrows used to indicated connectedness. The direction of the arrows matters. In the slide on the left in Figure 12.15, the circle of arrows arranged counterclockwise feels like a vicious cycle.

When you observe the left-to-right dynamic and arrange arrows clockwise, you achieve the virtuous circle, as in the slide on the right.

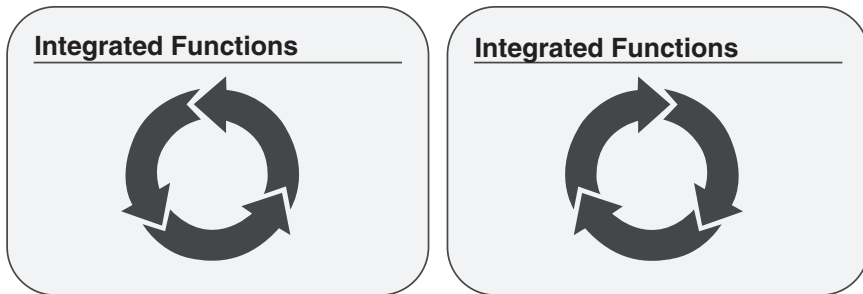


Figure 12.15 Vicious Cycle Versus Virtuous Circle

While all of the above examples are based on the left-to-right dynamics, there is another dimension to create visual messaging: depth.

In/Out

Ford Tamer wanted to show the positive forces driving Inphi's business growth trends in his presentation. However, in the first draft of his slide on the left in Figure 12.16, the arrows pointed inward, creating the sense of an implosion.

Once Ford realized the difference, he asked Molly to revise the arrows to point out. In just a few moments, she sent the revised version you can see in the slide on the right.

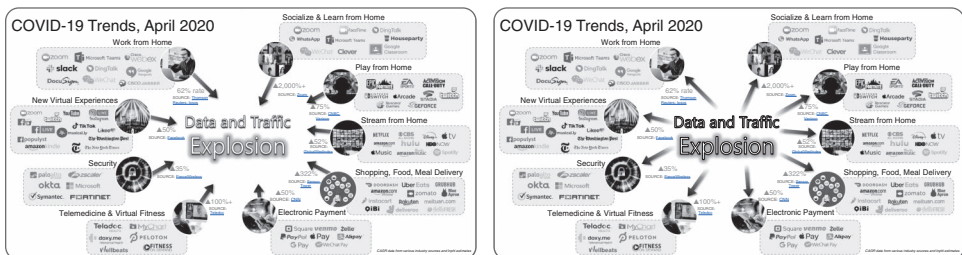


Figure 12.16 Implosion Versus Explosion in an Inphi Slide

Your audiences may not be overtly aware of such subtle design differentials, but these powerful cultural and neurological forces will send them subconscious visual cues. Design your slides to send positive visual messages.

Now it's time to take all the basic design concepts discussed so far and assemble them into a continuous, unified deck—in the next chapter.

Visual Storytelling

Case Studies: Amanda Foreman • Anton Chekhov • Michael Ball, Canexia Health • Bruce Schuman, Intel

*Don't tell me the moon is shining; show me the glint of light on broken glass.*¹

Anton Chekhov

■ Show Versus Tell ■

History and pop culture rarely mix, but noted historian Amanda Foreman merged the two divergent disciplines in a *Wall Street Journal* article about comic strips. In “The Power of Telling Stories in Pictures,”² she traced the form she calls “narrative sequential art” back to 2450 B.C.E., when the Sumerians memorialized a military victory carved in stone.

Since then, countless civilizations—Greeks, Romans, Asians, Mayans—have told their stories in sequential images. And yet, modern-day business presenters continue to tell their stories in words rather than images, ignoring that eternal commandment of writing: “Show don’t tell,” eloquently expressed by the great Russian novelist Anton Chekhov in the epigraph.

That is, until the advent of mobile phones. Since then, the quaint concept of home movies, the old 8 mm kind, has transformed and exploded into a brand-new category: visual storytelling. A Google search for the term produced 101 million results at the time of writing. New superfast lenses, digital editing, filters, slow motion, freeze frames, morph cuts, and special effects enable anyone with a

mobile phone to easily produce slick, entertaining videos they can post on social media platforms and go viral in a flash.

Admittedly, this surging tide of creativity has also raised the visual level of storytelling in business. Companies are now investing considerable time, effort, and money to produce artful videos—either in-house or outsourced—to tell their stories. Such videos, however, cannot supplant the quotidian pitches that road warriors must deliver when they go into battle armed with only slideshows. While these troops may include a fancy prepackaged video clip in their presentations, they must still deliver their bread-and-butter pitches with a slideshow.

That's where visual storytelling comes in, and it brings us to the ultimate stage of presentation design: continuity.

■ Continuity ■

To learn how to create visual continuity, let's use as a point of departure the shuffle-the-deck legacy. This default practice produces a slide-to-slide sequence with logic only at each individual juncture. This becomes apparent when you view all the slides spread out in a panoramic grid view known as a storyboard, as shown in Figure 13.1.

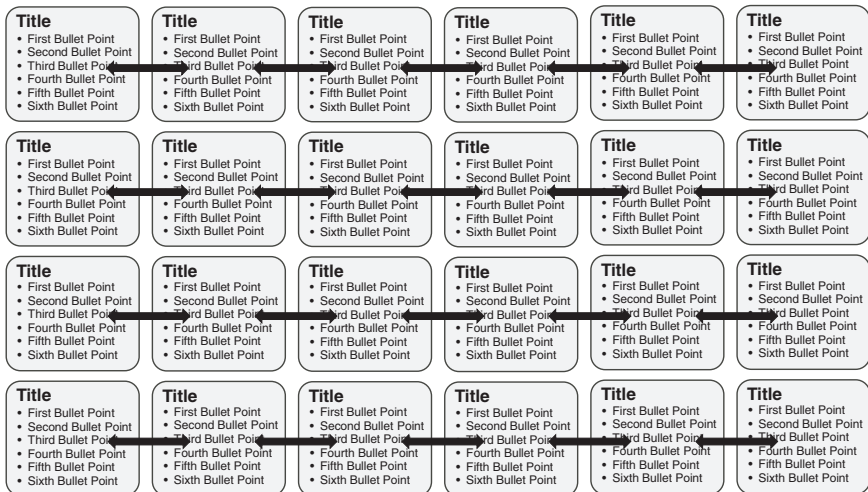


Figure 13.1 *Slide-to-Slide Sequence in the Storyboard View*

In this arrangement, each slide essentially restarts the story from scratch, making it difficult for the audience—as well as the presenter—to follow the

progression of the narrative. Remember the Third Cardinal Sin: *no clear flow*. Instead, every presentation should connect all the slides in an overarching flow—the Story Arc (see Figure 13.2).



Figure 13.2 The Story Arc in the Storyboard View

In Chapters Four and Five, you learned to create a Story Arc *conceptually*—without any slides—by sequencing a set of Roman Columns, first with Inductive Logic and then with Deductive Logic, but they are purely narrative techniques. Graphics can assist and even amplify those verbal techniques to create a clear, connected progression.

In print—books, magazines, newspapers, reports, white papers—designers and editors provide readers with a variety of visual signposts to help track the author’s flow: a table of contents, an index, callouts, and running heads along the top or bottom of the page. Russian novels list the multiple names and nicknames of the characters up front. Play scripts list the Cast of Characters before the first scene. These print conventions enable readers to navigate through written texts.

Presentations are different. There, the only visual signpost is the slide, and once that disappears from the screen and a new slide appears, the audience cannot rewind. Presenters must provide visual markers. In the next chapter, you’ll learn a set of graphic techniques that you can use to express continuity in your slides, but before we turn on the abundant tap of fonts, colors, shapes, and images, you want to be sure that, as you transition from the StoryForm to the

Storyboard, you carry forward the narrative superstructure that you so carefully constructed in conceptual form (see Figure 13.3).

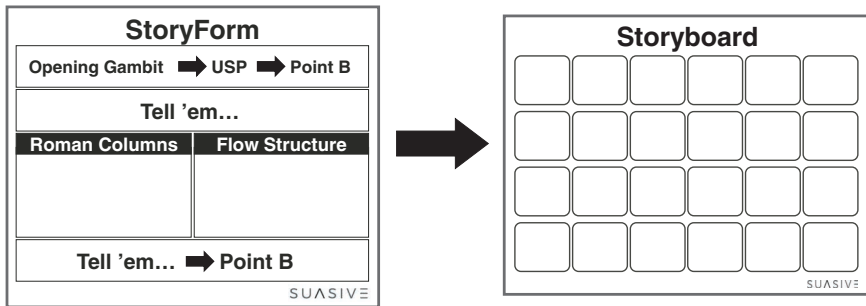


Figure 13.3 *Transport the StoryForm to the Storyboard*

There are five steps to preserve the logical flow of your story as you develop your slideshow.

■ The Storyboard Development Process ■

1. **Carry forward the Flow Structure.** Transport the major story sections onto the storyboard by overlaying them onto groups of slides.
2. **Insert *only* the titles.** Insert the titles of every slide in each section.
3. **Verbalize the titles.** As with the Roman Columns, narrate the titles in “one long sentence.”
4. **Add the design elements.** Add the *Plus* part of *TitlePlus* to each slide with text, numbers, images, or tables.
5. **Use graphic continuity.** Amplify your narrative continuity with visual elements, the graphic design options you’ll find in the next chapter.

Television and film directors use storyboards to envision their end products, whether a 60-second commercial or a multimillion-dollar movie epic. These professional creators draw sketches of the camera angles and visual composition of every scene and then lay out the individual scenes to illustrate the progressive sequence (see Figure 13.4).

VISUAL STORYTELLING



Figure 13.4 *Typical Media Storyboard*³

The major presentation software programs provide a version of a storyboard: in Google Slides, it is called Grid view; in Microsoft PowerPoint, Slide Sorter; and in Apple Keynote, Light Table.* Figure 13.5 shows the Suasive Storyboard.

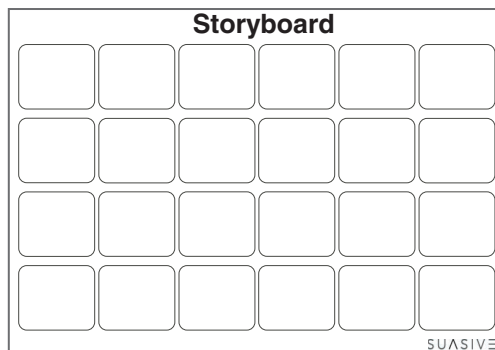


Figure 13.5 *The Suasive Storyboard*

* You can download the Suasive Storyboard by visiting our website: suasive.com/resource-center/.

To simplify illustrating this process, the Suasive Storyboard shows only four rows with six slides in each row. Your presentation may have more slides or rows.

Step 1. Carry Forward the Flow Structure

Carry forward the logic of the StoryForm by transporting the major sections of your story onto the Storyboard and overlaying each section over a group of slides, as in Figure 13.6.

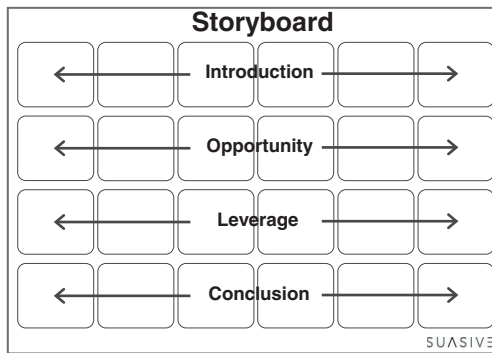


Figure 13.6 Storyboard with Major Sections

The top line is composed of a set of slides that create an Introduction consisting of the Opening Gambit sequence and the Agenda.

Then, assuming that you have chosen Opportunity/Leverage as your Flow Structure, the second line has a group of slides illustrating the Opportunity.

The third line has a group of slides expressing how your company Leverages the Opportunity.

The slides in the fourth line form a concluding section that ends with a Summary.

In this panoramic view, you may decide to shift some slides within a section or from one section to another, or you might find that you can eliminate some slides and still maintain the overarching flow of the Story Arc.

The presentation software programs have similar functions that enable you to group slides into sections, but that requires using actual slides. To keep you from thinking about design matters such as font, color, and size, I recommend that during this first step, you stay focused on maintaining the integrity of the Story Arc by using only key words, skeletal lines, and arrows.

Step 2. Insert Only the Titles

Next, add *only* the title of each slide in the deck. (Remember to limit each title to one line.) The bullets, graphs, images, and other content will come in a later step; for now, maintain the logic of your narrative in the titles—as headlines (see Figure 13.7).

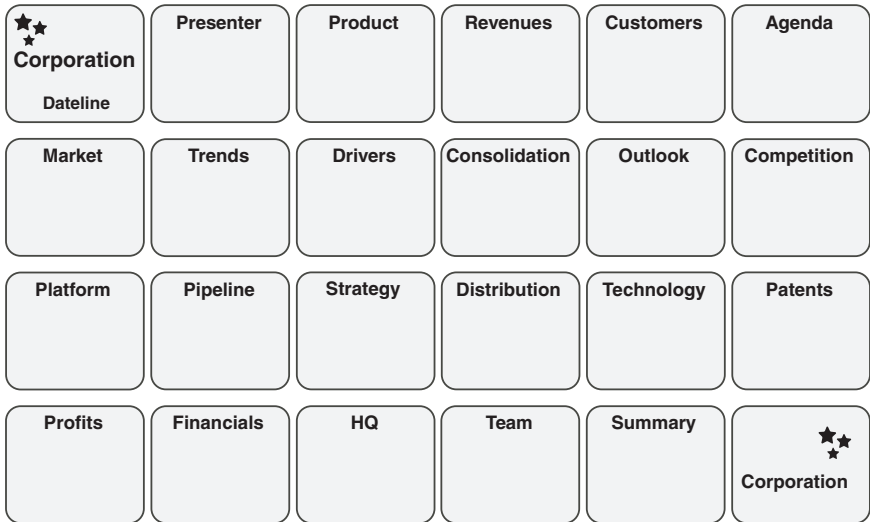


Figure 13.7 *Only the Titles in the Storyboard*

Step 3. Verbalize the Titles

In Chapter Seven, you learned the many benefits of Verbalization:

- Validate sequential logic by connecting the Roman Columns in “one long sentence.”
- Build confidence with repeated practice.
- Establish the running time.

In this step, we merge Verbalization of your narrative with this early draft of the slide deck.

Begin your Verbalization with the all-important Opening Gambit sequence and Agenda—the first 90 seconds—mapped to the slides (see Figure 13.8).

PRESENTING TO WIN



Figure 13.8 *Verbalize the Opening Gambit Sequence*

For your convenience, I've repeated the narrative steps of the Opening Gambit sequence you learned in Chapter Seven:

- Opening Gambit
- Link forward to the USP
- USP
- Link forward to Proof of Concept (POC)
- POC
- Link forward to your Point B
- Point B
- Link forward to "Tell 'em what you're gonna tell 'em"
- String the Agenda in one long sentence
- Identify the Agenda as a roadmap and forecast the time
- Link forward into the first Roman Column

Now Verbalize the steps above with the first six slides in Figure 13.8 as follows:

- **Slide One: *Corporate Logo*.** This is the first slide your audience sees. It serves the same purpose as the main curtain in a theater when the lights go down and the show begins: to signal a clean start. Customize

this slide with your company name and logo, as well as the name and logo of the the audience's company or organization. To customize even further, include the location and the actual date of your presentation. Use this slide as a backdrop for your greeting.

Verbalize: “Thank you for attending...”

- **Slide Two: *Presenter*.** To reinforce Presenter Focus, this slide has only your name and title as a simple background for your Opening Gambit. Resist doing as some presenters do, starting with an image. Keep the attention on you.

Verbalize: Deliver your Opening Gambit and link forward to...

- **Slide Three: *USP*.** Choose a simple image that illustrates your USP so that the audience gets it @ Glance.

Verbalize: Describe your company's USP with a *TitlePlus*. Then go on to succinctly describe what your company does and how it does it. Then link forward to...

- **Slides Four and Five: *POC*.** These are the POC slides. I've indicated these in Figure 13.8 as “Revenues” and “Customers,” but you can use other forms of proof to validate the worth of your USP, such as “Endorsements” or “Market Share.”

Verbalize: Discuss the POC to show how well your USP is performing. Then culminate your syllogism with your Point B and link forward to...

- **Slide Six: *Agenda*.** String your Roman Columns into one long sentence.

Verbalize: Speak the string aloud. Then forecast the length of your presentation and link forward to the first Roman Column of the next row.

Continue your Verbalization through the rest of the deck using the same “one long sentence” technique as Canexia Health's Michael Ball did in the Introduction and Intel's Bruce Schuman did in Chapter Four. They did it as part of their story development. In Chapter Seven we extended the “one long sentence” to string together all the bullets in the Agenda. Now, we extend the technique even further: to string together all the titles of the slides in the full Storyboard (see Figure 13.9).

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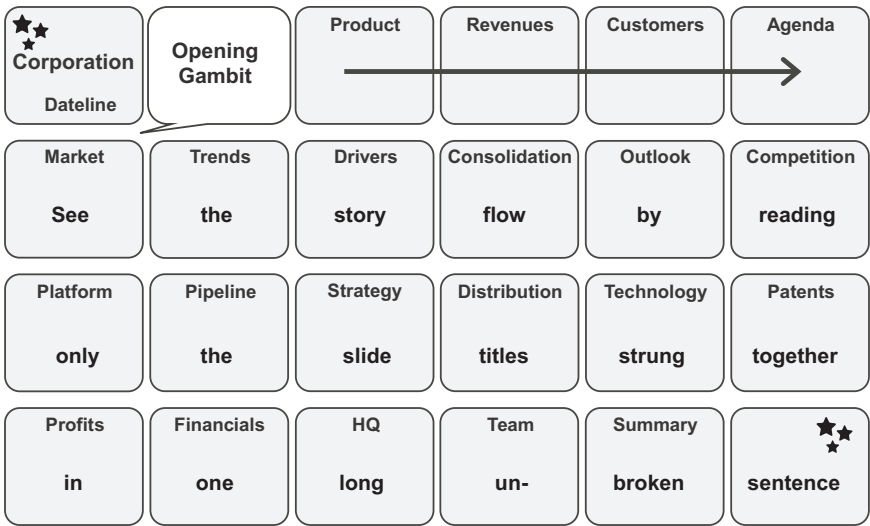


Figure 13.9 Use the "One Long Sentence" to String Together All the Slides

Now you have a continuous Story Arc that ties together all the slides, as in Figure 13.10.

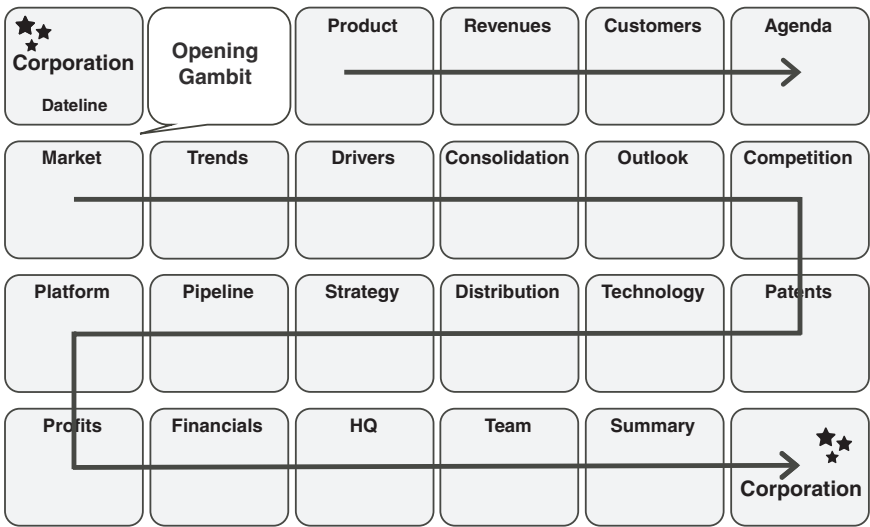


Figure 13.10 The Story Arc

Step 4. Add the Design Elements

Having diligently maintained the logic of your story in the first three steps, you are now finally ready to add the design details of the slides—the *Plus* parts of *TitlePlus*, the below-the-line components—by using the four graphic options text, numbers, images, and tables (see Figure 13.11).

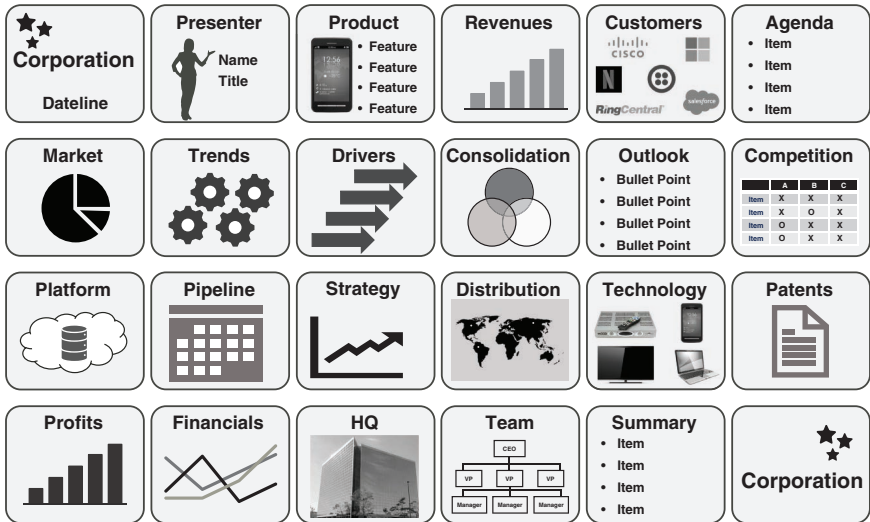


Figure 13.11 Adding the Plus Parts of the *TitlePlus*

This is where most presenters start the process.

Please note that in these views, I've used only elementary indications of the *Plus* components as placeholders. Although you now have a bigger palette of techniques to design your slides, I've kept them simple in this step to keep you focused on the Story Arc.

When you're done, you may find—in this view—that each slide is different from the next. This unstructured arrangement produces a visual gap between slides, disrupting the continuous flow you have so diligently applied with Inductive and Deductive Logic (see Figure 13.12).

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Figure 13.12 No Two Slides Alike

Of course, your narrative can provide verbal continuity from slide-to-slide, but you can also use graphics for even further continuity. That is the fifth step in the Storyboard Development Process. Coincidentally, there are five options for Graphic Continuity, and you'll see them in the next chapter.

Five Graphic Continuity Techniques

Case Studies: Fred R. Barnard • William Safire • Andy Rachleff, Wealthfront • The IC Deep Dive Presentation • Jon Perera, Highspot • Kyocera • UPS • Nike

*A picture is worth a thousand words.*¹

Fred R. Barnard

■ The Primacy of Pictures ■

The universally familiar epigraph for this chapter is most commonly attributed to an ancient Chinese or Japanese philosopher. But most of the more than 37 million results from an internet search attribute the phrase to Fred R. Barnard, an American advertising executive who is said to have coined the phrase in the 1920s.

Leave it to William Safire to clarify the matter. Safire, whom you met in Chapter Seven, is my constant go-to expert “On Language,” always fulfilling the title and mission of his brilliant *New York Times* column. His scrupulous research found that Barnard, who used the aphorism in an ad, had originally attributed it to a “famous Japanese philosopher (whom nobody ever heard of because he never existed).”² Six years later, Barnard switched his purported source to a “Chinese Proverb” and “hired a calligrapher to put the words into Chinese characters....Barnard later confessed he made that attribution to an ancient Asian ‘so that people would take it seriously.’”

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And then Safire concluded:

*He was right; we do slavishly accept the primacy of pictures over prose.*³

Extend that primacy of pictures to add continuity to your slideshows.

To demonstrate why graphic continuity is so important, please try a simple exercise with Figure 14.1, which you saw in the previous chapter. Please scan this Storyboard line by line, from slide-to-slide.

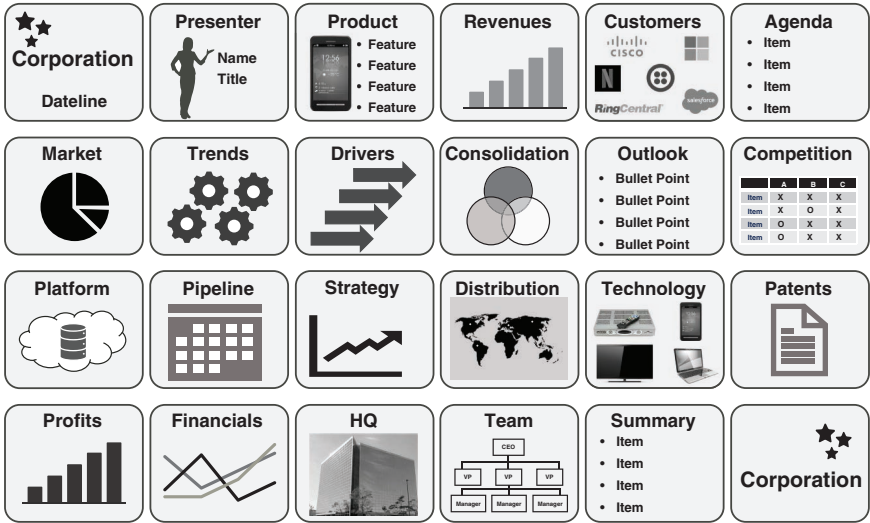


Figure 14.1 Storyboard View

You likely had to reset your thinking every time you moved from one slide to another. Because no two slides are alike, the presentation essentially begins again with each slide, forcing you to think about each new image as you come to it.

Now consider your audience members, who, without this panoramic view, see only one slide at a time. The result: they have to work even harder than you did for each new image. All this effort may cause them to lose track of your narrative.

There are five techniques you can use to help express the flow of your story.

■ Five Graphic Continuity Techniques ■

1. **Bumper Slides.** Slides inserted between major sections of a presentation to serve as simple, clear transitions.
2. **Indexing/Color Coding.** A recurring object as an index, highlighted in different colors to map the different sections of a longer presentation.
3. **Icons.** Symbolic images to express relationships among ideas.
4. **Anchor Objects.** A recurring image that is an integral part of the story.
5. **Anticipation Space.** Empty areas that are subsequently filled, establishing and then fulfilling subliminal expectations.

Let's look at each of these five techniques in greater detail, along with illustrative examples.

1. Bumper Slides

A Bumper Slide is a partition between the major sections of your presentation. Like a divider in a loose-leaf binder, a Bumper Slide creates a clear transition. This tracking technique is drawn from publishing. Look at any nonfiction book, and you're likely to find that it is divided into parts and chapters; most often each part is separated from the next part by a full page containing only the part number and/or a line of text.

As a transition, a Bumper Slide serves as the closure of the outbound section and a lead to a new section. Editors and writers refer to these transitions as “outros” and “intros.” In a book, the reader's mind is cleared of the last subject and primed for the next. In a presentation, you can prime your audience by closing the outbound section and leading to the new while a Bumper Slide is on the screen. Think of the Bumper Slide as a palate cleanser in a fine meal—what the French call an *amuse-bouche*.

Figure 14.2 shows a very simple and effective form of this option: a single line of text. To differentiate the Bumper Slide from all the others, center the text both horizontally (left to right) and vertically (top to bottom). The one line functions as a preview of the next section.

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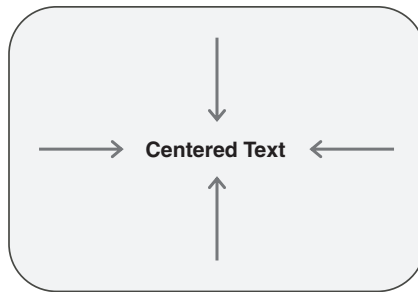


Figure 14.2 *Centered Text as Bumper Slide*

For example, you might have a Bumper slide reading “Market Opportunity” and another reading “Unique Technology,” each of which serves to introduce a subsequent set of slides on each topic.

You can also use a simple image or symbol as a Bumper, as in Figure 14.3.



Figure 14.3 *Icon as Bumper Slide*

Or the image could be your company logo, an image relevant to the overall theme of your presentation, or an icon that suggests the content of the subsequent section of the presentation.

Bumper Slides in Action

Wealthfront, an automated investment service firm, was founded by Andy Rachleff, whom I met when I coached him and his partners to finance the start of Benchmark Capital, now one of the leading venture capital firms in Silicon Valley. Andy quickly went from being an eager student to a popular teacher with his own technology entrepreneurship course at Stanford Graduate School of Business. He then carried his lessons from Benchmark to Wealthfront. In the deck he created for the Wealthfront Equity Plan, Andy used four simple images to represent the four types of grants his firm manages: a plus sign for New Hires,

a ladder for Promotions, a star for Performance, and a pine tree for Evergreen (see Figure 14.4).

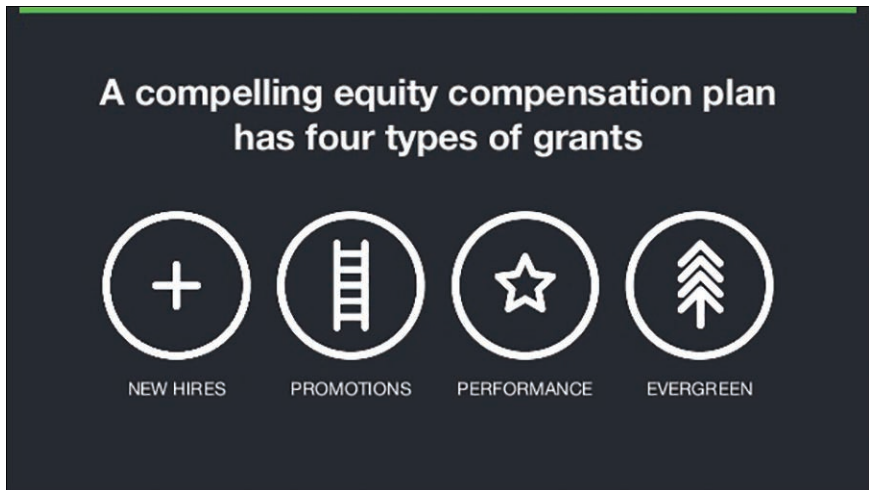


Figure 14.4 *Wealthfront Bumper Slide*⁴

In his presentation, Andy first highlighted the plus sign and then followed it with five related slides about New Hires. Then he repeated the Bumper slide, shifted the highlight to the ladder, and followed it with four slides about Promotions. He did the same with Performance and Evergreen, following each with several related slides. At the end of the series, he summarized the entire sequence with a repeat of the Bumper without highlights. Between the Bumpers, Andy showed detailed slides with tables, area charts, and bullets that illustrated his narrative. The Bumpers tracked his flow.

Another popular approach is to use the Agenda slide as a Bumper to track the progress of the story by returning to the Agenda between sections. For this approach, each Bumper slide displays the complete Agenda with the upcoming item highlighted or bolded.

But beware of the design approach in which the outbound item—the one already discussed—is dimmed or half-toned. If the audience wants to look back at that earlier item, they have to strain or squint.

Instead, make all the bullets, including the outbound bullet, full tone or color; then highlight, bold, or change the color of only the inbound bullet—the one that you are about to discuss. You can see the difference side-by-side in Figure 14.5.

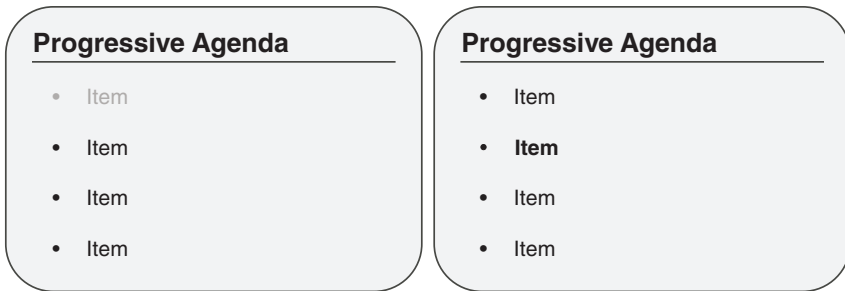


Figure 14.5 *Agenda as Bumper: Outbound Dimmed on the Left, Inbound Bolded on the Right*

A caution: Use this recurring Agenda approach only with longer presentations—30 minutes or more. In shorter presentations, if you reprise your Agenda after just one or two slides, your audience feels patronized. They think, “I get it! You don’t have to remind me!”

In longer and more complicated presentations, this technique can help your audience recognize these milestones and stay on track.

2. Indexing/Color Coding

For longer presentations—those that are longer than Andy Rachleff’s Wealthfront deck, which had only a few slides in each section—you can use the Indexing/Color Coding technique to create a visual roadmap. In this approach, choose an icon such as a wedged pie or a stacked pyramid, as your Index, with each wedge or level color-coded. Place the full pie or pyramid in a corner of every slide as a recurring object. Then, as you move from section to section, shift the highlight or color of each wedge or level to track your progress.

This technique is particularly useful in technical presentations in which each of several sections goes into granular detail, with many slides. A Silicon Valley IC company developed a deep dive technical presentation with many slides in each section to describe its four-part strategy for chip design. The presentation began with an overview of the strategy represented by a large pie chart divided into four quadrants, each quadrant a different color or shade, as in Figure 14.6.

FIVE GRAPHIC CONTINUITY TECHNIQUES

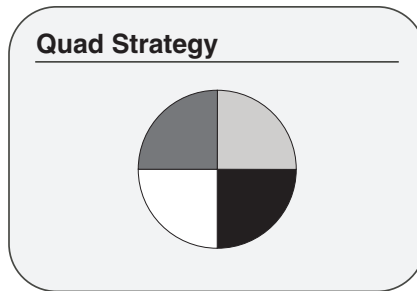


Figure 14.6 *Pie Chart as Color-Coded Index*

Then, as they began their discussion of the first element of the strategy, they shrunk the pie and shifted it to the upper right corner as an Index. The first wedge remained filled with its original color or shade, while the other wedges had no fill, as in the slide on the left in Figure 14.7 below. After discussing the first strategy element with several subsequent slides, they transitioned to the second strategy element and shifted the highlight color/shade to the second wedge, as in slide on the right.

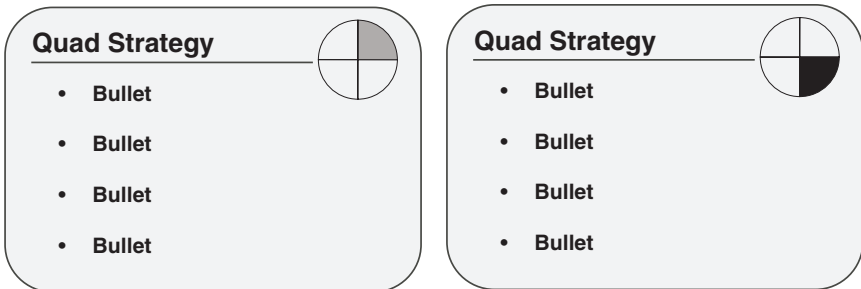


Figure 14.7 *Indexing/Color Coding Progression*

You can anticipate the progression of this presentation. They shifted the highlight to each of the next two wedges in turn, coming around the circle to complete the circuit and maintain the flow.

3. Icons

Icons are symbols that express relationships between or among the ideas of your presentation. Let's look at some familiar Icons and how you can use them to help illustrate the flow of your presentation.

In Chinese cosmology, Yin/Yang are the dual, contrasting life forces that are complementary and interrelated. For Western audiences, Yin/Yang simply

indicates “two-part harmony.” You can use the Yin/Yang Icon (see Figure 14.8) to describe the integration of two related entities, such as the benefits of a merger between two companies or how two products work together.

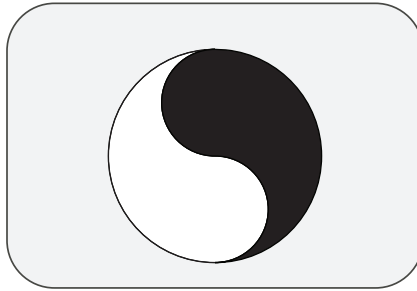


Figure 14.8 *Yin/Yang*

Once you establish the two-part relationship, you can split the Icon into two and, in a new slide showing only the white Yang, as in the slide on the left in Figure 14.9, add bullets, and discuss the details about that part.

After discussing the white element, transition to the black Yin element alone, add new bullets, and discuss, as in the slide on the right.

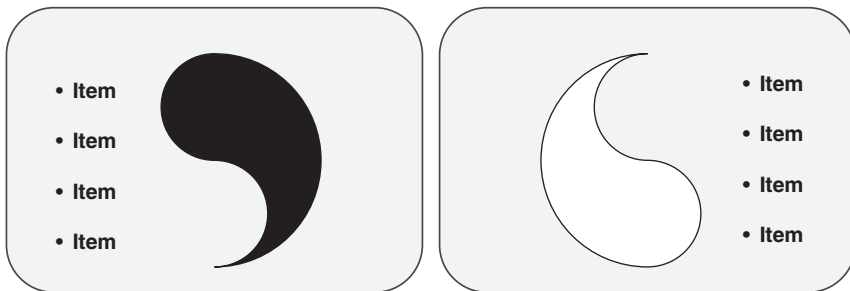


Figure 14.9 *White and Black Parts with Bullets*

In Chapter Five, you read about the commonly held theory that three is an easy quantity to remember. If your presentation contains three elements, you can express those relationships with an Icon. Among the many triplex options are a triangle, three interlocking arrows, and a three-ring Icon with overlapping circles, as in the slide on the left in Figure 14.10. (If you choose that image, be sure to position two rings at the bottom, as the wider base makes a more stable image.) Similarly, if your story contains four key elements, you can use a four-pointed compass star, as in the middle slide. And if your company is at the center

FIVE GRAPHIC CONTINUITY TECHNIQUES

of multiple forces dynamically interacting, you can use the nucleus of an atom icon, as in the slide on the right.



Figure 14.10 *Three-Ring Icon, Compass Star, and Atom with Nucleus*

In each case, just as with the Yin/Yang Icon, step through each element, one at a time, adding details; and maintain continuity by returning to the principal Icon.

4. Anchor Objects

While Indexing/Color Coding involves using a recurring generic icon, an Anchor Object option creates continuity with a recurring image that is an integral part of the story. The image can be a photograph, a sketch, a map, an icon, a screenshot, a logo, or clip art.

With this approach, you begin a series of slides with the first slide displaying an image—in this case, a photograph—and a set of bullets, as in the slide on the left in Figure 14.11. In the very next slide, (the middle slide), the image remains anchored in the identical place, and you replace the bullets with a set of new but related bullets, establishing a contiguous relationship between the two slides. In the third slide (the slide on the right), the image continues as an anchor, and you replace the bullets with a set of new but still related bullets, creating visual continuity.

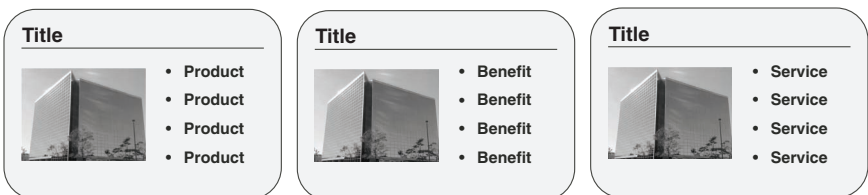


Figure 14.11 *Anchor Object Sequence for Progressive Continuity*

What makes Anchor Objects such an effective continuity technique goes back to the science of neurology. When a new slide appears, your audience's

eyes, having already processed the Anchor Object once, recognize it instantly and, without having to process it again, quickly sweep past it to take in the new information in the new bullets. By relating the new information to the preceding information, your audience sees the continuity.

You can also calculate the exact size and position of the Anchor Object and then create visual continuity by replacing it with another image of the same size and position. Although the image is new, the identical size and position reduces the processing for the audience's eyes. Subliminally, they sense the relationship between the two slides. Figure 14.12 shows the effect of replacing a photo with a bar chart of exactly the same position and dimensions.

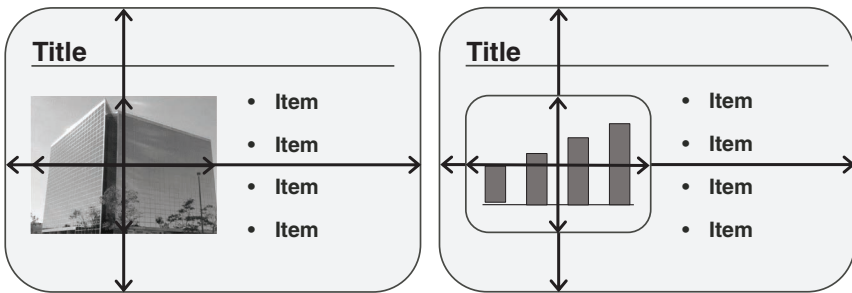


Figure 14.12 Two Anchor Objects with Identical Dimensions and Positions

Another variation of this technique is to use two objects as Anchors: one of them the slide title and the other an image. In Figure 14.13, both the title “Product” and the cube are Anchor Objects. Each of them remains fixed in the identical position on each slide. In the slide on the right, the subtitle changes to “Premier” from the preceding “Basic,” and the label on the cube changes to “Beta” from the preceding “Alpha.” Your audience’s eyes are drawn to the new information and see the relationship between the two slides.

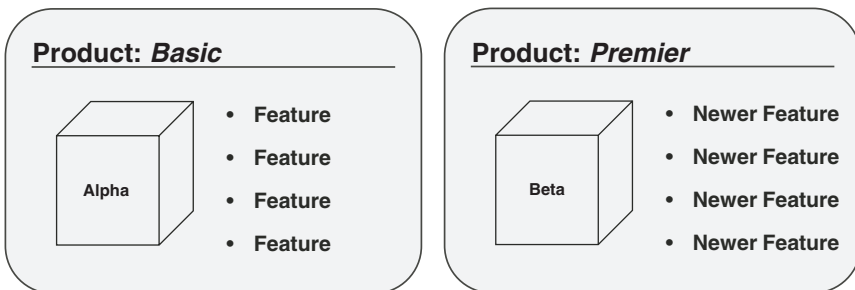


Figure 14.13 Title and Cube as Anchor Objects

Anchor Objects in Action

Highspot, a company that provides advanced sales enablement tools and software, was formed by several Microsoft alumni. One of them, Jon Perera, Highspot's CMO, deployed the Anchor Objects technique—along with the hockey stick dynamic—to show the seven essential factors of the sales enablement process: up-and-to-the-right, culminating in a dollar sign, as in Figure 14.14.

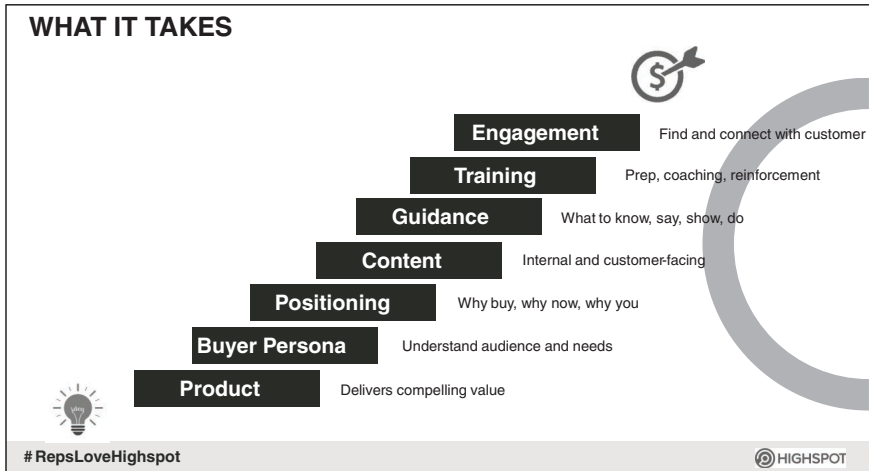


Figure 14.14 Highspot Anchor Objects Slide

While showing this slide, Jon discussed what it takes for the sales process to be effective. Then, using the seven rectangles as Anchor Objects, he proceeded to a progression of other slides in which he changed the title of the slide and the bullets adjacent to the boxes to discuss what often goes wrong in each of the seven factors. He concluded with a culminating slide that showed the seven rectangles intact and a final set of new bullets showing that Highspot provides the best solution for each factor.



(Video 22) KYOCERA Document Solutions UK 2014 TV Ad
<https://youtu.be/jlRteUA8SEk?t=20>

An advertisement from Kyocera, the large Japanese ceramics and electronics company, uses a single sentence as an Anchor Object: “If the document is important, the technology is important” (see Figure 14.15).

PRESENTING TO WIN



Figure 14.15 Kyocera Ad with Sentence as an Anchor Object

And then, as the sentence remains anchored in place, the word “technology” is replaced in rapid order by a progression of other words in the identical position: “workflow,” “access,” “scanning,” “app,” “mobile,” “printing,” “security,” “innovation,” “solution,” and “company.”

The clear message is that Kyocera provides all the important functions to create important documents.



(Video 23) *Can you believe all the ings we fit under one roof*
<https://youtu.be/e11BNZCMriQ>

In a similar vein, UPS created an advertisement called “Can you believe all the ings we fit under one roof?” which uses the suffix “ing” as an Anchor Object, as in Figure 14.16.



Figure 14.16 UPS Ad with the Suffix “ing” as an Anchor Object

Then, in a rapid animated series, the ad brings in nearly two dozen services: “print,” “copy,” “fax,” etc., each in black text, positioned so that each noun ends with the same “ing” suffix in white text as an Anchor.

FIVE GRAPHIC CONTINUITY TECHNIQUES

The animation ends with one more sentence: “Have we missed any ing?” making the clear point that UPS provides a robust range of services.



(Video 24) *You Can't Stop Us* | Nike

<https://youtu.be/WA4dDs0T7sM>

Nike created a stunning video ad that their website describes as a “dynamic series detailing 36 pairings of athletes, relating the kinetic movement of one sport to another across a split screen.”⁵ The ad shows athletes entering in motion from the left and then, with the action continuing across the split, another athlete completing the same action. The matching dimensions and actions of the different athletes serve as Anchor Objects that create fluid continuity. Figure 14.17 shows a still image of the ad in which two different groups of athletes are raising their arms in victory and meeting in an apex at the juncture.



Figure 14.17 Nike Ad with Athletes' Actions as Anchor Objects

In one of the 36 pairings, an athlete enters in gym clothes and exits in a team uniform; in another, a male athlete begins an action, and a female completes it; and in another, a disabled athlete starts an action, and an able-bodied athlete completes it. In all cases, the movement across the split is continuous, conveying the message that Nike outfits all athletes.

The ad was undoubtedly created using sophisticated professional digital editing technology that is beyond the capability of consumer software—and beyond the scope of quotidian business presentations—but it is a superb example of using the Anchoring concept to express continuity.

5. Anticipation Space

Imagine that you're watching a film. In one scene, a woman is standing alone in the center of the frame, occupying most of the screen, as in the slide on the left in Figure 14.18. After a moment, the camera zooms out slowly, positioning the woman on one side of the screen, leaving an empty space on the other side, as in the slide on the right. While the woman remains visible, our attention is drawn to the right, which could be an empty room or a busy street. What would you anticipate?

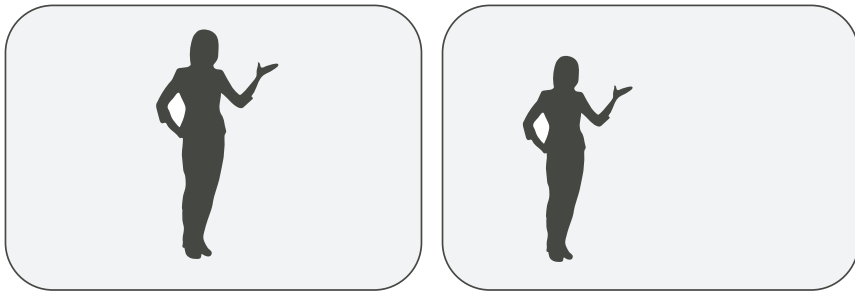


Figure 14.18 *Anticipation Space in Cinema*

When I ask clients this question, they invariably respond, “Someone or something is going to enter the scene.”

Of course, they're correct. Years of watching movies and television have conditioned us to recognize that when there is an empty space on the screen, that space is going to be filled. In our imagined movie scene, the woman's companion would enter the space, as in Figure 14.19.

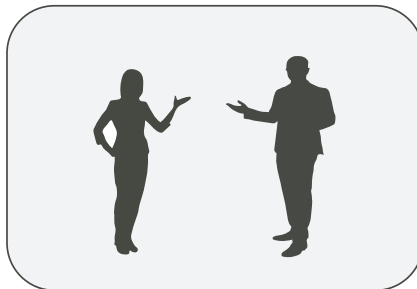


Figure 14.19 *Anticipation Fulfilled: Cinema*

You can create the same sense of anticipation in your presentation audience by using simple graphic elements in your slides. In the slide on the left in Figure 14.20, you see two boxes: one filled, one empty. Of course, you anticipate

FIVE GRAPHIC CONTINUITY TECHNIQUES

that the empty space on the right side will be filled—and you expect four items to appear, corresponding to the four items on the left. Three items would disappoint you; five would confuse you. Four delivers what you anticipate.

When you fill the space with four items, as in the slide on the right, it provides what your audience requires, fulfills their anticipation, and satisfies their expectations. The clear message: our company understands what you need and delivers the right solution for you.

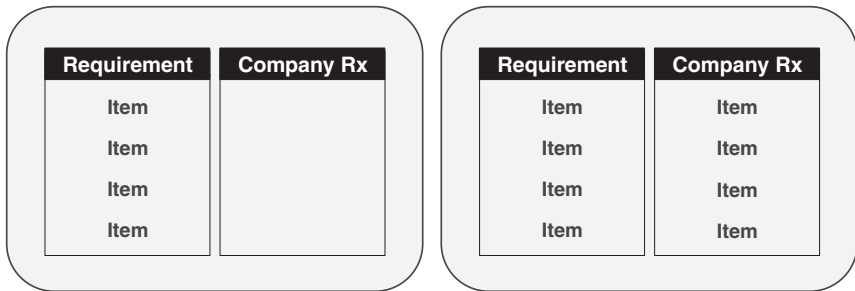


Figure 14.20 *Anticipation Fulfilled: Business*

These Graphic Continuity techniques add clarity and coherence to your presentations. Artfully used, they can make even a long, complex story easier for your audience to absorb and follow. The techniques are also the final step in the Storyboard Development Process that began in the previous chapter.

Storyboard Development Process

1. **Carry forward the Flow Structure.**
2. **Insert *only* the titles.**
3. **Verbalize the titles as one long sentence.**
4. **Add the design elements.**
5. **Use graphic continuity.**

■ Presenter Focus Revisited ■

Throughout this entire chapter and in the previous three chapters on slide design, I have never once mentioned the WIIFY; and in the same stretch, I have only mentioned Point B briefly, as part of the narrative of the Opening Gambit

sequence. Yet throughout the earlier part of the book, I stressed the importance of making multiple statements of each.

Which raises a question: Where in your Storyboard does your Point B and/or your audience's WIIFY go—on which slide?

The right answer is nowhere. Point B and the WIIFY do not appear on *any* slide. Certainly not, as is far too often the case, in the title or subtitle at the *beginning* of a slide. In Chapter Eleven, you read how many presenters, follow the pervasive apocryphal belief that the message should go upfront. This misguided practice not only negates the role of the presenter, but also telegraphs the punch line. Instead, you, as the presenter, should lead your audience to a conclusion by *speaking* your Point B and/or their WIIFY at the *end* of the slide.

I ask this as a trick question to reinforce the Presenter Focus Model: You tell your story; your slides do not.

Imagine a company CEO presenting to an audience of potential investors and concluding with the slide in Figure 14.21.

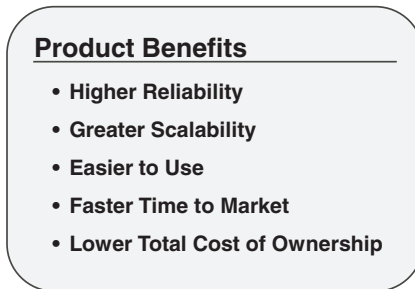


Figure 14.21 *Product Benefits Slide*

The CEO would discuss the product benefits and then summarize the slide by saying, “You can see that our product provides a rich set of benefits to our customers” and then move on to the next slide.

But that would be an opportunity missed.

Instead, the CEO should add:

This rich set of customer benefits produces repeat business for our company. Repeat business translates into recurring revenues. Recurring revenues translate into shareholder value and an excellent investment opportunity.

That statement contains two WIIFYs and a Point B, none of which is on the slide. The presenter leads the audience to a conclusion.

Be Suasive. Be Heard.

Animate Your Graphics

Case Studies: Walt Disney • William Shakespeare • General Hugh Shelton • Sir Isaac Newton

Of all of our inventions for mass communication, pictures still speak the most universally understood language.¹

Walt Disney

■ Pictures in Motion ■

When Walt Disney introduced Mickey Mouse to the world in 1928, it was the first step onto a golden brick road that led to what is now a giant global mass media and entertainment conglomerate consisting of movie studios, theme parks, television networks, a streaming platform, and a monster merchandise machine. The animation techniques that Disney pioneered with a simple camera stand in his uncle's garage have matured into a dazzling array of computer-generated imagery (CGI) effects that are now deployed in multimillion-dollar movie epics, television advertising, and mobile phones.²

While this chapter is not intended to make you another Walt Disney, you'll find that all the techniques here are based on the same fundamental cinematic principles that Disney and other professional animators use. You can incorporate those same techniques to bring your slideshows to life.

■ Cinema Techniques ■

In cinema, directors and editors use camera composition, movement, and montage editing to evoke specific emotions in an audience. The movement of subjects in front of the camera and the movement of the camera itself, along with the juxtaposition of the shots, can create either positive or negative feelings.

In a romantic movie, when long-separated lovers finally come together in an embrace, the scene is likely to be filmed in long, smooth shots, conveying sensuality and abandon. In a cops-and-robbers drama, a car chase is usually captured in sharp angles and edited with short, rapid cuts to create tension. In a Western, when a wagon train of settlers moves across the screen, the camera slowly zooms back from a close-up until the entire panorama of the prairie is visible to express the vast challenge of the journey. And in a suspenseful murder mystery, when the detective, searching for clues in a dark, empty house, suddenly hears a click, there is a quick cut to a close-up of a door handle turning, heightening the tension.

Presentation animation doesn't offer the range and power of options available to a film director, but from all of the above, you can derive one simple overarching principle about animation: you can use motion to help tell your story by expressing your message with action. Motion can mirror or evoke the feeling you want to create in your audience. To reprise Shakespeare: "suit the action to the word, the word to the action."³

■ Slideshow Animation ■

Sophisticated visual effects have become a standard element in business. Websites, ads, presentations at industry conferences, display booths at trade shows, and even conventional prepackaged corporate pitches display dynamic visual effects that rival the production values of prime-time blockbuster movies.

Most of these examples of animation are crafted by professional graphic artists and technicians using complex software. They render objects and images in vivid, opulent detail for animation as well as for conventional presentations.

For the rest of us—the vast universe of businesspeople for whom presentations are a daily routine—there are the consumer software programs such as Apple Keynote, Google Slides, and the one that led the charge, Microsoft PowerPoint.

Creating animation can be daunting. We've all seen far too many presentations that unleash all the bells and whistles of slide animation with frenetic, pyrotechnic displays that resemble a Fourth of July celebration.

This excess reached epidemic proportions in the military. General Hugh Shelton, the chair of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, having seen one too many Pentagon slideshows with animated tanks and whirling pie charts, issued a directive demanding simplicity in Defense Department presentations: "We don't need Venetian-blind effects or fancy backdrops. All we need is the information."⁴

One would expect that military personnel, as well as businesspeople—conservative segments of the population by nature—would be aware that flashy animation projects a negative image. And yet, business slideshows that look like MTV videos are as common as car crashes in Hollywood movies—and just as irritating.

Any visual aid becomes a visual hindrance when it's misused, but any sword can cut both ways. Well-designed and appropriately applied animation can enhance your message. Just as you can create basic text, tables, numbers, and images to express your concepts, you can also express them more vividly by using animation to enhance meaning. To do that, we return to the point where we must always begin: your audience.

■ Animation and Audience Advocacy ■

As with every other element of every presentation, your animation must make your story easy for your audience to absorb and comprehend. The two Suasive Meta Design Techniques in Chapter Ten that drove the basics of slide design also drive the fundamental rationale for animation:

- @ Glance
- Title*Plus*

If your audience cannot understand a slide @ Glance, and you cannot describe it with a one-sentence Title*Plus*, you should animate. For instance, although the slide in Figure 15.1 is a single-subject, it would be difficult for you to describe in one sentence because of the diverse elements.

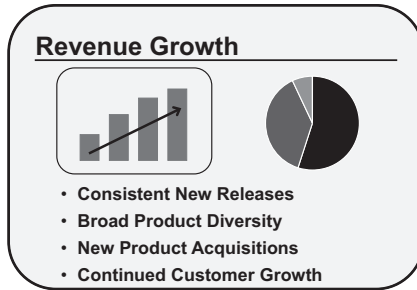


Figure 15.1 Single-Subject Slide with Multiple Elements

Animation is the solution. Start by showing only the title and the bar chart of the slide, as on the left in Figure 15.2. The *TitlePlus* would be “Here you see how our revenues have grown over the past four years.” Your audience will get it @ Glance and turn back to listen as you go on to discuss the revenue growth and add value.

Then click on the animation to bring in the pie chart in the slide on the right. Say the *TitlePlus*: “This pie chart represents the regional contributions to that revenue growth.” Your audience will get it @ Glance and turn back to listen as you go on to discuss each wedge in more detail.

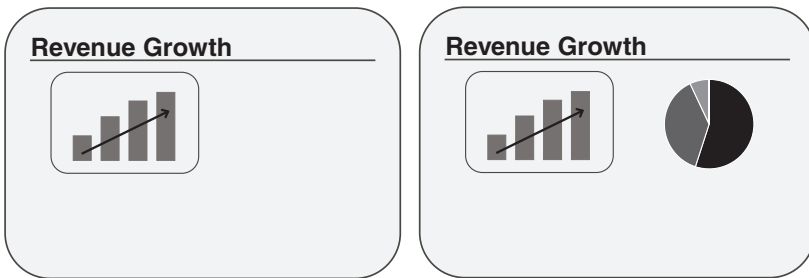


Figure 15.2 Single-Subject Slide with Individual Elements Animated

Now you can fill the Anticipation Space at the bottom of the slide by animating the four bullets in Figure 15.1 and stating the *TitlePlus*: “These are the four drivers that created our impressive revenue growth.” Your audience will get it @ Glance (because each bullet begins with an adjective in parallel grammar) and turn back to you as you go on to add value in your discussion of the bullets.

Therefore, the Suasive Meta Design Techniques drive not only the design of every slide but the overall rationale of animation: to deliver visual images to your audience in clear, easy-to-digest, bite-sized stages.

This brings us to another important aspect of Audience Advocacy.

■ Nurture and Nature in Animation ■

As you also read in Chapter Ten, your audience's eyes and brains are driven by two powerful—and yet contradictory—forces: nurture and nature. Nurture has made the left-to-right dynamic dominant (see Figure 15.3).



Figure 15.3 *Centuries of Left-to-Right Habituation*

When motion is involved, the left-to-right force is intensified.

For your presentation audience to feel positive about your ideas, your animation should follow the innate, natural eye movement: left to right. If you want to send a negative message (about your competition, for example), reverse direction and move your images right to left. As you will see below, there are other psychological perceptions you can create with motion, but because the lion's share of any presentation is about you or your company, you want to send positive messages. Make left to right the default direction for your animation.

Nowhere is connection between movement and feeling more apparent than in dating apps. Visitors seeking companionship scour dating apps in search of prospective mates and either reject or accept them. The app developers have implemented those choices by having users swipe left to reject or swipe right to accept, as in Figure 15.4.

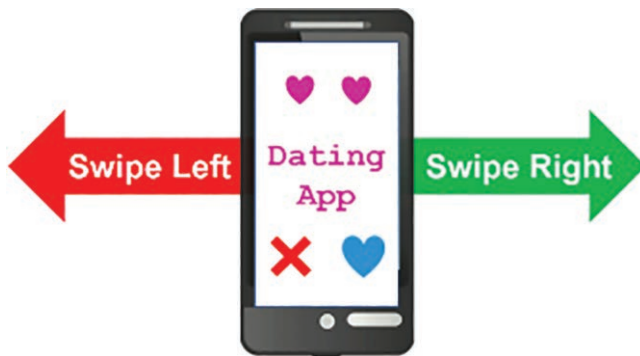


Figure 15.4 *Dating App with Accept or Reject Options*

Your audience's eyes are also driven by their sensitive optic nerves—the nature factor. When there is motion on the presentation screen, their eyes will look at the moving image reflexively. If that movement is counter to the message you are trying to convey, it will confuse them. If the movement supports your message, your audience will be more receptive to your ideas.

Send positive messages: make the default direction for your animation left to right.

And now let's look at specific guidelines for the major options for slide animation.

■ Animation: Metaview ■

All the presentation software programs enable movement in multiple directions, speeds, and duration. And all movement falls into two major types:

- Movement from slide-to-slide, or inter-slide
- Movement within a slide, or intra-slide

Each program has slightly different nomenclature for each of these options. For our purposes, I refer to them as:

- ***Transition***: Movement from slide-to-slide, or inter-slide
- ***Animation***: Movement within a slide, or intra-slide

Each of these major options has four subcategories:

- Movement onto the screen
- Movement off the screen
- Movement inside the screen
- Special effects on the screen

Each program also has slightly different nomenclature for each of these options. For our purposes, I refer to them as:

- ***Entrance***
- ***Exit***
- ***Motion***
- ***Emphasis***

There is one other animation feature that merits special attention because it provides the ultimate technique to add continuity to your presentation. PowerPoint calls it Morph, and Keynote calls it Magic Move.

With this feature, an image on one slide can change size, position, or color in one fluid continuous action as it moves to another slide. For instance, to implement the Indexing/Color Coding technique you read about in Chapter Fourteen, you first establish the index with the color-coded/shaded pie chart in full on one slide, as shown on the left in Figure 15.5.

Then, using the Morph/Magic Move feature, you can shrink and move the pie chart to the upper-right corner of the next slide in one continuous, fluid move as in the slide on the right.

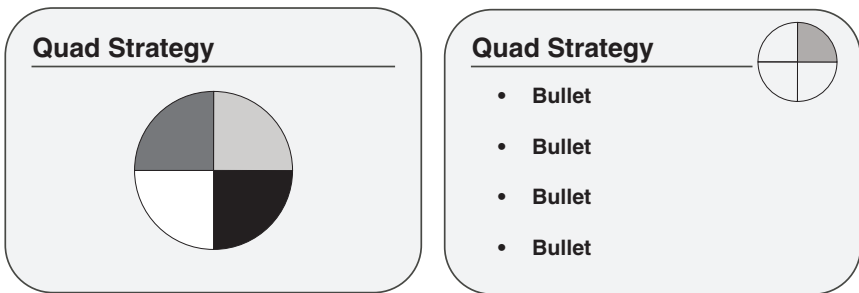


Figure 15.5 Use the Morph/Magic to Move and Shrink the Index to the Corner of the Next Slide

Here are Microsoft's instructions to create the Morph effect:

To use the Morph transition effectively, you'll need to have two slides with at least one object in common—the easiest way is to duplicate the slide and then move the object on the second slide to a different place or copy and paste the object from one slide and add it to the next. Then, apply the Morph transition to the second slide to see what Morph can do to automatically animate and move your object.⁵

■ Animation: Nuts and Bolts ■

Each of the presentation software programs offers a broad array of graphic tools you can deploy to take any presentation from static to dynamic. Browse through the menus of your particular program to see the many choices. Your first reaction

to many of them will be, “Wow! Cool!” Your second reaction may be, “Yes but when would I *ever* use that?”

*To everything there is a season, and a time to every purpose under the heaven.*⁶

Let me provide you with a “when” rationale for each of the most frequently used options.

Wipe

The Wipe option creates the effect of drawing a curtain to open a window, revealing outside light—the light in this case being the new information you reveal to your audience. The Wipe should be your primary choice for a basic reason: it enables the principle of Minimize Eye Sweeps.

For people like General Shelton, who (with good reason) resist *any* animation, the Wipe is a good place to start. This option is so elemental, it barely feels like animation.

Because your audience is driven by nurture and nature to start each new slide at the left and then move to the right, make the left-to-right Wipe your default choice for all Transitions and Animations.

On the other hand, a right-to-left Wipe move is against the grain and sends a negative message. You can use the right-to-left Wipe to indicate the negative factors in your story: the shortcomings of competing products, past problems your company has conquered, or market forces that pose major obstacles for your industry.

As a coach, I use the right-to-left Wipe in my program slides to indicate what *not* to do. The subtle sense of discomfort participants feel in watching the countermovement of images reinforces the cautionary point of my message.

Another way to use motion to express action is to use a bottom-to-top Wipe to indicate rising revenues, increasing market share, or growing profits; and a top-to-bottom Wipe to indicate declining expenses, a falling error rate, or reduced employee turnover.

Fly and Peek

These effects are seemingly cousins of the Wipe, but beware: although they bring text and objects onto the screen as the Wipe does, Fly and Peek move so fast that they blur the text or object as it appears or disappears. Of course, if you want to

suggest a feeling of speed or haste, use Fly or Peek. If you want your audience to take in your images comfortably or read your text easily, stay with the Wipe.

None/Appear

The None/Appear effect, which pops new information onto the screen abruptly, is a slideshow version of what is known in cinema as a cut. Filmmakers use this device to create sudden juxtapositions. Use this effect if you want to express sharp contrast between two images—say the difference between the sleek new design of your product packaging and the clunky packaging of your competitor's product.

In virtual presentations however, because of wide variations of bandwidth, upload/download speeds, and latency, animation can pixelate, slow down, or look choppy. To reduce bandwidth requirements, you may have to restrict your animation in these presentations to None/Appear.

Dissolve and Fade

The Dissolve and Fade options provide smooth transitions. These options are often used in cinema to indicate the passage of time. In a Dissolve, an outbound image gradually fades out and overlaps with an inbound image gradually fading in. In a Fade, the image dips to black for an instant. You've seen these effects countless times in films to indicate the shift of night into day, of one season into the next, or of youth into old age.

Consider using a Dissolve in a presentation to indicate a segue between related concepts—say the image of a product dissolving into an image of the new, upgraded version of the same product; or an image of a metastasized cell fading away due to the application of a new drug.

But use Fades and Dissolves reservedly because the effects create a sense of detachment or separation. Business presentations deal with closely related subjects in real time, so use these effects sparingly. Moreover, at any speed, these options take more time and can slow the pace of a presentation. The Wipe expresses continuity and connectivity more rapidly.

Circle

This option expresses either compression or expansion, depending on whether the movement is in or out. Choose the direction that relates to the innate shape of the compressing or expanding object. For instance, a widening circle can express an expanding pie chart or globe, or a hub radiating out to its spoke structure. On the

other hand, shrinking or condensing a pie chart or globe can express contraction or consolidation of a market or a process. The direction of your animation depends on the message you want to deliver.

Wheel

The Wheel effect enables you to highlight a single word, number, or object on a slide much as you would draw a colored circle around a section of a document. Draw an oval around the item you want to call out and bring it in with the Wheel animation, as in Figure 15.6.

Point	Point	Point	Point	Point
Point	Point	Point	Point	Point
Point	Point	Point	Point	Point
Point	Point	Point	Point	Point

Figure 15.6 *Oval Highlighting One Word with a Wheel Animation*

Emphasis

This feature provides multiple ways to call out a word or an image by changing font size, style, or color. Once you emphasize an image, you can go on to discuss it in detail.

Grow/Shrink and Motion Paths

While the Morph/Magic Move option enables you to move objects and change their size and color *between* slides, you can also create each of those effects *within* a slide by using the Grow/Shrink and Motion Paths effects.

With Grow/Shrink, you can enlarge or reduce the size of any object. This allows you to call out the object, discuss it in detail, and then return it to its original size.

With Motion Paths, you can move any object from one part of the screen to another. The movement expresses the point you make in your narration: escalating revenue potential, declining costs, shifting strategic directions, realigning alliances, or progressive development.

Blinds, Random Bars, and Checkerboard

These three effects are very dramatic. Used arbitrarily, they could distract from your presentation. However, the Blinds and Random Bars effects which have the same vertical structure as bars, create effective transitions between two different bar charts. In the same way, the Checkerboard effect, having the same vertical and horizontal structure as a table, creates an effective segue between two different tables.

Use any of these effects with caution. Any animation that provokes an audience response of “Huh?” or “What was that?” or “I don’t get it!” only detracts from your message. Whenever in doubt, default to the left-to-right Wipe.

■ Animation and the Presenter ■

Although the focus of this book is on story and slides rather than delivery skills, before concluding, it is important to touch briefly on how the presenter’s body language and voice relate to slide animation. Remember that the optic nerves in your audience’s eyes cause them to react to light and motion reflexively. The instant your animation starts, all their attention suddenly shifts away from you to the screen.

Human brains have difficulty processing multiple inputs, especially if those inputs are separate sights and sounds. The movement of your slide animation is so demanding that your audience hears very little of what you are saying and sees very little of what you are doing. Moreover, anything you do or say creates extra sensory data that conflicts with the motion on the presentation screen.

Therefore, you must stop moving, stop speaking, and allow the animation to complete its full course of action. This instruction is part of a skill called *Slide Synchronization*SM that you’ll find in detail in *The Power Presenter*. Briefly, for our purposes, the key to synchronizing your body language and voice with your slide animation is to pause and allow your audience to process the action of the slide.

The pause refreshes the audience’s minds—and yours.

PRESENTING TO WIN

“Action” is the operative word here. The action in your slide animation is there to express your message. Remember Sir Isaac Newton’s Third Law of Motion:

*For every action, there is an equal and opposite reaction.*⁷

In summary, this chapter on Animation together with the two preceding chapters on Visual Storytelling and Graphic Continuity describe the visual tools to take your slides beyond headlines to being true aids to help you tell your story.

The Virtual Presentation

Case Studies: Alexander Graham Bell • Ernest Hemingway • Salzburg University Study • Kate Murphy • Mysty Rusk, San Diego Angel Conference • University of London and University of Padova • Elizabeth McNair • Errol Morris • Sagi BenMoshe, Intel Corporation • Amir Bassan-Eskenazi, CommonGround • John Suler • Jeremy Bailenson • William Shakespeare • Ray A. Smith, *The Wall Street Journal* • Claude Taylor and Jessie Bahrey, Room Rater • Phil Libin, *mmhmm*

*Mr. Watson—come here—I want to see you!*¹

Alexander Graham Bell

■ “Now Joining the Meeting...” ■

Ever since March 10, 1876, when Alexander Graham Bell beckoned his assistant, who was in the next room, with the first words spoken on the first telephone, humans have been striving to close the gap that separates them from other humans in different locations. Mobile phones, the internet, and video conferencing, in rapid order of appearance, facilitated those efforts considerably, and then the coronavirus pandemic of 2020 propelled them into warp speed. Or, to borrow Ernest Hemingway’s apt phrase, “gradually, then suddenly.”²

In a matter of days, most of the planet’s population was sheltering in place, and many were working from home. Zoom quickly took its place in our common

vocabularies alongside Kleenex, Xerox, and Google. Zoom even created a black sheep relative known as “Zoom Fatigue,” which generated demand for guidelines on how to make this once-ancillary medium become the main event—and to do so effectively. As a measure of the rapid pace of change, I made no mention of virtual presentations in the first edition of this book.

However, irrespective of the pandemic, the surging growth of e-commerce, major advances in mobile technology, the rapid globalization of business, and the cost and stress of travel have all made virtual presentations a permanent part of our lives.

To show you how to make all your virtual presentations winning main events let’s examine seven challenges the medium poses and then show you not only how to overcome each of them but how to optimize your impact.

■ Seven Challenges ■

1. Physical Separation from Your Audience
2. Where to Look?
3. Continuity
4. Attention Span
5. What to Wear?
6. Over Your Shoulder
7. Technology

As is only appropriate, the first challenge brings us right back to the essence of every presentation: Audience Advocacy.

1. Physical Separation from Your Audience

Close encounters create meaningful engagements. Psychologists, novelists, poets, composers, and artists have crafted countless works about how well—and not so well—humans communicate with other humans. By all measures, the optimal medium for humans to relate is in the immediacy of face-to-face engagement. Scientists agree. A study at the Salzburg University of Applied Sciences concluded:

*Empathy in real-life interactions is significantly better than in virtual ones.*³

As the gold standard, direct engagement has many catchphrases that express the advantage of close encounters: “person-to-person,” “one-to-one,” “live and in-person,” “suit up and show up,” “work the room,” “heart-to-heart,” and “eye-to-eye.”

The Challenge

When communicating via a virtual platform, the technology converts face-to-face engagements into video and audio imagery, diminishing the effectiveness and power of the engagement. Kate Murphy, who speaks authoritatively on human communication in her book *You're Not Listening*, described the distortions imposed by the technology in her *New York Times* article “Why Zoom Is Terrible”:

[I]n a grid reminiscent of the game show “Hollywood Squares”...the way the video images are digitally encoded and decoded, altered and adjusted, patched and synthesized introduces all kinds of artifacts: blocking, freezing, blurring, jerkiness and out-of-sync audio.

Think of how often you’ve been in a virtual meeting that was stopped in its tracks with cries of “You’re breaking up!” “You froze!” or “I can’t hear you!”

Murphy went on to describe the negative effects:

*Psychologists, computer scientists and neuroscientists say the distortions and delays inherent in video communication can end up making you feel isolated, anxious, and disconnected.*⁴

Those feelings escalate for presenters who deliver high-stakes pitches, such as startup company entrepreneurs who pitch to investors for financing. Mysty Rusk, the founder of the San Diego Angel Conference, a venue for early stage companies to make such pitches, described the challenge:

*Virtual pitches bring their own set of unique challenges, since important nuances of a compelling pitch include storytelling and establishing a connection with the audience; much more difficult to achieve virtually.*⁵

The altered dynamics of virtual meetings have impacted me, too, both professionally and personally. Although I had been delivering virtual sessions for some time, once the pandemic struck, I adapted my existing in-person program to incorporate the many tools of the virtual platform.

On the personal side, when I started engaging in “Zoom Cocktail Hours,” I realized that, when the customary interactive engagement of small groups (even if only four people) shifts to what Kate Murphy characterized as the “Hollywood Squares” format, the interactions change significantly. The three-dimensional openness of an in-person group converts into a series of flat, two-dimensional individual images. And the crosstalk of live dialogue, with what is effectively surround sound, merges into a single monaural channel with one person speaking at a time. Even with friends I have known for years, the interpersonal dynamics became quite constrained. So, just as with my virtual coaching, I adapted by deploying the solutions I offer you here.

The Solution

To compensate for the technology distortions and delays, you must strengthen the interpersonal connections—and you can do that by amplifying your narrative. The primacy of the story—again. You’ll recall from Chapter Nine that one of the most powerful—and yet least implemented—rhetorical techniques is to customize every presentation to every audience with External Linkages. The physical separation of virtual engagements makes those linkages even more important. For your convenience, I’ve repeated the options here and extended them to the virtual environment.

External Linkages

- **Direct References.** Address the members of your audience by name.

Virtual technology makes Direct References easy. As soon as participants log in to a meeting, the virtual platform embeds their names below their pictures, as in Figure 16.1. Whenever you address participants, call them by their names.

- **Mutual References.** Refer to a person, a company, or an organization related to both you and your audience.

This is essential homework for any presentation, whether virtual or in-person. In your preparation, search for relationships common to you and your audience and reference them throughout. Create bonds with your audience and develop synergies.

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Figure 16.1 *Virtual Gallery View with Participant Names*

- **Ask Questions.** Address a question directly to one or more members of your audience.

Most of the virtual platforms provide a polling feature that actively engages and involves the audience by asking them to respond to multiple-choice or yes/no questions. The feature then instantly tabulates their responses and provides information you can use for customization; it also provides you with a measure of how your message is being received. With that knowledge, you can adjust your content to either go deeper on a point or move along in your narrative.

- **Contemporize.** Refer to an event that is happening on the same day as your presentation.

Here, too, the virtual platform makes this technique easy and even more dynamic than a verbal reference in your narrative. Using the screen sharing feature, you can bring up a live site, a current publication, or a blog post published that day.

- **Localize.** Refer to the venue of your presentation.

The virtual venue is universal, but your audience has a headquarters location, and each of the individuals has a home base. As part of your homework, search for these locations and find ways to bring them into your exchanges.

- **LinkedIn.** Research your audience members' professional career paths to find common ground.

Just as with Mutual References above, this is essential homework for every presentation, virtual and in-person. Bond with your audience by citing mutual business connections or relationships.

- **Customized Opening Slide.** Start your presentation with a slide that displays a logo of your audience's company or organization, the location, and the presentation day's date.

By including the current date, you make your session fresh and relevant. Road warriors who repeatedly deliver the same pitch in-person avoid this option for fear that they might show the wrong date. For both in-person and virtual presentations, you can avoid that error by programming the date text in your slides to update automatically. Keep in mind that your virtual audience may be in different time zones and factor that into your references.

2. Where to Look?

Most presentation training, as a matter of course, focuses on body language and voice—the skills messengers must possess to deliver their messages effectively. You can find chapter and verse lessons and exercises for the full range of those skills in *The Power Presenter*. You'll see that I've addressed every skill with variations for in-person and virtual presentations.

However, one of those skills, eye engagement—the most important factor in *every* human engagement—presents a particular challenge in virtual presentations. Our term for this dynamic is *EyeConnect*® rather than eye contact—a longer and more purposeful duration of engagement.

In a study of infants in their first year, researchers at the University of London and the University of Padova found that:

*Making eye contact is the most powerful mode of establishing a communicative link between humans. During their first year of life, infants learn rapidly that the looking behaviors of others conveys significant information....The exceptionally early sensitivity to mutual gaze demonstrated in these studies is arguably the major foundation for the later development of social skills.*⁶

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But the technology of virtual platforms poses a paradoxical challenge. Illustrator and designer Elizabeth McNair captured the paradox in her cartoon published in *The New Yorker*: a man and a woman are speaking on a video call with the caption reading “I can’t tell whether you’re gazing into my eyes or checking your e-mail” (see Figure 16.2).



Figure 16.2 New Yorker Cartoon by Elizabeth McNair

The Paradox

Basic empathy instinctively drives humans to look at the person with whom they are speaking; in a virtual presentation, presenters instinctively look at the images of their audience on the screen. And being human, people also look at the image of themselves. But because the webcam is either embedded in the frame *over* the screen or mounted *on top* of the screen, the presenter appears to be looking *up*, *down*, or *away* from, rather than *at* the audience.

Disconnect!

The Solution—Thus Far

Ideally, the camera should be in the middle of the screen so that the presenter can see the audience and, at the same time, appear to be looking at them. But that, in itself, is a physical paradox: *two objects cannot occupy the same space at the same time.*

A creative filmmaker came up with a workaround solution. According to an industry publication, director Errol Morris crafted a homemade system for his Oscar-winning documentary *The Fog of War*. The rig combined two cameras with modified teleprompters so that:

...the subject looks into the face of the questioner rather than a cold camera lens. The questioner looks into his or her device and sees the face of the on-camera subject. Each person can observe the expressions and body language of the other while the interview is going on. Most importantly, direct eye contact with the person being interviewed is maintained on camera.⁷

Videoconferencing, on the other hand, has mainly focused on the telecommunication technology. More than 25 years ago, I worked with a startup videoconferencing company whose engineers were quite aware of the engagement paradox. They were considering developing a system of reflective glass plates to act as mirrors. But neither that company nor the other videoconferencing companies that have come along in the intervening two and a half decades have solved the problem.

Until now. Under the leadership of Sagi BenMoshe, corporate vice president of the Emerging Growth and Incubation group, Intel Corporation is developing a solution called “Eye Contact Correction.” Using Artificial Intelligence (AI), the technology allows users to do what comes naturally: look directly at the faces of the audience on the computer screen, which in most cases, requires looking down (see Figure 16.3).

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Figure 16.3 *Intel Eye Contact Correction Image: Off*

But when the Eye Contact Correction feature is switched on, the technology electronically shifts the image of the speaker's pupils *up* so the user *appears* to be looking at the webcam (see Figure 16.4).



Figure 16.4 *Intel Eye Contact Correction Image: On*

Amir Bassan-Eskenazi, the CEO of CommonGround, a Silicon Valley company, is developing another solution for the paradox. CommonGround's technology captures the presenter and the audience members' images and, using AI and 3D modeling, encodes each user's expressions and gestures (see Figure 16.5).

PRESENTING TO WIN

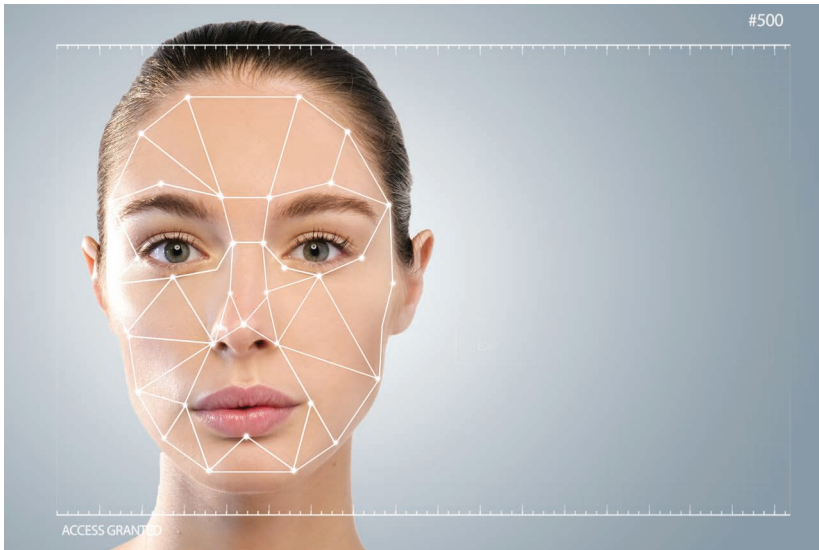


Figure 16.5 *CommonGround 3D Modeling*

The technology then transmits all the information into a virtual room where it is synthesized and rendered (see Figure 16.6).



Figure 16.6 *CommonGround 3D Virtual Room*

All the participants appear in 3D images and engage, making eye contact with each other, and controlling their own point of view. By creating this immersive meeting room experience, AI resolves the paradox.

Until Intel, CommonGround, or another technology, becomes universally available, what you must do now is make *CamConnect*SM, the virtual version

of EyeConnect, both based on the same core principle of a longer and more purposeful duration of engagement.

CamConnect means that you speak directly to the webcam. This will feel very unnatural to you because your eyes are empathically drawn to look at your audience. Even more unnatural, you will only see your audience out of the corners of your eyes. However, because your audience will see you addressing them directly, it will feel natural to them.

Truth be told, your audience's feelings are more important than yours.

To make your audience your primary focus—and to avoid looking at yourself—you can hide your own image from the gallery, a feature most of the virtual platforms provide. This will remove your image from your screen but leave it on your audience's screens—and help you maintain your engagement with them.

When you make CamConnect, follow these two important guidelines:

- **Speak at the level of the webcam.** Otherwise, you will appear to be looking down or up at your audience. In photography and cinematography, when the camera is positioned above a subject, it is called a high angle shot; when it is below a subject, a low angle shot. Each of these positions creates a different emotional message.

Author John Suler describes these dynamics in his book *Photographic Psychology*: the high angle shot makes “the subject appear to be in an inferior position relative to your dominant and more powerful point of view”; and a low angle shot creates “the feeling that the subject is big, high, powerful, dominant, imposing, authoritative, or menacing.”⁸

The only feeling you want to create in your audience is empathy, so make CamConnect at eye level. If you use the webcam built into your laptop, raise your laptop on a stand, a small box, or a pile of books; if you use an external webcam, mount it on a tripod raised to your eye level.

- **Look away from the webcam.** Break CamConnect briefly from time to time, or you will appear to be staring. In an experiment at Stanford University's Virtual Human Interaction Lab, founding director Jeremy Bailenson discovered the importance of occasionally breaking engagement, which he explained in a *Wall Street Journal* article:

*[M]y colleagues and I studied the consequences of this “constant gaze,” using virtual classrooms...the learners reported being very uncomfortable getting stared at for an entire lesson. Just like you might be feeling on Zoom.*⁹

PRESENTING TO WIN

Spend most of your time speaking to the webcam but break away every now and then. When you do, look at your audience, your slides, or your notes. Of course, if your slides and notes are composed as *Less Is More* headlines, you will get your prompts @ Glance, and be able to return to your primary focus, *CamConnect*.

The eyes have it.

3. Continuity

In this day and age of hyperconnectivity, all audiences fall victim to distractions on their mobile phones and computers, but because the participants in virtual presentations are usually alone, they do so to a far greater extent than in-person. We've all watched pets and children stroll into the virtual space, seen people munching lunch, texting on their mobile phones, or heard traffic or leaf blowers in the background. Such distractions break an audience's concentration.

The Challenge

How to meet the heightened challenge of your audience's shorter-than-usual attention span.

The Solution

Provide enhanced continuity with your narrative and your graphics.

Narrative Continuity

As with the first challenge, amplify your narrative. Once again, we return to the primacy of the story, this time using continuity to keep your audience on track.

Create a solid narrative structure with the ten steps of Story Development from the front end of this book, with particular emphasis on the tenth: Internal Linkages. Use these narrative techniques to keep your audience on track. For your convenience, I've repeated a summary of the list from Chapter Eight here:

- Reference the Flow Structure
- Logical Transition
- Cross-Reference
- Rhetorical Question
- Recurring Opening Gambit
- Bookends
- Mantra
- Internal Summary
- Enumeration
- Do the Math
- Reinforce Point B
- Say Your Company Name

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One more very valuable continuity technique is a function that is available in most presentation software programs: Presenter View.

Presenter View. This view displays the current slide as well as a preview of the next slide in sequence. To demonstrate, Figure 16.7 shows two slides from the deck I use in my coaching programs.

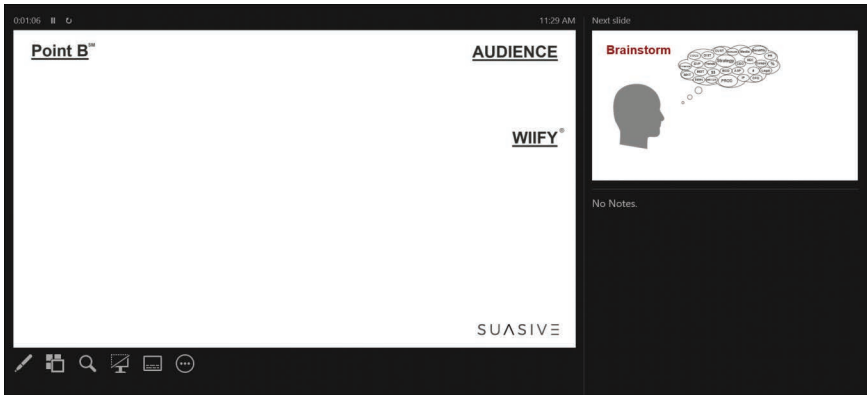


Figure 16.7 *Presenter View of Suasive Presentation*

The larger image on the left—the Suasive FrameForm—is the current slide; the smaller image on the right—the Brainstorming slide—is the next slide in sequence. In the program, I discuss them just as I did in Chapter Three.

You will need two monitors to implement Presenter View: one with the slideshow that your audience sees; the other with Presenter View that only you see. Mount your webcam over the monitor with the Presenter View so that you address your audience directly. Once you have set up this arrangement, do a trial run with a colleague to be sure that they see only the slideshow.

Then, when you break away from CamConnect to a preview of the next image, your eyes travel a very short distance to get a quick prompt of the next slide.

Of course, Presenter View is available for all presentations, but I recommend that you *never* use it for in-person ones. In that setting, your eyes must travel from EyeConnect with your audience all the way down to your computer—a much longer distance than they travel in the virtual setting. This move produces a “nosedive”—which makes a presenter appear to be furtively searching for what to say next.

Presenter View not only provides you with a prompt but enables you to create continuity by making a Forward Link to the next slide.

Forward Link. Let's say you're discussing a slide about your company's product, and the next slide in sequence is your customer list. You can create a Forward Link by glancing at the preview of the customer slide and then saying, "Now, let's look at the top tier customers who bought our leading product..."—*and then* click to it. By making this forecast, you bridge the two slides and maintain your audience's attention.

This is far more effective than clicking to the customer slide and *then* saying, "Now let's look at our top tier customers." That sentence provides no clear connection between the two slides. It's as if you are restarting your presentation from scratch.

Beware of the Forward Link, however, when you deliver in-person presentations. That's because, you must be absolutely certain which slide comes next from memory (difficult without Presenter View). In the heat of the moment, you might forget the sequence. Such an awkward moment can happen whether you are presenting your deck for the first time or the one hundred and first time. It can happen with a presentation that has been thrust into your hands only moments before the start or with a presentation you have delivered so many times you are on autopilot.

In any of these cases, you might make a Forward Link to the wrong slide by saying, "Let's look at the impressive revenues our product has generated." But then, when you turn to the screen, you see the customer slide. At that point, your stomach sinks and you emit a nervous cough and mumble, "But first let's look at our customers!"

While forward links are difficult in in-person presentations, their ease of use in virtual presentations makes them an invaluable asset in creating continuity throughout your narrative.

Graphic Continuity

In Chapter Fourteen, you learned a set of Graphic Continuity Techniques to help you track the flow of your story for your audience. For your convenience, I've repeated a summary of the list:

- Bumper Slide
- Indexing/Color Coding
- Icons
- Anchor Objects
- Anticipation Space

While they all provide milestones that track your flow, let me call particular attention to the first, the Bumper Slide. Not only does this option create continuity but it also provides part of the solution to the next challenge, Attention Span.

4. Attention Span

Prolonged exposure to the Fifth Cardinal Sin, *too long*, has caused audiences to respond with little tolerance and short attention spans.

The Challenge

Short attention spans, when combined with the innate obstacles of virtual presentations—Zoom fatigue, physical separation, and potential distractions—heighten the challenge of keeping your audience engaged. Extraordinary times call for extraordinary measures.

The Solution

The key is to constantly involve your audience by engaging them in any or all of these three participatory activities: *open the virtual floor* to interactive discussion; *manage the time* with tracking reminders throughout; and incorporate the variety of *virtual platform tools* to promote involvement.

Open the Virtual Floor

As with in-person presentations, a Bumper Slide—with a centered, single-line headline—serves as a break between sections and allows you to make a transition (see Figure 16.8).

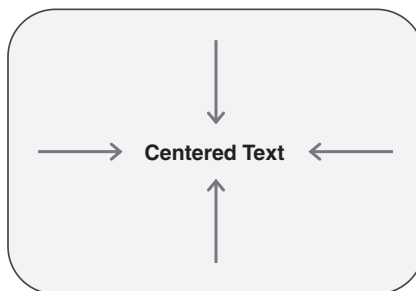


Figure 16.8 *Centered Text as a Bumper Slide*

In virtual presentations, a Bumper Slide has the added benefit of giving you the opportunity to pause your forward progress and open the virtual floor to questions, reactions, feedback, or discussion to keep your audience involved.

Time Management

Be as diligent about timing as an air traffic controller. In advance of your virtual presentation, as well as at the beginning and periodically throughout, announce and remind the audience of the total running time. As the session proceeds, count down the remaining time. Although you and the participants can see the actual time on the computer screen, your tracking the time of the session is as important as your forecasting the length of the presentation as you saw in Chapter Seven.

Take short breaks at least every 90 minutes. Announce the total length of each break at the start. In the event that the people in your virtual audience are in different time zones, announce those breaks referencing only the minutes—such as, “Let’s all return at 15 minutes past the hour.”

Under no circumstances should any virtual presentation or session exceed five hours.

Enlist a producer or colleague to help track the time and to facilitate some of the tools of a virtual meeting: chat, polls, audience reactions, and videos.

The Virtual Toolbox

All the virtual platforms offer a variety of features that invite audience participation and promote interactive engagement. Below is an extensive list of options across platforms:

- **Virtual whiteboard.** Open the virtual whiteboard and ask your audience to join you in brainstorming by sharing ideas with words and images.
- **Screen sharing.** Share documents, slideshows, spreadsheets, or images for everyone to see.
- **Annotation.** Access the range of annotation tools that enable you or your audience to highlight a particular word, number, or object on any shared image.
- **Polling.** Use the polling feature to ask the audience about their knowledge and opinions. The tabulated results can prompt further interactive discussion.
- **Live chat.** Invite the audience to submit questions privately to you or your producer or colleague, privately to each other, or to the entire group via chat.
- **Breakout rooms.** Divide your audience into small subgroups and send them to individual breakout rooms where they can interact with each

other. You can move in and out of these rooms to interact with them. Then, when everyone returns to the main room, you can prompt further interaction by having people share and comment on the exchanges they had during the breakouts.

- **Audience attendance and reaction display.** Some virtual platforms allow the audience to react with digital icons such as a thumbs up or a raised hand. Read these reactions and adjust your content based on them.

Read the Reaction/Adjust the Content

One of the prime delivery skills in *The Power Presenter* is “Read the Reaction/Adjust the Content,” which I explain and illustrate in a full chapter. For our purposes, here is a brief summary from that book:

*Read the nonverbal reaction of the one person you are addressing. Look at that person long enough to see if they are getting it or not getting it. If that person is getting it, you will get head nods. If that person is not getting it, you will get a quizzical look or a frown....respond to the nonverbal reaction verbally.*¹⁰

When you make your periodic breaks away from CamConnect, read the *nonverbal* reactions on the faces of your audience—even though you are seeing them as only postage stamp-sized images—and then Adjust your Content to what you’ve seen by saying:

- “Niles, you smiled when I mentioned that. You’ve seen that yourself?”
- “Ahn, do you have a question?”
- “Sue, you rolled your eyes. You’ve been there before?”
- “Hans, you were about to say...?”

These questions and statements are likely to prompt responses from Niles, Ahn, Sue, or Hans and bring them into the conversation. You can then react to whatever they say and extend the interaction further.

In a virtual keynote to a large audience, such exchanges would be difficult (or even impossible), but you can still Read the Nonverbal Reaction of individual members and Adjust the Content.

5. What to Wear?

When the coronavirus prompted many businesses to go fully remote, people presenting from home became more casual about their attire. Many dressed up above the waist and dressed down below the waist—in sweatpants. This style became so pervasive that *GQ*, the influential men’s fashion magazine, declared, “The sweatpant has supplanted the blue jean in the pants-wearing American imagination.”¹¹

As the pandemic wore on, the sweatpants look began to work its way up above the waist, too. When combined with effects of shuttered barber shops and beauty salons, presenters began to look like they were attending a slumber party.

The Challenge

Whenever you appear in front of an audience, your goal is to position yourself as an authority on the subject you are presenting. As Shakespeare wrote, *the apparel oft proclaims the man*.¹²

Dressing down diminishes your authority.

The Solution

Dress up. Given the absolute fact that there is no arguing taste, I never opine about fashion or style, but whenever a client asks my advice on what to wear, my only response is: *Plus One*.

Plus One means try to determine what your audience will be wearing and escalate your attire one notch. For instance, if you present to a virtual industry trade show where the general attire is jeans and T-shirts, step up to business casual: wear a jacket and a shirt or blouse. If you present to a virtual industry conference where the usual attire is business casual, dress more formally: neckties for men and suits for women. In the event you can’t predetermine the attire, opt for the high end. Plus One applies to all presentations, virtual and in-person.

Dressing up will also improve your effectiveness as a presenter. In his *Wall Street Journal* article “The Science Behind WFH Dressing for Zoom,” Ray A. Smith cites two scientific studies: one “showed that the combination of wearing certain clothes and their symbolic meaning led to more focused attention,” and the other “found that dressing more formally for work leads to the higher levels of abstract, big-picture thinking associated with someone in a powerful position.”¹³

Proclaim your power with your attire.

6. Over Your Shoulder

A popular Twitter account called Room Rater rates the backgrounds of virtual calls on a scale of 1 to 10. The account's critics, Claude Taylor and Jessie Bahrey, rate everything from color choices to floral arrangements, with sassy comments like "cord violations" about exposed cables or "hostage setting" when there is no background. The pair has accumulated more than a quarter of a million followers and drawn the attention of no less an authority than *House Beautiful* magazine, the Hearst Corporation's venerated bible of interior design.¹⁴

The Challenge

Your virtual audience sees you and everything else in the video frame. If there are peculiar objects, bright lights, ceiling fans, windows with glaring sunlight, or the like behind you, your audience will be distracted.

The Solution

Avoid distractions. Choose a neutral setting such as curtains or doors so that the focus remains on you. That said, some presenters choose to dress up their surroundings by sitting in front of a wall decorated with art or photographs. Some sit in front of bookshelves, particularly authors and experts who have their own books prominently displayed face out.

Some presenters use the virtual background. This is based on the technology professional broadcasters use (green screen or chroma key), but the virtual version is not quite as robust and the background often "bleeds" into the foreground, particularly the stock shot options of city vistas or moonscapes. The safest option is the "Blur" effect and, while it bleeds too, it does so much less perceptibly than the others and creates a textured, distraction-free background. Whichever background you use, be sure to run a test before you use it.

Bottom line: keep the focus on you.

Phil Libin, the founder of Evernote, the popular note-taking app, has started a new company with the unusual name *mmhmm*,¹⁵ which, as its website states, "makes video calls less boring." In the video below, Libin demonstrates the app's ability to insert slides, photos, and videos behind the presenter and to vary the size and position of any of those the elements. As Libin describes it, "It's instant *Weekend Update*...SNL [*Saturday Night Live*]."¹⁶



(Video 25) *Make great video presentations with mmhmm*
<https://youtu.be/c8KhKBL0SMk>

Put yourself front and center but always look over your shoulder to be sure that your background rates a 10 out of 10 from Room Rater.

7. Technology

Kate Murphy's string of artifacts above perfectly captured the erratic instability of video and audio signals that bedevil the technology of virtual presentations. Another Murphy, no relation, summarized those artifacts with Murphy's Law:

Anything that can go wrong will go wrong.

A relative of the second Murphy was O'Toole, whose law reads:

Murphy was an optimist.

The Challenge

Given the rapid rate of change in technology and the accelerated rate of adoption of virtual communications, the technology is sure to improve—someday. In the meantime, you have to optimize the existing technology.

The Solution

Follow the fail-safe strategy that airlines use: add redundancy to your virtual setup—for your computer, camera, microphone, and internet lines.

Beyond redundancy, if you present virtually often, you should also optimize the quality of your equipment. That subject is outside the scope of this book, but you can readily find many options for every budget on the web.

In this chapter, you saw the many unique factors of virtual presentations, and you also saw that every one of those aspects ultimately relates to a universal set of best practices—all of which I will summarize in the next and culminating chapter.

Coda: Ending with the Beginning

Case Studies: Stephen Covey • William Safire

*Begin with the End in Mind*¹

The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People

Stephen Covey

Let me end the book by returning to the beginning. In the Preface, I recounted an industry event I attended in Bangalore where a young entrepreneur asked me, “What changes have you seen in presentations over your years in business, and what changes have you had to make in your process?”

My response to him then is the same today: “It’s still the same old story.”

■ The Primacy of the Story ■

Persuading your audience requires, above all, that you tell a compelling, succinct, relevant, and well-articulated story that is crystal clear about where you want to lead your audience—your Point B—and how you will get them there. To do that, you must distill the essential elements of your story, arrange them in a logical flow, and convey them with authoritative words that include the benefits for your audience: their WIIFYs. And you must support your presentation with Less Is More slides that illustrate your messages clearly.

If you prepare your presentation with all these elements at their optimum, you will experience a remarkable secondary benefit: your delivery skills will improve. When you have full command of your story, you become more confident and can deliver a polished, poised, and persuasive presentation.

Think of a well-crafted story illustrated by well-designed slides as an advanced communications satellite and the presenter as a Saturn rocket. NASA spends millions of dollars and thousands of hours building such satellites. If the

rocket misfires, the satellite doesn't go into orbit. If the messenger is less than optimal, the message doesn't get delivered.

However, if you try to work on your delivery style before your story and slides are “baked,” it would be like trying to rub your stomach and pat your head at the same time. That's why I have dedicated this entire book to provide you with the complete repertory of techniques to develop your story and, separately, the complete repertory of techniques to deliver your story in *The Power Presenter*—except for the brief reference to two crossover skills here.

One of those crossovers, Slide *Synchronization*, which you read about in Chapter Fifteen, integrates your body language, voice, slide design, and slide animation. That leaves one more factor to integrate: your narrative.

*End with the Beginning in Mind.*²

■ The Suasive Three-Step Narration ■

Ever since the beginning of this book, I've stressed the importance of maintaining a clear flow throughout your presentation on the global level of the Story Arc; now let's take that flow to an even more granular level: each individual slide. Integrate your story and your slide with the Suasive Three-Step Narration technique, as in Figure C.1:

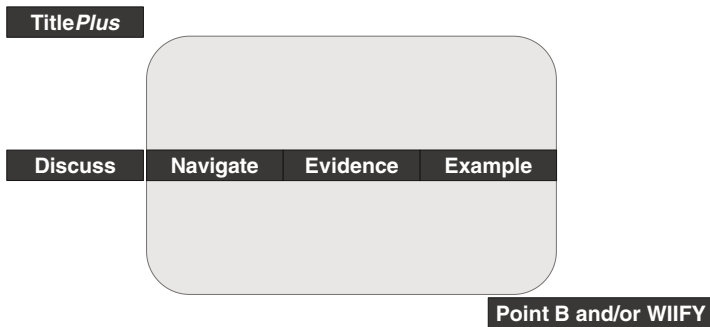


Figure C.1 *The Suasive Three-Step Narration*

1. Start each slide with a **TitlePlus**.

Describe the slide in one succinct sentence by referencing the title above the line and the other elements below the line.

2. Discuss each slide.

After stating the *TitlePlus*, add value by discussing content that is *not* on the slide.

- As part of your discussion, *navigate* your audience's eyes, directing them to the part of the slide you are discussing. For example, "At the top...", "The image on the right...", or "The green bars represent..."
- Add further value by including *evidence* such as a statistic or a significant fact.
- Add even further value with an *example* that shows your product, service, or company in action, such as in a customer use case.

3. Culminate with your Point B and/or a WIIFY for your audience.

Conclude your discussion with your call to action and/or a benefit to your audience.

To demonstrate, here is how the Three-Step Narration would apply to a typical pie chart illustrated in Figure C.2:

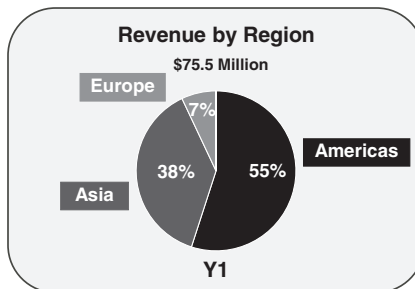


Figure C.2 Pie Chart for Verbal Navigation

1. Start each slide with a *TitlePlus*.

This pie chart shows how each of our three sales regions contributed to our revenue growth.

2. Discuss each slide.

We launched our product line in North America and Asia simultaneously two years ago and only recently entered the European market.

• **Navigate:**

As a result, our Americas revenues, in black, contributed the largest share, at 55 percent; moving clockwise, Asia, in dark gray, was at 38 percent, and Europe, in light gray, is just getting started, at 7 percent.

- **Evidence or example:**

I'm pleased to tell you that, just after our launch in Europe, we partnered with the leading distributor in France.

3. Conclude with your Point B and/or a WIIFY for your audience.

With their efforts, I expect that our growth in Europe will escalate rapidly. When you combine the new partnership with the new product line we'll be launching globally this month, I'm confident that you'll be seeing strong revenue growth across the board in our next report.

Another way to view the Suasive Three-Step Narration is to paraphrase the universal axiom for speechmaking:

- **Tell 'em** what they see.
- **Tell 'em** what they don't see.
- **Tell 'em** that what you've shown 'em is worthy of their consideration.

I've dedicated many pages in this book to the importance of stating Point B and WIIFYs throughout your story. In this closing chapter, I've brought the two skills together to culminate your narrative. Jointly, the two concepts take on a new name, *Topspin*[®]—as an analogy with the tennis power stroke that indicates adding an extra thrust to your story. By ending your discussion of any slide with Topspin, you lead your audience to a conclusion.

That's persuasion.

You can also apply that same culminating function to follow your answer to a question. You'll find a full discussion of Topspin in the third book in this trilogy, *In the Line of Fire: How to Handle Tough Questions When It Counts*.

■ Disruptive but Better ■

In one final return to the beginning, most of the techniques in this book had their origins in and grew out of my experience at CBS, an environment quite different from the world of business. I sincerely hope you've found them valuable—and disruptive. I expect the latter because after more than three decades of coaching, I find that most business presentations still default to the legacy practice of starting the process with slides. I also sincerely hope that, although disruptive, you found these techniques to be easy to implement and effective in producing persuasive results.

■ Every Audience, Every Time ■

I've illustrated many of the concepts in this book with examples from IPO roadshows. That unique presentation is the ultimate in high-stakes assignments, comparable to piloting a space flight, conducting a symphony, or winning a gold medal at the Olympics. I hope you found these IPO case studies to be clear illustrations of the Suasive techniques.

More importantly, I hope you've recognized that you can employ these very same techniques in every presentation or speech of your own. The underlying fundamentals of the Suasive techniques have existed since Aristotle. Abraham Lincoln, Winston Churchill, John F. Kennedy, and Martin Luther King, Jr. used them—and so can you.

You may have a long and successful business career and never have the opportunity to deliver an IPO roadshow. But whatever type of presentation you do deliver, wherever you deliver it, and whoever is in your audience, you want every one of your 15, 20, or 30 minutes in front of them to be powerful and persuasive. The challenge is as important as convincing your executive team to support a new business idea, as rewarding as supporting a charitable cause, as close to home as winning your neighbor's support in a local election, or as personal as capturing the interest of a classroom of first graders on Parents' Day. In every case, your reputation is on the line.

William Safire, the veteran speechwriting expert I've quoted more than once in this book, defines the goal of every presentation in his authoritative book *Lend Me Your Ears: Great Speeches in History*:

*[A] great speech is made for a high purpose—to inspire, to ennoble, to instruct, to rally, to lead.*³

You may never get to compete in the Olympics, but every time you set out to persuade, you're striving to succeed. Go for the gold!

Be Suasive. Be Heard.

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<https://youtu.be/whwRMzwGXIQ>

11. CES 2020 Delta Keynote and State of the Industry Address
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12. Closing Tipping Point Breakfast 2019—Daniel Lurie
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<https://youtu.be/sFGnFKMSmL0>
21. Hans Rosling's 200 Countries, 200 Years, 4 Minutes—The Joy of Stats—BBC Four
<https://youtu.be/jbkSRLYSojo>
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<https://youtu.be/jlRteUA8SEk?t=20>
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24. You Can't Stop Us | Nike
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